THE BLUE SILENCE

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A Novel

DARYA MALAK

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CONTENTS

Prologue	The Box	1
Chapter One	The Retirement	11
Chapter Two	The Boy From Merbau	27
Chapter Three	The First Envelope	45
Chapter Four	Room 17	63
Chapter Five	The Policeman Who Disappeared	81
Chapter Six	The Border	101
Chapter Seven	The Informant	123
Chapter Eight	The Night Raid	151
Chapter Nine	The Photograph	171
Chapter Ten	The Price Of Silence	185
Chapter Eleven	Special Intelligence	201
Chapter Twelve	The Invisible War	215
Chapter Thirteen	Orion	229
Chapter Fourteen	Aisyah	245
Chapter Fifteen	The Accountant	257
Chapter Sixteen	Seven Minutes	271
Chapter Seventeen	The Dead Witness	285
Chapter Eighteen	The Second Envelope	299
Chapter Nineteen	The Circle	313
Chapter Twenty	Three Policemen	327
Chapter Twenty-One	The Promotion	343
Chapter Twenty-Two	The Leak	355
Chapter Twenty-Three	Six Names	369
Chapter Twenty-Four	The Missing Phone	381
Chapter Twenty-Five	Aisyah Investigates Rahman	393
Chapter Twenty-Six	The Old Case	405
Chapter Twenty-Seven	The Pattern	411
Chapter Twenty-Eight	Farid	417
Chapter Twenty-Nine	The Wrong Enemy	423

Chapter Thirty	The Archive	429
Chapter Thirty-One	The First Name	435
Chapter Thirty-Two	The Father	447
Chapter Thirty-Three	The Bargain	457
Chapter Thirty-Four	The Betrayal	467
Chapter Thirty-Five	The List	481
Chapter Thirty-Six	The Missing Name	499
Chapter Thirty-Seven	The Truth	523
Chapter Thirty-Eight	The Choice	551
Chapter Thirty-Nine	The Blue Silence	559
Chapter Forty	The Man In The Crowd	585

PROLOGUE

THE BOX

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

The rain had started before Maghrib and had not stopped.

It came down in heavy tropical sheets, swallowing the buildings beyond the compound fence and turning the security lights into pale yellow smudges. Water spilled from the gutters of the old records annex in continuous streams, hitting the concrete below with a sound like distant applause.

Abdul Malik bin Samad sat behind the steering wheel of his Proton and wondered, for the third time, why he had agreed to come.

At sixty-seven, Malik had spent four years teaching himself how not to wake before dawn.

Thirty-eight years in government service had trained his body to rise at five-thirty without an alarm. Retirement had not cured him immediately. For the first six months he had still shaved every morning before remembering there was nowhere he needed to be.

Eventually the habit loosened.

He learned to drink his kopi slowly.

He learned to sit on the veranda while his wife complained that he was finally discovering the existence of his own house.

He learned that grandchildren had schedules more complicated than cabinet ministers.

And he learned that files, unlike people, rarely missed you when you left.

He looked through the rain at the long, low building.

MNPS RECORDS ANNEX 4

The sign had faded until the blue letters were almost grey.

He had worked inside that building for seventeen years.

Tonight it looked smaller.

That bothered him.

Malik switched off the engine.

For several seconds he listened to the rain hammering the roof of the car.

Then he reached into the passenger seat and picked up the folded sheet of paper.

It had arrived that afternoon through an old colleague named Firdaus, who still worked part-time helping the department prepare older records for digitisation.

A disposal list.

Hundreds of case numbers scheduled for destruction after their retention periods expired.

Nothing unusual.

Old administrative investigations.

Closed theft files.

Minor disciplinary cases.

Cases nobody remembered because nobody needed to.

Malik had almost thrown the list away.

Then he saw the number halfway down the third page.

17/94

There had been no title beside it.

Only:

CASE FILE 17/94 — RETENTION EXPIRED — DESTROY

Malik had stared at the line for nearly a minute.

He remembered the number.

That was the problem.

He remembered numbers better than names.

Numbers never changed their faces.

He folded the paper again, slid it into his shirt pocket and opened the car door.

Rain struck his trousers before he could raise the umbrella.

“Old fool,” he muttered.

The guard at the gate was young enough to be his grandson.

He looked at Malik’s retired-service identification card, then at Malik.

“Encik used to work here?”

"Before you were born."

The guard smiled politely.

Young people always thought old men were joking when they told the truth.

"I was told you were coming."

"Who told you?"

The guard glanced toward the security office.

"Administration."

Malik waited.

The young man said nothing more.

That was the first thing Malik disliked.

The second was that the main entrance to Annex 4 was already unlocked.

Inside, the building smelled exactly as he remembered.

Paper.

Dust.

Air-conditioning.

A faint trace of dampness that no maintenance contractor had ever successfully defeated.

Malik closed the umbrella and stood beneath the fluorescent lights.

The corridor was empty.

Rows of grey metal doors disappeared into the building.

He knew every room.

Or had known them.

Some doors now carried barcode scanners. New cameras hung from the ceiling. A digital access panel had replaced the old handwritten register beside the archive entrance.

Progress.

Malik had always been suspicious of the word.

A woman from administration met him near the records counter.

She introduced herself as Inspector Salina, though Malik knew immediately that she did not work permanently in records. Records officers moved differently. They had the patience of librarians and the posture of people whose enemies were humidity and missing signatures.

Salina watched people.

"Encik Malik."

"Inspector."

"Thank you for coming."

"You have people here who know how to destroy files."

A small smile.

"We were told you might remember the older classification system."

"We had labels. Not hieroglyphics."

Again the polite smile.

She handed him a temporary access card.

"Firdaus said there was one file you wanted to check."

Malik looked at her.

"I never told Firdaus which file."

The smile remained.

Just slightly.

"No?"

"No."

Rain rattled against the high windows.

Salina glanced at the disposal list in Malik's hand.

"Perhaps he guessed."

"Perhaps."

For a moment neither spoke.

Then she stepped aside.

"Storage C. Aisle nineteen."

Malik felt something tighten behind his ribs.

He had not asked where the file was.

Storage C had once contained major criminal investigation records.

Not the most sensitive ones. Those were stored elsewhere.

But important cases often passed through C before being reclassified or transferred.

Malik entered alone.

The overhead lights activated in sections as he walked.

Click.

Hum.

Light.

Darkness ahead.

Click.

Hum.

Light.

He passed aisle eleven.

Fourteen.

Seventeen.

By aisle nineteen, he had begun remembering things he would rather have forgotten.

A superintendent named Harun Ismail standing at the counter after midnight.

Rainwater on his shoulders.

A cardboard evidence box in his hands.

A voice lower than usual.

Malik, if anyone asks, this box never came through here.

Malik had laughed because he thought Harun was joking.

Harun had not laughed.

That had been thirty-two years ago.

Malik stopped.

Shelf 19-C.

The box was there.

At first he felt relief.

Then he lifted it.

Too light.

Files developed weight over time.

Not physical weight alone.

The thickness of correspondence.

Statements.

Evidence inventories.

Authorisation forms.

Copies of copies.

Seventeen-Ninety-Four had once required two hands.

This box could be carried with two fingers.

Malik placed it on the metal worktable beneath the aisle light.

The cardboard lid had been replaced.

The original boxes from 1994 were brown. This one was grey.

A modern barcode label showed the correct case number.

He opened it.

Six sheets of paper.

That was all.

A closure memorandum.

Two administrative notices.

A retention review.

A transfer slip.

An unsigned destruction authorisation.

And a final sheet stating:

NO MATERIAL EVIDENTIARY VALUE REMAINING

Malik read the sentence twice.

Then again.

Someone had emptied the file.

Not recently.

The paper inside had yellowed at different rates. The transfer slip was dated eighteen years earlier.

He lifted everything out.

Nothing beneath.

He ran his hand along the bottom of the box.

Cardboard.

Then stopped.

There was a slight rise beneath the inner fold.

Malik pushed his thumb against it.

Something had been placed between the base and the reinforced lining.

His breathing changed.

He checked the aisle.

Empty.

He pulled a small steel ruler from the stationery cup on the table and worked it beneath the cardboard seam.

The lining lifted.

A single folded sheet lay underneath.

No letterhead.

No stamp.

Handwritten.

Malik knew the handwriting before he finished unfolding it.

Harun Ismail had written his capital letters slightly forward, as though every word was leaning toward the next.

There was only one sentence.

They don’t control people. They control what people are afraid to lose.

Below it:

H.I.

Malik did not move.

Somewhere deep inside the annex, a metal door closed.

The sound travelled through the building.

He looked toward the end of the aisle.

Nothing.

He folded the note and slipped it into his shirt pocket.

Then the lights went out.

Not one section.

All of them.

The ventilation system stopped.

The sudden silence was so complete Malik could hear rainwater moving through the pipes inside the wall.

He stood perfectly still.

"Hello?"

His own voice sounded foolish.

No answer.

Then—

a footstep.

Not close.

A shoe against concrete.

Malik's fingers tightened around the edge of the table.

Another step.

From the cross-aisle beyond the shelves.

He considered calling out again.

Did not.

At sixty-seven, he no longer believed courage required announcing your location.

He reached for his phone.

The screen illuminated his face.

No signal.

Another footstep.

Closer.

Malik switched off the screen.

Darkness returned.

He smelled something.

Rain.

Someone had entered recently from outside.

Wet clothing carried its own smell.

The footsteps stopped.

Malik could feel rather than see that someone was standing at the far end of the aisle.

He waited.

His heart beat hard enough to hurt.

Then emergency lights flickered on.

Dim amber lamps appeared along the ceiling.

Aisle nineteen was empty.

Malik stared toward the cross-passage.

No one.

He looked down.

The box was gone.

He had not heard it move.

The table held only the ruler and the six loose administrative sheets.

Malik stepped backward.

He almost knocked over the chair.

His first thought was to find Salina.

His second was not to.

He walked quickly toward the exit.

Not running.

Running invited attention.

Old habits remained useful.

At the archive door, the access panel was dark.

He pushed.

The door opened.

Inspector Salina was no longer at the counter.

Neither was anyone else.

Malik crossed the corridor and left through the main doors.

The young guard at the front gate was talking on his phone.

He looked up.

“Finished, Encik?”

Malik opened his umbrella.

“Yes.”

“Find what you needed?”

Malik looked at him.

The boy's expression was ordinary.

Perhaps genuinely so.

"No."

He walked into the rain.

Inside his car, Malik locked all four doors.

His hands were shaking.

He hated that more than the fear.

He took the handwritten note from his pocket.

Still there.

He read it one final time.

Then he removed his phone and scrolled through contacts that had survived three devices and two retirements.

The number had no name.

Only three initials.

He had not called it for eleven years.

Malik pressed dial.

One ring.

Two.

A click.

No greeting.

Malik watched rain crawl down the windscreen.

"It's me."

Silence.

He swallowed.

"Someone is looking for Seventeen-Ninety-Four."

Nothing.

For several seconds he wondered if the connection had failed.

Then a man's voice answered.

Older than Malik remembered.

Still controlled.

"Who?"

Malik looked through the rain toward Annex 4.

Behind one of the upper windows, a figure stood beneath the emergency lighting.

Watching his car.

Malik's mouth went dry.

"I don't know."

The figure stepped away from the window.

Malik gripped the phone.

“But I think they found what Harun left behind.”

The line remained silent.

Then the voice said:

“Go home, Malik.”

“What?”

“Go home.”

“And the file?”

A pause.

“There is no file.”

Malik looked at the handwritten sentence in his hand.

Before he could reply, the call ended.

For a long moment he sat in the dark car.

Then he folded Harun’s note into four equal parts and placed it inside his wallet, behind a photograph of his grandchildren.

He started the engine.

As Malik drove out through the gate, he did not notice the black sedan parked beneath the trees across the road.

Its headlights remained off.

It waited until he turned onto the main road.

Then followed.

CHAPTER ONE

THE RETIREMENT

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Dato' Rahman Aziz had attended enough retirement ceremonies to know that almost everything said at them was true and almost nothing was complete.

Thirty-five years of service became twelve minutes behind a lectern.

Mistakes disappeared.

Enemies became colleagues.

Arguments became challenges overcome.

Decisions that had destroyed friendships were described as moments of leadership.

And men who had spent half their careers complaining about the service inevitably stood beneath the crest of the Malaysian National Police Service and declared that wearing the uniform had been the greatest honour of their lives.

Perhaps it was.

Contradictions did not automatically make people liars.

Rahman stood beneath the covered grandstand at MNPS headquarters with his hands behind his back and watched Deputy Commissioner Idris Hamzah deliver his final speech.

The morning rain had ended an hour earlier.

Heat now rose from the parade ground in visible waves.

Rows of officers stood beneath the white sky, ceremonial uniforms immaculate despite the humidity. Blue tunics. Polished shoes. Medals catching the sun. Flags moved lazily in air too heavy to deserve the word breeze.

Beyond the compound walls, Kota Aruna went about its morning.

Motorcycles filtered between cars.

Construction cranes turned slowly above new towers.

Somewhere outside the gates, someone was probably reporting a stolen phone, someone else was being arrested, and an investigating officer who had been awake since yesterday was trying to convince a printer to work.

Inside the compound, a string quartet played.

Rahman had always found that amusing.

Institutions possessed extraordinary confidence in music.

“Dato’.”

He turned.

Inspector Imran Taib stood half a step behind him, rigid enough to appear physically uncomfortable.

Rahman looked at his collar.

One side sat slightly higher than the other.

“Your uniform.”

Imran froze.

“Sir?”

“Collar.”

The young constable—no, inspector now, Rahman reminded himself—adjusted it immediately.

“Thank you, sir.”

“You’ve been promoted. You don’t need to look frightened anymore.”

Imran attempted a smile.

“Yes, sir.”

Rahman looked back toward the podium.

“You can start tomorrow.”

Imran’s smile became real.

He moved away.

On stage, Idris was thanking his wife for thirty-four years of patience.

That part, Rahman thought, was probably the truest thing anyone had said all morning.

He shifted his weight.

His left knee had started reminding him about age two years earlier and had since become increasingly committed to the argument.

He ignored it.

A camera shutter clicked nearby.

Rahman resisted the instinct to look away.

His dislike of photographs had become public knowledge decades ago, which unfortunately meant photographers treated getting one as a professional challenge.

“Smile.”

Rahman turned his head.

Datuk Farid Kamal stood beside him.

At sixty-six, Farid still wore a ceremonial uniform as though it had been tailored around his posture. His silver hair was cut short. His expression carried the relaxed amusement of a man who rarely appeared hurried because he had learned long ago that making other people wait was its own form of authority.

“I am smiling,” Rahman said.

Farid looked at him.

“No. That is the face you use when prosecutors ask for another week.”

“I have only one face.”

“Your wife tells me otherwise.”

Rahman gave him a look.

Farid smiled.

There were officers who demanded respect by announcing rank.

Farid had never needed to.

He was one of those men who caused a room to lower its voice when he entered.

Not from fear.

Attention.

Rahman had admired that quality when he was younger.

Perhaps he still did.

On the parade ground, Idris reached the portion of his speech about integrity.

Farid’s smile faded slightly.

“Here it comes.”

Rahman glanced at him.

“You’ve heard it before?”

“We all give the same speech eventually.”

“I won’t.”

Farid turned.

“You’re not planning to retire?”

“I said I won’t give the speech.”

"That sounds like something a man says shortly before giving the speech."

Rahman almost answered.

Then Idris said his name.

"—and officers like Dato' Rahman Aziz remind us that integrity is not an idea printed on the wall. It is something an officer carries every day."

Applause rolled across the grandstand.

Rahman's jaw tightened.

Several people turned toward him.

Farid clapped.

Slowly.

With evident enjoyment.

Rahman looked at him.

Farid leaned closer.

"One of the last men who still believes the uniform means something."

Rahman waited until the applause died.

"That's not what he said."

"It's what everyone heard."

Rahman watched Idris continue speaking.

He disliked public praise for the same reason he disliked accusations without evidence.

Both created versions of a man other people expected him to become.

"Reputation," Farid said quietly, "is dangerous."

Rahman glanced sideways.

"Why?"

"Eventually people expect you to live up to it."

There was humour in Farid's eyes.

But something else too.

Rahman could not identify it.

Before he could ask, the ceremony moved into its final sequence.

The guard commander called the parade to attention.

Hundreds of boots struck the ground together.

The sound crossed the square like one enormous door closing.

Rahman felt it in his chest.

There had been a time, long ago, when that sound had filled him with uncomplicated pride.

Twenty-three years old.

New uniform.

His father's hands adjusting his collar at a bus station in Seri Merbau.

If you cannot change the world, don't become another source of its damage.

Rahman had remembered the sentence for thirty-five years.

The older he became, the less simple it sounded.

The receiving line after the ceremony took forty minutes.

Rahman shook hands with retired commissioners, state commanders, ministers' representatives, businessmen, former officers, widows, journalists and people whose exact relationship to the institution was never explained but who somehow attended everything.

He smiled when necessary.

Nodded when appropriate.

Accepted three invitations to lunch he would never attend.

Near the end, Hana appeared beside the press enclosure.

Rahman recognised his daughter before she raised a hand.

She was wearing a cream blouse, dark trousers and the expression she used when professionally pretending not to be related to him.

He excused himself from a former director and walked over.

"You're working?"

"Unfortunately."

"At a retirement ceremony?"

"Government editor thinks important people say important things when they're emotional."

"Has he attended many retirement ceremonies?"

"He has people like me for that."

Hana leaned forward and kissed his cheek.

The photographer beside her immediately lifted his camera.

Rahman stared at him.

The camera lowered.

Hana laughed.

"You know that only makes them want the picture more."

"He has enough pictures."

"He has none of you behaving like a human being."

"Then he should photograph somebody else."

She looked toward the stage.

"Uncle Idris looks happy."

"He is."

"You believe him?"

"He retired."

"That isn't what I asked."

Rahman studied her.

At twenty-four, Hana had inherited Mariam's ability to make ordinary questions sound like cross-examination.

It was one reason she had become a journalist.

One reason Rahman had spent the last three years pretending he was comfortable with it.

"Your mother coming?" he asked.

"Changing subject."

"Answering a different question."

"Police training?"

"Marriage."

Hana smiled.

"She'll be here for lunch."

Then the journalist returned.

"Is it true there'll be senior command changes before the end of the year?"

"No."

"No meaning it isn't true or no meaning you're not answering?"

"Yes."

"Abah."

Rahman smiled despite himself.

There were few people in the country permitted to sound irritated while calling him that.

His secure phone vibrated inside his jacket.

One short pulse.

He ignored it.

Hana saw.

"Work?"

"It usually is."

"You're at somebody else's retirement ceremony and they still can't leave you alone?"

"The criminals didn't receive the programme."

"That almost sounded like a joke."

"Don't tell anyone."

His phone vibrated again.

Two pulses this time.

Priority.

Rahman's attention shifted.

Hana noticed immediately.

The change was small, but she had grown up studying it.

"What happened?"

"Nothing."

"That face means something happened."

"I have one face."

"Uncle Farid says otherwise."

Rahman stared at her.

Hana grinned.

He reached inside his jacket.

Before he could remove the phone, a movement beyond her shoulder caught his attention.

Across the parade ground, near the visitors' gate, an old man stood alone.

Grey shirt.

Dark trousers.

No tie.

No medal ribbon.

No visitor lanyard that Rahman could see.

He was perhaps seventy.

Perhaps older.

Distance made age uncertain.

But there was nothing uncertain about the direction of his gaze.

The old man was looking directly at Rahman.

"Abah?"

Rahman did not answer.

Something about the man's face disturbed him.

Not recognition exactly.

Recognition lived in memory.

This felt like memory searching for somewhere to land.

The eyes.

He had seen those eyes before.

A photograph?
An interview?
A file?
The old man tilted his head slightly.
Not greeting.
Acknowledgment.
Rahman stepped away from Hana.
“Wait here.”
“What?”
He crossed the edge of the parade ground.
A protocol officer moved toward him.
“Dato’, lunch is—”
“Later.”
Rahman kept walking.
The old man remained near the gate.
Thirty metres.
Twenty-five.
A group of officers passed between them.
Rahman shifted left.
When the officers cleared—
the man was gone.
Rahman stopped.
The visitors’ gate stood open behind two uniformed guards.
Outside, cars moved slowly along the access road.
No grey-haired man.
Rahman walked to the gate.
“Sir?”
The guard straightened.
“The elderly gentleman who was standing here.”
The guard looked confused.
“Which gentleman, Dato’?”
“Grey shirt. About seventy. He was here ten seconds ago.”
The two guards exchanged glances.
“One of the guests?”
“If I knew that, I wouldn’t be asking.”
The younger guard looked beyond the gate.
“No one went through just now, sir.”

Rahman stared at him.

"You're sure?"

"Yes, sir."

The second guard nodded.

Rahman looked toward the security cameras above the entrance.

"Who monitors those?"

"Control room, sir."

His phone vibrated again.

Three pulses.

Urgent.

Rahman took it out.

The device was separate from his normal phone, encrypted and issued only to designated senior commanders.

No caller identification.

Only text.

ORION ACTIVATED

Below it:

REPORT — SECURE OPERATIONS CENTRE 4

Then:

COMMAND AUTHORITY: DCP RAHMAN AZIZ

Rahman's expression changed.

He read it again.

ORION.

The name meant nothing to him.

That meant it meant something.

At his rank, operations did not usually arrive without context.

Especially operations giving him command authority.

A final line appeared.

NO ELECTRONIC ACKNOWLEDGEMENT. REPORT IN PERSON.

Hana had followed him halfway across the parade ground.

She stood waiting.

Farid was farther behind her, speaking with two retired officers.

Rahman looked toward him.

As if feeling the attention, Farid turned.

For half a second their eyes met.

Farid's face revealed nothing.

Then one of the retired officers said something and Farid looked away.

Rahman slipped the secure phone back into his jacket.

"Everything all right, Dato'?" the guard asked.

Rahman looked once more beyond the gate.

The old man was nowhere in sight.

"No."

The guard stiffened.

Rahman realised what he had said.

He corrected himself.

"Probably."

He walked back toward Hana.

She folded her arms.

"You just abandoned me in the middle of a sentence."

"You'll survive."

"That's very reassuring."

"I need to go."

Her irritation vanished.

"Where?"

"Office."

"Today?"

"Yes."

"What happened?"

Rahman hesitated.

Thirty-five years of instinct told him to say nothing.

He saw Mariam in his daughter then—not in her face, but in the way she waited without filling silence for him.

He chose the closest thing he could give her to honesty.

"I don't know yet."

Hana studied him.

That answer worried her more than secrecy would have.

"Abah—"

"I'll call your mother."

"You mean you'll message her four hours from now after she calls me asking where you are."

Rahman almost denied it.

Could not.

Hana sighed.

"Fine."

She touched his arm.

"Be careful."

It was an ordinary thing for a daughter to say.

But something in him tightened anyway.

He nodded.

Then walked away.

Secure Operations Centre 4 sat beneath an administrative building most officers at headquarters passed every day without noticing.

Rahman took the private lift down two levels.

The lift required a palm scan after the access card.

When the doors opened, an armed security officer checked his identity again.

That was unnecessary.

Which meant somebody wanted everyone entering to understand the seriousness of what waited inside.

Rahman surrendered both phones.

A technician placed them inside a sealed cabinet.

"Any watch with wireless capability, Dato'?"

Rahman held up his wrist.

Old mechanical watch.

The technician smiled.

"One advantage of age."

Rahman looked at him.

The smile disappeared.

"Sorry, Dato'."

Rahman continued down the corridor.

A reinforced door opened.

Inside was a windowless operations room dominated by screens and one long table.

Five people were already seated.

Rahman recognised two.

SAC Razak Salleh from Internal Integrity.

Inspector Daniel Lim from the Digital Threats Centre, though Rahman knew him more by reputation than personally.

Daniel was younger than expected, wearing a jacket that looked as if it had been retrieved from the back seat of a car five minutes earlier.

Next to him sat a woman Rahman had seen in disciplinary briefings.

Inspector Nur Aisyah Othman.

She looked at Rahman without the automatic deference he was accustomed to receiving from junior officers.

Interesting.

Two others sat farther down the table.

An Organised Crime Directorate superintendent.

A senior financial investigator.

No one was talking.

At the far end stood Farid Kamal.

Rahman stopped.

Farid had removed his ceremonial jacket.

His sleeves were rolled once at the wrist.

The relaxed amusement from the parade ground had disappeared.

“Close the door,” Farid said.

The security officer behind Rahman did.

Locks engaged.

Farid waited.

Then touched a control.

The central screen illuminated.

A photograph appeared.

A man lying beside an open car door.

Blood beneath his head.

MNPS identification card on the ground.

Rahman recognised him.

Inspector Hafiz Rashid.

Organised Crime Directorate.

Dead eight months.

Officially killed during a robbery investigation.

Farid changed the image.

A woman appeared.

Passport photograph.

Rahman did not recognise her.

“Protected witness,” Farid said. “Missing for eleven months.”

Another image.

A warehouse.

Burned.

Another.

A bank transfer network.

Another.

An evidence inventory.

Three items marked missing.

Then Farid displayed a photograph of an empty apartment.

On a table inside it sat six cups of coffee.

Still steaming when police arrived.

Rahman stared at the picture.

Something moved inside his memory.

Warm food.

Running fans.

A cigarette burning in an ashtray.

An empty warehouse decades earlier.

Harun standing beside him.

Now you understand.

Farid switched off the screen.

“The official position,” he said, “is that these cases are unrelated.”

No one moved.

Farid looked around the table.

“The official position is wrong.”

Rahman sat slowly.

Daniel opened his laptop.

Aisyah remained perfectly still.

Farid continued.

“Over fourteen months, three operations involving organised crime, financial investigations and protected intelligence failed shortly before execution. In each case, the target changed behaviour after the operational plan had been finalised.”

Rahman said, “A leak.”

Farid looked at him.

“That was the original assumption.”

"Was?"

Daniel spoke for the first time.

"Because it's worse than that."

Rahman turned toward him.

Daniel rotated the laptop.

A series of access logs filled the screen.

User accounts.

Time stamps.

Document IDs.

"Three different operations," Daniel said. "Three different teams. Three different command structures."

He tapped the screen.

"The same thing happened in all three."

"What?"

"Somebody accessed information they weren't supposed to know existed."

Rahman studied the logs.

"Same account?"

"No."

"Same terminal?"

"No."

"Same department?"

"No."

Rahman looked at him.

Daniel leaned back.

"That would have been easier."

Silence settled over the room.

Rahman felt Harun's voice again, thirty years old and perfectly clear.

The thief outside the station worries me less than the man who can rewrite what happened after we arrest him.

Farid placed both hands on the table.

"The Inspector-General authorised a compartmentalised task force forty-eight hours ago."

The screen changed.

One word appeared.

ORION

Rahman looked at Farid.

"Why me?"

Farid held his gaze.

"Because if we are right, the people you're investigating may include police officers."

Nobody spoke.

"And," Farid continued, "because until we know otherwise, everyone with access to this room is a potential source of compromise."

Rahman's eyes moved slowly around the table.

Razak.

Daniel.

Aisyah.

The superintendent.

The financial investigator.

Farid.

Then himself.

Aisyah broke the silence.

"Does that include command?"

Farid looked at her.

"Yes."

"Does that include you?"

A fraction of a pause.

"Yes."

Aisyah nodded once.

Rahman noticed Farid watching her.

Farid turned back to him.

"ORION needs a commander."

Rahman looked again at the photographs on the darkened screen.

A dead officer.

A missing witness.

Evidence that had disappeared.

An operation that had arrived too late.

The past had a habit of changing clothes and pretending to be new.

Rahman thought of the grey-haired man at the visitors' gate.

Those eyes.

A face he could almost remember.

Then Daniel spoke quietly.

"Dato'."

Rahman looked at him.

Daniel pointed to the access logs.

“Someone knew.”

Rahman studied the screen for another moment.

Then he pulled the nearest file toward him.

“Then we start there.”

Outside, somewhere above two floors of concrete, the retirement lunch began without him.

And in a parking area across the road from MNPS headquarters, a black sedan pulled away from the kerb and disappeared into Kota Aruna traffic.

CHAPTER TWO

THE BOY FROM MERBAU

SERI MERBAU — 1991

The bus to Kota Aruna was scheduled to leave at six-forty in the morning.

By six-fifteen, Aziz had already checked his son's ticket four times.

Rahman noticed but said nothing.

His father had never been a man who admitted to nervousness. He disguised it as preparation.

Ticket.

Wallet.

Identity card.

Offer letter.

Two white shirts.

Black shoes.

Prayer cap.

Toothbrush.

The brown envelope containing every official document anyone had told them might possibly be required.

Everything had been checked the night before.

Then again before Subuh.

Then once more after breakfast.

Now Aziz stood beside the old intercity bus at Seri Merbau station, holding the ticket as though he personally intended to inspect the driver before allowing the vehicle to leave.

"You put the letter in the bag?"

"Yes, Abah."

"Not the big bag."

"The small one."

"Why?"

“You told me to keep it with me.”

Aziz considered this.

“Good.”

Rahman smiled.

His father saw it.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“You’re laughing.”

“No.”

“I know your face.”

Rahman looked away before the smile grew.

The bus station was waking around them.

Engines coughed to life beneath corrugated roofs.

A newspaper seller arranged bundles on a wooden table.

Someone dragged a crate of bottled drinks across the concrete.

From the food stall at the far end came the smell of fried mee and kopi thick with condensed milk.

The morning sky above Seri Merbau was still colourless.

Rahman had lived twenty-three years beneath that sky.

He had imagined leaving many times.

University.

Government service.

Kuala Lumpur.

Anywhere larger than the town where everybody seemed to know who his father was before they knew who he was.

Now that the bus was waiting, he felt an unexpected desire for it to leave without him.

His mother had refused to come to the station.

She had said there was no point crying in public when she could do it properly at home.

Rahman had laughed.

She had not.

His younger sister had made him promise to bring back something from the city.

She had not specified what.

Only something “city.”

Rahman had no idea what that meant.

His father checked the time.

Six-twenty.

“You should board early.”

“The bus isn’t leaving yet.”

“Better to wait inside than run outside.”

Rahman picked up the smaller bag.

Aziz took the larger one before he could.

“I can carry it.”

“I know.”

His father carried it anyway.

They moved toward the luggage compartment.

Rahman watched him lift the suitcase.

Aziz had worked as a schoolteacher for thirty-one years and still dressed as if an inspector might arrive unannounced at any moment.

Long-sleeved shirt.

Dark trousers.

Belt polished.

Hair combed straight back.

He had never earned much money.

But Rahman had never once seen him leave the house looking careless.

Aziz believed dignity was a form of discipline.

He believed most things were forms of discipline.

When the suitcase had been loaded, the two men stood beside the bus.

Rahman waited for advice.

His father had been giving advice for the last two weeks.

Wake early.

Don’t borrow money.

Don’t sign anything you don’t understand.

Never be rude to clerks because clerks remember things officers forget.

If a senior officer offers food, eat.

If a senior officer offers money, ask why.

Write to your mother.

Pray even when tired.

Especially when tired.

Rahman expected one final list.

Instead Aziz reached up and adjusted his son's collar.

Rahman immediately felt twelve years old.

"Abah."

"It's crooked."

"It isn't."

"It was."

Aziz flattened the cloth with two fingers.

Then stepped back.

For several seconds he said nothing.

The station noise seemed to move around them.

A driver called out destinations.

A baby started crying.

Somebody laughed loudly near the ticket counter.

Aziz looked at his son.

Rahman suddenly realised how old his father looked.

Not elderly.

Not yet.

But older than he had seemed the day before.

"Listen to me," Aziz said.

Rahman nodded.

"If you cannot change the world, don't become another source of its damage."

Rahman waited for the rest.

There was none.

"That is all?"

"That is enough."

"You've been talking for two weeks."

"And you remember none of it."

"I remember."

"Then good."

The bus conductor called passengers aboard.

Aziz held out his hand.

Rahman looked at it.

For a moment the gesture seemed too formal between father and son.

Then he took it.

His father's grip was strong.

"Do your work properly," Aziz said.

"Insha-Allah."

"And don't come home talking like people from the city."

Rahman laughed.

His father released his hand.

"That is not a joke."

Rahman climbed aboard.

He found his seat near the middle.

Through the glass he saw Aziz standing exactly where he had left him.

The bus engine deepened.

Rahman lifted one hand.

His father did the same.

The bus pulled away.

Seri Merbau slid past the window.

The station.

The row of old shophouses.

The mosque dome.

The bicycle shop.

The road leading toward his school.

Then the town disappeared behind rubber trees and morning mist.

Rahman settled back into his seat.

He repeated his father's sentence silently.

Not because he fully understood it.

Because he did not want to forget it.

* * *

The training centre was larger than Rahman had expected.

Everything seemed to have been designed to remind recruits that individual importance ended at the gate.

Blocks of identical buildings.

Identical bunks.

Identical uniforms.

Identical instructions delivered by people who appeared to regard lateness as a moral defect.

Rahman arrived at twelve minutes past three.

By three-twenty, he had been shouted at twice.

The first time because he stood in the wrong line.

The second because he corrected the first mistake too slowly.

He decided this was efficient.

By evening, he knew the names of six men in his dormitory.

By the following morning, he remembered four.

There was Suresh from Klang, who had studied accounting and spoken confidently about becoming an investigating officer despite not yet knowing how to polish his boots.

Jalil from Terengganu, whose father and two uncles were policemen and who therefore behaved as if policing were an inherited disease.

Lee Chong Wei—not the badminton player, he explained immediately, though the famous athlete was still a child at the time—from Penang, who possessed an extraordinary ability to fall asleep within seconds of lights out.

And Marzuki from Sabah, who laughed at almost everything.

Rahman spoke little.

He watched.

He had always watched.

At school his teachers mistook silence for shyness.

His father knew better.

“You are collecting things,” Aziz once told him.

Rahman had asked what things.

His father replied, “Everything.”

The training centre gave him more than enough to collect.

Which instructors enjoyed humiliation.

Which recruits complained when supervisors were absent.

Who borrowed money.

Who returned it.

Who polished only the visible parts of their shoes.

Who moved quickly when officers were watching and slowly when they were not.

The details seemed insignificant.

Rahman remembered them anyway.

Three weeks into the programme, selected recruits were sent for an introductory criminal-investigation attachment.

Rahman had requested it.

So had nearly everyone else.

The phrase criminal investigation sounded important.

It sounded like detectives.

Murders.

Robberies.

Interrogations.

The kind of policing newspapers wrote about.

Instead, their first morning involved chairs.

Forty-eight recruits sat in a lecture room beneath fans that moved warm air from one side of the ceiling to the other.

A whiteboard stood at the front.

No projector.

No photographs.

No evidence table.

Rahman wondered if they were in the wrong room.

At eight precisely, a man entered carrying one file.

He looked to be in his mid-forties.

Medium height.

Lean.

No dramatic presence.

Nothing about him suggested the kind of officer recruits would imitate.

He placed the file on the desk and looked at the room.

Nobody spoke.

The nameplate on his uniform read:

HARUN ISMAIL

Superintendent.

He did not introduce himself.

Instead he picked up a marker and wrote one question on the board.

WHAT DOES A CRIMINAL LOOK LIKE?

The recruits waited.

Harun turned.

“Well?”

A hand went up.

“A suspicious person, sir.”

Harun nodded.

“What does a suspicious person look like?”

The recruit hesitated.

“Someone behaving strangely.”

“Define strangely.”

No answer.

Another recruit tried.

“Someone avoiding police, sir.”

“Most sensible criminals avoid police.”

A few recruits smiled.

Harun did not.

Suresh raised his hand.

“Someone nervous, sir.”

“Nervous people commit crimes?”

“No, sir.”

“Then why are you all nervous?”

Laughter spread through the room.

Harun waited for it to die.

He pointed toward one recruit in the front row.

“What does a murderer look like?”

The recruit froze.

“Sir?”

“A murderer.”

“Dangerous.”

“How?”

The recruit had nothing.

Harun walked slowly along the first row.

“A thief?”

Silence.

“A corrupt officer?”

The room became still.

Harun looked at them one by one.

“A terrorist?”

Nobody answered now.

He returned to the board.

Then beneath the question he wrote:

LIKE EVERYONE ELSE.

He capped the marker.

“Most of the time.”

That was the first thing Superintendent Harun Ismail ever taught Rahman.

And for reasons Rahman could not explain, it stayed with him.

Harun leaned against the desk.

“If criminals looked like criminals, your work would be very easy.”

A few recruits smiled.

“If liars sweated every time they lied, investigation would be very easy.”

He glanced around.

“If honest people always told the truth, investigation would be very easy.”

The smiles disappeared.

“None of those things happen.”

He picked up the file.

“Your job is not to decide who looks guilty.”

He dropped it onto the desk.

“You collect facts.”

The sound echoed through the room.

“You test them.”

He tapped the file.

“You test them again.”

Another tap.

“And after that, if you are still lucky, you might understand what happened.”

A recruit raised his hand.

“Sir, what if you already know who did it?”

Harun looked at him.

“Then you are dangerous.”

The room went quiet.

Rahman felt himself sit slightly straighter.

Harun continued.

“Knowing and proving are not the same thing. Believing and knowing are not the same thing. A confession and the truth are not always the same thing.”

He let that settle.

“Your first enemy in an investigation is not the suspect.”

He tapped one finger against his temple.

“It is the story you have already decided to believe.”

Rahman wrote that down.

He did not know then that he would remember the sentence thirty-five years later without needing the notebook.

* * *

Two days later, Harun took twelve recruits outside for an observation exercise.

No guns.

No arrests.

No criminals.

He led them to a busy commercial street and stopped near a coffee shop.

"You have three minutes," he said.

"To do what, sir?" Jalil asked.

Harun pointed at the street.

"Look."

That was all.

Cars moved past.

Motorcycles filled gaps between them.

A delivery van stopped illegally near a pharmacy.

Two schoolboys shared an iced drink.

An elderly Chinese man unlocked a hardware shop.

A woman carrying plastic bags crossed between parked cars.

Rahman watched.

Three minutes passed.

Harun checked his watch.

"Done."

He led them into an empty room above the coffee shop.

Then began asking questions.

"How many motorcycles were parked outside the clinic?"

Recruits guessed.

"Colour of the delivery van?"

White.

Blue.

Grey.

Arguments.

"What was the hardware-shop owner's shirt?"

Nobody knew.

"What number was on the taxi that stopped at the traffic light?"

Silence.

Harun moved through the questions without expression.

Then he looked at Rahman.

"How many people entered the pharmacy?"

"Four."

Harun said nothing.

"One old woman. Two men together. Then a woman with a green umbrella."

Harun nodded.

"What colour was the taxi?"

"Red and white."

"Number?"

Rahman paused.

"Four-three-seven-one."

Suresh turned toward him.

Harun's expression changed slightly.

"You wrote it down?"

"No, sir."

"You knew I would ask?"

"No."

"Then why remember it?"

Rahman considered the question.

Because it was there seemed like a foolish answer.

But it was the truth.

"It was there, sir."

Harun looked at him for several seconds.

Then he said:

"Most things are."

The others laughed lightly.

Harun did not.

He made a small mark beside Rahman's name on the sheet he was carrying.

Rahman saw him do it.

He pretended not to.

* * *

That evening, Suresh sat on the lower bunk polishing his shoes and said, “He likes you.”

Rahman looked up from the letter he was writing home.

“Who?”

“Superintendent Harun.”

“No.”

“He wrote something beside your name.”

“He wrote beside everybody’s name.”

“Not mine.”

“Maybe he doesn’t like you.”

Suresh considered this.

“Possible.”

From the next bed Marzuki laughed.

Suresh threw a polishing cloth at him.

Rahman went back to his letter.

He had started it three times.

The first version sounded too formal.

The second made training sound too easy.

The third made it sound too hard.

Finally he wrote:

Mak, Abah, I am well.

Then stopped.

He wanted to tell his father about Harun’s question.

What does a criminal look like?

He wanted to tell him about observation.

About facts.

About how a person could look at one street and somehow fail to see almost everything in it.

Instead he wrote:

Training is good. Food is okay. Do not worry.

He stared at the sentence.

Then added:

I remembered what Abah told me.

That was enough.

He folded the letter.

Across the room, recruits argued about whether they would rather work criminal investigations, narcotics or traffic.

Rahman listened.

For the first time since leaving Seri Merbau, he did not feel as though he had travelled somewhere temporary.

Something had begun.

He simply did not yet know what.

* * *

Harun called his name the following afternoon.

“Recruit Rahman.”

Rahman stopped outside the lecture room.

“Sir.”

Harun stood alone inside sorting files.

“Come.”

Rahman entered.

Harun handed him a sheet of paper.

A typed witness statement.

“Read it.”

Rahman did.

A shopkeeper reported seeing two men run from an alley shortly after midnight.

One wore a red shirt.

The other carried a bag.

Rahman finished.

Harun said, “What do you know?”

Rahman looked at the statement.

“Two men ran from an alley.”

“Do you?”

Rahman read again.

The witness said two men ran from an alley.

He corrected himself.

“We know the witness says he saw two men.”

Harun nodded.

“What else?”

“He says one wore red.”

Harun waited.

Rahman caught himself.

“He says one wore red.”

“Good.”
“The second had a bag.”
Harun waited again.
Rahman smiled slightly.
“He says the second had a bag.”
Harun took the page back.
“What time?”
“Shortly after midnight.”
“That is what the statement says.”
“Yes, sir.”
“What time did the witness see them?”
Rahman frowned.
“It doesn’t say exactly.”
“Then do you know?”
“No.”
Harun placed the statement on the desk.
“That’s investigation.”
Rahman looked at him.
Harun pointed at the sheet.
“Most people read that and start building two men in their heads.”
He raised two fingers.
“One red shirt. One bag. Midnight.”
He lowered his hand.
“Maybe every part is true.”
Then:
“Maybe none of it is.”
Rahman nodded.
Harun studied him.
“Why did you join?”
Rahman had expected questions about the statement.
“Police, sir?”
“No. Gardening.”
Rahman hesitated.
Harun waited.
“My father is a teacher.”
“That doesn’t answer the question.”
Rahman thought about it.

He had given better answers during recruitment interviews.
Public service.
Duty.
Stability.
Protecting society.
All true.
None felt sufficient now.
“I wanted work that mattered.”
Harun’s face gave nothing away.
“Everything matters to the person it happens to.”
Rahman absorbed that.
Harun collected his file.
“You are from Seri Merbau?”
“Yes, sir.”
“Small town.”
“Yes.”
“Good.”
Rahman was unsure why.
Harun moved toward the door.
Then stopped.
“People from small towns notice when something changes.”
He looked back.
“Don’t lose that.”
And left.
Rahman remained alone in the room.
On the desk lay the witness statement.
He read it again.
This time much more slowly.

* * *

Months later, when the training period ended and new officers received their postings, Rahman packed his belongings into the same suitcase his father had loaded onto the bus.

The suitcase looked older.
So did he.
Not physically.
Something subtler had changed.

He had entered training believing police work began when someone broke the law.

Now he understood that it often began much earlier.

A look.

A decision.

A lie.

A detail nobody thought mattered.

And sometimes it began afterward—

when people decided what the official version of an event would become.

On his final evening at the centre, Rahman walked past the investigation block.

The building was mostly dark.

One office light remained on.

Harun sat inside reading a file.

Rahman considered knocking.

He wanted to thank him.

For what, he wasn't sure.

Harun had not done anything dramatic.

He had not saved Rahman's life.

Had not given him a promotion.

Had not even been particularly kind.

He had simply taught him to look.

Rahman decided gratitude could wait.

There would be time.

He continued toward the dormitory.

Inside the office, unseen by Rahman, Harun turned to a fresh page in his notebook.

At the top he wrote:

RAHMAN AZIZ

Below it:

Observant. Patient. Does not rush to speak.

Harun paused.

Then added one final line.

Watch what he becomes.

He closed the notebook.

Outside, Rahman walked into the night believing the future was something waiting ahead of him.

He did not yet understand that some futures began long before a man recognised them.

And some followed him for the rest of his life.

CHAPTER THREE

THE FIRST ENVELOPE

KOTA ARUNA — 1992

The first bribe Rahman Aziz was ever offered did not look like a bribe.

It looked like an envelope.

Cream-coloured.

Unsealed.

Placed neatly beneath the corner of a police file as though it had always belonged there.

Rahman noticed it because the file had not been lying flat.

That was all.

No whispered offer.

No nervous glance.

No businessman leaning across a table and saying, Take this and make the problem disappear.

Nothing dramatic.

Just an envelope where no envelope had been before.

For several seconds Rahman stared at it.

Then he looked through the open office door.

Nobody was watching.

At least nobody appeared to be.

The district station was alive with the usual late-afternoon noise.

A telephone rang somewhere near the charge counter.

A typewriter struck paper in uneven bursts.

Two constables argued quietly over whose turn it was to collect food.

From outside came the sound of motorcycles starting beneath the covered parking area.

Rahman touched the envelope with one finger.

It was thick enough to contain money.

He already knew that.

He simply did not yet know what he was supposed to do with the knowledge.

“Something wrong?”

Rahman turned.

Sergeant Salleh Musa stood in the doorway holding two glasses of tea.

Salleh was forty-seven and had been in uniform longer than Rahman had been alive enough to remember things properly.

He had a broad face, patient eyes and the habit of carrying tea everywhere as though station work could not proceed without it.

Rahman pointed at the envelope.

Salleh looked.

Then at Rahman.

Then back at the envelope.

“What?”

“It wasn’t there before.”

Salleh entered the room and placed one glass beside Rahman.

“Maybe it walked.”

Rahman waited.

Salleh took a drink.

Rahman said, “It’s money.”

“You opened it?”

“No.”

“Then maybe it’s a letter.”

Rahman looked at him.

Salleh smiled.

“Open.”

Rahman pulled the envelope free.

Inside were several fifty-ringgit notes.

Not many.

Enough.

He counted without removing them completely.

Five hundred ringgit.

Nearly half a month’s salary.

He looked at Salleh.

The sergeant’s expression did not change.

“Who left it?”

Rahman asked.

“You tell me.”

“The businessman?”

Salleh shrugged.

Rahman knew which businessman.

Everyone in the station did.

Lim Kee Seng.

Forty-three.

Owner of two hardware shops, a transport company and, depending on who was speaking, either the most unlucky businessman in the district or a man remarkably comfortable operating close to stolen goods.

Three nights earlier a lorry carrying electrical equipment had been hijacked outside Kota Aruna.

The driver had been tied up and left beside a plantation road.

Half the cargo had disappeared.

Two days later, several boxes bearing matching serial numbers were discovered in a rented warehouse connected to one of Lim’s companies.

Lim denied knowing anything about them.

His warehouse supervisor denied knowing anything about them.

The supervisor’s assistant disappeared.

Nobody had yet been charged.

Rahman had spent most of that afternoon checking invoices.

He had expected police work to contain more danger.

It contained far more paper.

“Return it,” Rahman said.

Salleh lifted one eyebrow.

“To who?”

“Encik Lim.”

“He gave it to you personally?”

“No.”

“Did you see him put it there?”

“No.”

“Then how do you know it’s his?”

Rahman looked again at the money.

The logic irritated him.

Salleh saw that.

“Good,” the sergeant said.

“What?”

“You’re thinking.”

“I know where it came from.”

“No. You believe where it came from.”

Rahman thought immediately of Harun.

Knowing and proving are not the same thing.

He disliked hearing the same lesson from someone else.

“Then I’ll give it to the investigating officer.”

Salleh drank more tea.

“You can.”

Rahman waited.

“But?”

“No but.”

“There is always a but when you say it that way.”

Salleh smiled.

“You’ve been here four months and you already know me.”

Rahman folded the envelope closed.

“Where is Inspector Faizal?”

“Lunch.”

Rahman looked at the wall clock.

It was almost five.

Salleh followed his gaze.

“Long lunch.”

Rahman stood.

“I’ll put it in his drawer.”

“Don’t.”

The answer came quickly enough to stop him.

Rahman turned.

Salleh placed the tea down.

For the first time since entering, the older man’s face was completely serious.

“If you’re going to hand money to someone, hand it to him when he’s standing in front of you.”

“Why?”

Rahman stared at him.

Rahman understood.

Because once the envelope entered someone else's drawer, Rahman would no longer know what happened to it.

He sat again.

The envelope remained between them.

Five hundred ringgit.

It seemed to occupy far more space than paper should.

* * *

Rahman had met Lim Kee Seng that morning.

Lim arrived at eleven-twenty wearing a pale blue shirt with gold cufflinks.

He carried no briefcase.

His lawyer did.

Rahman had noticed that before anything else.

People who came to a police station with lawyers behaved differently from people who came alone.

Not necessarily guiltily.

Prepared.

Lim greeted everyone.

Not just senior officers.

Everyone.

The constable at the front desk.

The clerk.

Salleh.

Rahman.

He shook hands warmly and remembered names from his previous visit.

When someone remembered the name of the most junior officer in the room, Rahman had learned, there was usually a reason.

"Encik Rahman, yes?"

"Constable."

"Sorry, sorry. Constable Rahman."

Lim smiled.

"You were helping with my statement yesterday."

"Yes."

"Very hardworking."

Rahman did not know what response was expected.

So he nodded.

Inspector Faizal arrived several minutes later and invited Lim and his lawyer into the interview room.

The door remained closed for almost an hour.

Afterward, Lim emerged smiling.

He saw Rahman sorting warehouse invoices and approached.

“You haven’t eaten?”

Rahman looked at the clock.

“No.”

“Come. We go makan.”

“I have work.”

“Everyone has work.”

Lim laughed.

“I buy.”

“No, thank you.”

The answer seemed to surprise him.

Not offend.

Just surprise.

“You police cannot eat?”

“We can.”

“Then come.”

Rahman shook his head.

“I have work.”

Lim studied him for a moment.

Then smiled again.

“Next time.”

He walked away.

Later, food arrived anyway.

Four containers from a restaurant near the commercial district.

Fish.

Chicken.

Vegetables.

Rice.

Far more than the officers on duty had ordered.

Salleh opened the bags.

“Who ordered this?”

A constable at the counter said, “Lim.”

Several officers laughed.

Nobody appeared concerned.

Rahman did not eat.

Salleh noticed.

“Why?”

“He’s involved in the investigation.”

“So?”

Rahman stared at him.

Salleh took a piece of chicken.

“He sent food.”

“That doesn’t bother you?”

“It bothers me if the food is bad.”

Rahman did not laugh.

Salleh sighed.

“Rahman.”

“Yes?”

“If I eat his chicken, does that make the stolen televisions disappear?”

“No.”

“If the evidence is enough, does eating his chicken stop us arresting him?”

“No.”

“Then what exactly has he bought?”

Rahman had not known how to answer.

Now, hours later, looking at the envelope on the desk, he did.

Something.

Perhaps not an arrest.

Perhaps not yet.

Maybe only familiarity.

A sense that Lim was generous.

Friendly.

Helpful.

The kind of man who bought lunch.

The kind of man whose explanation deserved another listen.

Rahman looked at Salleh.

“Do you think lunch matters?”

Salleh considered him carefully.

“Yes.”

The answer surprised Rahman.

"You ate it."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because I was hungry."

Rahman frowned.

Salleh smiled again.

"You want the world to be simple very badly, don't you?"

Rahman said nothing.

"It isn't."

* * *

Inspector Faizal returned at five-thirty.

He was thirty-eight, recently promoted and already developing the slightly exhausted manner of a man convinced promotion had given him additional work without additional hours in the day.

Rahman followed him into his office.

"Sir."

Faizal dropped a stack of files onto his desk.

"If it's another invoice, tomorrow."

Rahman placed the envelope beside the files.

Faizal looked at it.

"What?"

"Someone left this on the investigation file."

"Someone?"

"I think Encik Lim."

Faizal looked up.

"You think?"

"I didn't see him leave it."

Faizal opened the envelope.

His expression did not change.

"How much?"

"Five hundred."

Faizal counted.

Then placed the notes back inside.

"Did you ask anyone?"

"Sergeant Salleh."

“Anyone else?”
“No.”
“Good.”
Rahman waited for Faizal to call Lim.
He did not.
Instead Faizal leaned back.
“Why do you think he left it?”
Rahman almost said because Lim was guilty.
But Harun’s training intervened.
“To influence us.”
“Us?”
“Me. The investigation.”
“How?”
“I don’t know.”
“Did he ask you to change anything?”
“No.”
“Destroy anything?”
“No.”
“Lose any evidence?”
“No.”
“Did he even mention the money?”
“No.”
Faizal tapped the envelope against the desk.
“What do you want me to do?”
“Return it.”
“To him.”
“Yes.”
“Why?”
Rahman stared.
“Because we can’t accept it.”
Faizal watched him for several seconds.
Then nodded.
“All right.”
He stood.
“Come.”
They found Lim outside near his car.
His lawyer had already left.

Lim was talking to another businessman when Faizal called his name.

"Encik Lim."

Lim turned.

"Inspector."

Faizal held out the envelope.

"This belongs to you?"

Lim looked at it.

His face changed so little Rahman might have imagined it.

"What is it?"

Faizal opened the envelope enough for the money to show.

Lim looked genuinely puzzled.

Or convincingly so.

"I don't know."

"It was left with one of our files."

Lim glanced at Rahman.

Then smiled.

"Ah."

Rahman felt his jaw tighten.

Lim took the envelope.

"Petrol."

Faizal said nothing.

"For the boys," Lim continued. "They've been going back and forth to the warehouse. Petrol, food. Small thing."

Faizal's voice remained pleasant.

"Don't."

Lim blinked.

"No offence."

"None taken."

"Just appreciation."

"Appreciate us by answering questions."

Silence.

Then Lim laughed softly.

"Inspector, you are very serious."

"So are stolen goods."

Lim slipped the envelope into his shirt pocket.

"Understood."

He turned toward Rahman.

“No hard feelings.”

Rahman said nothing.

Lim entered his Mercedes.

The car pulled away.

Faizal watched until it disappeared from the station yard.

Then he looked at Rahman.

“Well?”

“Well what, sir?”

“You returned it.”

“Yes.”

“You feel honest now?”

Rahman was not sure whether it was a joke.

“No.”

“Good.”

Faizal walked back toward the station.

Rahman followed.

At the entrance Faizal stopped.

“The envelope is easy.”

Rahman waited.

“The envelope is obvious.”

Faizal pointed toward the road where Lim’s car had disappeared.

“One day somebody will offer you something that doesn’t look like money.”

Rahman said nothing.

“A favour.”

Faizal held up one finger.

“A better posting.”

Another.

“Help for a relative.”

Another.

“Information you desperately need.”

His hand lowered.

“Maybe all they ask is that you remember them kindly.”

Rahman listened.

“That is harder.”

Faizal went inside.

Rahman remained outside.

The evening call to prayer began somewhere beyond the station compound.

For a moment he stood listening.

Then he followed.

* * *

The investigation continued for another six weeks.

Rahman expected Lim to complain.

He did not.

Expected him to avoid the station.

He did not.

Expected hostility.

Instead, Lim became friendlier.

He greeted Rahman every time.

Never mentioned the envelope again.

The evidence against him remained incomplete.

Several warehouse workers contradicted one another.

The missing assistant was not found.

Invoices showed irregularities but not enough to establish that Lim personally knew the goods were stolen.

Eventually prosecutors approved charges against the warehouse supervisor and two other men.

Not Lim.

Rahman read the recommendation twice.

Then carried it into Inspector Faizal's office.

"Sir."

Faizal looked up.

"Don't tell me there's another envelope."

Rahman put down the report.

"Why isn't Lim charged?"

"Because we don't have enough."

"He owns the warehouse."

"That isn't a crime."

"The company is his."

"Still not a crime."

"The stolen goods were there."

"Which helps us prove stolen goods were in his warehouse."

Rahman felt irritation rising.

"He knew."

Faizal leaned back.

"Show me."

Rahman pointed at the file.

"Everything is there."

"Then show me where."

Rahman opened it.

Invoices.

Statements.

Warehouse records.

Vehicle entries.

Nothing said:

Lim Kee Seng knew.

Nothing proved he ordered the goods accepted.

Nothing proved he arranged the theft.

Nothing connected him directly to the hijacking.

Rahman hated the file in that moment.

Not because it was wrong.

Because it refused to become what he believed.

Faizal watched him.

"You think the envelope means he is guilty."

"It means he wanted something."

"Yes."

"What?"

"I don't know."

"Exactly."

Faizal leaned forward.

"Maybe he knew the goods were stolen."

Rahman waited.

"Maybe he didn't."

Faizal tapped the report.

"We charge what we can prove. Not what annoys us."

Rahman remembered Harun again.

Your first enemy in an investigation is the story you have already decided to believe.

He closed the file.

Faizal studied him.

“Still think returning the envelope was the important part?”

“Yes.”

Faizal shook his head.

“No.”

Rahman frowned.

“The important part is what happens after.”

“I don’t understand.”

Faizal stood and walked to the window.

Outside, officers moved through the compound.

“You refused five hundred ringgit.”

He turned.

“Good.”

Rahman waited.

“But now you’re angry because the evidence doesn’t give you the result you want.”

Faizal pointed at the file.

“If you change that report because you hate the man who tried to pay you, then the envelope still bought something.”

Rahman said nothing.

Faizal continued.

“It bought your judgment.”

That hit harder than Rahman expected.

“Integrity isn’t just refusing money.”

Faizal returned to his desk.

“It is refusing yourself when you become the problem.”

Rahman picked up the file.

At the door he stopped.

“Sir.”

“Yes?”

“Did you know he would not be charged when you returned the money?”

Faizal’s face became unreadable.

“I knew we didn’t have enough then.”

Rahman considered this.

“And you still returned it.”

Faizal almost smiled.

"Now you're learning."

* * *

That night Rahman sat alone at his desk after most officers had gone.

The stolen-goods file rested in front of him.

He read the statements again.

This time he tried to remove Lim Kee Seng from his mind.

Not excuse him.

Remove him.

What did the evidence actually say?

A lorry was stolen.

Goods appeared in a warehouse.

The warehouse supervisor had falsified an entry.

A vehicle connected to one suspect entered after midnight.

Lim's company owned the property.

Lim had attempted to give police money.

All true.

None automatically proved the next thing.

Rahman wrote a fresh summary.

He removed one sentence from his earlier draft:

It is believed Lim Kee Seng directed the receipt of stolen property.

There was no evidence for it.

Only suspicion.

His fingers hesitated above the typewriter.

Then he struck the keys.

Investigation continues into the knowledge and involvement of company ownership. No direct evidentiary link has yet been established.

He read the sentence.

He disliked it.

Which told him it was probably honest.

"Still here?"

Salleh stood beside the doorway.

Rahman pulled the page free.

"Finishing report."

Salleh walked closer.

"The famous envelope case."

Rahman looked at him.

"You knew?"

"The whole station knew five minutes after you found it."

Rahman stared.

Salleh shrugged.

"Police station."

He looked at the report.

"What happened?"

"No charge against Lim."

Salleh nodded.

"You angry?"

"A little."

"Good."

"Why does everyone keep saying that?"

"Anger tells you something matters."

Salleh pulled out a chair.

"Just don't let it write your report."

Rahman looked at him.

Maybe the station was full of philosophers pretending to be policemen.

Or policemen became philosophers after enough years because nothing else made the job bearable.

Salleh leaned back.

"You want to know something?"

Rahman waited.

"The first time someone offered me money, I refused."

Rahman was surprised.

"You sound shocked."

"No."

"You are."

Rahman smiled faintly.

Salleh continued.

"I was twenty-two."

"What happened?"

"I was very proud."

"Of refusing?"

"Yes."

Salleh's expression turned distant.

"I went home thinking I was a good man."

He rubbed his thumb across the rim of the tea glass.

"Six months later a friend asked me to check a vehicle registration for him."

Rahman listened.

"I checked."

"Why?"

"He was my friend."

"Was it illegal?"

"I wasn't supposed to do it."

"What happened?"

"Nothing."

Salleh smiled without humour.

"That was the dangerous part."

Rahman understood.

Nothing happened.

No money.

No punishment.

No dramatic consequence.

Only a line crossed so quietly nobody noticed.

Salleh stood.

"You refused five hundred today."

"It was six weeks ago."

"To an old man, that is today."

Rahman smiled.

Salleh walked toward the door.

Then stopped.

"You think people become corrupt because somebody hands them a bag of cash?"

Rahman did not answer.

Salleh shook his head.

"Sometimes."

He looked down the darkened corridor.

"Mostly they become corrupt one reasonable decision at a time."

He left.

Rahman sat alone.

The station had gone almost silent.

Outside, rain began tapping against the windows.

He took the revised report and placed it inside the file.

Then closed it.

For some reason his father's voice returned.

If you cannot change the world, don't become another source of its damage.

Rahman had always assumed his father meant obvious damage.

Cruelty.

Dishonesty.

Crime.

He was beginning to understand there were quieter kinds.

A favour that seemed harmless.

A meal nobody considered important.

An envelope explained as petrol money.

A sentence added to a report because an investigator was certain of something he could not prove.

He turned off the desk lamp.

Before leaving, he looked once more at the file.

The envelope was gone.

But the question it had left behind remained.

And years later, when men offered him things far more valuable than money, Rahman would remember that the first price ever placed on his integrity had been five hundred ringgit.

The frightening part was not that he had refused it.

The frightening part was how simple that refusal had been.

He had not yet encountered the difficult offers.

CHAPTER FOUR

ROOM 17

SERI MERBAU — 1993

The dead watch stopped at 10:17.

Rahman noticed it before he noticed the blood.

It lay beneath a wooden display cabinet inside the rear room of Kedai Emas San Lee, half hidden among shattered glass and loose receipts. The leather strap was broken. One hand pointed slightly past ten. The other rested between three and four.

10:17.

Rahman crouched beside it without touching.

Behind him, the shop owner sat against the wall with a towel pressed to the side of his head. Blood had soaked through the fabric and darkened the collar of his shirt.

His name was Chong Wai Mun.

Fifty-eight years old.

Goldsmith.

Married.

No serious criminal history.

No known enemies according to the first officer who had spoken to him.

The front shutters had been forced.

Two display cases were smashed.

Several trays of jewellery were missing.

The rear office looked as though somebody had searched it after becoming impatient.

Drawers open.

Documents scattered.

One chair overturned.

The safe stood open.

Inspector Faizal entered behind the photographer.

“What have you got?”

Rahman pointed beneath the cabinet.

“Watch.”

Faizal crouched.

“Victim’s?”

“Don’t know.”

“Photograph first.”

Rahman nodded to the photographer.

Three photographs.

Wide.

Closer.

Then one with evidence marker fourteen beside it.

Only after that did Rahman lift the watch with gloved fingers and place it inside a clear evidence bag.

“Time?” Faizal asked.

“Ten-seventeen.”

“What time did robbery happen?”

Rahman checked his notebook.

“Victim said around ten-thirty.”

Faizal looked at the watch.

“Maybe.”

That word again.

Rahman had come to dislike it.

He wrote:

ITEM 14 — WRISTWATCH — REAR OFFICE FLOOR — 22:17 DISPLAY

Faizal watched him.

“Don’t write that it stopped during the robbery.”

“I wasn’t.”

“You were thinking it.”

Rahman looked at him.

Faizal almost smiled.

“Thinking is free. Reports are expensive.”

Then he walked away.

* * *

Chong's first statement was taken at the clinic.

Sergeant Salleh sat beside the door while Faizal questioned him.

Rahman took notes.

"What time did they enter?" Faizal asked.

"Maybe ten-thirty."

"How many?"

"Three."

"You saw all three?"

"I think."

"What were they wearing?"

"Dark clothes."

"Masks?"

"Two."

"And the third?"

Chong touched the dressing near his temple.

"No mask."

"You saw his face?"

"A little."

"Recognise him?"

"No."

"Anything about him?"

Chong hesitated.

"Malay."

Rahman wrote it down.

Faizal continued.

"Where did they come from?"

"Back."

"Back door?"

"Yes."

Rahman's pen stopped.

At the scene, the obvious forced entry had been at the front shutters.

Faizal noticed the pause but did not look at him.

"Was the back door locked?"

"I don't remember."

"You normally lock it?"

"Yes."

"Tonight?"

"I think."
Faizal changed direction.
"What did they want?"
"Safe."
"They knew where it was?"
Chong looked down.
"Yes."
"How?"
"I don't know."
"What did they say?"
"Open."
"Anything else?"
"No."
Rahman looked at Chong.
Something was missing.
Not necessarily from the statement.
From the way he told it.
Fear did strange things to memory.
Sometimes it removed details.
Sometimes it sharpened them.
Sometimes it rearranged them into a version a person could live with.
Faizal placed a photograph of the broken watch on the table.
"Yours?"
Chong looked at it.
"No."
"Employee?"
"No."
"Recognise it?"
"No."
The answer came too quickly.
Rahman looked up.
Faizal said nothing.
He slid the photograph back into the file.

* * *

By the following morning, a typed statement had been placed inside the case file.

Rahman read it once.

Then again.

The wording bothered him.

He took out his notebook.

The statement said:

At approximately 2230 hours, three unknown male suspects entered the premises after forcing the front shutter.

Rahman looked at his notes.

Chong had said:

Back door.

The statement continued:

Victim was unable to observe any of the suspects sufficiently for identification.

Rahman read that line twice.

Chong had said one man was unmasked.

He had described him, however vaguely.

None of it appeared.

At the bottom:

Statement prepared by Constable Hamid Rahim.

Below that:

Supervised by Sergeant Salleh Musa.

Rahman carried the statement to the front counter.

Salleh was drinking tea.

Rahman put the paper in front of him.

“You supervised this?”

Salleh glanced at it.

“No.”

Rahman waited.

Salleh looked more carefully.

Then at the signature.

“That isn’t mine.”

“It looks like yours.”

“It looks like somebody trying to remember mine.”

Rahman felt a coldness beneath his ribs.

“When did you leave?”

“Two.”

“This says three-fifteen.”

Salleh put down his cup.
“Where is Hamid?”
“Night shift.”
“Home by now.”
Rahman took the statement.
“I’m calling Faizal.”
Salleh nodded.
No joke this time.

* * *

Hamid arrived less than an hour later.
He looked as though he had dressed in the dark.
Shirt untucked at one side.
Hair still wet.
Faizal closed the office door.
Rahman and Salleh remained inside.
The statement lay on the desk.
Faizal pointed.
“You prepared this?”
Hamid looked at it.
“Yes.”
“At three-fifteen this morning?”
“Yes.”
“Where?”
“Station.”
“Victim was here?”
A pause.
“Yes.”
Rahman watched his hands.
Still.
Too still.
Faizal asked again.
“Chong came here after the clinic?”
“Yes.”
“What time?”
Hamid swallowed.
“About three.”

Salleh said nothing.
Faizal turned the paper around.
“Who supervised?”
Hamid looked at the signature.
“Sergeant.”
“No,” Salleh said.
Hamid stared at him.
Salleh continued.
“I was home.”
The room became quieter.
Faizal’s voice did not change.
“Who signed it?”
“I don’t know.”
“You submitted it.”
Hamid looked at the floor.
“I was told the earlier statement wasn’t clear.”
“By who?”
No answer.
“Who told you?”
Hamid rubbed one thumb over the other.
“I can’t remember.”
Rahman knew immediately that was not true.
Faizal did too.
“Did Chong come to this station?”
Silence.
“Hamid.”
“No.”
The word was barely audible.
Rahman felt anger rise.
Faizal saw it and raised one hand.
Not yet.
“Then where did this statement come from?”
“I rewrote it.”
“Why?”
“The first notes were confusing.”
“You removed the description of the unmasked suspect.”
Hamid’s eyes moved toward Rahman.

Then away.
“Victim wasn’t sure.”
“Did the victim tell you that?”
No answer.
Faizal leaned forward.
“Did he?”
“No.”
The admission sat between them.
Salleh asked:
“Why put my signature?”
“I didn’t.”
“Then who did?”
“I don’t know.”
Rahman believed that part.
Or wanted to.
Hamid looked frightened now.
Not guilty.
Not exactly.
Frightened.
Faizal watched him.
“Is somebody asking you to change this case?”
Hamid shook his head.
Too quickly.
“No.”
“Are you taking money?”
“No.”
“Are you protecting someone?”
“No.”
Each answer came faster than the last.
Faizal pushed the statement away.
“Go outside.”
Hamid stood.
His hand reached the door.
Then stopped.
He looked back.
“The watch.”
Rahman straightened.

"What about it?"

Hamid's face changed.

"I'd check it."

"Check what?"

"Just make sure it's still there."

Rahman looked at Faizal.

"Why?"

Hamid stared at the floor.

"I don't know."

Then he opened the door and left.

* * *

Room 17 sat behind the station's rear corridor.

Officially it was the Temporary Property and Evidence Store.

Nobody called it that.

The painted number on the metal door had been retouched so many times that the white figures no longer matched.

Munusamy, the property officer, arrived with the keys.

Faizal held the evidence log.

"Item fourteen."

Munusamy checked.

"C-three."

The door opened.

The room smelled of dust, paper, old metal and plastic.

Shelves ran almost to the ceiling.

Evidence bags.

Boxes.

Sealed envelopes.

Property taken from people who had already forgotten the exact moment police removed it.

Rahman followed Munusamy to C-three.

Bag 12.

Bag 13.

Bag 15.

The space between them was empty.

Munusamy frowned.

"Where's fourteen?"

“That is what we’re asking,” Faizal said.
They searched adjacent shelves.
Nothing.
Rahman checked the log.
Item 14 had been received.
Seal number entered.
Time recorded.
Everything normal.
Except the evidence itself was gone.
Faizal said:
“Who came in here after one this morning?”
Munusamy retrieved the access ledger.
Three entries.
01:22 — Munusamy.
02:05 — duty officer.
04:10 — blank item reference.
The name beside the final entry belonged to Inspector Faizal.
Everyone looked at him.
“I was at home.”
Rahman studied the signature.
It was close.
Not exact.
Like Salleh’s.
Someone had created a paper trail.
Not a sophisticated one.
Just good enough to pass if nobody looked closely.
Faizal shut the ledger.
“Nobody enters this room until I say.”
Munusamy hesitated.
“What about evidence intake?”
“Use the secondary store.”
“This could take days.”
“Then it takes days.”
He locked the door.
Rahman stared at the number.
17.
A room full of evidence was supposed to represent certainty.

Objects did not forget.

Objects did not become afraid.

Objects did not change their stories.

But objects could disappear.

And once they did, paper could be made to explain almost anything.

* * *

Superintendent Harun arrived that afternoon.

Rahman had not seen him for months.

He looked the same.

Controlled.

Unhurried.

The kind of man whose stillness made everyone else feel noisy.

Faizal had requested assistance because the case now contained two separate problems:

the robbery,

and whatever had happened inside the station.

Harun listened as Rahman reconstructed the events.

The shop.

The watch.

Chong's statement.

Hamid's rewrite.

The false signatures.

The missing evidence.

He interrupted only once.

"Why does the watch matter?"

"It stopped at ten-seventeen."

"So?"

"Victim says robbery around ten-thirty."

"So?"

Rahman exhaled.

"It may show the timing is wrong."

"May."

"Yes."

"Anything else?"

"Fingerprints."

"Maybe."

"Blood."
"Maybe."
"Could identify whoever owns it."
"Maybe."
Rahman almost smiled despite himself.
Harun noticed.
"Something funny?"
"You like that word."
"You don't."
"No."
"You should."
"Why?"
"Because certainty makes investigators lazy."
Harun looked at the photograph.
"What do we know about the watch?"
Rahman thought carefully.
"That it was in the rear office when we processed the scene."
"Yes."
"It was entered as evidence."
"Yes."
"And now it's gone."
Harun nodded.
Rahman continued.
"So somebody thought it mattered."
Harun looked at him.
"Better."
He tapped the photograph.
"That is information."
"Someone being afraid of it?"
"Someone acting because of it."
Harun gathered the documents.
"You don't always begin by asking what evidence proves."
He looked toward the rear corridor.
"Sometimes you ask who is frightened by its existence."

* * *

Harun inspected Room 17 himself.

He examined the lock.
The shelf.
The access ledger.
He asked who held keys.
Who could request the spare.
Whether the corridor camera worked.
It did not.
“Since when?”
Munusamy looked embarrassed.
“Two months.”
“Repair order?”
“Submitted.”
“Once?”
“Twice.”
Harun nodded.
He did not say convenient.
Rahman thought it.
They sat at the small property desk.
Harun moved slowly through the ledger.
He stopped on another entry several weeks earlier.
“Hamid.”
Rahman leaned closer.
The constable’s name appeared beside a late-night access time.
No evidence item listed.
No supervising officer.
Faizal frowned.
“He shouldn’t have been here.”
Rahman said:
“You think he took something before?”
Harun looked at him.
“No.”
Rahman corrected himself.
“You think he entered.”
“Yes.”
“That isn’t the same thing.”
Something almost like approval crossed Harun’s face.
“No.”

He closed the ledger.

"Good."

The word irritated Rahman.

Harun stood.

"A room like this is supposed to be boring."

Salleh looked at him.

Harun continued.

"Once an evidence room becomes interesting, somebody has failed."

His eyes went to the shelves.

"Maybe the criminal."

Then to the men around him.

"Maybe us."

* * *

They questioned Hamid again after sunset.

This time Harun led.

No shouting.

No accusation.

He asked about procedure.

The evidence room.

The false statement.

Who asked him to rewrite it.

Hamid resisted everything.

Not aggressively.

Quietly.

"I made a mistake."

"What mistake?" Harun asked.

"I thought the original statement wasn't clear."

"So you invented one?"

"No."

"You changed facts."

"I thought they were wrong."

"Based on what?"

Hamid said nothing.

Harun let the silence sit.

Eventually:

"Are you afraid of someone?"

Hamid's eyes rose.
For one second Rahman saw something unmistakable.
Then it disappeared.
"No."
Harun did not challenge him.
"Did you take the watch?"
"No."
That answer was immediate.
Clean.
Harun watched him.
"Do you know who did?"
"No."
"Do you know why it matters?"
"No."
Another pause.
Then Hamid looked toward the door.
"I want a transfer."
Faizal frowned.
"What?"
"A transfer."
"Where?"
"Anywhere."
"Why?"
Hamid looked at Harun.
"I don't want this case."
Harun asked:
"Because you changed the statement?"
Hamid said nothing.
"Or because of whoever asked you to?"
Hamid's face closed.
He stood.
"I want a transfer."
"You don't get to walk out."
"I know."
"Sit."
Hamid sat.
But the interview was effectively over.

Whatever door had opened inside him had already shut.

* * *

Near midnight, Rahman copied the access-register pages Harun had marked.

The photocopier clicked and flashed.

One page.

Then another.

Then another.

Harun stood beside him drinking kopi.

“Why copies?” Rahman asked.

“Because we’re working from the original.”

“That doesn’t answer me.”

Harun looked at him.

“Files get moved.”

Rahman glanced toward Room 17.

“Evidence too.”

“Yes.”

“Do you think someone will alter the register?”

“I think keeping one copy costs almost nothing.”

Harun took the warm pages from the tray.

Rahman watched him place them inside an ordinary brown envelope.

Nothing secretive about it.

Nothing dramatic.

Still, something about the act stayed with him.

Police records were supposed to be the memory of the institution.

Yet Harun had just made a second memory.

In case the first changed.

* * *

At the station entrance before dawn, Harun stopped beside Rahman.

“Yesterday, what worried you?”

“The watch.”

“And now?”

Rahman looked through the corridor toward the locked evidence room.

"The person who could remove it."

Harun nodded.

"The thief outside the station worries me less than the man who can rewrite what happened after we arrest him."

Rahman said nothing.

Harun started down the steps.

Then turned.

"One more thing."

"Yes, sir?"

"Don't decide Hamid is guilty yet."

"He changed a statement."

"Yes."

"He lied."

"Yes."

"He accessed evidence storage."

"Yes."

Rahman waited.

Harun said:

"You know what he did."

Pause.

"You don't know why."

Then he left.

Rahman remained beneath the station lights.

Until that morning, he had believed danger waited on the other side of an arrest.

Criminals.

Weapons.

Gangs.

Men running into darkness.

Room 17 taught him something less comfortable.

Sometimes the danger came afterward.

When the suspect had already been arrested.

When the report had already been typed.

When the evidence had already been locked away.

A door could be secure.

A register could be signed.

A file could look complete.

And none of those things guaranteed the truth was safe.
Sometimes danger already had a key.

CHAPTER FIVE

THE POLICEMAN WHO DISAPPEARED

SERI MERBAU — 1993

Constable Hamid Rahim asked to speak to Harun on a Wednesday afternoon.

By Thursday morning, he was gone.

Rahman was at the front counter when Hamid approached him.

It was raining outside.

Not heavily.

Just enough to darken the station steps and leave the officers returning from patrol smelling of wet cloth.

Hamid stood beside Rahman's desk for several seconds without speaking.

Rahman looked up.

"You need something?"

Hamid glanced toward the investigation rooms.

"Superintendent Harun here?"

"He went to regional headquarters."

"When coming back?"

"Tonight."

Hamid nodded.

Did not leave.

Rahman put down his pen.

"What?"

"I need to talk to him."

"About the robbery?"

Hamid looked at him.

Rahman immediately knew the question had been too direct.

"Maybe."

“What does that mean?”

Hamid checked the room behind them.

Nobody appeared to be watching.

“I’ll tell him.”

“You want me to call him?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Hamid rubbed one hand across the back of his neck.

“Tell him I’ll meet him tonight.”

“Here?”

“No.”

He removed a small piece of paper from his pocket.

An address.

A roadside coffee shop eight kilometres outside town.

“Ten-thirty.”

Rahman looked at it.

“Why not here?”

Hamid’s eyes met his.

“Not here.”

There was something in his face Rahman had not seen during either interview.

Decision.

Or desperation.

“Are you in trouble?”

Hamid almost laughed.

Not because anything was funny.

“You ask too many questions.”

“Occupational problem.”

For a moment Hamid looked like the officer Rahman had known before Room 17.

Then it vanished.

“Just tell him.”

He walked away.

Rahman called after him.

“Hamid.”

The constable stopped.

Rahman held up the address.

“Will you actually come?”

Hamid did not answer.

Then:

“Yes.”

It was the last time Rahman saw him.

* * *

Harun arrived at ten-fifteen.

They drove separately.

Rahman had not originally been invited.

Harun told him to come anyway.

“Why?”

“You took the message.”

That was all.

The coffee shop stood beside a dark road lined with rubber trees.

At ten-thirty there were six customers.

At ten-forty, four.

At eleven, only Rahman, Harun and the shopkeeper remained.

Hamid did not come.

Rahman checked the road every time headlights appeared.

Motorcycle.

Lorry.

Taxi.

Nothing.

At eleven-fifteen Harun asked the shopkeeper whether Hamid had visited earlier.

The man looked at the photograph.

“No.”

“At all this week?”

“No.”

Harun paid for the coffee.

Outside, Rahman said:

“Maybe he changed his mind.”

Harun looked at the empty road.

“Maybe.”

Rahman hated the word again.

* * *

They drove to Hamid's house.

Lights off.

Car gone.

Front gate locked.

Harun knocked.

No answer.

A neighbour opened her window.

She recognised the uniforms.

"Encik Hamid not home."

"When did he leave?" Rahman asked.

"Last night, I think."

"With family?"

She thought.

"Wife and children left earlier."

"Earlier when?"

"After Maghrib."

"Hamid with them?"

"No."

"Where did they go?"

The woman shrugged.

"Maybe family."

"Did you see Hamid leave?"

"Later."

"What time?"

"Eleven maybe."

"Alone?"

The neighbour hesitated.

"There was a vehicle."

"What vehicle?"

"Government, I think."

"Police?"

"I don't know."

"Colour?"

"Dark."

"Who was inside?"

She shook her head.

"It was raining."

Harun asked:

"Did Hamid carry luggage?"

"One bag."

"What kind?"

"Small."

"Did anyone force him into the vehicle?"

"No."

"Was he afraid?"

The woman looked uncomfortable.

"I don't know."

Harun thanked her.

Rahman waited until they reached the car.

"Government vehicle."

"Maybe."

"No sign of force."

"No."

"Family already gone."

"Yes."

Rahman looked back at the dark house.

"So he planned it."

Harun opened the driver's door.

"Perhaps."

Rahman did not move.

"You think he's running."

Harun looked at him.

"I think we don't know where he is."

* * *

At seven the following morning, Inspector Faizal found the transfer order.

It had been placed in the station's incoming administrative tray.

No envelope.

No delivery note.

Just one typed sheet.

CONSTABLE HAMID RAHIM

Effective immediately:

SPECIAL ADMINISTRATIVE ATTACHMENT
Authority:
REGIONAL PERSONNEL COMMAND
Destination:
blank.
Faizal read it twice.
Then called Salleh.
Then Rahman.
Harun arrived twenty minutes later.
He placed the transfer order flat on the desk.
“When was this received?”
The station clerk checked.
“It was in the tray when I came.”
“Who brought it?”
“I don’t know.”
“Courier book?”
“No entry.”
Faizal pointed at the paper.
“Can they transfer a man without telling us where?”
The clerk looked uncomfortable.
“I don’t know, sir.”
Harun called regional personnel.
The conversation lasted less than a minute.
He put the phone down.
“What?”
Rahman asked.
“They confirm the transfer.”
“Where?”
“Special attachment.”
“To where?”
“They wouldn’t say.”
“Who authorised it?”
“Restricted.”
Rahman stared.
“For a constable?”
Harun said nothing.
Faizal reached for the phone himself.

Harun stopped him.

“I already asked.”

“And?”

“They confirmed the document.”

“That doesn’t mean Hamid is there.”

Harun looked at him.

“No.”

The word changed the room.

Rahman said:

“Can they confirm he reported?”

Harun picked up the phone again.

Another call.

Longer.

This time Rahman watched his face.

Nothing until the end.

Then a slight tightening around the mouth.

Harun hung up.

“Well?” Faizal asked.

“They won’t confirm.”

Salleh frowned.

“Won’t or can’t?”

“They didn’t say.”

* * *

Rahman returned to Hamid’s house after breakfast.

This time Salmah was there.

She opened the door only after seeing his identification through the window.

Her eyes were red.

The children were somewhere inside.

Rahman heard a television playing quietly.

“Where is Hamid?”

It was the first thing she asked.

Rahman had expected her to know.

He felt the ground shift beneath the conversation.

“You don’t know?”

“If I knew, why would I ask you?”

She opened the door wider.
“Police took him.”
“We don’t know that.”
“I saw the vehicle.”
“You were here?”
“I came back after midnight.”
She crossed her arms.
“He told me to take the children to my sister.”
“Why?”
“He wouldn’t say.”
“When?”
“Yesterday afternoon.”
“Was he frightened?”
Salmah looked away.
“Yes.”
“Did he say someone threatened him?”
“No.”
“Did he say he was being transferred?”
“No.”
“Did he take clothes?”
“One bag.”
“Documents?”
“I don’t know.”
“Money?”
“I don’t know.”
Rahman paused.
“Did he tell you when he would return?”
Salmah’s face changed.
That was the question she had been avoiding.
“No.”
The television continued inside.
Children laughing at something on screen.
Salmah lowered her voice.
“He said if anyone asked, I should say I didn’t know where he was.”
“Who would ask?”
“He didn’t say.”
“Did he mention Superintendent Harun?”

Her eyes flickered.

Barely.

Rahman saw it.

"Yes."

"What did he say?"

"He said he needed to tell him something."

"What?"

"I don't know."

"Did he write anything down?"

"No."

"Leave anything?"

"No."

She became angry.

"You are the police."

Rahman said nothing.

"You should know where he is."

The sentence landed harder than accusation.

Because she was right.

Or should have been.

* * *

Back at the station, Hamid's desk had been cleared.

Rahman noticed after lunch.

Not simply tidied.

Cleared.

No pens.

No notebooks.

No spare uniform items.

No photographs.

Nothing.

He found the duty clerk.

"Who emptied this?"

She looked confused.

"Personnel."

"When?"

"This morning."

"Who?"

“Two officers.”
“Names?”
“I didn’t ask.”
Rahman’s irritation sharpened.
“They showed paperwork?”
“Yes.”
“What paperwork?”
“Transfer collection.”
“Where is it?”
She found the carbon copy.
Official form.
Hamid’s name.
Service number.
Transfer authority.
Two signatures Rahman did not recognise.
Everything correct.
Everything neat.
He carried it to Harun.
The superintendent read it.
“Anything wrong with it?”
Rahman asked.
“Not visibly.”
“That is the problem.”
Harun looked at him.
Rahman continued.
“If it was fake, at least we’d know.”
Harun handed the paper back.
“You’re learning to fear the right things.”
Rahman did not appreciate the lesson.
“Where is he?”
“I don’t know.”
“Do you think regional command knows?”
“I don’t know.”
“Do you think this is connected to Room 17?”
Harun sat back.
“I don’t know.”
Rahman felt anger rising.

"You don't know anything."

Harun looked at him calmly.

"That is correct."

The answer stopped him.

Harun continued.

"And until we do, that is what we say."

Rahman looked away.

The discipline of uncertainty was harder when somebody's life occupied the question.

* * *

By afternoon the rumours began.

Hamid had been suspended.

Hamid had confessed.

Hamid had been transferred to intelligence.

Hamid had fled with evidence.

Hamid had taken money.

Hamid had been arrested.

Hamid was under protection.

Hamid was in Kota Aruna.

Hamid had left the country.

Every version contained somebody who claimed to know someone who knew.

Salleh found Rahman listening to two constables argue near the rear stairs.

"Stop."

Rahman looked at him.

"I wasn't saying anything."

"You were listening."

"So?"

Salleh lit a cigarette.

"You keep feeding on rumours, soon you'll forget what hunger feels like."

Rahman stared at him.

Salleh exhaled.

"What do we actually know?"

Rahman answered automatically.

“Hamid asked to meet Harun.”
“Good.”
“He didn’t show.”
“Yes.”
“His wife and children left before him.”
“Yes.”
“A vehicle collected him.”
“Maybe.”
Rahman caught himself.
Salleh almost smiled.
“Transfer order appeared.”
“Yes.”
“Regional confirms it.”
“Yes.”
“Destination restricted.”
“Yes.”
“Anything else?”
Rahman thought.
“No.”
Salleh flicked ash into a drain.
“That is your case.”
“It isn’t much.”
“No.”
“Doesn’t it bother you?”
Salleh looked toward the station.
“More than if we had found a body.”
Rahman looked at him.
“Why?”
“Bodies answer one question.”
Salleh took another drag.
“This answers none.”

* * *

Harun spent the rest of the day calling offices in Kota Aruna.
Personnel.
Administration.
Regional command.

A contact in intelligence.
Someone in disciplinary affairs.
Rahman did not know all of them.
The answers did not improve.
Hamid's service status remained active.
Salary continuing.
No disciplinary suspension.
No arrest notation.
No leave.
No resignation.
Simply:
SPECIAL ATTACHMENT
By five-thirty, Harun closed the door to Faizal's office.
Rahman, Salleh and Faizal sat with him.
"We stop asking through open channels."
Faizal frowned.
"Why?"
"Because we're creating a list of everyone interested in Hamid."
Rahman understood slowly.
"And we don't know who reads that list."
Harun looked at him.
"No."
Salleh said:
"You think somebody inside is covering him?"
Harun replied:
"I think somebody with administrative authority moved him."
"Same thing."
"No."
Salleh studied him.
Harun continued.
"Maybe they are protecting him."
"From who?"
"I don't know."
"Maybe they're protecting someone from him."
Harun said nothing.
That silence was answer enough.
Rahman looked toward the closed door.

The station suddenly felt smaller.

* * *

The next morning a second memorandum arrived.

CONSTABLE HAMID RAHIM — NO LONGER UNDER DISTRICT COMMAND

All administrative inquiries regarding his posting were to be directed through regional personnel.

No explanation.

No name.

No telephone number beyond the general switchboard.

Faizal read it and put it down.

“That is ridiculous.”

Harun picked it up.

“No.”

Faizal looked at him.

“It is very deliberate.”

That was worse.

Rahman asked:

“What do we do?”

Harun read the memo once more.

“Officially?”

“Yes.”

“Nothing.”

Rahman stared.

“You’re serious?”

“Yes.”

“So we just accept it?”

“I didn’t say that.”

“Then what?”

Harun folded the memo carefully.

“We continue the robbery.”

“And Hamid?”

Harun looked at him.

“We remember.”

Rahman did not understand at first.

Harun opened his briefcase.

He removed copies of the Room 17 access pages they had made the previous night.

One copy of Hamid's transfer order.

One copy of the revised victim statement.

Nothing more.

He placed them into a brown folder.

"You're keeping those?"

"Yes."

"Official file?"

"No."

Rahman looked at him.

Harun met his eyes.

"Files move."

That was all.

No explanation of an archive.

No admission that he no longer trusted the institution.

Just copies.

Just caution.

Rahman understood enough to be uncomfortable.

* * *

Days became weeks.

Hamid did not return.

No confirmation came.

His wife received no official explanation beyond the transfer notice.

His salary continued entering their bank account.

Once, Salmah told Rahman, a man from "the department" called and said Hamid was safe.

She asked to speak to him.

The caller refused.

Asked for a name.

The line disconnected.

There was no way to verify the call.

The station adapted.

Institutions were good at adapting.

Another constable used Hamid's desk.

His locker was reassigned.

His name disappeared from the new duty roster.
Not maliciously.
Administratively.
The empty space closed.
One afternoon Rahman stopped in front of the roster.
He remembered where Hamid's name had been.
Night shift.
Tuesday.
Wednesday.
Thursday.
Now another name occupied the box.
He took out his notebook.
The old entry was there in his handwriting.
Proof only to himself.
Harun approached behind him.
"What?"
Rahman pointed.
"His name is gone."
"He was transferred."
"That isn't what I mean."
Harun understood.
Rahman looked at the sheet.
"How long before nobody remembers he was ever here?"
Harun did not answer immediately.
"Longer than you think."
Then:
"Shorter than you hope."
"Some transfers are movements," Harun said. "Others are messages."
"Which is this?"
"Ask who is meant to read it."
They stood together in the corridor.
Phones rang at the front counter.
Somebody laughed inside the charge room.
A complainant argued about a missing motorcycle.
Ordinary police work continued around them.
Rahman said:
"You believe he's alive?"

Harun's eyes remained on the roster.
"Yes."
"You know?"
"No."
"Why believe it?"
Harun finally looked at him.
"Because belief and evidence are not the same thing."
Rahman almost smiled.
It faded quickly.
"What if we never find out?"
Harun considered the question.
"Then we don't."
"That is not good enough."
"No."
Harun looked down the corridor.
"But sometimes it is what the truth gives you."
He started walking.
Rahman followed.
At the rear stairs, Harun stopped.
"Rahman."
"Yes?"
"Do not make Hamid into one thing."
"What does that mean?"
"You saw him change a statement."
"Yes."
"You saw him lie."
"Yes."
"You saw him afraid."
"Yes."
Harun nodded.
"So which one is the truth?"
Rahman thought.
"All of them."
"Exactly."
He continued downstairs.
Rahman remained at the landing.
For days he had been trying to decide what Hamid was.

Corrupt.

Victim.

Coward.

Witness.

Criminal.

Policeman.

Perhaps Harun was right.

A man could be more than one thing at the same time.

* * *

Months later, Hamid's name would still appear occasionally in Rahman's thoughts.

Never with an answer.

Only questions.

Who had picked him up?

Who authorised the transfer?

What had he intended to tell Harun?

Was he being protected?

Silenced?

Moved?

Had he run willingly?

Had he returned somewhere under another assignment?

No evidence resolved any of it.

Only paperwork remained.

A transfer order.

An administrative memorandum.

A service record stating:

SPECIAL ATTACHMENT

Somewhere, according to the institution, Constable Hamid Rahim still belonged to the Malaysian National Police Service.

But nobody in Seri Merbau could say where he slept.

Where he worked.

Who commanded him.

Or whether he was still alive.

That was when Rahman first understood that a man did not need to vanish in darkness to disappear.

Sometimes all it took was a form.

A stamp.

A signature.

And enough people willing to accept that the correct department must know more than they did.

Hamid had disappeared.

The paperwork said otherwise.

For the first time in his career, Rahman wondered which version the institution would eventually choose to remember.

CHAPTER SIX

THE BORDER

NORTHERN COMMAND — 1995

The border taught Rahman that the law could be visible from a distance and negotiable up close.

His transfer order arrived on a Monday.

By Thursday, he was standing beside a two-lane road forty kilometres north of Seri Merbau, watching lorries move toward the frontier under a sky the colour of old tin.

The district was called Bukit Lada.

It was smaller than Rahman expected and busier than it had any right to be.

Rubber estates surrounded most of the town.

Low shop houses clustered around the central market.

A mosque stood opposite a Chinese temple at one end of Jalan Besar, both older than nearly every government building nearby.

Beyond the town, the road narrowed between plantations before opening again near customs facilities and the border crossing.

Everything moved through Bukit Lada.

Fruit.

Timber.

Electronics.

Cooking oil.

Cigarettes.

Spare parts.

Live chickens.

People.

Some of it declared.

Some of it not.

Rahman's new district chief, Superintendent Halim Zain, told him this on his first morning.

Halim was fifty-two and carried himself like a man who had long ago accepted that administration would eventually kill him if criminals failed first.

He pointed through the office window toward a line of lorries moving along the main road.

"Every one of those drivers knows where the roadblocks are."

Rahman looked at him.

"How?"

Halim shrugged.

"Eyes."

"Police leak?"

"Sometimes."

Rahman's attention sharpened.

Halim noticed.

"Don't start."

"Start what?"

"You came from Seri Merbau."

"So?"

"So I heard about you."

Rahman said nothing.

Halim sat behind his desk.

"Every district is different."

"Law isn't."

"No."

Halim smiled faintly.

"People are."

He pushed a file across the desk.

"Learn the place before you try to fix it."

Rahman opened the file.

Vehicle theft.

Smuggling.

Unlicensed alcohol.

Illegal cigarettes.

Fuel diversion.

A page of names.

He recognised none of them.

“What is this?”

“People you’ll hear about.”

“Suspects?”

“Some.”

“And the rest?”

“Businessmen.”

Rahman looked up.

Halim took a sip of coffee.

“In Bukit Lada, sometimes the difference depends on what day you ask.”

* * *

The station operated differently from Seri Merbau.

Not badly.

Differently.

At Seri Merbau, officers referred to suspects by case number or surname.

At Bukit Lada, everybody seemed to know everybody.

“Ah Chong’s lorry.”

“Pak Din’s nephew.”

“Ravi’s warehouse.”

“Boon’s boys.”

Names floated through the station without files attached to them.

A trader arrived to report stolen diesel and stayed for tea.

A transport company owner walked behind the counter to greet an inspector.

A fruit seller dropped off rambutans for the entire night shift.

Rahman watched all of it.

The first week, he refused the rambutans.

The second week, Sergeant Mat Nor put a plate on Rahman’s desk anyway.

“They came from the market.”

“From who?”

“Fruit.”

“That wasn’t my question.”

Mat Nor sighed.

“You want statement from the rambutan?”

Rahman looked at him.

Mat Nor laughed.

“Eat.”

Rahman did.

They were good.

He disliked that this felt relevant.

Mat Nor had served at the border for eighteen years.

He knew which lorries belonged to which families, which restaurants stayed open after midnight, which roads flooded first and which drivers lied badly.

He also seemed capable of identifying people by engine sound.

“Blue Isuzu,” he said one evening before a lorry appeared around the station corner.

Rahman looked outside.

Blue Isuzu.

“How?”

“Gearbox.”

“That is ridiculous.”

“Listen tomorrow.”

Rahman did.

Mat Nor was right.

The border had its own language.

Not written anywhere.

Vehicles.

Schedules.

Familiar faces.

Who crossed at dawn.

Who crossed after midnight.

Which drivers carried cash.

Which ones carried weapons.

Which ones acted nervous because they were smuggling something and which ones acted nervous because police made them nervous.

Rahman began filling notebooks.

Mat Nor found one on his desk.

“You writing book?”

“No.”

"What all this?"

"Registrations."

"Why?"

Rahman looked at him.

"Because they are there."

Mat Nor stared.

Then shook his head.

"You are strange."

Rahman had heard worse.

* * *

His first night roadblock came two weeks later.

Six officers.

Two marked vehicles.

Portable lights.

Cones narrowing the road.

A senior inspector named Zulkifli supervised.

The humidity was thick enough to make uniforms cling within minutes.

Mosquitoes ignored rank.

For the first hour, nothing happened.

Motorcycles.

Families.

A bus.

Two produce lorries.

A taxi driver who appeared more offended by being stopped than inconvenienced.

Rahman checked licences.

Vehicle permits.

Cargo.

Mat Nor moved faster.

He seemed to know half the drivers.

"Your mother okay?"

"How is the baby?"

"Tell Ah Keong stop overloading this thing before the axle leaves without him."

Rahman watched.

It looked casual.
But Mat Nor still checked documents.
Still inspected loads.
Familiarity did not automatically mean negligence.
That distinction mattered.
At eleven-forty, headlights appeared around the bend.
A heavy lorry.
Canvas-covered load.
Green cab.
Rahman raised his hand.
The driver slowed.
Before the lorry fully stopped, Inspector Zulkifli stepped forward.
He looked at the registration.
Then at the driver.
The driver lowered the window.
“Boss.”
Zulkifli nodded.
“Late.”
“Loading delay.”
“What carrying?”
“Tiles.”
Zulkifli glanced at the canvas.
Then waved one hand.
“Go.”
Rahman stepped forward.
“We’re not checking?”
Zulkifli looked at him.
“Documents are fine.”
“We haven’t seen them.”
The driver stared straight ahead.
Zulkifli’s face hardened slightly.
“I’ve checked this company all week.”
Rahman glanced at the canvas.
“Then one more time won’t hurt.”
Mat Nor stopped inspecting another car.
The air changed.
Not dramatically.

Enough.

Zulkifli stepped closer.

“What is your rank?”

Rahman knew the answer was not needed.

“Inspector.”

“And mine?”

“Senior Inspector.”

“So?”

Rahman said nothing.

Zulkifli pointed at the lorry.

“Let him through.”

Rahman looked at the driver.

The man still did not look at him.

Then Rahman moved aside.

The lorry rolled forward.

As it passed, Rahman noticed the rear suspension.

Too high.

Not low.

If it was carrying tiles, either the load was lighter than claimed or the lorry was nearly empty.

He memorised the registration.

Mat Nor came beside him after the vehicle disappeared.

“You saw.”

“Yes.”

“What?”

“Not much weight.”

Mat Nor said nothing.

“You know the lorry?”

“Yes.”

“Tiles?”

“Sometimes.”

“What else?”

Mat Nor looked down the road.

“Things.”

Rahman waited.

Mat Nor glanced at him.

“You need to learn something.”

"What?"
"Not every lorry you don't check is corruption."
"I didn't say it was."
"You thought."
Rahman almost replied.
Stopped.
Harun's voice returned.
Believing and knowing are not the same thing.
Mat Nor saw the hesitation.
"Good."
Rahman frowned.
"Everyone says that when they're annoying me."
Mat Nor laughed.
"Then maybe you are learning."

* * *

The roadblock continued until two in the morning.
The green lorry did not return.
At the station, Rahman checked the registration.
The lorry belonged to Sinar Utara Trading.
Registered cargo business.
No active warrants.
Several minor transport violations.
Nothing else.
He checked company directors.
One name appeared repeatedly across other transport firms.
Still nothing criminal.
Mat Nor leaned against the doorway.
"You going home?"
"Soon."
"You find your tiles?"
"No."
"Maybe they were tiles."
"Maybe."
Mat Nor smiled.
Rahman closed the file.
He had no evidence of wrongdoing.

Only:

a lorry waved through,

a familiar driver,

a questionable load.

That was not enough.

He knew that now.

But knowing when not to act did not mean forgetting what he had seen.

He wrote the registration number in his notebook.

Then went home.

* * *

Three nights later, Rahman saw the green lorry again.

Not at a roadblock.

He was returning from a stolen-motorcycle report at a village south of town.

Past midnight.

No traffic.

The green lorry turned off the main road ahead.

Rahman recognised the rear lights before the plate.

It took an industrial road toward an old agricultural warehouse complex.

Rahman slowed.

His partner that night, Constable Kumar, looked over.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"You slowed."

Rahman pointed.

"That lorry."

"What lorry?"

"Green."

Kumar leaned forward.

"I see."

Rahman followed at a distance.

The lorry turned again.

No signal.

Warehouse road.

“Should call station,” Kumar said.

“We don’t know anything yet.”

“Exactly why we should call.”

Rahman picked up the radio.

He reported their location.

Routine observation.

No request for backup.

Then continued.

The lorry entered through an open warehouse gate.

A smaller van was already parked inside.

Lights on.

Rahman stopped the police vehicle two hundred metres away.

Kumar looked at him.

“We going?”

“We’re looking.”

“We can look from here.”

Rahman opened his door.

Kumar muttered something in Tamil.

Rahman assumed it was not praise.

They approached on foot.

No attempt at stealth sophisticated enough to pretend they were intelligence officers.

Just darkness, distance and common sense.

The warehouse was supposed to store agricultural machinery.

Rahman knew that because the sign at the gate said so.

What he heard inside was not machinery.

Boxes moving.

Men talking quickly.

A vehicle door slamming.

Rahman and Kumar reached the side wall.

A gap between wooden panels gave them partial view.

Six men.

Green lorry.

White van.

Cartons being transferred.

Not tiles.

The boxes were small.

Unmarked.
One man cut open a carton.
Inside:
cigarette packets.
Foreign labels.
No Malaysian tax markings Rahman could see.
Kumar whispered:
“Smuggling.”
Rahman nodded.
He reached for the radio.
Static.
The warehouse’s metal structure interfered.
He moved back.
Inside, one of the men suddenly looked toward the wall.
Rahman froze.
The man stepped closer.
Maybe he heard something.
Maybe not.
A dog barked behind another building.
The man turned away.
Rahman backed toward the road.
Then his heel struck a loose piece of metal.
Clang.
Everything inside stopped.
Kumar whispered:
“Very good.”
A voice shouted.
“Police!”
Rahman had no idea whether they had actually seen him.
Then three men ran.
That answered the question.
“Kumar!”
They moved.
Rahman entered through the side opening.
One man bolted toward the rear.
Another ran between the vehicles.
The third climbed into the white van.

Rahman shouted:

“Police! Stop!”

The van engine started.

Kumar reached for the driver’s door.

The van reversed suddenly.

He jumped aside.

Rahman saw the rear bumper coming toward him and threw himself behind a stack of pallets.

The van smashed through a loose gate panel and accelerated toward the road.

Kumar ran back toward their vehicle.

Rahman pointed.

“Go!”

“You?”

“Go!”

Kumar hesitated once.

Then sprinted.

Rahman pursued the man running toward the rear fence.

Not because he had planned to.

Because he was already moving.

The suspect hit the fence and climbed.

Rahman caught his shirt.

Fabric tore.

The man kicked backward.

Rahman took the heel against his shoulder.

Pain exploded down his arm.

He lost grip.

The suspect dropped on the other side.

Rahman climbed after him.

The ground beyond the fence sloped sharply into a drainage ditch.

The suspect slipped.

Rahman did not.

For once, caution won.

He came down slower.

The man recovered and ran through waist-high grass.

Rahman followed.

No heroic sprint.

No effortless chase.
Within fifty metres his lungs were burning.
The suspect was younger.
Faster.
Then the man made the mistake of looking back.
His foot struck the edge of a concrete culvert.
He went down hard.
Rahman reached him seconds later.
The suspect rolled.
Something flashed in his hand.
Rahman stopped.
Knife.
Small.
But close enough.
“Drop it.”
The suspect breathed heavily.
“So serious, abang.”
Rahman held position.
The man was maybe twenty-two.
Thin.
Sharp face.
Hair too long for a policeman’s approval.
He looked more amused than frightened.
“Drop the knife.”
“It is not mine.”
“You are holding it.”
“Temporary.”
Rahman stared at him.
The man smiled.
Even now.
Rahman heard distant engine noise.
Kumar pursuing the van.
“Last time.”
The smile faded slightly.
The man looked at the knife.
Then threw it aside.
“Happy?”

“Hands behind your back.”
“Not really.”
Rahman moved forward.
The man complied.
Too easily.
Rahman cuffed him.
“What is your name?”
The suspect looked over his shoulder.
“Depends.”
“On what?”
“Who asking.”
“The police officer handcuffing you.”
“Then probably Muhammad Khairul.”
“Probably?”
“My mother is very certain.”
Rahman tightened one cuff.
Khairul winced.
“See? Serious.”
Rahman pulled him up.
“Walk.”
Khairul looked toward the warehouse.
“You should catch the driver.”
“We will.”
“No.”
He smiled again.
“You won’t.”
Rahman stopped.
“What does that mean?”
“Means he drives faster than your car.”
“You know him?”
Khairul looked innocent.
“No.”
“You were in the warehouse with him.”
“Many people in warehouse.”
“What was in the boxes?”
“Boxes.”
“Cigarettes.”

“Then why ask?”
Rahman started walking again.
Khairul followed.
“First posting here?”
Rahman stopped.
Khairul nearly walked into him.
“How do you know?”
Khairul looked at him as though the answer were obvious.
“Everyone knows everyone here.”
“That isn’t an answer.”
“You write too much.”
Rahman stared.
Khairul nodded toward the pocket containing his notebook.
“Local police don’t write every registration number.”
For the first time Rahman felt something other than irritation.
“You saw me?”
“At roadblock.”
“When?”
Khairul smiled.
“See?”
Rahman said nothing.
Khairul continued.
“You remember cars.”
“I remember people too.”
“Good skill.”
They walked back toward the warehouse.
A siren approached in the distance.
Khairul looked almost relaxed.
“How many officers tonight?”
Rahman glanced at him.
“Why?”
“Just talking.”
“Six at roadblock three nights ago.”
Rahman stopped again.
Khairul turned.
The amusement remained.
“You were there?”

“Maybe.”

“Where?”

“Road has many places.”

Rahman studied him.

Khairul’s smile became smaller.

Not nervous.

Careful.

Rahman realised this young man knew more about police routines than someone in handcuffs should.

“Who tells you where roadblocks are?”

Khairul laughed.

“Roadblock has lights.”

“That isn’t what I asked.”

“People have eyes.”

The exact answer Superintendent Halim had given Rahman.

That bothered him.

Khairul saw it.

“Don’t worry, Inspector.”

Rahman said nothing.

Khairul looked toward the approaching police lights.

“Everybody watches everybody here.”

* * *

The white van did not get far.

Kumar and another patrol car found it abandoned three kilometres away.

Driver gone.

Inside were more untaxed cigarettes.

The green lorry remained at the warehouse.

Its driver had also disappeared.

Four men were arrested.

Two escaped.

Muhammad Khairul gave the least useful statement Rahman had ever taken.

The arrest sheet said Muhammad Khairul.

Every officer at the border post called him something else.

Kelana. The wanderer. He had earned it by never being where the last report put him.

Name.

Address.

Age.

Occupation:

“Sometimes transport.”

Transport what?

“Depends.”

For whom?

“People.”

Which people?

“Customers.”

Why was he at the warehouse?

“Helping friend.”

Which friend?

“He left.”

Rahman sat opposite him in the interview room.

Khairul seemed comfortable.

Too comfortable.

“You think this is funny?”

“No.”

“You keep smiling.”

“Face like this.”

Rahman stared.

Khairul added:

“My mother says handsome.”

Rahman closed the file.

“Those cigarettes were smuggled.”

“So?”

“You were handling them.”

“I was near them.”

“I arrested you beside the warehouse.”

“Outside.”

“You ran.”

“Police shout, everyone run.”

“Honest people don’t.”

Khairul leaned forward slightly.

“That what they teach you?”

Rahman said nothing.

Khairul leaned back.

“No wonder you look tired.”

Rahman opened the file again.

“You were at the roadblock three nights ago.”

Khairul’s eyes flickered.

Small.

There.

“You said that, not me.”

“You knew how many officers were there.”

“I can count.”

“You knew I was new.”

“You are.”

“How?”

Khairul shrugged.

“You don’t talk like here.”

“That isn’t it.”

“No.”

“Then what?”

Khairul looked at him for a long moment.

Then:

“You still think roadblock is secret.”

Rahman felt the words land.

“Explain.”

“Nothing to explain.”

“Who tells you?”

“Tea shop.”

“What?”

Khairul smiled.

“Driver stops for tea. Sees police car. Calls friend. Friend calls cousin. Cousin tells another driver.”

He moved his cuffed hands slightly.

“By time you put first cone, everybody knows.”

Rahman considered this.

It was plausible.

Completely ordinary.

No conspiracy required.

Only people.

Phones.

Tea shops.

Drivers.

Habits.

"That's all?"

Khairul smiled.

"Enough, no?"

Rahman hated that he could not tell whether the answer was true.

* * *

The case against Khairul was not as strong as Rahman wanted.

He had been present.

He had run.

He had carried a knife.

But he was not the warehouse tenant.

Not the lorry driver.

Not the owner of the cigarettes.

He claimed he had been hired that night to move boxes.

There were no documents directly tying him to the shipment.

The investigating officer told Rahman:

"He'll probably get minor charge."

"He knew what he was moving."

"Prove."

Rahman recognised the lesson.

Again.

Always prove.

Khairul was released on bail two days later.

Rahman watched from the station entrance as he collected his belongings.

A cheap watch.

Wallet.

Coins.

One folded bus ticket.

Khairul walked toward the gate.

Then turned.
“Inspector.”
Rahman waited.
“You always remember registration numbers?”
“Why?”
“Just asking.”
“Yes.”
Khairul nodded thoughtfully.
“Then I need better car.”
Rahman stared.
Khairul laughed.
At the gate he stopped again.
“You are staying long?”
“Here?”
“Yes.”
“Why?”
“Because this place will make you less serious.”
“I doubt it.”
Khairul grinned.
“Then maybe more interesting.”
He started walking.
Rahman called:
“Khairul.”
The young man looked back.
“Next time I see you, try not to be running from a warehouse.”
Khairul considered that.
Then raised one hand.
“No promises.”
He walked toward the bus stop.
After several steps he turned once more.
“Don’t worry, Inspector.”
Rahman waited.
Khairul smiled.
“You’ll see me again.”
Then he disappeared into the afternoon crowd.
Rahman stood at the gate watching people move through Bukit Lada.
Drivers.

Traders.

Porters.

Shopkeepers.

Police.

People who knew one another by name.

People who knew where roadblocks stood before police believed the roadblocks had begun.

He had arrived thinking the border separated one place from another.

Two weeks had taught him something different.

The most important borders were rarely marked by signs.

There was the border between legal trade and smuggling.

Between familiarity and favour.

Between knowing a man and protecting him.

Between routine information and dangerous information.

Rahman still did not know whether Inspector Zulkifli had waved the green lorry through because he trusted the driver, because he was lazy, because he had checked the company before—

or because of something else.

He had no evidence.

So he wrote the registration number in his notebook.

And waited.

CHAPTER SEVEN

THE INFORMANT

NORTH CORRIDOR — 1999

Muhammad Khairul—Kelana, to everyone who had ever lost him—had learned to dress better.

That was the first thing Rahman noticed.

The second was that he no longer ran.

Four years earlier, Rahman had chased him through wet grass behind a smuggling warehouse while Khairul carried a knife and complained about being arrested.

Now he was sitting beneath a ceiling fan in an interview room, wearing a clean white shirt, dark trousers and shoes that cost more than anything Rahman remembered him owning.

No handcuffs.

No grin.

Not at first.

Rahman closed the door behind him.

Khairul looked up.

Then the grin appeared.

“Inspector.”

“Khairul.”

“Still remember me.”

“I remember people who kick me.”

Khairul looked offended.

“I kicked you?”

“Fence.”

“Ah.”

He nodded.

“You held my shirt.”

“You were escaping.”

“I was leaving quickly.”

Rahman sat opposite.

Four years had sharpened Khairul.

The thin young man from the warehouse had filled out slightly. His hair was shorter. A faint scar now ran from the edge of his jaw toward his ear.

His eyes had changed most.

Still amused.

Less careless.

“Nice shirt,” Rahman said.

Khairul looked down.

“You like?”

“No.”

“Then why mention?”

“To see if you stole it.”

Khairul laughed.

“There. You got joke now.”

“I always had jokes.”

“No.”

Rahman opened the file.

“Possession of stolen vehicle parts.”

Khairul stopped smiling.

The case was small by the standards of the district.

A workshop outside Padang Seroja had been raided after an insurance investigator traced parts from several stolen vehicles to the premises.

Engines.

Gearboxes.

Doors.

Chassis sections with numbers partially removed.

Khairul had been present when police arrived.

Again.

He insisted this was becoming coincidence.

Rahman disagreed.

The workshop owner had disappeared.

Two employees were arrested.

Khairul claimed he had gone there to collect money owed to him.

“What kind of money?” Rahman asked.
“Business.”
“What business?”
“Transport.”
“You own lorries now?”
“Sometimes.”
“That means no.”
“It means sometimes.”
Rahman looked through the file.
“You were standing beside a stripped Toyota.”
“Many people stand beside Toyota.”
“That one had been stolen three days earlier.”
“I didn’t know.”
“You never know.”
“Correct.”
Rahman looked up.
Khairul smiled again.
“You should write that.”
“I might.”
Rahman closed the file.
“What do you want?”
Khairul’s expression changed.
Not much.
Enough.
“Why you think I want something?”
“Because you asked to speak to me.”
“Maybe miss you.”
Rahman waited.
Khairul lasted seven seconds.
Then sighed.
“You still no fun.”
“What do you want?”
Khairul leaned back.
“Small help.”
“No.”
“I haven’t asked.”
“The answer is still no.”

“Very difficult doing business with you.”
“We are not doing business.”
Khairul tapped one finger against the table.
“The workshop case.”
“What about it?”
“I was there only.”
“That’s what your statement says.”
“I tell you something useful, you tell prosecutor I helped.”
Rahman studied him.
“You want the charge dropped.”
“I want you say I cooperate.”
“If you cooperate.”
Khairul smiled.
“Same thing.”
“No.”
“Close.”
“Not close.”
Khairul’s smile disappeared again.
Rahman continued.
“I don’t control charges.”
“You can talk.”
“I can report exactly what you do.”
“And ask them to consider.”
“I can state that you provided useful information.”
Khairul watched him.
“Useful means?”
“Useful.”
“If very useful?”
“Then the report says very useful.”
Khairul shook his head slowly.
“You really talk like police.”
“I am police.”
“You know other policemen say easier things.”
“Then talk to them.”
Silence.
Rahman leaned back.
Khairul looked toward the mirrored glass.

Nobody was behind it.
Rahman had made sure.
Finally Khairul said:
“Tomorrow night.”
Rahman waited.
“Blue lorry. Refrigerated.”
“Registration?”
Khairul gave it.
Rahman wrote it down.
“Coming from where?”
“North.”
“Going where?”
“Kota Aruna.”
“What is inside?”
“Frozen fish.”
Rahman looked up.
Khairul smiled.
“And?”
“Something under the fish.”
“What?”
“Cigarettes.”
“Untaxed?”
“Yes.”
“How much?”
“Enough.”
“Route?”
“Main road until Sungai Rusa. Then old quarry road.”
“Time?”
“After midnight.”
“Driver?”
Khairul shrugged.
“Driver changes.”
“Who owns the lorry?”
“Company.”
“What company?”
“Seri Anggun Cold Transport.”
Rahman wrote.

"Where did you get this?"
Khairul smiled.
"No."
"If I'm supposed to act on it, I need to assess source reliability."
"Source is me."
"You could be lying."
"Then don't go."
Rahman looked at him.
Khairul leaned forward.
"You asked what I want. I tell you. You don't like, fine."
"What do you get if police stop that lorry?"
Khairul's face became blank.
There.
Rahman saw it.
Something personal.
"Nothing."
"Wrong answer."
Khairul looked away.
"Maybe I don't like them."
"Who?"
"People with lorry."
"Why?"
"Business."
"What business?"
Khairul gave him a tired look.
"You ask same question many ways."
"Sometimes one works."
"Not today."
Rahman closed his notebook.
"If this is revenge, I need to know."
"It is information."
"If you're using police to attack a competitor—"
"Police don't arrest cigarettes because I don't like someone?"
"That isn't the point."
"It is to me."
Rahman considered him.
Then:

"I'll verify the intelligence."

"And my case?"

"If the intelligence materially assists an investigation, I record that."

"You speak to prosecutor?"

"If asked."

Khairul frowned.

"No promise?"

"No."

"Not even little?"

"No."

Khairul sat back.

Then began smiling.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"Khairul."

"You haven't changed."

Rahman gathered the file.

Khairul said:

"That might be problem."

* * *

The lorry existed.

That was the first test.

Seri Anggun Cold Transport existed too.

Registered six years earlier.

Two refrigerated lorries.

One warehouse.

No significant criminal record.

Rahman checked the registration Khairul had provided.

Match.

The owner was a fifty-six-year-old man named Tan Bak Hui.

No warrants.

No major convictions.

Several customs compounds dating back years.

Nothing dramatic.

Rahman took the intelligence to his immediate superior, Deputy Superintendent Azman Karim.

Azman read the note.

“Source?”

“Confidential.”

“Reliable?”

“Previously involved in smuggling.”

“That doesn’t make him reliable.”

“No.”

“Has he given information before?”

“Not formally.”

Azman looked up.

“So we are building an operation because a thief wants help with another case.”

“Alleged thief.”

Azman smiled.

“You sound like defence lawyer.”

“We haven’t charged him.”

“You believe him?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Rahman pointed at the vehicle details.

“He gave specific information we can test without exposing the source.”

Azman looked again.

“Who else knows?”

“You. Me.”

“Customs?”

“Not yet.”

“Why?”

Rahman hesitated.

Azman noticed.

“Room 17 still living in your head?”

Rahman said nothing.

Azman knew some of the story.

Not all.

Enough.

He pushed the paper back.

“Different district.”

"I know."

"Different people."

"I know."

"You cannot investigate everyone as though they already betrayed you."

"I know."

Azman studied him.

"Do you?"

Rahman did not answer.

Azman sighed.

"Use a small team. Don't intercept before the turn unless you see offence. If the source is wrong, we lose nothing except sleep."

He stood.

"And Rahman."

"Yes?"

"If the information is good, record the assistance accurately."

"I will."

"If it is bad?"

"I record that too."

Azman smiled slightly.

"Harun trained you well."

The name still landed heavily.

Rahman hid it.

* * *

The lorry appeared at 12:43 a.m.

Blue cab.

White refrigerated box.

Correct registration.

Rahman watched through binoculars from an unmarked vehicle parked beneath trees beside an abandoned petrol station.

Inspector Faridah Noor sat beside him.

A second team waited farther south.

"No offence yet," she said.

"I know."

"Just reminding."

"I know."

"You say that when annoyed."

Rahman lowered the binoculars.

"You've worked with me three months."

"Enough."

The lorry passed.

They waited.

Then followed.

No siren.

No lights.

Distance maintained.

The vehicle travelled south for twenty minutes.

Exactly as Khairul had said.

At Sungai Rusa it slowed.

Turned left.

Old quarry road.

Faridah looked at Rahman.

"Source getting interesting."

"Maybe."

"You hate being happy."

"Drive."

"I am driving."

"Then drive quietly."

She smiled.

The quarry road wound between low hills and abandoned extraction sites.

Few streetlights.

The lorry continued another six kilometres.

Then stopped beside a fenced compound.

Two smaller vehicles waited.

Rahman called the second team.

They held position.

From the darkness, they watched the rear doors open.

Men began unloading boxes.

At first, frozen seafood cartons.

Then one man climbed deeper into the lorry.

Removed a false internal panel.

Behind it:

more cartons.

Different size.

Faridah whispered:

“There.”

Rahman radioed.

“Move.”

The interception was short and inelegant.

One man ran into scrub and escaped.

Another tried to drive away in a pickup but reversed directly into a drainage ditch.

The lorry driver surrendered immediately.

A fourth man argued that he had merely come to buy fish.

Nobody believed him.

When officers opened the hidden section, they found thousands of packets of untaxed cigarettes.

Khairul had been right.

Almost exactly.

Rahman stood beside the lorry while evidence photographs were taken.

Faridah approached.

“Good source.”

“So far.”

She stared at him.

“Someone gives you sunrise, you complain night ended.”

Rahman looked inside the compartment.

“Why did he give it?”

“Does it matter?”

“Yes.”

“For arrest?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Rahman thought about the interview.

Khairul’s expression when asked what he gained.

“He wanted something more than consideration on his case.”

“Revenge?”

“Maybe.”

“Business competition?”

"Maybe."

Faridah groaned.

"You and that word."

Rahman almost smiled.

* * *

By sunrise, the arrests were completed.

The cigarettes were photographed, counted and sealed.

The lorry was seized.

Rahman returned to the station with dust on his trousers and no sleep.

Muhammad Khairul was sitting on the bench outside his office.

Rahman stopped.

"How did you get in?"

Khairul looked around.

"Door."

"Why are you here?"

"You went?"

Rahman opened his office.

"Come."

Khairul entered.

Rahman closed the door.

He sat.

Khairul remained standing.

"Well?"

Rahman looked at him.

"You knew it was there."

Khairul smiled.

"Good morning to you also."

"Sit."

Khairul sat.

"How did you know?"

"I know things."

"Who told you?"

"No."

"You want me to record cooperation."

"Yes."

“Then cooperate.”
“I gave lorry.”
“Give source.”
“No.”
Rahman leaned back.
“Then I report that you supplied information leading to a seizure.”
Khairul grinned.
“Very useful information?”
“Yes.”
“Write very.”
Rahman ignored him.
“Why that shipment?”
Khairul’s smile faded.
“You caught criminals.”
“That isn’t an answer.”
“It should be enough.”
“It isn’t.”
Khairul glanced at the window.
“Those people cheated someone.”
“You?”
“No.”
“Friend?”
“Maybe.”
“What happened?”
Khairul tapped the table.
“Inspector, you catch cigarettes or catch feelings?”
Rahman stared.
Khairul sighed.
“They use small transport people. Promise payment. Then don’t pay.”
“You?”
“No.”
“You keep saying no.”
“Because answer is no.”
“Who did they cheat?”
“A driver.”
“Name?”
“No.”

"Why protect him?"

"Because he didn't ask police."

Rahman understood enough.

"You did."

Khairul smiled faintly.

"Maybe I believe in public service."

Rahman did not return the smile.

"I will document exactly what happened."

"Good."

"That does not guarantee anything in the workshop case."

"I know."

"Do you?"

Khairul leaned back.

"Your problem, Inspector, you think everyone wants guarantee."

"Most people do."

"Some people want door open."

Rahman looked at him.

"What door?"

"Later."

He stood.

"Where are you going?"

"Breakfast."

"You're still connected to an active investigation."

"I have lawyer."

"Of course you do."

Khairul's grin returned.

"Good lawyer."

"Who?"

Khairul paused.

Then named a small firm Rahman recognised from several criminal cases.

Not because the firm was criminal.

Because criminals needed lawyers too.

Rahman wrote the name down.

Khairul watched.

"See?"

"What?"

"Everything go notebook."

"Yes."

"One day notebook become heavier than you."

"Go eat."

Khairul left laughing.

* * *

The prosecutor did take Khairul's assistance into account.

Not the way Khairul had hoped.

But enough.

The workshop case remained weak against him.

The prosecution proceeded on a lesser matter connected to possession of suspected stolen property.

Khairul pleaded guilty after negotiation.

Fine.

No prison sentence.

Rahman made no recommendation beyond accurately recording the intelligence he had supplied.

Two weeks later, a note arrived at the station.

No signature.

Only:

Very useful. Thank you.

Rahman threw it away.

Then retrieved it from the bin.

He did not know why.

He placed it inside the file.

* * *

Khairul disappeared from Rahman's direct view for almost a year.

His name did not.

It surfaced around transport companies.

Night entertainment.

Warehouses.

Vehicle imports.

Once in connection with illegal gambling, though nothing was proved.

Twice as a person who "knew someone."

Never quite high enough to become a priority target.

Never low enough to disappear into the street.

Rahman began to understand that Khairul's real occupation was not transport.

It was proximity.

He stood near people who moved things.

Goods.

Money.

Messages.

Introductions.

He seemed to know drivers without owning lorries.

Warehouse operators without holding leases.

Lawyers without having enough cases to justify the familiarity.

Criminals without formally belonging to their groups.

Then, one wet night near the end of 1999, Khairul called Rahman's office.

Not station.

Direct line.

Rahman stared at the telephone after recognising the voice.

"How did you get this number?"

"Telephone directory."

"It is not listed."

"Then different directory."

Rahman pinched the bridge of his nose.

"What?"

"Tea."

"No."

"Mamak."

"No."

"Very rude."

"Khairul."

"Not police station."

Rahman went still.

"Why?"

"No trouble."

"Then say it on the phone."

"Phone also has ears."

Rahman looked at the receiver.

“Your imagination is improving.”

“Your investigation also.”

Click.

The line went dead.

* * *

The mamak was twenty minutes outside the town centre.

Open twenty-four hours.

Plastic tables beneath fluorescent lights.

Football playing silently on a television fixed near the drinks counter.

At two in the morning, only three other tables were occupied.

Truck drivers.

Two university students sharing cigarettes.

An old man reading yesterday’s newspaper.

Rahman arrived alone.

Khairul was already there with teh tarik and roti kosong.

“You’re late.”

“Three minutes.”

“Police time?”

“Normal time.”

Rahman sat.

A waiter approached.

“Kopi O kosong.”

Khairul looked offended.

“At two morning you drink this?”

“You called me.”

“Still.”

The waiter left.

Rahman studied Khairul.

He wore jeans and a dark shirt.

No expensive shoes this time.

“What do you want?”

Khairul tore the roti.

“Talk.”

“Then talk.”

“You always start romance like this?”

Rahman looked at him.
Khairul laughed.
“Okay.”
He ate.
Rahman waited.
The mamak sounds filled the silence.
Metal spoon against glass.
A lorry changing gears on the road.
Football commentary too low to understand.
Finally Khairul asked:
“You know those cigarette people?”
“The ones you gave us?”
“Not them.”
“Who?”
“The group.”
“What group?”
“See.”
Khairul pointed at him with a piece of bread.
“That.”
“That what?”
“You police like groups.”
Rahman frowned.
“People commit crimes together.”
“Sometimes.”
“Usually.”
“No.”
The waiter delivered Rahman’s coffee.
Khairul waited until he left.
“Police like gang names.”
Rahman took a drink.
“Criminals also.”
“Some.”
Khairul smiled.
“Good for business.”
“Explain.”
“Name make people scared.”
“Gang A. Gang B. Gang C.”

He moved pieces of roti into three separate piles on his plate.
“This one gambling.”
First pile.
“This one cigarettes.”
Second.
“This one car.”
Third.
“Police see three gangs.”
“Because they are three groups.”
“Yes.”
Khairul moved his glass between them.
“But same transport man.”
Rahman watched.
Khairul placed the spoon between the first and second piles.
“Same lawyer.”
The sugar container between second and third.
“Same person arrange warehouse.”
Another object.
“Same tow-truck company.”
He sat back.
“Who important?”
“The gangs.”
Khairul shook his head.
“They get arrested.”
“They make the money.”
“Some.”
“They control the business.”
“Some.”
Rahman leaned forward.
“What are you saying?”
Khairul looked around the mamak before continuing.
“You look at loud people.”
“Because loud people are committing the crimes.”
“Yes.”
“Then?”
“Loud people change.”
Khairul picked up one piece of roti and ate it.

“Gang leader goes jail.”
Another.
“Second man gets shot.”
Another.
“Police raid club.”
The three piles disappeared.
But the glass, spoon and sugar container remained.
Khairul pointed.
“These people still there.”
Rahman studied the improvised diagram.
“Transporters.”
“Some.”
“Lawyers.”
“Some.”
“Warehouse people.”
“Some.”
“Middlemen?”
Khairul smiled.
“Better.”
“Brokers?”
“Sometimes.”
“People who arrange introductions.”
“Yes.”
“Are they criminals?”
Khairul considered this.
“Some days.”
Rahman frowned.
“That isn’t an answer.”
“It is border answer.”
“We’re not at border.”
“Same country.”
Rahman took another drink.
“What exactly do these people do?”
“Make things move.”
“Illegal things.”
“Legal also.”
“Give me names.”

Khairul laughed.
“No.”
“You called me.”
“To teach.”
“I didn’t ask for education.”
“You need.”
Rahman ignored the insult.
“Why tell me this?”
Khairul’s amusement faded.
“Because you keep arresting people who can be replaced.”
“That is police work.”
“Yes.”
“Then?”
“You think when you remove one group, road empty.”
Khairul shook his head.
“Road never empty.”
A lorry passed outside as if on cue.
Neither man commented.
Rahman said:
“You’re describing infrastructure.”
Khairul thought about the word.
“Maybe.”
“People who provide services to criminals.”
“Yes.”
“That isn’t new.”
“No.”
“Then what am I missing?”
Khairul stared into his tea.
“The same people help people who hate each other.”
Rahman went quiet.
Khairul continued.
“Two gangs fight.”
He made fists with both hands.
“They won’t sit same table.”
He opened them.
“But both use same man to move money.”
“Why?”

“Because he works.”

“Same lawyer?”

“Sometimes.”

“Same transporter?”

“Yes.”

“Same corrupt officer?”

Khairul looked at him.

Rahman noticed the change immediately.

“You know one?”

“No.”

“Khairul.”

He raised both hands.

“No.”

“Then why react?”

“Because now you make story bigger.”

Rahman watched him closely.

Khairul lowered his hands.

“I tell you simple thing.”

“Which is?”

“Criminals need ordinary things.”

“Transport.”

“Yes.”

“Storage.”

“Yes.”

“Lawyers.”

“Yes.”

“Money movement.”

Khairul nodded.

“Introductions.”

Another nod.

“But gang is not problem,” Khairul said.

“Then what is?”

“Gang run when police come. Problem is who tell them police coming.”

Rahman thought of the roadblock years earlier.

Drivers warning other drivers.

Tea shops.

Phone calls.
Nothing mysterious.
Nothing requiring a central organisation.
Just relationships.
“Information,” Rahman said.
Khairul stopped.
Rahman saw it.
“Information too.”
Khairul picked up his glass.
“Everybody need information.”
“What kind?”
“Who arrested.”
“Who talking.”
“Who owes money.”
“Who police watching.”
Rahman became still.
Khairul drank.
“Who tells them that?”
“Many people.”
“Police?”
“Sometimes police.”
“Who?”
Khairul sighed.
“You always want name.”
“Names are useful.”
“Names get old.”
“What does that mean?”
“Today one man. Tomorrow another.”
Rahman looked at him.
“What are you involved in now?”
Khairul smiled again.
“There he is.”
“Who?”
“Police.”
“I never left.”
“I know.”
Rahman leaned closer.

“If you are feeding me information because you want protection from someone, say it.”

“No.”

“If somebody is forcing you—”

“No.”

“If you are trying to make me attack competitors—”

Khairul rolled his eyes.

“You think too much.”

“You asked for me.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

For several seconds, Khairul did not answer.

Then:

“Because you remember.”

Rahman frowned.

“Remember what?”

“Everything.”

“That isn’t true.”

“More than other people.”

Khairul looked toward the road.

“You see lorry one time, four years later maybe still remember plate.”

“Maybe.”

“You see person with someone, you remember.”

Rahman waited.

Khairul shrugged.

“Useful.”

“To you?”

“Maybe one day.”

Rahman’s expression hardened.

“I am not your private database.”

Khairul laughed.

“No.”

Then more quietly:

“That why useful.”

Rahman did not like the answer.

* * *

They sat for another half hour.

Khairul gave no names.

Rahman extracted no confession.

No secret organisation emerged from the table.

Instead, Khairul described ordinary criminal ecology.

A bookmaker who used a legitimate courier company.

A car-theft group that rented storage from a businessman who claimed not to ask what tenants stored.

A lawyer who represented clients from several rival groups.

Drivers who moved cargo without asking about ownership.

Debt collectors who worked for whoever paid.

Clerks who sometimes searched public records for friends.

Nightclub managers who introduced people.

None of these facts alone proved coordination.

Most were not even automatically criminal.

That was what made the idea uncomfortable.

Rahman had spent years organising investigations around offences and offenders.

Khairul was describing connections between them.

Not a hierarchy.

A marketplace.

Rahman asked:

“Why don’t they betray each other?”

“They do.”

“Then how does any of this work?”

Khairul smiled.

“Same way police work.”

Rahman’s eyes hardened.

Khairul raised one hand.

“Listen first.”

Rahman said nothing.

“You don’t like every policeman.”

“No.”

“You trust every policeman?”

“No.”

“You still use same system.”

Rahman considered him.

Khairul continued.

"Criminal also."

"You're saying crime is an institution?"

Khairul laughed.

"No. Criminal too stupid for institution."

Rahman nearly smiled.

Khairul pointed at him.

"But people need people."

That was the simplest thing he had said all night.

It was also the most difficult to dismiss.

* * *

At 3:07 a.m., Khairul checked his watch.

"I go."

Rahman looked at him.

"That is all?"

"You want dessert?"

"You dragged me here to tell me criminals know transporters."

"No."

"Lawyers."

"No."

"Middlemen."

Khairul shook his head.

Rahman waited.

Khairul stood.

The mamak had become almost empty.

A worker wiped tables nearby.

The television showed football highlights.

Khairul placed cash beneath his glass.

Then looked down at Rahman.

"You keep looking at gangs."

Rahman said nothing.

"Wrong place."

"The gangs are committing the crimes."

"Yes."

"Then they're the problem."

Khairul shook his head.

"The gang isn't the problem."

Rahman looked up.

"What is?"

Khairul's expression lost its amusement.

For once, he looked entirely serious.

"The people who know when you're coming."

He walked away.

Rahman remained at the table.

Outside, Khairul crossed the road and disappeared between parked lorries.

Rahman looked at the objects still scattered across the plate.

Glass.

Spoon.

Sugar container.

The gangs were gone.

The connections remained.

He did not yet know whether Khairul had given him insight or simply another criminal's way of making himself seem important.

There was no evidence of anything larger.

No organisation.

No hidden command.

No grand design.

Only a simple possibility.

Police spent enormous effort watching criminals.

Perhaps criminals had become equally good at watching police.

Rahman finished the cold kopi.

Then took out his notebook.

CHAPTER EIGHT

THE NIGHT RAID

NORTH CORRIDOR — 2000

The rain began before briefing and did not stop.

By nine at night it had erased the hills beyond the operations compound and turned the road outside into a strip of reflected light.

Rahman stood beneath the covered walkway watching water pour from the roof.

Behind him, officers arrived one at a time.

No marked vehicles.

No uniforms except those packed inside bags.

No radios switched on until they entered the secure room.

The operation had no name.

That was deliberate.

Superintendent Harun Ismail had returned to the North Corridor three days earlier and immediately made everyone uncomfortable.

Not through anger.

Through questions.

Who had access to the surveillance reports?

Who printed the target maps?

Who serviced the vehicles?

Who prepared the warrant?

Who knew the actual location?

Who knew only the district?

Who knew only the departure time?

Rahman had watched officers begin answering confidently and finish less certain.

Harun had always possessed that effect.

Tonight he stood at the front of a windowless meeting room with a folded map behind him and twelve sealed envelopes on the table.

There were twenty-two officers in the operation.

Only twelve knew they would be raiding a warehouse.

Only six knew which warehouse.

Until now.

Harun checked the wall clock.

21:07.

“Doors.”

An inspector locked them.

Harun looked around the room.

“No telephone calls from this point.”

Nobody moved.

“If somebody needs to contact family, you should have done it already.”

An officer near the back raised his hand.

“Sir, estimated finish?”

“No.”

A few men smiled.

Harun did not.

“You finish when the operation finishes.”

He picked up the first envelope.

The room became quiet.

Rahman sat beside Inspector Faridah Noor, who had worked with him on the cigarette-lorry seizure the previous year.

She whispered:

“He looks happy.”

Rahman glanced at Harun.

“He never looks happy.”

“Exactly.”

Harun’s eyes moved toward them.

Faridah immediately faced forward.

Rahman did the same.

Harun began.

“For the last eleven weeks, regional intelligence has been monitoring a smuggling network moving contraband through the northern corridor.”

A photograph appeared on the board.

A warehouse surrounded by old rubber land.

Single-storey structure.

Corrugated roof.

Rear access road.

“Official tenant is Maju Sentosa Agricultural Supplies.”

Another photograph.

Fertiliser bags.

Plastic drums.

Farm equipment.

“Official business is agricultural distribution.”

Harun changed the photograph.

Night surveillance.

A covered lorry entering after midnight.

Another.

Two vans leaving before dawn.

Another.

Men unloading cartons.

“Unofficial business is more interesting.”

Nobody laughed.

Harun pointed to a map.

“The warehouse is believed to be a consolidation point for untaxed cigarettes, counterfeit goods and possibly narcotics moving south.”

Rahman studied the layout.

One main entrance.

Rear loading area.

Drainage canal along the western side.

Rubber estate east.

Secondary dirt road to the north.

Harun continued.

“Surveillance confirms activity tonight.”

Rahman looked at him.

That explained the urgency.

“How recent?” another officer asked.

“Less than ninety minutes.”

Good.

Rahman felt the operation become real.

Harun opened the first envelope.

“Team One.”

He handed it to the leader.

“Main gate.”

Second.

“Team Two. Rear loading bay.”

Third.

“Team Three. Eastern perimeter.”

Fourth.

“Road intercept.”

Nobody opened the envelopes yet.

Harun looked at them.

“You open these only when instructed.”

An officer frowned.

“Sir, we need route planning.”

“You already have route planning.”

“Without target?”

“You have the route to the release point.”

Now several men looked at one another.

Harun continued.

“At twenty-two hundred, all teams move separately to staging locations. Final coordinates will be issued ten minutes before deployment.”

Rahman understood.

Compartmentalisation.

Even now, most officers did not know exactly where they were going.

A senior inspector named Roslan raised a hand.

“This because of the last operation?”

The room changed slightly.

Harun’s face did not.

“What last operation?”

Roslan hesitated.

Everyone knew.

Two months earlier, customs and regional police had prepared an interception against a convoy carrying illegal cigarettes.

The convoy never appeared.

Neither did three vehicles observed using the route almost every night before the operation.

Maybe coincidence.

Nobody had proved otherwise.

Roslan said:

“Nothing, sir.”

Harun nodded.

“That is what I thought.”

He looked around the room.

“No discussion of previous failures tonight. We deal with the operation in front of us.”

But the previous failures remained in the room anyway.

* * *

At 21:42, Harun called Rahman aside.

They stood near a stack of folded riot shields.

“Your team takes rear access.”

Rahman nodded.

“Faridah with you.”

“Yes.”

“Four others.”

“Understood.”

Harun handed him a sealed envelope.

“Don’t open.”

Rahman accepted it.

“You trust me that little?”

Harun looked at him.

“I trust you enough not to take that personally.”

Rahman almost smiled.

“Who knows the target?”

Harun’s expression changed.

“You.”

“You.”

“Yes.”

“Who else?”

“People who need to.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is tonight.”

Rahman studied him.

Years earlier, that would have frustrated him more.

Now he recognised the boundary.

Harun said:

“Your job is not to know everything.”

“I know.”

“Do you?”

Rahman looked at the envelope.

“Yes.”

Harun nodded.

Then walked away.

* * *

They left the compound at ten.

Rain hammered the roof of the unmarked van.

Nobody spoke much.

Faridah drove.

Rahman sat beside her with the sealed envelope on his lap.

Four officers occupied the rear.

All wore plain dark clothing over protective vests.

Weapons secured.

Radios silent.

The van smelled of wet fabric, coffee and the rubber matting beneath their boots.

At 22:31 the radio came alive.

One click.

Then Harun’s voice.

“Proceed release point.”

Faridah turned onto a plantation road.

They drove another eleven minutes.

At 22:42:

“Open.”

Rahman tore the envelope.

Inside:

target coordinates.

A simple diagram.

Entry assignment.

Time:

23:05

Faridah glanced over.

“You know it?”

Rahman did.

He had passed the warehouse several times during unrelated investigations.

“Fifteen minutes.”

He turned to the officers behind.

“Listen.”

They leaned forward.

“Rear access. We hold the loading bay and northern track. Nobody enters the building until Team One announces breach unless immediate threat.”

One constable asked:

“Expected numbers?”

“Six to twelve.”

“Weapons?”

“Unknown.”

“Dogs?”

“Unknown.”

Faridah said:

“Very comforting.”

Rahman ignored her.

“No unnecessary movement. No hero work. If somebody runs, you identify yourself before pursuit. If you lose visual, you do not shoot at shadows.”

Nobody joked.

“Understood?”

Four nods.

Rahman looked out the window.

Rain streaked sideways through the headlights.

He thought of the border.

Warehouses.

Khairul.

The people who know when you’re coming.

Rahman pushed the thought away.

Tonight was not about Khairul.

Tonight was about one warehouse.

One operation.

One set of facts.

That discipline mattered.

* * *

At 22:58 they killed the headlights.

The van rolled the final distance in darkness.

The rain covered engine noise.

Good.

Also bad.

It covered everything else.

Rahman stepped out.

Water entered his shoes almost immediately.

Faridah moved beside him.

The team spread.

The warehouse stood eighty metres ahead.

No obvious external lights except one yellow bulb near the rear loading bay.

A lorry sat beneath the awning.

Another vehicle beside it.

Rahman's pulse changed.

Targets still present.

He lifted the radio.

"Rear team in position."

A voice answered.

"Hold."

They waited.

Rain.

Nothing else.

Rahman watched the loading bay.

No movement.

One minute.

Two.

At 23:04:

"Stand by."

Rahman raised one hand.

The officers tightened.
23:05.
Harun's voice:
"Go."
Team One hit the main entrance.
The crash of metal came faintly through the rain.
Rahman moved toward the rear.
Faridah beside him.
Two officers took the northern corner.
One covered the lorry.
Rahman reached the loading bay.
Door half open.
That was wrong.
He held up a hand.
They stopped.
From inside came a low mechanical hum.
Fan.
Maybe refrigerator.
No voices.
Rahman looked at Faridah.
She looked back.
He announced:
"Police!"
No answer.
Again.
"Police!"
Nothing.
Radio:
"Main entry clear."
Rahman's stomach tightened.
He moved inside.

* * *

The warehouse was warm.
That surprised him first.
Not empty.
Warm.

A ceiling fan turned above a folding table.

Another fan pushed damp air through a doorway.

The lights were on.

A pot sat on a portable gas stove.

Rahman moved past stacked cartons.

“Clear left.”

“Clear.”

“Office.”

“Clear.”

“Rear room.”

“Clear.”

Every word made the silence worse.

No suspects.

No workers.

No guards.

Nobody.

Team One appeared from the opposite side.

Harun entered behind them.

Rahman looked around.

There were cartons everywhere.

But many were empty.

Some stacked neatly.

Others open.

One pallet held agricultural chemicals exactly as the warehouse’s official paperwork claimed.

Nothing illegal immediately visible.

Faridah stopped beside the folding table.

“Sir.”

Rahman joined her.

Four plates.

Rice.

Fried egg.

Fish.

One plastic container of sambal.

Rahman held his hand over a plate without touching.

Warm.

Not hot.

Warm.

A metal cup beside it still held tea.

Steam barely visible.

Harun came over.

He looked.

Then at the surrounding room.

“How long?”

Rahman said:

“Minutes.”

Faridah pointed toward the stove.

“Gas still on low.”

One officer called from the rear.

“Sir.”

They moved.

Near the loading entrance, an ashtray sat on a crate.

Several cigarette ends.

One still carried a thin thread of smoke.

Harun crouched.

Did not touch.

Rahman stared at it.

Faridah said softly:

“They were here.”

Nobody answered.

The warehouse suddenly felt inhabited by absence.

A shirt hanging from a nail.

Cards abandoned mid-game.

A mobile-phone charger plugged into the wall with no phone attached.

Wet footprints leading toward the northern exit.

An opened soft drink.

Two motorcycle helmets.

An office drawer left open.

On the floor near the rear door:

a broken elastic band and several small notes of currency.

Somebody had left quickly.

Very quickly.

Harun stood.

“Seal every exit.”
An officer said:
“Already done.”
“Search perimeter.”
“Teams moving.”
Harun turned to Rahman.
“Vehicles?”
“Lorry and van outside.”
“Keys?”
“Checking.”
Rahman radioed.
The lorry keys were missing.
The van keys were on the driver’s seat.
Harun looked toward the north side of the building.
“Track?”
Rahman moved with two officers.
Behind the warehouse, rainwater ran through ruts in the dirt.
Several tyre marks.
Fresh.
Difficult to read under the rain.
One set led away toward plantation roads.
Motorcycles, probably.
Maybe more.
The rear perimeter team had seen nothing.
Rahman asked:
“When did you arrive?”
“Twenty-two fifty-six.”
“Anyone pass?”
“No, sir.”
“You sure?”
“Yes.”
The answer came defensively.
Rahman stopped himself.
No accusation.
Not yet.
He walked back inside.
Harun was standing beside the table.

Looking at the food.

Not moving.

Rahman knew that posture.

He was thinking.

* * *

The search took forty minutes.

No contraband.

No narcotics.

No untaxed cigarettes.

No documents naming suppliers.

Nothing proportional to eleven weeks of surveillance.

Only legitimate stock.

Empty cartons.

A few tools.

Personal items.

The intelligence had not been wrong.

Surveillance photographs proved material had been moved through the building.

But tonight, somebody had removed whatever mattered.

And left dinner behind.

Rahman checked his watch.

23:51.

Harun called the team leaders together.

“Who knew the final target?”

Nobody answered immediately.

Harun looked at Roslan.

“You.”

“Yes.”

“Since when?”

“Briefing room. After envelopes opened.”

“Exact time.”

“Ten-forty-two.”

Harun looked at Faridah.

“You?”

“When Inspector Rahman opened the envelope.”

“Rahman?”

“Same.”
Harun continued around the group.
Times.
Access.
Routes.
Harun asked who used a telephone after briefing.
Nobody.
Who left the secure area?
Two officers had gone to the toilet.
One technician had serviced a radio fault.
A driver had changed vehicles after a battery problem.
All ordinary.
Potentially meaningless.
Potentially not.
Rahman watched the expressions around him.
Irritation.
Embarrassment.
Suspicion beginning to form.
Harun saw it too.
“Stop.”
The room quieted.
“Nobody accuses anybody.”
He pointed around them.
“We don’t know what happened.”
One inspector said:
“They were tipped.”
Harun looked at him.
“We don’t know that.”
“The food is warm.”
“That proves they left recently.”
“They left before us.”
“Yes.”
“They knew.”
Harun’s expression hardened.
“That is an interpretation.”
The inspector looked away.
Harun continued.

"Could be coincidence. Could be surveillance detection. Could be somebody outside saw vehicles moving. Could be one of them got nervous. Could be information leaked."

He let the last possibility sit.

"Until evidence separates those possibilities, all of them remain possibilities."

Rahman heard Harun's old lesson inside the words.

Your first enemy is the story you have already decided to believe.

But this time the lesson felt heavier.

Because Rahman already had a story.

Khairul at the mamak.

The people who know when you're coming.

* * *

At one in the morning, rain still fell.

The search teams worked through the warehouse.

Photographs.

Fingerprints.

Vehicle examinations.

Documents seized for review.

Rahman stood beneath the rear awning drinking coffee from a paper cup.

Harun joined him.

For a while neither spoke.

Water poured from the roof in a continuous curtain.

Rahman said:

"They knew."

Harun looked out into the rain.

"Maybe."

"The food."

"Yes."

"The cigarette."

"Yes."

"Fresh tracks."

"Yes."

"No contraband."

"Yes."

Rahman turned toward him.
“You don’t believe coincidence.”
Harun remained quiet.
“That isn’t the same as proving a leak.”
“No.”
“But you believe it.”
Harun looked at him.
Rahman recognised the distinction.
Belief.
Evidence.
Again.
“How many people knew?”
“Enough.”
“That isn’t useful.”
“It is accurate.”
“Someone had to tell them.”
“Maybe.”
Rahman almost laughed from frustration.
“Sir.”
Harun looked faintly amused.
“Still hate the word?”
“Yes.”
“Good.”
Rahman stared at the rain.
“There have been other operations.”
“Yes.”
“Targets changing behaviour.”
“Yes.”
“Vehicles disappearing.”
“Yes.”
“Now this.”
Harun said nothing.
Rahman turned.
“Is that why tonight was compartmentalised?”
“Yes.”
The answer came without hesitation.
“And it still failed.”

Harun looked back through the open warehouse door.

Officers moved around the abandoned food.

The spinning fans.

The ashtray.

The empty pallets.

"Yes."

Rahman felt something settle inside him.

Not certainty about who.

Certainty about the problem.

"You expected this?"

"No."

"But you were afraid of it."

Harun took a slow drink.

"Yes."

"Why didn't you tell us?"

"What would I tell you?"

"That we might have a leak."

Harun looked at him.

"And then?"

Rahman had no answer.

"If the leak is real," Harun continued, "telling everyone we suspect a leak tells the leak too."

Rahman looked toward the officers inside.

Men he knew.

Men he had worked with.

Men who had stood beside him in arrests.

Some younger.

Some senior.

Some exhausted and wet and angry because the operation had failed.

He disliked where his mind was going.

Harun saw it.

"Don't."

"Don't what?"

"Start choosing."

Rahman said nothing.

"You will look at every officer in that room and build a reason."

Harun nodded toward the warehouse.

"Don't."

"What if one of them did it?"

"Then evidence will have to take us there."

"And until then?"

"We work."

Rahman breathed out.

Rain mist blew beneath the awning.

Harun's shirt was wet at one shoulder.

For once he looked older.

Rahman said:

"Years ago, you told me the thief outside the station worried you less than the man who could rewrite what happened afterward."

Harun remembered.

Rahman continued.

"This feels different."

"Yes."

"The report isn't being changed."

"No."

"The evidence isn't disappearing after we collect it."

"No."

Rahman looked inside.

"They moved before we arrived."

Harun said nothing.

Rahman understood.

Room 17 had taught him what happened when somebody interfered after police acted.

Tonight had shown him something more dangerous.

What if somebody could interfere before police acted at all?

An investigation could be destroyed without altering a single page.

A target only needed time.

Five minutes.

Ten.

Enough to close a door.

Move a vehicle.

Clear a warehouse.

Finish almost all of dinner.

Rahman thought again of Khairul.

Not a gang.

Not a grand secret.

Only people watching people.

Drivers.

Shopkeepers.

Officers.

Phones.

Habits.

Maybe that was all this was.

Maybe somebody had seen them.

Maybe somebody had called.

Maybe.

Harun placed his empty cup on the railing.

"Rahman."

"Yes?"

"Look inside."

Rahman did.

The fan still turned above the abandoned table.

One plate had a spoon resting in the rice.

A chair stood pushed back at an angle, as though its occupant had risen suddenly.

The cigarette in the ashtray had finally gone out.

Harun's voice came quietly beside him.

"Now you understand."

Rahman did.

Not who.

Not how.

Not how far it went.

Only this:

Someone had known enough.

And whatever had happened tonight, the police had arrived second.

CHAPTER NINE

THE PHOTOGRAPH

KOTA ARUNA — 2000

Harun did not show Rahman the photograph at headquarters.

Rahman would remember that afterwards more clearly than the photograph itself.

He waited until the afternoon briefing ended, until the last detective had carried his files out, until the corridor outside the temporary operations room had gone quiet. Then he took a thin brown envelope from beneath a stack of intelligence summaries and said, “Come.”

Rahman glanced at the envelope.

“Where?”

“Somewhere with bad coffee.”

“That narrows nothing.”

Harun almost smiled.

They drove in Harun’s unmarked Proton through the old administrative quarter of Kota Aruna, past government buildings whose white paint had surrendered to rain and traffic soot. The afternoon was heavy, the sky low over the city, but the storm had not yet broken.

Harun chose a coffee shop near the old courthouse.

Not hidden.

Not secure.

Just ordinary enough that nobody would wonder why two policemen were there.

The place served civil servants, court clerks, lawyers, delivery drivers and men who seemed to have no employment except reading newspapers slowly. Ceiling fans pushed warm air in tired circles. A radio behind the counter played an old Malay song through static.

Harun ordered kopi without sugar.

Rahman ordered tea.

Neither spoke until the drinks arrived.

Then Harun placed the brown envelope on the table and rested one hand over it.

“Tell me what you see.”

Rahman looked at him.

“I haven’t seen anything yet.”

“That is a useful condition. Try to keep it.”

Harun slid one photograph from the envelope.

Black and white.

Long lens.

Taken from across a restaurant.

Assistant Commissioner Ramli Osman sat at a corner table facing Goh Kian Boon.

Rahman knew both men.

Everybody in their part of the service knew Ramli.

Senior officer. Good operational record. Controlled manner. A reputation for remembering junior officers’ names and never raising his voice in meetings.

Goh Kian Boon was different.

Businessman on paper.

His name had appeared at the edges of gambling investigations, stolen cargo, protection complaints and several unexplained warehouse transfers. Each time, the case had reached one of his employees, one of his tenants, one of his business partners or somebody who knew somebody who worked for him.

Never Goh himself.

In the photograph, Ramli was smiling.

Goh leaned toward him across the table.

No uniform.

No other police officer visible.

No file on the table.

No obvious reason for them to be together.

Rahman felt the answer arrive before caution could stop it.

“That is the leak.”

Harun did not react.

Rahman looked up.

"You disagree?"

"I asked what you see."

"I see a senior police officer meeting a criminal businessman."

"Good."

"That is not enough?"

"For what?"

Rahman looked back at the photograph.

"They know each other."

"Probably."

"Ramli is smiling."

"People smile at enemies."

"Goh is leaning in."

"So are you."

Rahman sat back.

Harun uncovered a second photograph.

Same restaurant.

Ramli arriving alone.

Third.

Goh already seated.

Fourth.

Ramli glancing toward the entrance.

Fifth.

A waiter pouring tea.

Sixth.

Goh speaking.

Seventh.

Ramli listening.

Seventeen photographs in all.

Harun arranged them across the table in sequence.

The meeting lasted forty-three minutes.

Goh arrived first.

Ramli came nine minutes later.

They ate.

They spoke.

At one point Goh handed Ramli something too small to identify clearly.

A business card.

A folded receipt.
A slip of paper.
Maybe nothing more than sugar sachets being moved out of the way.
The camera angle did not tell them.
Nothing changed the basic fact.
Nothing proved what Rahman wanted it to prove.
Harun tapped the first image.
“What does this establish?”
“They met.”
“Good.”
“The meeting was planned.”
“Why?”
“Goh arrived first. Ramli arrived alone.”
“That proves sequence, not arrangement.”
Rahman looked at him.
Harun said, “Again.”
“They were comfortable with each other.”
“Interpretation.”
“Ramli stayed forty-three minutes.”
“Fact.”
“They spoke privately.”
“Probably.”
“They exchanged something.”
“Maybe.”
Rahman exhaled.
“You can do this forever.”
“Yes.”
Harun gathered three photographs and placed them aside.
“That is why we have rules.”
Rahman disliked the answer.
He disliked the exercise more.
“Give me alternatives.”
“Authorised intelligence contact.”
“Yes.”
“Goh could be an informant.”
“Yes.”
“Ramli could be handling him.”

“Yes.”

“Official meeting.”

“Possible.”

“Personal business.”

“Yes.”

“Family matter.”

“Possible.”

“Coincidence?”

“For forty-three minutes?”

“Unlikely is not impossible.”

Rahman looked again at Goh’s face.

“Corruption.”

“Yes.”

Harun nodded.

“Also possible.”

Rahman lowered his voice.

“Which do you believe?”

“That is another bad question.”

“Why?”

“Because what I believe can become a shortcut.”

Harun drank his kopi.

“Your instinct tells you where to look. Evidence tells you what you may say.”

Rahman looked toward the street.

A court clerk hurried across the road carrying files beneath one arm.

A traffic policeman stood beneath a tree, writing something in a small notebook.

Ordinary city.

Ordinary afternoon.

The photograph felt less dramatic here than it had in Rahman’s mind.

That bothered him.

Harun reached into the envelope again.

Two older photographs.

In the first, a detective sat inside a parked car with a bookmaker.

In the second, a uniformed inspector stood outside a restaurant beside a known smuggler.

“Which looks more corrupt?” Harun asked.

Rahman studied both.

The detective's face was partly hidden.

The bookmaker appeared to be passing him an envelope.

The uniformed inspector was smiling beside the smuggler.

"Both."

Harun waited.

Rahman corrected himself.

"Neither. Not from the photograph alone."

"Good."

Harun tapped the first image.

"Authorised source meeting. Detective later received a commendation."

Then the second.

"Inspector convicted three years later for taking money."

He placed Ramli's photograph between them.

"Which one looks different?"

"It doesn't."

"No."

Rain began lightly against the coffee-shop awning.

The air changed.

Harun gathered the two old photographs but left Ramli's on the table.

"Truth can become visible before it becomes provable."

Rahman said nothing.

"That gap is where investigators get hurt."

"Because we move too early?"

"Or too late."

Harun looked out toward the street.

For a few seconds, his expression went somewhere else.

"Hamid disappeared because I did not understand soon enough what kind of problem I was looking at."

The name changed the air more than the rain.

Constable Hamid Rahim.

Room 17.

Altered statement.

Missing watch.

Transfer order with no destination.

A policeman who had asked to meet Harun and then vanished into administration.

Rahman had learned not to ask about him in open rooms.

Here, he asked.

"You think Ramli connects to Hamid?"

"I think I have a photograph."

"That is all?"

"For now."

"You must suspect something."

Harun looked at him.

"Of course."

"What?"

"That if I tell you my suspicion before you build your own evidence, I may damage both."

Rahman disliked that too.

Harun saw it.

"Being senior does not make my theory safer than yours."

"No."

"It makes it more dangerous."

"Because people listen."

"Exactly."

Rahman looked down at Ramli Osman.

Senior officer.

Good record.

Respected.

A man whose signature could move people, authorise searches, reassign personnel and ask questions that made other people nervous.

And a man drinking tea with Goh Kian Boon.

"Will you investigate him?"

"Yes."

"Internal?"

"Quietly."

"Does he know?"

"If he is innocent, he should not be damaged by our suspicion."

"And if he is guilty?"

"He should not know where our suspicion begins."

Rahman nodded.

Harun slid the photograph back into the envelope.

“Start at the edges.”

“What edges?”

“Where he was. What he signed. Who had reason to contact him. Which files crossed his desk. Which meetings were authorised.”

“And bank accounts?”

“Later.”

“Why later?”

“Because money is seductive.”

Rahman frowned.

“Seductive?”

“It looks objective. A number appears, you think the number explains the man.”

Harun stood.

“It rarely does.”

They spent the next three weeks investigating the edges.

No dramatic surveillance.

No hidden microphones.

No sudden midnight search.

Harun requested duty rosters, travel claims, authorised contact records and historical case assignments through channels narrow enough not to create gossip.

Rahman built a chronology.

Ramli had been in the same district as Goh during two earlier investigations.

So had thirty-one other officers.

Ramli had once approved a transfer involving an officer later suspected of gambling debt.

The transfer request had originated two levels below him and was supported by medical documentation.

Ramli’s brother owned a trading company that had used a warehouse leased from a cousin of one of Goh’s associates.

The tenancy predated the criminal investigation and ended without incident.

Ramli had attended two business-association dinners where Goh was also present.

So had judges, customs officers, elected representatives, bankers and half the commercial establishment of Kota Aruna.

Each discovery felt close enough to matter.

None survived the next question.

“Could this happen if he were innocent?” Harun asked.

Usually, the answer was yes.

Rahman began to understand why experienced investigators sometimes became reckless or timid.

Doubt was exhausting.

Certainty was easier.

One night, after six hours of document review, Rahman circled Ramli’s name on a photocopied meeting list.

Harun watched.

“Why?”

“Third appearance.”

“Three appearances in what period?”

“Fourteen months.”

“How many meetings total?”

Rahman checked.

“Seventy-eight.”

“So?”

Rahman uncircled the name.

Harun said nothing.

That was worse.

Rahman put down his pen.

“You enjoy this.”

“No.”

“You do.”

Harun shook his head.

“I enjoy watching a theory survive attack.”

“Mine is not surviving.”

“Then it is saving you time.”

Rahman leaned back.

The temporary office smelled of paper, instant coffee and old air-conditioning.

“What if he is guilty and we explain everything away?”

“That is a real risk.”

“And what if he is innocent and we keep digging until something looks dirty?”

“Also real.”

“How do you know when to stop?”

Harun looked at the file.

“You don’t.”

“That is not useful.”

“No.”

Harun closed the folder.

“You decide when the evidence has either grown or failed to grow. Then you record why.”

“Record doubt?”

“Especially doubt.”

Rahman looked at him.

Harun added, “A file that contains only what supports your theory is not an investigation. It is advertising.”

One evening Harun took him to the restaurant from the photograph.

It stood in an old row of shophouses behind the court complex, popular with businessmen who wanted private rooms without hotel prices.

They chose a table with a clear view of the corner where Ramli and Goh had sat.

The manager remembered Goh.

Everyone remembered Goh.

“He comes sometimes,” the manager said.

“With many people?”

“Businessmen. Lawyers. Government people.”

“Police?”

The manager shrugged.

“Maybe. Many government people look like police.”

Rahman showed him Ramli’s official photograph without identifying him.

The manager squinted.

“Possible.”

“You remember him?”

“Face looks familiar.”

“From this restaurant?”

“Maybe from newspaper.”

Harun watched silently.

Rahman asked, “Did Goh meet this man here?”

The manager looked again.

“Could be.”

“Did they argue?”

The manager laughed.

“No idea.”

“Who paid?”

“Don’t know.”

“Anyone join them?”

“Don’t remember.”

“Did Goh give him anything?”

The manager frowned.

“Brother, that was months ago.”

Outside, Harun said, “Useful?”

“No.”

“It tells us memory is not a camera.”

Rahman looked through the restaurant window.

“Then why photograph people at all?”

“Because cameras forget less.”

Harun opened the car door.

“They just understand nothing.”

Two days later, a Special Intelligence liaison confirmed that Ramli had participated in authorised contact with businessmen connected to gambling investigations during the same period.

The confirmation came in a one-page note.

No source names.

No operational details.

Only enough to establish that Ramli had legitimate reason, at least sometimes, to meet men like Goh Kian Boon.

Rahman read it twice.

“This clears him?”

Harun shook his head.

“No.”

“It explains the meeting.”

“It explains why such a meeting could be legitimate.”

“That is almost the same thing.”

"It is not."

"Can we ask whether Goh was an authorised contact?"

"Not through this channel."

"Why?"

"Compartmentalisation."

Rahman looked irritated.

Harun said, "The institution can hide corruption behind secrecy. It can also protect legitimate work with the same secrecy. Your job is to know the difference without pretending the difference is obvious."

Rahman looked at the note.

The confirmation made Ramli's corruption less certain.

He felt almost disappointed.

Harun noticed.

"That feeling will ruin you if you feed it."

"What feeling?"

"Wanting your suspicion to be right because you have invested in it."

"I want the truth."

"Everybody says that."

Harun took the note back.

"Most people want their version of the truth to win."

Rahman stared at him.

"You think that is what I am doing?"

"I think you are human."

A week later, the discreet review of Ramli Osman was reduced.

Not closed.

Reduced.

No unexplained money.

No suspicious assets.

No evidence of unauthorised disclosure tied to the failed warehouse raid.

No witness placing him inside any criminal arrangement.

No document establishing that his meeting with Goh was corrupt.

Rahman disliked the unfinished ending.

"So that is it?"

"For now."

"What if he is the leak?"

Harun looked at him.

"Then facts will have to become less shy."
Rahman almost smiled.
Almost.
Harun removed the original photograph from the case folder.
He placed it in a fresh envelope and handed it to Rahman.
"Keep it."
"Why?"
"To remind you."
"Of Ramli?"
"No."
Harun tapped the envelope.
"Of the distance between seeing the truth and proving the truth."
Rahman accepted it.
"Will we ever know what they were talking about?"
"Maybe."
"And if we don't?"
Harun picked up the remaining file.
"Then we don't."
Rahman looked at him.
"That doesn't bother you?"
"Yes."
"You don't look bothered."
"That is practice."
Harun walked toward the door.
Rahman stayed seated for another moment.
The photograph lay in his hand.
Two men at a table.
One with a criminal reputation.
One with police authority.
A smile.
A conversation.
A gesture across a table.
Everything visible.
Almost nothing known.
Years later, Rahman would forget the restaurant manager's face.
He would forget most of the vehicle logs and meeting lists.
He would forget which day the Special Intelligence note arrived.

He would remember the photograph.

Not because it proved Ramli Osman corrupt.

Because it did not.

That was the lesson.

Seeing was not proving.

Suspicion was not evidence.

A pattern was not a conclusion.

The most dangerous moment in an investigation was sometimes the instant a fact looked exactly like the answer you wanted.

CHAPTER TEN

THE PRICE OF SILENCE

KOTA ARUNA — 2000

The file was six years old and still had no ending.

Harun placed it on the conference table just after seven in the morning.

CASE 17/94.

The original cover had once been cream. Years of handling had turned the edges grey. Additional volumes sat beneath it, held together by cotton tape and labels from three different offices.

Rahman had seen the number before.

On copied statements.

On warehouse photographs.

On the back of a vehicle-registration request.

In Harun's handwriting beside names that seemed unrelated until they appeared for a second or third time.

He had never seen the whole file assembled.

"Is that all of it?" he asked.

Harun looked at the stack.

"No."

Rahman waited.

Harun added, "That is part of the problem."

Outside the conference room, headquarters was beginning its morning noise. Telephones. Lift doors. Shoes in the corridor. A printer starting and stopping somewhere beyond the wall.

Inside, Harun opened the first volume.

The investigation had begun in 1994 with organised gambling and protection payments in three districts.

It should have stayed ordinary.

Bookmakers.

Collectors.

Small businessmen paying to avoid trouble.

Police names mentioned by frightened people who later withdrew what they had said.

Then transport companies appeared.

Warehouse leases.

A customs forwarding firm.

A lawyer representing men from supposedly rival groups.

A businessman who knew another businessman who could make an introduction.

Nothing extraordinary by itself.

That was what made the file difficult.

Harun turned to a relationship diagram.

The page was crowded with names and arrows.

Some lines ended with question marks.

Some had been crossed out.

Several names carried the note NO LINK FOUND.

Rahman recognised one.

Goh Kian Boon.

Another.

Ramli Osman.

The photograph had earned a place in the file, but not the place Rahman once wanted.

Beside Ramli's name Harun had written:

MEETING CONFIRMED. PURPOSE NOT ESTABLISHED.

Rahman looked at him.

"You kept him in."

"I kept the fact in."

"Same difference."

"No."

Harun closed the diagram.

"You still want him to be guilty."

"I want to know."

"That is better."

Harun pulled another sheet forward.

Three groups investigated over four years.

Different offences.

Different districts.

Different visible leaders.

The same freight broker had serviced two.

The same legal firm had represented people in all three.

The same commercial lender had restructured debts for businesses connected to two investigations.

One police contact appeared in a witness account, then disappeared from later statements.

Another officer had transferred shortly after a complaint.

No single line proved coordination.

Together, the repetitions had begun to trouble Harun.

Rahman pointed to the page.

“You think they work together.”

“I think they use some of the same people.”

“That is working together.”

“No.”

Harun shook his head.

“Rivals can use the same lawyer. Criminals can use the same transporter. Half the city can know the same fixer.”

“Then what are we looking at?”

Harun leaned back.

“That is what I want permission to find out.”

Rahman looked at the stack.

“You don’t have permission?”

“I have permission to investigate cases.”

“This is a case.”

“Not anymore.”

The answer stayed with him.

Harun tapped the file.

“Cases begin with offences. This has become relationships.”

“And relationships are not crimes.”

“Correct.”

“So?”

“So the moment I ask to investigate the relationships themselves, I am asking the service to examine people who may never have committed an offence.”

Rahman understood.

"Police included."

"Yes."

That was the dangerous part.

Not because the file proved widespread corruption.

It did not.

Because it contained enough repeated contact to make senior people uncomfortable and not enough proof to tell them exactly what the discomfort meant.

Harun stood.

"Bring your notebook."

"Where?"

"Upstairs."

Rahman looked at the case volumes.

"Meeting?"

Harun tied the first stack closed.

"Yes."

"With who?"

"People who will decide whether this stays an investigation."

He looked at Rahman.

"Or becomes a secret."

They took the lift to the sixth floor.

Rahman had been there twice before.

The offices were quieter.

Carpets thicker.

Doors farther apart.

Nobody hurried in the corridor.

Senior authority had its own acoustics.

A secretary led them into a meeting room with polished wood walls and a long table.

Four people were already inside.

A Deputy Director from Criminal Investigation.

An Assistant Director from Internal Affairs, before the directorate had adopted its later name.

A legal adviser Rahman knew only by reputation.

And a man Rahman had not met.

Young for the room.

Early thirties.

Dark suit.

No unnecessary papers in front of him.

Superintendent Farid Kamal from Special Intelligence.

Harun introduced Rahman without embellishment.

"Inspector Rahman Aziz. He worked the North Corridor pieces and the recent warehouse operation."

Farid looked at him for one second longer than politeness required.

"Your raid was leaked."

Rahman answered, "Possibly."

Farid's expression changed slightly.

"Possibly?"

"We had advance departure. We do not know how they knew."

Farid nodded once.

"Good."

The Deputy Director gestured for them to sit.

"This is not a briefing. We are here because Superintendent Harun has requested formal expansion of 17/94 into a cross-directorate inquiry."

Harun said, "Correct."

The Deputy Director looked at the file.

"Into what, exactly?"

Harun had prepared for the question.

He opened one page.

"Organised criminal facilitation, including possible police compromise, commercial intermediaries and repeated information movement between groups that appear operationally separate."

The legal adviser frowned.

"That is not a charge."

"No."

"Not even one offence."

"No."

"Then define the investigative predicate."

Harun said, "Repeated obstruction patterns. Witness withdrawal. Target foreknowledge. Overlapping intermediaries. Evidence irregularities."

The Internal Affairs officer asked, "Named police suspects?"

"Some names."

"Evidence?"

"Mixed."

"That means no."

"That means mixed."

The officer's mouth tightened.

Harun did not.

The Deputy Director turned to Farid.

"Special Intelligence?"

Farid opened the thin folder in front of him.

"We have related reporting."

Harun looked at him.

"How related?"

"Commercial facilitators appearing across multiple organised-crime subjects."

"Names?"

"Some overlap."

"Which?"

Farid did not answer immediately.

"Source-protected."

Harun's jaw tightened.

"There is always a protected source when someone doesn't want to answer."

Farid met his eyes.

"And there is always an investigator who thinks source protection is an excuse until the source is dead."

The room went quiet.

Rahman watched both men.

No hostility in Farid's voice.

No disrespect.

That made the disagreement sharper.

The Deputy Director said, "Enough."

Farid turned one page.

"Our assessment is that Superintendent Harun is correct about one thing."

Harun waited.

"Several criminal investigations are touching the same service relationships."

Rahman felt the room change.

The legal adviser asked, “Service relationships?”

“Transport. Finance. Legal access. Introductions. Information.”

Harun said, “Police protection.”

Farid looked at him.

“Sometimes, perhaps.”

“You have reporting.”

“I have intelligence.”

“Same thing when convenient.”

“No.”

Farid’s voice stayed calm.

“Intelligence may tell me where to look. It does not always tell you what you can prove.”

Rahman thought of Harun in the coffee shop.

Your instinct tells you where to look. Evidence tells you what you may say.

The same principle.

Different conclusion.

Harun heard it too.

“You think we should wait.”

“I think we should map.”

“For how long?”

“Until we understand what connects the contacts.”

“People are already being warned.”

“Maybe.”

“Witnesses have changed statements.”

“Yes.”

“Files have been altered.”

“Yes.”

“A raid was compromised.”

“Possibly.”

Harun glanced toward Rahman.

Farid had returned the word deliberately.

Rahman noticed.

Harun said, “And your answer is more intelligence.”

“My answer is less noise.”

Harun leaned forward.

“Noise?”

“If we open a visible cross-directorate integrity inquiry now, everyone whose name appears in this file will change behaviour.”

“Good.”

“Not if you want to know what they are doing.”

“I want to stop what they are doing.”

Farid’s eyes remained steady.

“You do not yet know what that is.”

The room went still again.

Rahman disliked Farid in that moment.

Not personally.

Intellectually.

Because the argument was difficult to dismiss.

Harun said, “If an officer is selling information, we investigate the officer.”

“Yes.”

“If a businessman is paying him, we investigate the businessman.”

“Yes.”

“If someone is altering evidence, we secure the evidence.”

“Yes.”

“So what exactly are you asking us not to do?”

Farid closed his folder.

“I am asking you not to announce to every compromised relationship that we have finally noticed the pattern.”

Harun stared at him.

“Pattern.”

“Yes.”

“You believe there is one.”

“I believe repetition deserves explanation.”

Harun sat back.

For the first time that morning, he looked almost satisfied.

“Then approve the inquiry.”

“No.”

The satisfaction disappeared.

Farid continued.

“Not as you have framed it.”

“Why?”

"Because you are trying to turn an intelligence map into a criminal case before you know whether the centre exists."

"There may be no centre."

"Exactly."

The sentence landed harder than Rahman expected.

Harun looked at the relationship diagram.

Farid said, "What if there is no organisation? What if these are recurring facilitators used by different groups for different reasons?"

"Then we establish that."

"Publicly?"

"Formally."

"And if one of those facilitators is also an authorised source?"

Harun said nothing.

"If one police contact is legitimate and another corrupt?"

Silence.

"If one transport company carries contraband on Monday and controlled intelligence cargo on Friday?"

The Deputy Director looked sharply at Farid.

Farid stopped there.

Too much already.

Harun noticed.

"So that is it."

"What?"

"You are already using some of them."

Farid's expression did not change.

"I did not say that."

"You didn't need to."

The Deputy Director cut in.

"Superintendent Harun."

Harun looked at him.

The warning was clear.

Rahman felt something colder than suspicion.

Not proof of corruption.

Compartmentalisation.

Different parts of the police touching the same people for different purposes and refusing to show one another why.

He understood suddenly how a criminal relationship could hide inside legitimate secrecy.

And how legitimate secrecy could look exactly like corruption from outside.

The legal adviser folded his hands.

"We need a decision."

The Deputy Director looked first at Harun.

"Your recommendation?"

"Formal cross-directorate inquiry. Controlled access. Documented integrity review of every police name. Preservation of all related records. No administrative transfers without notification to the inquiry."

The last point was deliberate.

Hamid.

Everyone in the room who knew the history understood.

The Deputy Director turned to Farid.

"Yours?"

"Retain 17/94 under restricted intelligence status. Build a joint analytical map. Validate each police association before referral. No overt action against intermediaries solely on relationship evidence."

Harun said, "That is containment."

Farid looked at him.

"That is investigation."

"No."

"That is patience."

"No."

Farid waited.

Harun's voice lowered.

"That is silence."

The word stayed on the table.

No one moved.

Farid said, "Silence can protect an investigation."

Harun answered, "It can also protect what the investigation is supposed to find."

Neither man raised his voice.

Rahman understood, much later, that this was the beginning of the argument that would outlive one of them.

The Deputy Director called a short recess.

Harun walked into the corridor.

Rahman followed.

For several seconds Harun said nothing.

Then, “What do you think?”

Rahman had expected instruction, not the question.

“Farid is right about some of it.”

Harun looked at him.

Rahman continued carefully.

“If Special Intelligence has authorised contacts in the same network, a broad inquiry could expose them.”

“Yes.”

“And if we act too early, people change behaviour.”

“Yes.”

“But if we wait, they keep doing whatever they are doing.”

“Yes.”

Rahman exhaled.

“So both choices are bad.”

Harun looked toward the closed meeting-room door.

“Welcome to senior policing.”

Rahman almost smiled.

Harun did not.

“What would you choose?” Rahman asked.

“Action.”

“Even if it burns sources?”

“Not blindly.”

“But faster than Farid.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

Harun looked at him.

“Because institutions are very good at learning to live with temporary measures.”

Rahman said nothing.

“Restriction becomes procedure. Procedure becomes habit. Habit becomes nobody’s decision.”

Harun looked back toward the room.

“And then one day everyone can explain why nothing happened.”

The meeting resumed twenty minutes later.

The decision was already made.

Rahman could tell before anyone spoke.

The Deputy Director read from a handwritten note.

Case 17/94 would remain active but restricted.

No formal cross-directorate criminal-conspiracy inquiry would be opened.

A smaller intelligence working group would examine recurring intermediaries.

Police names would be validated before any integrity referral.

Distribution of the relationship map would be limited.

Existing criminal investigations could continue on their own evidence.

Harun asked, “Who controls the working group?”

The Deputy Director answered, “Jointly.”

“That means?”

“Criminal Investigation and Special Intelligence.”

Harun looked at Farid.

Farid did not look pleased.

That mattered.

He had won the argument and did not behave like a man who had won anything.

Harun asked, “Internal Affairs?”

“Referral basis only.”

“Meaning after validation.”

“Yes.”

“By us.”

“Yes.”

Harun closed the file.

“I want my objection recorded.”

The legal adviser said, “It will be.”

“Full objection.”

“Yes.”

“Not a summary.”

The Deputy Director’s patience thinned.

“Yes, Harun.”

Harun stood.

“Then I have nothing else.”

Farid spoke before he reached the door.

“Superintendent.”

Harun stopped.

Farid said, “I am not asking you to stop.”

Harun turned.

“What are you asking?”

“To understand the whole system before we tell it we are coming.”

Harun looked at him for a long moment.

Then said, “And while we are understanding it?”

Farid did not answer.

Harun left.

Rahman followed.

In the lift, neither spoke.

At the ground floor, Harun walked past the main exit and continued toward the records wing.

Rahman caught up.

“Where are we going?”

“To make copies.”

Rahman stopped.

Harun kept walking.

“Of what?”

“Everything we are allowed to have.”

“Why?”

Harun turned.

“Because restricted files become difficult to find.”

“That sounds paranoid.”

“Yes.”

“You say that like it doesn’t bother you.”

“It bothers me.”

Harun continued walking.

“It also makes me useful.”

The copying took most of the afternoon.

Not secret copies.

Not stolen documents.

Harun logged access where required.

He copied his own analysis, statements already within his authority, photographs, public company records, selected routing sheets and the relationship diagrams he had created.

He did not copy protected source material from Special Intelligence because he did not have it.

He did not invent what he could not see.

That distinction mattered to him.

At six, Rahman watched him place duplicates into separate brown folders.

"Where will these go?"

"Different places."

"Why?"

"If one file goes missing, I want to know it went missing."

Rahman looked at him.

"Is that what happened to Hamid's records?"

"I don't know."

"But you think it could."

"I think certainty is expensive."

Harun wrote CASE 17/94 — WORKING DUPLICATES on one folder.

Underneath, smaller:

NOT COMPLETE.

Rahman noticed.

"Why write that?"

"So nobody mistakes this for the whole truth."

He capped the pen.

"Partial files create complete confidence in stupid people."

Rahman smiled despite himself.

Harun did not.

He opened his notebook and wrote one line.

There is no gang. There is a network.

Rahman read over his shoulder.

"You just told them there may be no organisation."

"Yes."

"That says network."

"A network is not an organisation."

"What is the difference?"

Harun looked at him.

"An organisation knows it is one."

Rahman stared at the line.

Harun added beneath it:

Do not assume command because relationships repeat.

Then closed the notebook.

At the door, Rahman asked, "Do you trust Farid?"

Harun considered.

"Yes."

The answer surprised him.

"You argued for two hours."

"That is not the same thing."

"Do you trust his judgment?"

"Sometimes."

"His reasons?"

Harun looked toward the corridor.

"I think Farid believes an institution survives by choosing which dangers it can afford to confront."

Rahman waited.

"And you?"

"I think every danger you postpone sends you a bill."

Harun switched off the office light.

The room fell dark except for the corridor glow.

"What bill?"

Harun looked at the brown folders stacked in his arms.

"You usually find out later."

They walked toward the lift.

Behind them, Case 17/94 remained in restricted custody.

Not closed.

Not solved.

Not destroyed.

That was the official truth.

Years later, Rahman would understand that silence rarely began as a conspiracy.

Sometimes it began as caution.

A protected source.

An incomplete file.

A senior officer trying not to ruin a legitimate operation.

A decision to wait until the evidence was stronger.

All reasonable.

All temporary.

The price came when temporary silence learned how to survive the reason that created it.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

SPECIAL INTELLIGENCE

KOTA ARUNA — 2003

Rahman's transfer order arrived without explanation.

Three lines.

Effective Monday.

Report to the Special Intelligence Directorate.

No congratulations. No indication whether the move was promotion, reassignment or punishment.

He read it twice before taking it to his superintendent.

"Did you request this?"

The superintendent looked at the order.

"No."

"Did Harun?"

"No idea."

Rahman waited.

"That is all?"

"That is all I know."

Harun had been absent from Rahman's working life for months.

Not formally missing.

Not declared dead.

Simply no longer present.

Calls went unanswered. Messages came back through other people. One officer said Harun had taken leave. Another said he had been moved to a restricted assignment. A third told Rahman to stop asking questions that were not his business.

None of the answers matched.

Now Special Intelligence wanted him.

Rahman folded the order and put it in his pocket.

"Who signed?"

The superintendent looked again.

"Recommendation routed through Farid Kamal."

That answered one question and created another.

Farid was waiting when Rahman reported to SID headquarters on Monday morning.

The building looked less dramatic than Rahman expected.

No hidden bunker.

No mirrored glass.

An old government complex attached to a newer communications wing, guarded by men who did not wear uniforms and looked at identification longer than necessary.

Farid met him in a plain office with two steel cabinets, one dead plant and a wall map of Malaysia marked with removable pins.

"You came."

"The order suggested I should."

Farid looked at him.

"Still unhappy about 17/94?"

"Yes."

"Good."

Rahman frowned.

Farid gestured toward the chair.

"Sit."

Rahman did.

Farid opened a thin personnel file.

"You are good at case work."

"That sounds like the beginning of a criticism."

"You think evidence is what exists after something happens."

"Often."

"In intelligence, sometimes your job is to understand what may happen before evidence exists."

"That sounds less reliable."

"It is."

"Then why do it?"

"Because waiting can be fatal."

Rahman looked at him.

"That was Harun's argument."

Farid nodded.

"Yes."

No defensiveness.

No attempt to win an old debate.

Rahman asked, "Where is he?"

Farid's eyes remained on the file.

"Not here."

"I know."

"Then ask him when you see him."

"I have tried."

Farid closed the folder.

"We are not discussing Harun today."

The answer followed Rahman through the morning.

During security processing, he saw the internal staff directory open on a clerk's terminal.

Harun Ismail's name was not where Rahman expected it.

He waited until the clerk turned away.

"Search Harun Ismail."

The clerk looked at him.

"Purpose?"

"Professional contact."

"Directorate?"

"Criminal Investigation."

The clerk typed.

A result appeared, then disappeared behind a restricted-access notice.

The clerk's posture changed.

"Contact through your chain, sir."

"He is still serving?"

"I can't tell you."

"You just searched his name."

"I can tell you to contact through your chain."

Rahman stood there for another second.

It was not proof of anything.

A restricted directory entry could mean leave, special assignment, security protection, disciplinary review or twenty other things.

He knew that.

He also knew how quickly uncertainty became story.

So he did not write one.

When he returned upstairs, Farid was waiting beside the lift.

“You asked the registry about Harun.”

Rahman looked at him.

“That travelled quickly.”

“This building exists because information travels quickly.”

“Then tell me where he is.”

Farid pressed the lift button.

“No.”

“Can’t or won’t?”

The doors opened.

Farid entered.

Rahman followed.

Farid said, “Today, there is no useful difference.”

The lift descended.

Rahman felt anger rise.

Farid looked at him.

“You think withholding an answer proves the answer is bad.”

“No.”

“You do.”

Rahman said nothing.

Farid continued, “Sometimes you are not entitled to know something simply because you care about it.”

That sentence stayed with Rahman longer than the refusal itself.

He hated it.

He also knew it was true.

“Why?”

“Because you are here to learn a different job.”

The answer irritated Rahman.

He let it stand.

Farid took him downstairs to a secure briefing room.

Three folders waited on the table.

No names on the covers.

Farid pointed to the first.

“Source report.”

Second.

“Officer assessment.”

Third.

“Independent verification.”

Rahman looked at him.

“Three files for one piece of information?”

“If we are doing it properly.”

Farid opened the source report.

A protected human source claimed a shipment of pseudoephedrine precursor was being moved through a bonded warehouse outside Kota Lagenda.

The source identified a company, an approximate date and a lorry registration.

No photograph.

No recording.

No physical evidence.

Rahman read the page.

“Arrest team?”

Farid shook his head.

“Why?”

“Because this is what someone told us.”

“The source reliable?”

“That is a different question.”

Farid opened the second folder.

The handling officer assessed the source as historically reliable on logistics and warehouse activity, weak on financial details, with possible self-interest because the target group competed with his employer.

Rahman read.

“So he may be telling the truth for selfish reasons.”

“Most useful sources are not saints.”

“Then this makes the information stronger?”

“It makes the source easier to understand.”

Farid opened the third folder.

Customs records showed the company had booked bonded space.

A traffic camera placed a matching lorry near the district on two prior nights.

Commercial registry records linked the company to a director already known in a narcotics inquiry.

No illegal shipment had yet been observed.

Rahman nodded.

"Now we act."

"Maybe."

Rahman looked at him.

Farid almost smiled.

"Intelligence is not evidence with poorer manners."

"Then what is it?"

"Source. Assessment. Verification."

He tapped each file.

"Never let one become the other."

Rahman read the source report again.

"Who is the source?"

"You do not need to know."

"If I am working the case—"

"You are not working the source."

"That matters."

"Exactly."

Rahman stared at him.

The logic was irritating because it was clean.

Compartmentalisation.

The same word that had frustrated Harun.

Different people allowed to know different pieces because disclosure itself could create risk.

Farid said, "You will meet him tonight."

Rahman looked up.

"I thought I did not need to know."

"You do not need his registered identity."

"That is different."

"Yes."

They met the source in the rear office of a shuttered motorcycle workshop.

His name for the file was Johan.

Whether that was his real name, Rahman did not ask.

He was in his forties, thin, with a tired face and hands marked by warehouse work.

He refused tea.

"Too long," Johan said.

"What is?"

"This meeting."

Farid sat near the door.

Rahman sat opposite Johan.

"Tell me about the shipment."

Johan looked at Farid.

Farid said, "Tell him what you saw. Not what you think it means."

Johan nodded reluctantly.

"Two men came to Warehouse Six. Not normal workers. One asked if rear gate camera still broken."

"When?"

"Thursday."

"What company?"

"Meridian Chemicals."

"Exact name?"

Johan frowned.

"Maybe Meridian Industrial. Something Meridian."

Rahman wrote nothing yet.

"What did you see?"

"Drums."

"What colour?"

"Blue."

"Labels?"

"Covered."

"How many?"

"Maybe twenty."

Rahman asked, "Pseudoephedrine?"

Johan shook his head.

"I don't know."

"You said the shipment was precursor."

"I said the men handling it were the same people who moved precursor before."

Farid did not move.

Rahman felt the correction.

Source statement.

Not conclusion.

"Who told you the rear camera was broken?"

"Nobody. I heard them ask."

"Did they know you were there?"

"No."

"Why tell us?"

Johan's expression hardened.

"They will bring trouble to my warehouse."

"Your warehouse?"

"My boss's."

"Your boss knows you speak to police?"

"No."

"What do you want from us?"

Johan laughed softly.

"Everybody wants something, Inspector."

"What do you want?"

"Not to be arrested if you raid the place while I am working."

"That can be arranged if you are cooperating."

Farid spoke from the door.

"No promise."

Rahman turned.

Johan's face changed.

Farid continued.

"We can take your cooperation into account. We cannot promise what another officer may lawfully have to do."

Johan looked at Rahman.

"This is why I prefer the other one."

"What other one?"

Farid said, "He means me."

Rahman understood.

The source had not come for friendship.

He came because relationships had been built slowly enough that truth could travel without guarantees.

After the meeting, Rahman said, "You made him nervous."

"He should be nervous."

"He may stop talking."

"Then the relationship was too weak."

"You could have protected him."

"I am protecting him."

Rahman looked back at the closed workshop.

"Didn't sound like it."

Farid said, "Protection is not the same as lying."

The first month in SID was mostly spent learning how information could be mishandled without anyone lying.

A source report used the phrase "weapons moving north."

An analyst converted it into "suspected firearms shipment."

A briefing slide reduced that to "arms transfer."

By the time a senior officer repeated it orally, the caveat had vanished.

Rahman traced the wording backward.

No weapon had been seen.

The source had used a slang term that could also refer to tools used in illegal workshops.

The final interpretation might still prove correct.

But the certainty had grown while the evidence had not.

Farid made Rahman rewrite the chain.

SOURCE WORDING.

HANDLER INTERPRETATION.

ANALYTICAL ASSESSMENT.

VERIFIED FACT.

Four separate lines.

"Why four?" Rahman asked.

"Because people remember the strongest sentence."

"That sounds like a communication problem."

"It is an integrity problem."

Farid pointed to the final line.

"If you cannot show where certainty entered, you cannot show whether it belonged there."

Rahman thought of altered statements.

Photos that looked like answers.

Official summaries cleaner than the evidence beneath them.

The tools were different.

The danger was familiar.

SID did not make uncertainty disappear.

It institutionalised uncertainty and hoped the labels survived the people reading them.

The operation ran for six days.

No raid.

No marked cars near the warehouse.

A surveillance team watched the lorry.

Customs officers checked manifests without flagging the company publicly.

Financial analysts traced payment for the bonded space.

On the fourth night, a second lorry arrived using plates registered to a vehicle that had been written off two years earlier.

On the sixth, officers followed the shipment to an industrial compound outside Kota Lagenda.

That was enough.

Search warrants were obtained on evidence independent of Johan's identity.

Two sites were hit simultaneously.

Chemicals recovered.

Three arrests.

A laboratory dismantled.

Johan's name never appeared in the warrant affidavit.

Rahman read the final report.

It described surveillance.

Customs irregularities.

Vehicle registration evidence.

Recovered chemicals.

No source.

He turned to Farid.

"This is incomplete."

"Yes."

"It makes the operation look like we discovered the warehouse ourselves."

"No."

"It omits the reason we looked."

"For the general file."

Rahman felt something old tighten.

"17/94."

Farid looked at him.

"What about it?"

"This is how information disappears."

"No."

"How is it different?"

Farid opened another folder.

Inside was a restricted annex.

Source reporting.

Handling notes.

Reliability assessments.

Cross-references.

Johan.

All of it.

"It did not disappear."

"It disappeared from one version."

"It was compartmentalised."

"Same effect for anyone without access."

"Yes."

Rahman stared.

Farid said, "That is the point."

"You hear how that sounds?"

"Of course."

"Then how do I know this is protection and not concealment?"

Farid looked at him for a long moment.

"You don't, from one file."

"That is convenient."

"It is dangerous."

Farid closed the annex.

"That is why access controls must have accountability outside the operational team."

"Who?"

"Command review. audit. integrity. legal process where required."

"And if all of them accept the restriction?"

"Then you are asking a bigger question."

Rahman thought of Harun.

Files that became difficult to find.

Temporary restrictions that became permanent habits.

"What if someone uses source protection to hide misconduct?"

"Then that person is corrupting source protection."

"And nobody sees it because nobody has the whole file."

Farid's voice remained calm.

"That is possible."

"You say that like it is weather."

"No."

Farid leaned forward.

"I say it because pretending the risk does not exist makes us stupid."

Rahman looked at the two versions of the same operation.

One public to the organisation.

One restricted.

Both accurate.

Neither complete.

He had spent years believing an official file should contain the truth.

SID was teaching him that truth could be deliberately divided and still remain honest.

He was not sure whether that lesson made him wiser or more vulnerable.

Two months later, he handled Johan alone for the first time.

Farid observed from another room.

Johan brought information about a transport broker using legitimate cargo manifests to hide controlled chemicals.

Rahman asked what he saw.

Not what he believed.

Asked who else could confirm.

Asked what Johan wanted.

Asked what might make him lie.

Then he wrote three separate notes.

Source.

Assessment.

Verification.

Farid read them that night.

"You are learning."

Rahman looked at him.

"I am learning to leave things out."

"No."

"To put them where they belong."

"Who decides where they belong?"

Farid almost smiled.

"You."

Rahman did not.

"That is what worries me."

Farid handed the reports back.

"Good."

Rahman looked toward the dark window.

Harun had once warned him about files becoming secrets.

Farid was teaching him that some secrets protected people.

Both men were right.

That was the problem.

By the end of his first year in Special Intelligence, Rahman understood something he had resisted in Criminal Investigation.

Not everyone could be told everything.

Sometimes silence kept a source alive.

Sometimes omission preserved an operation.

Sometimes two records could describe the same event differently and both be true.

But he had learned something else too.

Protection and concealment could look identical on paper.

The difference lived in purpose, oversight and the honesty of the person deciding what others were allowed to know.

Rahman had not yet learned how easily those things could change.

CHAPTER TWELVE

THE INVISIBLE WAR

KOTA LAGENDA — 2006

The arrest order was valid.

Rahman's decision would have been easier if it had not been.

Musa Halim had spent eight months moving between legitimate freight companies and a precursor-chemical trafficking network operating through the North Corridor. He was not the head of anything. He was useful because he knew which warehouses would accept unusual cargo without asking questions and which drivers could be paid to change routes halfway through a journey.

Special Intelligence had watched him long enough.

Command wanted him arrested.

The instruction arrived at 16:20.

Musa was under surveillance in a coffee shop outside Kota Lagenda.

Rahman read the message twice.

DETENTION AUTHORISED. EXECUTE WHEN PRACTICAL.

Inspector Salim, sitting beside him in the surveillance vehicle, said, "We can take him when he comes out."

Rahman looked through the windscreen.

Musa sat alone near the rear wall of the shop.

He had been alone for eleven minutes.

"He is waiting."

Salim shrugged.

"For coffee."

"He ordered one twenty minutes ago."

"Maybe he likes the place."

Rahman checked the surveillance log.

Musa had changed vehicles twice that day.

Used a public phone.

Driven thirty kilometres south, then doubled back.

Not the pattern of a man going for coffee.

Rahman called the analyst desk.

“Any movement on Rizal Mahmud?”

The answer came after a pause.

“Unknown. Last device went dark forty minutes ago.”

Rizal was the higher-value target.

Suspected coordinator for precursor shipments feeding two clandestine laboratories.

No clean arrest opportunity yet.

No confirmed location.

Musa had been seen with one of Rizal’s drivers twice.

Rahman looked at the coffee shop.

“What if Musa is meeting him?”

Salim heard.

“Then we arrest both.”

“If Rizal comes.”

“If.”

Rahman knew the rule.

The arrest order was for Musa.

Not for a theory.

Not for the chance of someone bigger.

Command had decided the risk of leaving him free was no longer acceptable.

Rahman also knew that once Musa was arrested, every contact around him would change phones, routes and meeting places.

The network would contract.

Rizal might disappear.

The labs would move.

“Give it twenty minutes,” Rahman said.

Salim looked at him.

“Command said execute when practical.”

“It is practical in twenty minutes.”

“That is creative.”

“Log continued surveillance due possible contact.”

Salim hesitated.

Then wrote it.

At 16:47, a silver Toyota arrived.

The driver stayed inside.

Musa looked toward the window.

Rahman felt the decision tighten.

“Plate?”

The analyst read it back.

Registered to a car-rental company.

No known link.

Musa stood.

Salim reached for the radio.

Rahman stopped him.

“Wait.”

Musa left the shop and crossed to the Toyota.

Passenger door opened.

He got in.

The car pulled away.

Salim looked at Rahman.

“We had him.”

“Yes.”

“We still do.”

“Follow.”

They followed for nine kilometres.

The Toyota entered an industrial area where three surveillance teams were already positioned on separate roads.

Then it accelerated.

Not wildly.

Just enough.

One team lost visual at a traffic light.

Another picked it up two minutes later.

Then lost it again behind a line of container lorries.

At 17:18, the Toyota was gone.

Salim stared at the empty road.

“You need to call command.”

“I know.”

Rahman did not call.

Not yet.

That was the first breach.

The second came when the analyst reported activity at a bonded warehouse linked to Rizal Mahmud.

Three lorries arriving unexpectedly.

One had appeared previously in surveillance of Musa.

Rahman made the calculation in less than ten seconds.

If Musa had warned them, the warehouse might empty.

If Musa had gone there, they might still catch him.

If the movement was unrelated, the operation could be wasted.

Command had not authorised a warehouse action.

Rahman redirected two teams.

“Observe only.”

Salim said, “Rahman.”

“Observe.”

“You are extending the operation.”

“Yes.”

“Without command.”

“Yes.”

Salim looked at him.

“You want me to record that?”

Rahman hesitated.

“Record operational extension pending target reacquisition.”

Salim’s expression changed.

“That is not the same sentence.”

Rahman knew.

“Do it.”

The bonded warehouse became active at 18:05.

Not frantic.

Professional.

Forklifts.

Drivers.

Paperwork.

The kind of movement that could be normal if you ignored the hour and the fact that three lorries had arrived within twenty minutes of Musa disappearing.

A surveillance officer called.

“Blue drums.”

Rahman went still.

"How many?"

"Cannot confirm. Covered pallets. Marking matches chemical supplier."

"Photograph?"

"Working."

Another call.

"Second site moving too."

"What second site?"

"Old paint factory. Team Four picked up one of the lorries."

Rahman looked at Salim.

This was bigger than Musa.

He finally called Farid.

Farid answered on the second ring.

"Status?"

"Musa evaded surveillance."

A pause.

"After arrest opportunity?"

"Yes."

"How?"

Rahman did not soften it.

"I delayed detention. I believed he was meeting Rizal."

Silence.

Farid asked, "Was he?"

"Unknown."

"Command informed?"

"No."

Another pause.

"Continue."

Rahman told him about the warehouses.

Blue drums.

Two sites.

Vehicle movement.

Possible precursor transfer.

Farid said, "Do you have enough for action?"

"Not yet."

"Then get enough."

No anger.

That was worse.

“Farid.”

“Yes?”

“I exceeded the arrest instruction.”

“I heard you.”

“What now?”

“Now you make sure the next decision is based on what exists, not on the need to justify the last one.”

The line landed cleanly.

Rahman looked through the windscreen.

“Understood.”

By 19:10, the surveillance teams had photographs.

One pallet label matched a company already under court-approved financial monitoring.

The company had no legitimate reason to deliver chemicals to the old paint factory.

A second lorry carried a false plate.

A third vehicle left the bonded warehouse and drove directly toward the factory.

Farid obtained emergency legal authority through the duty prosecutor.

No shortcuts this time.

At 21:40, coordinated teams moved.

Eleven people were arrested across two sites.

Precursor chemicals recovered in quantities sufficient for two laboratories.

Documentation seized.

Phones.

Warehouse ledgers.

A handwritten delivery schedule.

Rizal Mahmud’s name appeared on two communication records.

He was not among those arrested.

Neither was Musa Halim.

The operation was called a success before midnight.

The next morning, Rahman interviewed one of the arrested drivers.

The man was twenty-seven, frightened and more interested in avoiding prison than protecting anyone.

He admitted moving chemical drums between the bonded warehouse and the paint factory.

“Who told you to move them?”

“Supervisor.”

“Name?”

The driver gave it.

Not Musa.

“Did you know Musa Halim?”

The man shook his head.

“Rizal Mahmud?”

A pause.

“I heard the name.”

“From who?”

“People.”

“Which people?”

The driver could not say.

Nothing in the interview proved Musa had led ORION—or anyone—to the warehouses.

Nothing proved he had not.

Rahman left with the uncomfortable possibility that the larger seizure might have happened even if Musa had been arrested at the coffee shop.

That possibility stripped some heroism from the story.

Good.

It deserved to.

On the third day, another suspect claimed the warehouse had already planned to move the chemicals before Musa entered the Toyota.

The claim was self-serving and unverified.

Still, Rahman recorded it.

The success of the operation could not be allowed to erase evidence that complicated the story of how the success happened.

By breakfast, senior command was calling it one of the largest precursor disruptions of the year.

Rahman should have felt relief.

Instead he kept seeing Musa walking toward the Toyota.

A clean arrest.

Allowed to leave.

Maybe the decision had led them to the warehouses.

Maybe it had not.

That difference mattered.

At 09:30, Farid called him into the office.

Two reports sat on the desk.

“Write the operation.”

Rahman sat.

“How?”

“Accurately.”

That answer did not help.

The general operational report described the surveillance of Musa, suspicious vehicle movement, emergence of warehouse activity, emergency warrant process and eleven arrests.

It stated:

TARGET MUSA HALIM DEPARTED SURVEILLANCE AREA PRIOR TO INTERDICTION.

True.

The restricted supervisory note stated:

DETENTION OF MUSA HALIM WAS AUTHORISED BEFORE DEPARTURE. CASE OFFICER RAHMAN AZIZ DELAYED EXECUTION BASED ON UNCONFIRMED ASSESSMENT THAT TARGET MIGHT LEAD TO HIGHER--PRIORITY SUBJECT. DELAY WAS NOT AUTHORISED BY COMMAND. TARGET WAS SUBSEQUENTLY LOST.

Also true.

Rahman read both.

The first felt cleaner.

Too clean.

“The general report should say I delayed.”

Farid looked at him.

“Should it?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because I did.”

“Who reads the general report?”

“Operational command. review boards. future investigators.”

"Does the supervisory annex remain attached under restricted access?"

"Yes."

"Then the breach is recorded."

"Not for everyone."

Farid leaned back.

"We are back to the same argument."

Rahman looked at the first report.

"It makes me look better."

"That is not its purpose."

"It still does."

"Yes."

Rahman looked up.

"Then it matters."

Farid did not disagree.

The wider operation produced results over the next two weeks.

Eleven arrests became nine viable prosecutions.

Two suspects became cooperating witnesses.

One warehouse ledger identified payments to transport contractors.

The chemical supply route was disrupted.

One planned laboratory never opened.

Rizal Mahmud disappeared from known locations.

Musa Halim disappeared completely.

Rahman had traded one available suspect for a larger operational outcome.

That was the story people told.

It was not fully true.

They did not know whether arresting Musa would have prevented the warehouse movement.

They did not know whether letting him move caused it.

They did not know whether he had led them anywhere.

They knew only that Rahman delayed, Musa escaped, and the same evening a larger structure became visible.

Success had connected the events in everyone's mind.

Rahman noticed how quickly outcome became explanation.

At the formal review, a deputy director asked, "Would you make the same decision again?"

Rahman paused.
“Yes.”
The answer came too quickly.
Farid looked at him from the side of the room.
The deputy director said, “Despite the unauthorised delay?”
“Yes.”
“Because eleven people were arrested?”
“Because the wider threat justified continued surveillance.”
“That is not what you knew at the time.”
Rahman stopped.
The room went quiet.
The deputy director continued.
“You know that now.”
“Yes.”
“You did not know it at 16:20.”
“No.”
“Then answer again.”
Rahman thought of the coffee shop.
Musa alone.
The Toyota.
Rizal missing.
Twenty minutes becoming an hour.
“I believed the potential intelligence value justified delay.”
“Belief is not authority.”
“No.”
“Would you do it again?”
Rahman looked at Farid.
Farid gave him nothing.
That was right.
Rahman said, “I don’t know.”
Salim caught Rahman in the corridor after the review.
“You should have taken Musa.”
Rahman looked at him.
“Yes.”
Salim seemed surprised.
“That easy?”
“No.”

"You still think waiting was right."

"I think the information justified considering it."

"That is not the same."

Rahman nodded.

Salim leaned against the wall.

"If the warehouse had been empty, would you still say it was a good decision?"

Rahman did not answer.

Salim gave a tired smile.

"That is what I thought."

Then he walked away.

Rahman remained in the corridor longer than necessary.

The question was simple.

The answer was not.

If failure would have made the decision wrong and success made it right, then morality had become luck.

He did not want to believe that.

He also did not know what else to call the difference.

The review ended without formal discipline.

The successful seizures mattered.

The lack of injury mattered.

The existing supervisory record mattered too.

Rahman received a written caution regarding unauthorised extension and delayed command notification.

No press.

No public reprimand.

No damage to promotion.

Mariam noticed the change before he told her anything.

"You won," she said that evening.

Rahman looked up from his food.

"What?"

"You have the face you make after an operation succeeds and you are still angry."

"I have a face for that?"

"You have several police faces."

He almost smiled.

She waited.

Rahman said, “We arrested eleven people.”

“That sounds good.”

“Yes.”

“But?”

He looked at the plate.

“I made a decision I was not authorised to make.”

Mariam was quiet.

“Did someone get hurt?”

“No.”

“Would someone have been hurt if you followed the order?”

“I don’t know.”

“Then what are you angry about?”

Rahman thought of the review question.

What did you know at 16:20?

“Because it worked.”

Mariam frowned.

“That is a strange reason.”

“Yes.”

He did not explain further.

Not because the operation was classified.

Because he did not yet know how to explain why success could frighten him more than failure.

Months later, his performance review described the operation as demonstrating “exceptional analytical judgment under fluid conditions.”

The wording made him uncomfortable.

He took the review to Farid.

“This ignores the breach.”

“No.”

“It praises the same decision.”

“It praises the outcome.”

“That is worse.”

Farid looked at him.

“Both files are true.”

Rahman put the commendation beside the restricted supervisory note.

One praised judgment.

One criticised procedure.

Same officer.

Same operation.

Same day.

Rahman said, “If someone reads only this, I am good.”

He touched the commendation.

“If someone reads only this, I am reckless.”

He touched the supervisory note.

Farid nodded.

“Yes.”

“Which am I?”

“That is not a file question.”

Rahman looked at him.

Farid continued.

“The danger is deciding the good outcome proves the breach was right.”

“Lives were saved.”

“Yes.”

“Drugs were stopped.”

“Yes.”

“Then result matters.”

“Of course.”

Farid tapped the restricted note.

“So does method.”

Rahman said, “You sound like Harun.”

Farid’s expression changed slightly.

“Harun was right about many things.”

“Not containment.”

Farid did not answer.

The silence lasted too long.

Rahman closed the folder.

He had crossed a line and received success on the other side.

That was more dangerous than failure.

Failure would have made the lesson obvious.

Success made the line look negotiable.

Years later, Aisyah would read both reports and ask what boundary Rahman recognised before harm occurred.

In 2006, Rahman did not yet have an answer.

He only knew that the operation had worked.

And somewhere inside that fact, a justification had begun learning how to protect itself.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

ORION

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

By the time Task Force ORION was created, three separate failures had already taught the same lesson.

Someone knew.

The first was Operation Meranti.

March 2025. It rained that night, as it seemed to whenever the police arrived second.

A warehouse in the eastern industrial belt of Kota Aruna had been under surveillance for six weeks. The target package was finalised at 18:40. Entry teams moved at 21:45.

Rahman stood at the command post two hundred metres back, beneath a tarpaulin that did not quite meet its frame, and listened to the radio.

“Main entry open.”

“Ground floor clear.”

“Annex clear.”

Then a pause long enough to be heard.

“Dato’. There is nobody here.”

He walked in himself.

The building was empty.

Not abandoned.

Empty.

Fans still running.

Food warm.

One cigarette crushed in a sink.

A pot sat on a portable stove beside four plates. Rahman held his palm over one without touching it, as he had once done in a warehouse in the

North Corridor, in the rain, twenty-five years earlier, with Harun watching.

Warm. Not hot.

He did not tell the team why he had done it. Nobody under fifty would have understood.

Superintendent Rafiq Hamdan crossed the floor with his helmet under his arm.

“The package was final at 18:40,” Rafiq said. “Nobody outside the planning room had the address.”

“Then somebody inside the planning room did.”

Rafiq did not argue.

The access audit later showed a valid police credential had opened the final target annex ninety-four minutes before the raid.

No malware.

No forced login.

No impossible hack.

A real credential.

The officer whose account had been used denied opening the file.

Rahman believed him.

That was the problem. He had begun to believe all of them.

He wrote the incident report himself, at his own kitchen table, at three in the morning, because the building had stopped feeling like a place where reports were read only by the people they were addressed to.

Under Cause he wrote: Unknown.

Under Responsible Officer he wrote his own name.

It was not required. It was not even wise. Mariam found it in the morning and read it standing at the counter with her coffee, then put it back exactly where it had been.

“Nobody asked you for that,” she said.

“I know.”

“It will be used.”

“By whom?”

She looked at him for a long time.

“That,” she said, “is what I thought you would say.”

The second failure was Salmah Yusof.

Protected witness.

Financial clerk.

She had agreed to testify about a logistics company moving cash through false service invoices.

Her relocation route changed twice.

Only a small group had the final movement plan.

On the morning of transfer, the escort vehicle reached the pickup point at 05:50.

Two officers. An unmarked Proton. A thermos of coffee between them, because the job was usually boring and had been boring for nine days.

Salmah did not come down.

At 06:05 the senior officer rang the apartment. At 06:10 he rang again. At 06:14 he took the stairs two at a time with his hand on his holster for the first time in nine days.

The door was unlocked.

The apartment had been cleaned.

Not searched. Cleaned. Surfaces wiped, bed stripped, the bin emptied and its bag taken away. Her phone sat in the centre of the kitchen table, charged to full, face up, like a gift.

No struggle.

No sign of anything at all.

Rahman arrived at 07:40 and stood in the doorway for a long time. He was not allowed to touch the phone for another two hours.

A different valid credential had accessed the protection schedule the previous evening.

Not the same officer.

Not the same directorate.

The third was Inspector Hafiz Rashid.

Hafiz had been working a cross-border transport investigation in the North Corridor.

He reported that someone inside enforcement knew which consignments were being watched.

Two days later, he died during what was initially recorded as a roadside confrontation with smugglers.

Rahman had spoken to him once, on the Thursday.

Hafiz had called the private line, which he should not have had.

“Dato’, I would rather say this in person.”

“Say it now.”

“Someone inside knows which consignments we are watching. Not guesses. Knows.”

Rahman had looked at the clock. A budget meeting in eleven minutes.

“Come Monday,” he said. “Bring everything.”

“Monday,” Hafiz agreed.

He died on Saturday.

At the funeral Rahman stood at the back, in the heat, under a borrowed umbrella. Hafiz’s mother asked him what had been supposed to happen on Monday. He told her it was only a meeting.

It was the first lie he had ever told a grieving woman. He did not yet know that it would not be the last.

The sequence never satisfied Rahman.

Neither did the missing phone.

The device entered evidence.

Then disappeared between regional inventory and headquarters transfer.

The transfer log showed another valid credential.

Different again.

Three failures.

Three access paths.

Three officers who appeared, on paper, to have legitimate reasons to be near the relevant systems.

No single obvious mole.

That was why ORION existed.

Farid asked for him on a Sunday, at his own house, on a veranda behind a hedge of hibiscus.

There was tea. There were no aides.

“Three failures and no mole,” Farid said. “Six directors who would each like to investigate the other five. I need one commander who will log his own mistakes.”

“That is not a compliment.”

“It is the only qualification I trust.”

Rahman turned the cup in its saucer.

“And if what you are looking for is in your own office?”

Farid did not blink.

“Then you will put me on the list. I would think less of you if you did not.”

Rahman said yes.

He would remember afterwards how easy it had been. How reasonable the man across the table had sounded. How the veranda smelled of rain on hot stone, and how, for the length of one cup of tea, he had felt entirely safe.

The first meeting took place in a secure operations room on the seventh floor of MNPS headquarters.

No windows.

Six workstations.

Two locked evidence cabinets.

One wall screen.

A whiteboard nobody had written on yet.

Rahman arrived first.

Old habit.

He walked the room once before sitting.

Door.

Cameras.

Emergency exit.

Network terminals.

Printer.

Document shredder.

The small things mattered.

Inspector Nur Aisyah Othman arrived three minutes later.

She carried one notebook and no visible interest in impressing him.

“Dato’.”

“Inspector.”

She looked around.

“This room has independent access logging?”

“Yes.”

“Who administers it?”

“Digital Security.”

“Under whose command?”

Rahman looked at her.

“Good morning to you too.”

“I asked a question.”

He almost smiled.

“Separate reporting line. ORION cannot edit the logs.”

"Good."

She sat.

Daniel Lim arrived next, carrying two laptops even though only one would be permitted inside the secure room.

A security officer stopped him.

Daniel looked offended.

"The second one is cleaner."

"You can take neither until cleared."

"It is literally my job to know whether systems are clean."

The officer pointed to a storage locker.

Daniel sighed and surrendered both.

Rahman watched him enter.

"Inspector Lim."

"Sir."

"You brought unauthorised devices into a secure area."

"I brought them to the secure-area entrance."

"That distinction may save your career one day."

"I make many distinctions."

Aisyah looked at him.

"I can already tell."

Rafiq arrived last among the permanent core.

CID operations.

Field experience.

Reliable enough to be trusted and senior enough to annoy everyone.

He looked at the empty whiteboard.

"So who are we arresting?"

Rahman said, "Nobody."

Rafiq took a seat.

"Excellent start."

Farid entered at 08:00.

By 2026 he carried authority differently than he had in 2000.

Less need to prove it.

More people adjusting themselves when he entered a room.

He stood at the head of the table.

"Task Force ORION is authorised as a joint command under organised crime, internal integrity, digital threats and criminal investigation."

Daniel glanced at Aisyah.

"Joint command. Those always go well."

Farid heard.

"They go badly when people protect their own directorates."

Aisyah said, "And when command protects itself."

Farid looked at her.

"Yes."

No offence.

Rahman noticed.

Farid continued.

"ORION is not to assume one cause links all three incidents."

He touched the screen.

Meranti.

Salmah.

Hafiz.

"Your mandate is to determine whether the failures resulted from corruption, procedural weakness, compromised technology, criminal penetration, coincidence, or some combination."

Rafiq asked, "Who has full access?"

"Not everyone."

Aisyah's expression sharpened.

Farid continued.

"Compartmentalisation remains necessary."

Rahman felt the old word again.

The same word from 17/94.

Still legitimate.

Still dangerous.

Farid looked at him.

"Rahman commands."

No ceremony.

No applause.

Farid left twenty minutes later.

The charter gave ORION unusual authority and almost no comfort.

It could request records across directorates.

It could preserve digital logs without waiting for the originating unit to approve the copy.

It could refer integrity matters directly to IID.

It could ask prosecutors for parallel legal review when an internal conflict existed.

What it could not do was make hierarchy disappear.

Every member still belonged somewhere else.

Aisyah to IID.

Daniel to Digital Threats.

Rafiq to CID.

Rahman to senior command.

Even the analysts seconded later would return to directors who signed their appraisals and controlled their careers.

Rahman read the charter aloud.

"Your greatest vulnerability is not access."

Daniel looked up.

"What is?"

"Loyalty."

Rafiq frowned.

"That is a dramatic way to describe employment."

Rahman shook his head.

"I mean institutional loyalty. The instinct to protect your home unit before the task force."

Aisyah said, "Or protect ORION from your home unit."

"Yes."

"Which one is correct?"

"Depends what you are protecting."

She watched him.

Again, the same test.

Not whether Rahman could say the right principle.

Whether he could live inside it.

The door closed.

The team looked at Rahman.

He stood.

"We begin with rules."

Daniel muttered, "Of course we do."

Rahman ignored him.

"No private copies."

Aisyah nodded.

"No case material on personal devices."

Daniel sighed.

“No informal source contact related to ORION without logging the existence of the contact.”

Rafiq frowned.

“Source identity?”

“No. Existence.”

Aisyah looked at Rahman.

That distinction interested her.

Rahman continued.

“Every major conclusion carries confidence level and alternative explanation.”

Daniel said, “That slows analysis.”

“Yes.”

“It also makes reports ugly.”

“Yes.”

“Fine.”

Rahman looked at each of them.

“No one is cleared because of rank.”

Aisyah said, “Including you?”

“Including me.”

“Farid?”

Rahman paused.

“Including Farid.”

Rafiq looked down.

The room changed slightly.

That was the first real moment ORION existed.

Rahman went to the whiteboard.

He wrote three lines.

FOLLOW THE MONEY.

FOLLOW THE INFORMATION.

FOLLOW THE PEOPLE CONNECTING THEM.

Daniel looked at the board.

“Very inspirational.”

“It is not inspiration.”

“What is it?”

“A method.”

Rahman capped the marker.

"Money tells you who benefits."

He pointed to the second line.

"Information tells you who knew."

Third.

"People tell you how one becomes the other."

Aisyah asked, "And if the police are the people connecting them?"

"Then we investigate the police."

No hesitation.

She watched him.

Rahman knew what she saw.

A senior officer with a reputation for integrity saying the correct thing in the first meeting.

Words were cheap.

She would want proof later.

Good.

Before any analysis began, Aisyah insisted on opening the evidence cabinet herself.

Rafiq said, "It is empty."

"That is why now is the best time."

She photographed the seals.

Recorded cabinet serials.

Logged the spare keys.

Named the two officers authorised to countersign emergency access.

Daniel watched.

"You do this with every room?"

"Every room that may later contain evidence people wish had never existed."

Rafiq looked at Rahman.

"You recruited optimism."

Rahman said, "I recruited memory."

Aisyah turned.

"Who investigates ORION?"

Rafiq gave a short laugh.

Daniel stopped typing.

Rahman answered, "IID."

"That is an organisation. I asked who."

"You."

"And if I am the problem?"

Rahman looked at her.

"Then someone else."

"Who chooses?"

"Not you."

"Not you either."

Rahman nodded.

"Agreed."

Aisyah wrote something in her notebook.

He did not ask what.

The exchange lasted less than a minute.

It would become important later.

They began with Meranti.

Daniel projected the access logs.

Seventeen users viewed supporting intelligence over six weeks.

Nine opened the planning directory.

Four opened the final annex.

One credential accessed it at 20:11.

The officer was in another building at the time, appearing on internal CCTV.

Daniel said, "Credential theft."

"Maybe," Aisyah replied.

"His card plus password."

"Or shared access."

"Policy violation."

"Still possible."

"Or remote session."

"Logged?"

"No."

"Then less likely."

Rahman let them argue.

Rafiq looked at the raid timeline.

"Targets left when?"

"Estimated twenty-five to forty minutes before entry."

"Could be external surveillance."

"Yes."

"Lookout saw police staging."

"Yes."

"Phone intercept?"

"Possible."

Aisyah said, "So the access event may be irrelevant."

Daniel looked offended.

"It is not irrelevant."

"I said may be."

"Data does not enjoy being called irrelevant."

"Data has no feelings."

Daniel looked at Rahman.

"She is going to be difficult."

Rahman said, "Good."

Salmah produced a different pattern.

Protection schedule accessed through a regional coordination account.

Credential valid.

User said the file had opened automatically during a broader briefing package.

Possible.

Hafiz's evidence transfer had passed through three custody points.

The device was logged at the first two.

At the third, the inventory listed "1 mobile device" without serial number.

Daniel stared.

"That is terrible."

Rafiq said, "It is common."

"Then common is terrible."

Aisyah looked at the form.

"Who signed?"

"Sergeant on duty."

"Interview."

Rafiq said, "He retired."

"Still interview."

Rahman watched the pieces gather.

Not yet a pattern.

Only vulnerabilities.

After lunch, Daniel built a simple matrix.

MERANTI — VALID ACCESS.

SALMAH — VALID ACCESS.

HAFIZ — VALID ACCESS / CUSTODY FAILURE.

He looked at Rahman.

“Someone knew.”

Aisyah said, “Or three someones.”

“Or weak systems.”

Rafiq added, “Or criminals watching us from outside.”

Daniel nodded reluctantly.

Rahman said, “Good.”

Daniel frowned.

“Which?”

“All of them stay alive until evidence kills them.”

They worked until after midnight.

By then ORION had requested personnel histories, financial declarations, system logs, evidence-transfer records and operational rosters.

Aisyah demanded independent integrity copies before directorates could “clean up administrative inconsistencies.”

Rafiq objected to the wording.

“Most admin mistakes are just mistakes.”

“I know.”

“You make it sound criminal.”

“I make it preservable.”

Daniel asked for raw metadata rather than exported reports.

The system administrator complained.

Daniel complained louder.

Rahman approved both requests.

At 23:15, a junior systems officer arrived with the first preserved audit export.

Daniel refused it.

The officer stared at him.

“You requested the logs.”

“I requested raw logs.”

“This is the report.”

“I can read the title.”

“It contains the same information.”

Daniel looked at Aisyah.

She said, “Does it?”

The officer hesitated.

“Mostly.”

Daniel leaned back.

“Beautiful word.”

Rahman asked, “What is missing?”

“System health events. failed authentication attempts. session handoffs. export actions. administrator overrides.”

“Relevant?”

“Maybe not.”

Aisyah said, “Then preserve them before deciding.”

The officer looked exhausted.

“It will take hours.”

Rahman said, “Take hours.”

After he left, Rafiq said, “We are going to become very popular.”

“No,” Aisyah replied.

“We are going to become very documented.”

Rahman looked at the empty evidence cabinet and the untouched whiteboard.

ORION had not solved anything.

It had only begun to make disappearance more difficult.

That was enough for the first day.

Before they left, Rahman created one additional rule and wrote it beneath the doctrine.

NO THEORY OWNS THE EVIDENCE.

Daniel read it.

“That is not a rule. That is philosophy.”

“It is a rule.”

“How do you enforce it?”

“By recording what would prove us wrong.”

Aisyah looked up.

“That I like.”

Rafiq said, “Until we spend all day disproving ourselves.”

Rahman capped the marker.

“Better than spending six months proving ourselves right.”

He thought of old cases that had become cleaner as they were remembered.

Photographs that became accusations.

Successful operations that became proof of judgment.

Restricted files that became accepted truth because nobody could see the missing pages.

ORION could not afford that.

Not if the problem was already inside the institution.

At 00:40, the room was quiet again.

Rafiq had left.

Aisyah was still reading personnel records.

Daniel sat before three screens.

Rahman looked at the whiteboard.

Money.

Information.

People.

Three simple lines.

Harun would have liked the first two.

He would have asked what was missing.

Rahman knew now.

Fear.

What people protected.

What they could not afford to lose.

Not yet.

Too early.

He turned to Daniel.

“What do the three failures have in common?”

Daniel rubbed his eyes.

“Nothing conclusive.”

“Good.”

Daniel looked annoyed.

“Do you want my answer or not?”

“Yes.”

“Each required information that existed inside police systems.”

Aisyah looked up.

“That does not mean the leak came through the system.”

“I know.”

“Could be conversation.”

“I know.”

"Observation."

"I know."

"Source compromise."

Daniel turned.

"I know."

Rahman raised one hand.

Daniel looked back at the screens.

Then said, more quietly, "But someone knew."

Rahman looked at the three case names.

Meranti.

Salmah.

Hafiz.

Three different failures.

Three different credentials.

Three different routes by which protected information might have escaped.

No single mole yet.

Only a fact ORION could not explain away.

Someone knew.

Somewhere between knowing and consequence, the police had failed to protect its own information.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

AISYAH

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Aisyah did not trust reputations.

She trusted records less.

Internal Integrity had sent her to ORION for exactly that reason.

On paper, DCP Dato' Rahman Aziz was exactly the kind of senior officer institutions liked to place in front of cameras after scandals.

Long service.

Operational experience.

No corruption finding.

No unexplained wealth.

No disciplinary conviction.

A reputation for refusing favours.

Too clean, Aisyah thought.

Not because clean officers did not exist.

Because reputations became summaries, and summaries removed the parts that complicated people.

She opened Rahman's personnel file at 06:40, before the others arrived.

The official record was almost boring.

Training.

CID.

Border postings.

Special Intelligence.

Organised crime.

Command.

Commendations.

Restricted-service citations without operational detail.

Promotions that looked regular for his performance.

No sudden wealth.

No suspicious family interests.

No unexplained leave.

Nothing that justified suspicion.

Aisyah did not need suspicion.

She needed vulnerability.

Everyone had one.

She searched his historical operational references.

The 2006 file appeared because one commendation cited an operation involving precursor chemicals and eleven arrests.

The general report praised Rahman's decision-making under fluid conditions.

Aisyah read it once.

Then searched for supervisory attachments.

Access restricted.

She used IID authority.

A second record appeared.

Same operation.

Different tone.

DETENTION OF MUSA HALIM WAS AUTHORISED BEFORE DEPARTURE.

CASE OFFICER RAHMAN AZIZ DELAYED EXECUTION BASED ON UNCONFIRMED ASSESSMENT THAT TARGET MIGHT LEAD TO HIGHER--PRIORITY SUBJECT.

DELAY WAS NOT AUTHORISED BY COMMAND.

TARGET WAS SUBSEQUENTLY LOST.

Aisyah sat back.

There.

Not corruption.

Something more useful.

A man who would break a rule when he believed the reason was good enough.

She opened both reports side by side.

The first was not false.

The second was not false.

Together they described a harder truth than either alone.

She printed nothing.

No unnecessary paper.

Instead she wrote in her notebook:

RAHMAN — 2006.

SUCCESS + UNAUTHORISED DISCRETION.

QUESTION: DOES HE TREAT GOOD OUTCOME AS VALIDATION?

Then beneath it:

DO NOT ANSWER BEFORE EVIDENCE.

Her father had taught her that without meaning to.

He had been a police officer for twenty-eight years.

Honest.

Quiet.

Never promoted as quickly as men who were better at being noticed.

He had come home angry sometimes, not because criminals escaped, but because everybody in the station knew why a file had stalled and nobody could prove it.

Once, when Aisyah was sixteen, she asked why he did not report a senior officer everyone disliked.

Her father had replied, “Because dislike is not evidence.”

At the time she thought that sounded cowardly.

Later she understood it as discipline.

She still wondered whether discipline had cost him too much.

At 07:35, Rahman entered SOC 4.

He saw her immediately.

“You’re early.”

“So are you.”

“I command the task force.”

“That changes sunrise?”

Rahman took off his jacket.

“No.”

He glanced at her screen.

“What are you reading?”

“Your career.”

He stopped.

Most senior officers would have asked why.

Rahman asked, “Find anything interesting?”

“Yes.”

He waited.

Aisyah did not explain.

He nodded once.

That irritated her slightly.

“You’re not going to ask?”

“If it matters, you will tell me.”

“Confidence.”

“Procedure.”

She looked at him.

“Same thing sometimes.”

“Dangerous sentence.”

Good.

He heard himself.

Daniel arrived five minutes later carrying coffee in a cup that violated the room rules.

Aisyah pointed at it.

“No drinks near evidence terminals.”

“There is no evidence on my desk.”

“There will be.”

Daniel looked at Rahman.

“Does she issue warnings recreationally?”

Rahman said, “Move the coffee.”

Daniel moved the coffee.

Rafiq arrived while complaining about traffic.

The day began.

For three hours ORION reviewed the three failures.

Meranti.

Salmah.

Hafiz.

Aisyah focused less on the crimes than on movement inside the institution.

Who knew what.

When.

Under which authority.

How long the information remained visible.

Which access was normal enough to avoid attention.

Meranti bothered her because the credential use looked suspicious but not impossible.

The officer whose account opened the final target annex appeared on camera elsewhere.

Password sharing was possible.

Session transfer possible.

Credential cloning possible.

Administrative error possible.

So was deliberate compromise.

She refused to circle the officer's name.

Daniel circled it anyway.

She uncircled it.

He stared.

"You touched my board."

"You labelled him suspect."

"He is a suspect."

"He is an access event."

"That is much less exciting."

"It is also true."

Daniel sighed.

Rahman watched from the other side of the room.

Aisyah expected him to support command speed over integrity caution.

Instead he said, "Use her wording."

Daniel looked betrayed.

"You recruited me for analysis."

"I recruited you to be right more often than you are interesting."

Rafiq laughed.

Daniel changed the label.

ACCESS EVENT — USER ID 14C.

Aisyah wrote another note.

RAHMAN ACCEPTS CORRECTION WHEN COST LOW.

TEST WHEN COST HIGH.

At lunch, SAC Razak Salleh called her.

She stepped into the secure corridor.

"Sir."

"You have access?"

"Yes."

"Resistance?"

"Normal."

"Rahman?"

"Cooperative."

Razak was silent.

Aisyah knew what that meant.

Too easy was also information.

"He knows you are reviewing him?"

"He knows I am reviewing everyone."

"That is not what I asked."

Aisyah looked through the glass toward SOC 4.

Rahman stood behind Daniel, reading an access timeline.

"He knows I have his personnel history."

"And the enhanced integrity scope?"

"No."

"Keep it that way."

Aisyah's jaw tightened.

"Why?"

"Because if ORION is compromised, command is within scope."

"I know."

"If you tell him he is a subject before we know whether he is a subject, you contaminate behaviour."

"He told the team nobody is exempt."

Razak said, "Good."

"You don't believe him?"

"I believe procedure should not depend on belief."

That was why Aisyah trusted Razak more than most senior officers.

He could make distrust sound like administration.

"What exactly am I looking for?"

"Conflicts. leverage. concealed operational history. source relationships outside expected controls. discretionary breaches that create exposure."

"Corruption?"

"If you find it."

"And if I don't?"

"Do not invent it."

Aisyah looked at her notebook.
2006.
Musa Halim.
Successful operation.
Unauthorised choice.
“Understood.”
Before he ended the call, Razak said, “Aisyah.”
“Yes.”
“Reputation is not clearance.”
“I know.”
“Neither is suspicion.”
She almost smiled.
“I know.”
Back inside, Rahman was waiting.
“Razak?”
She looked at him.
“Do you monitor my calls?”
“No.”
“You guessed.”
“You leave the room when IID calls.”
“That is observation.”
“Harun taught me.”
The name came unexpectedly.
Aisyah knew Harun Ismail only from old references.
Mentor.
Senior investigator.
Officially dead.
The circumstances were not in the ordinary personnel summary.
She said, “You talk about him as though he is still evaluating you.”
Rahman’s expression changed.
Only slightly.
“Maybe.”
Aisyah stored that.
Not evidence.
Vulnerability perhaps.
Later, they reviewed Salmah Yusof’s protection failure.

The final movement schedule had been exported as part of a broader regional coordination package.

Aisyah asked who approved the export.

Rafiq said, “Routine.”

“That is not a person.”

“Regional command.”

“That is not a person either.”

Rafiq frowned.

“You want the clerk?”

“I want everyone between creation and access.”

“That could be thirty people.”

“Then thirty names.”

Daniel looked delighted.

“Finally, someone who likes data more than people.”

Aisyah said, “I like neither.”

Rahman almost smiled.

The work continued.

By 18:00, Aisyah had fourteen potential integrity questions and zero proven misconduct findings.

That was good.

Real investigations should grow slowly.

Pressure made people mistake movement for progress.

At 19:20, Rahman called the team around the whiteboard.

“We need a rule for internal access.”

Daniel said, “Least privilege.”

Rafiq said, “Operational need.”

Aisyah said, “Independent review.”

Rahman looked at her.

“Explain.”

“ORION investigates compromise. If ORION controls its own audit, we create the same problem we are examining.”

Rafiq folded his arms.

“So IID audits us.”

“IID can be compromised too.”

Daniel said, “Cheerful.”

Aisyah ignored him.

Aisyah asked, “Then who investigates us?”

"You," Rahman said. "As I told you on the first day."

He had said it exactly that way the day before, at the first meeting, with the chairs still stacked against the wall and the whiteboard still smelling of its packaging.

She had come in carrying a box of files and a letter from Razak, and she had assumed, as everyone assumed, that a senior officer would spend the first morning explaining why he did not need her.

Rahman had read the letter standing up. He folded it along its original creases and handed it back.

"Who audits ORION?" he asked.

"IID."

"And who at IID?"

"I do not know yet."

"Then it is you." He had looked at the stacked chairs. "I would like that in writing, with your signature and mine. If I ever ask you to stop, the note says you did not have to."

It had been the strangest welcome of her career. She had written the note that afternoon. He had signed it without reading past the first line, then asked for it back, read the rest, and signed again.

She still did not know whether that was trust or technique.

The answer sat there.

Aisyah heard her father's voice.

Dislike is not evidence.

She heard Razak.

Reputation is not clearance.

She looked at the people in the room.

Rafiq, competent and defensive of CID.

Daniel, trusting data more than motive.

Rahman, trusted by everyone who needed a symbol of clean command.

Herself.

IID.

Integrity investigating integrity.

"Today, me," she said.

Daniel looked at her.

"That is not structurally reassuring."

"It is not supposed to be."

Rahman said, “And tomorrow?”

“Someone who can inspect my work.”

He nodded.

“Fine.”

Aisyah waited for qualification.

There was none.

Again, low-cost acceptance.

Again, not enough.

At 21:00, most of the team left.

Aisyah stayed.

Rahman stayed too.

He worked at the far table with no music and no unnecessary phone calls.

She reopened his 2006 records.

This time she read the commendation last.

Exceptional analytical judgment under fluid conditions.

A line like that could become armour.

Not because it was false.

Because institutions remembered praise more easily than caveats.

She searched for later operations involving unusual discretion.

Several appeared.

Source protection.

Delayed action.

Restricted reporting.

Nothing criminal.

Nothing clean enough to dismiss either.

A pattern of judgment exercised near the edge of authority.

She wrote:

RAHMAN DOES NOT APPEAR BOUGHT.

Then stopped.

Deleted it.

Too early.

Instead:

NO CURRENT EVIDENCE OF FINANCIAL CORRUPTION.

HISTORY SHOWS REPEATED WILLINGNESS TO USE DISCRETION BEYOND ORDINARY PROCEDURE WHERE OPERATIONAL BENEFIT EXPECTED.

RELEVANCE: POTENTIAL LEVERAGE / SELF-JUSTIFICATION / RECORD FRAGMENTATION.

She read the sentence twice.

Harsh.

Accurate enough.

Rahman appeared beside her desk.

She closed nothing.

Good.

He looked at the screen.

"That is me."

"Yes."

"Potential leverage."

"Yes."

"What would anyone leverage?"

"I don't know yet."

He read the line again.

"Self-justification."

"You disagree?"

"I dislike the phrase."

"That is not an answer."

"No."

He looked at her.

"I do not know."

That surprised her.

Senior officers usually knew exactly why their past decisions had been right.

Aisyah asked, "Did the 2006 operation save lives?"

"Yes."

"Did the outcome justify the breach?"

Rahman was silent.

Long enough to matter.

"At the time, I thought so."

"And now?"

"I know the outcome does not change what I knew before I made the decision."

Aisyah studied him.

He had learned the right lesson.

Or learned how to say it.

Both possibilities remained.

Rahman looked toward the dark whiteboard.

"Is that why IID sent you?"

"To ask about 2006?"

"To investigate me."

Aisyah's pulse changed once.

She kept her face still.

"Everyone is in scope."

"That is not what I asked."

She remembered Razak's instruction.

Keep it that way.

Aisyah said, "Then ask Razak."

Rahman watched her.

There was no accusation in his expression.

Only recognition that she had answered narrowly.

He nodded.

"Fair."

Then returned to his desk.

Aisyah looked at the line she had written.

Potential leverage.

The task force believed it was investigating how protected information escaped the police.

Aisyah's job was narrower and worse.

She had to determine whether the people hunting the compromise carried compromises of their own.

Including Rahman.

Including herself.

Who investigates us?

Today, me.

Tomorrow, someone else.

If the system was working.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

THE ACCOUNTANT

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Daniel trusted data because data did not lower its voice when a senior officer entered the room.

People did.

Spreadsheets did not.

Bank transfers did not.

Company-registration dates did not.

Phone metadata did not care about rank.

At least that was what he told himself.

By the fourth week of ORION, he had collected 387 companies connected, directly or indirectly, to the task force's cases.

Most were useless.

That was normal.

Legitimate subcontractors.

Catering firms.

Vehicle-rental companies.

Property holding companies.

Accounting practices.

Small businesses whose only crime was having once invoiced somebody interesting.

Daniel built the dataset anyway.

Company name.

Registration number.

Directors.

Shareholders.

Addresses.

Bank relationships where lawfully available.

Phone numbers.

Email domains.

Auditors.

Company secretaries.

Known transactions.

Police-case references.

Historical name changes.

He did not ask the graph to tell a story.

He told himself that repeatedly.

Then the graph began to look like one.

A cluster of logistics companies shared two company secretaries.

Three unrelated property firms used the same registered office before changing addresses within months of one another.

A transport contractor linked to Operation Meranti had paid a consulting company that later received money from a business associated with one of Salmah Yusof's former employers.

The amounts were not spectacular.

That made them more interesting.

No RM10 million transfer.

No cartoon bag of money.

RM18,400.

RM27,900.

RM12,600.

Amounts that could be explained by actual services.

Daniel hated explainable numbers.

They forced work.

He created filters.

Transactions near operational dates.

Director changes after police activity.

New companies formed after seizures.

Shared professional service providers.

The cluster expanded.

Aisyah stood behind him at 10:15.

"How many?"

"Three hundred eighty-seven."

"Criminal companies?"

"No."

"Suspect companies?"

"No."

"Then what are they?"

"Companies."

She nodded.

"Good."

Daniel looked at her.

"You thought I would overstate it?"

"Yes."

"That is hurtful."

"It is evidence-based."

He turned back to the screen.

"Forty-one have repeated connections worth reviewing."

"Worth reviewing is better."

"Seven are very interesting."

"Why?"

Daniel opened the graph.

Nodes appeared across the main screen.

"Shared financial architecture."

Aisyah looked.

"That is not an answer."

"Same service providers. Similar transaction timing. Repeated nominee directors. Same kind of invoice descriptions."

"Same accountant?"

"Sometimes."

"Same bank?"

"No."

"Same owner?"

"No."

"Then architecture may be your word, not theirs."

Daniel sighed.

"Do you practice being difficult?"

"Yes."

He enlarged one chain.

RZ Meridian Logistics sat near the centre of a modern cluster.

Not because all money flowed through it.

Because businesses around it repeatedly used the same kinds of financial bridges.

Consultancy.

Fleet maintenance.

Temporary storage.

Event services.

Equipment rental.

Perfectly ordinary categories.

That was the point.

Daniel said, “Look at payment behaviour.”

Aisyah leaned closer.

A logistics company paid a consultancy.

The consultancy paid a vehicle-services firm.

The vehicle-services firm paid a property company.

The property company made a director loan to another business.

No illegal transaction visible.

But the timing repeatedly followed enforcement pressure somewhere else in the network.

Aisyah asked, “How many examples?”

“Twelve strong. Twenty-seven weaker.”

“Over what period?”

“Six years.”

“Could be normal commercial activity.”

“Yes.”

“Could be tax structuring.”

“Yes.”

“Could be one professional adviser recommending the same structures to multiple clients.”

Daniel turned.

“Exactly.”

Aisyah frowned.

“That was not agreement with your theory.”

“It should be.”

“What theory?”

Daniel looked at the graph.

He had not named it yet.

Names were dangerous because people started protecting them.

But names were useful because analysts needed handles.

“One designer.”

Aisyah said nothing.

Daniel continued.

“Somebody understands how to move money through ordinary business relationships without creating one obvious laundering hub.”

“Or several people.”

“Possible.”

“Or standard professional practice.”

“Possible.”

“Or copied behaviour.”

“Possible.”

She looked at him.

“You sound disappointed.”

“I am maintaining alternatives.”

“You sound like you resent them.”

“I resent inefficient alternatives.”

Aisyah walked away.

Daniel looked at the graph.

One designer.

The idea fit too well.

That made it suspicious.

He knew that.

He kept working.

At noon, Grace from the financial-analysis team joined him with historical corporate records.

She had spent two days manually reconciling businesses whose registration numbers had changed after restructures.

Daniel respected anyone willing to do work software could not perform cleanly.

She placed a file beside him.

“You are missing predecessors.”

“I am never missing predecessors.”

“You are.”

She pointed to four modern companies.

Each had absorbed assets, directors or addresses from older entities through legitimate transactions.

Daniel added the historical links.

The graph shifted.

"Better," he said.

"Worse."

"Why?"

"Now your cluster is older."

"How old?"

"Some relationships go back to the late nineties."

Daniel looked at her.

"Case 17/94?"

"I did not say that."

"You implied it."

"I said old."

He searched the case references.

No direct match yet.

Good.

Too early for history to solve the present.

Grace pointed to a company-secretarial practice.

"Look at succession."

The original principal retired.

A partner took over.

The firm changed name.

Later merged.

Different company.

Same client base.

Same document habits.

Daniel leaned closer.

"Method continuity."

"Yes."

"That helps my theory."

Grace looked at him.

"How?"

"If one financial designer used the same professional network over time—"

"Or professionals teach junior professionals."

Daniel stopped.

Aisyah, across the room, looked over.

Daniel said, “Why is everyone attacking me today?”

Grace smiled.

“Because you keep saying ‘one.’”

He hated that they were right.

Not because the theory was necessarily wrong.

Because the graph did not yet require a single person.

Daniel created a new note:

CENTRAL FINANCIAL DESIGNER — POSSIBLE.

Then stared at it.

Too long.

He shortened it.

ACCOUNTANT?

Still not right.

He removed the question mark.

THE ACCOUNTANT.

Aisyah saw the new label from across the room.

“No.”

Daniel looked at her.

“It is a working node.”

“It is a person.”

“It is a label.”

“You gave it ‘The.’”

“That is grammar.”

“You gave it identity.”

Daniel leaned back.

“We need a handle.”

“Call it unknown financial architecture.”

“That is ugly.”

“Ugly is useful.”

“Rahman says that too.”

“He is right.”

Daniel looked at the black node on the screen.

THE ACCOUNTANT.

It sat between company clusters, not because any evidence identified a human being, but because his model needed somewhere to place the repeated financial logic.

Aisyah stood beside him.

"What evidence says one person?"

"Consistency."

"What kind?"

"Invoice categories recur. Amount bands recur. Timing around enforcement pressure. Use of professional intermediaries. Company closures before direct exposure. Successor entities appearing after."

"Could be templates."

"Yes."

"Could be a firm."

"Yes."

"Could be several advisers."

"Yes."

"Could be clients copying what worked."

"Yes."

"Then why one person?"

Daniel looked at the graph.

"Because the adaptations are coherent."

Aisyah waited.

"When law-enforcement attention changes, the financial behaviour changes in a way that suggests someone sees across multiple businesses."

"That is better."

"You agree?"

"I agree the behaviour may reflect shared knowledge."

Daniel sighed.

"You should have been a lawyer."

"No."

"Why not?"

"Too much talking."

Rahman entered during the argument.

He stopped at the screen.

"What is The Accountant?"

Daniel answered before Aisyah could.

"Unknown financial architect."

Rahman looked at the graph.

"One person?"

"Likely."

Aisyah said, "Unproven."

Daniel said, “I said likely.”

“Based on?”

“Pattern consistency.”

Rahman looked at Aisyah.

“Alternative?”

“Method. firm. inherited practice. multiple people responding to the same incentives.”

Daniel frowned.

“Inherited from who?”

“I don’t know.”

“Then it is not an alternative. It is a category.”

“It is exactly an alternative.”

Rahman raised a hand.

“Confidence.”

Daniel understood.

“High that the financial behaviour is not random.”

“High is what?”

“Eighty percent.”

Aisyah looked irritated.

Daniel continued before she could object.

“Moderate that coordination exists across some of the businesses.”

“Moderate?”

“Sixty.”

“One person?”

Daniel paused.

“Fifty-five.”

Aisyah said, “So barely better than your own uncertainty.”

“That is not how probability works.”

“It is how confidence sounds when you attach a dramatic name.”

Rahman looked at the node.

“Keep the label.”

Aisyah turned to him.

Daniel smiled.

Rahman continued.

“Mark it hypothesis.”

Daniel’s smile faded.

“Fine.”

He added:

THE ACCOUNTANT — ANALYTICAL HYPOTHESIS / IDENTITY UNKNOWN.

Rahman said, “Better.”

“It is longer.”

“That is not a problem.”

Daniel disagreed privately.

They spent the afternoon testing the hypothesis.

If one architect existed, there should be moments when unrelated businesses changed behaviour at similar times.

They found three.

After a large organised-crime arrest in 2021, five companies shifted from direct service invoices to layered subcontracting within four months.

After a banking compliance change, four businesses moved accounts to different institutions using similar board resolutions.

After a customs seizure in 2024, two transport companies and one warehouse operator changed beneficial ownership structures.

Interesting.

Not proof.

Grace found a normal explanation for one.

The same corporate advisory bulletin had recommended the ownership change.

Daniel removed the example.

That hurt.

Good analysis should hurt when facts improve it.

A second pattern collapsed when Aisyah discovered the companies shared an external auditor.

Daniel removed that too.

The third survived.

Five companies changing invoice behaviour after the 2021 arrests with no obvious common adviser.

He stared at it.

“There.”

Aisyah said, “One surviving example.”

“Five companies.”

“One event.”

"Repeated behaviour."

"Yes."

Daniel leaned toward the screen.

"You are impossible to impress."

"That is why I am here."

At 20:30, Daniel linked the financial graph to operational access records.

Not names.

Events.

Meranti planning window.

Salmah protection changes.

Hafiz's investigation dates.

Several companies in the seven-company cluster moved money or changed service providers near those periods.

The timing looked disturbing.

Then Daniel checked baseline activity.

The same companies made similar changes at other times too.

He swore.

Aisyah looked over.

"What?"

"My pattern has business activity."

"Tragic."

He rubbed his face.

"Data should be cleaner than people."

"It is."

"That is not helping."

"Clean data can still support a bad conclusion."

Daniel looked at her.

"That sounds like something you have been waiting to say all day."

"Yes."

She came over.

"True transaction."

"Yes."

"True director."

"Yes."

"True date."

"Yes."

"False story."

"Possible."

"That is your risk."

Daniel looked at the node.

THE ACCOUNTANT.

He knew she was right.

The graph contained facts.

The shape was his.

That distinction was easy to forget because software rendered both with equal confidence.

Before leaving, he saved a new version.

No deletion of failed theories.

Aisyah insisted.

He kept the discarded links in an analytical-history layer.

Rahman approved.

At 22:05, Daniel was alone in SOC 4.

The black node remained near the centre of the screen.

THE ACCOUNTANT — ANALYTICAL HYPOTHESIS / IDENTITY UNKNOWN.

He zoomed out.

Three hundred eighty-seven companies.

Forty-one worth review.

Seven strongly interesting.

One imagined architect.

He still believed there was a person behind the pattern.

Not because he needed a villain.

Because coherent adaptation usually came from intelligence, and intelligence usually lived somewhere.

Maybe one person.

Maybe a small team.

But someone.

He opened a private analytical note inside the official system.

NOT A FINDING:

Financial structures across multiple investigated businesses show recurring methods of obligation movement, payment layering, professional intermediation and post-enforcement adaptation. Working hypothesis:

one experienced financial coordinator may service multiple otherwise separate criminal-commercial relationships.

He paused.

Then added:

Alternative: recurring method reproduced by several professionals without central coordination.

He hated the second sentence.

That was probably why it needed to stay.

Daniel saved.

On the screen, the node remained.

THE ACCOUNTANT.

A name attached to uncertainty.

For now, that was all it was.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

SEVEN MINUTES

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

The warehouse was empty enough to feel rehearsed.

Rahman entered through the loading bay at 21:34, four minutes after the first tactical team had cleared the ground floor.

No suspects.

No weapons.

No drugs.

No desperate men hiding behind pallets.

Only fluorescent light, a forklift still warm and three cups of tea on a folding table near the office.

One cup had a skin of milk cooling at the surface.

Rahman did not touch the cup. He had held his palm over warm food in the rain, and again over four plates beside a portable stove. He knew what a warm room meant now. This was the third time he had arrived just after the people he came for.

Rafiq stood beside it.

“They were here.”

Rahman looked around.

“How long?”

“Not long.”

A tactical officer approached.

“Upper office clear. Back gate open. No sign of forced exit.”

“Vehicles?”

“Two company lorries. No private cars.”

Rahman looked toward the loading-bay doors.

RZ Meridian Logistics.

The name was painted in blue across the wall.

A respectable logistics business.

Customs licences.

Government contracts.

Warehouse services.

The kind of company Daniel's financial graph treated as interesting but not criminal.

The target of tonight's raid was its owner, Zafir Razak.

Forty-six.

Clean public profile.

Family photographs on business pages.

Donations to schools.

Board memberships.

No criminal conviction.

And three weeks of ORION work suggesting his company sat between illegal gambling money, warehouse access and transport services used by people already under investigation.

The warrant was narrow.

Financial records.

Specific storage bays.

Communications devices.

No fishing.

No performance.

Rahman looked at the tea again.

"CCTV."

Rafiq nodded.

"Already securing."

Aisyah came through the side door wearing a scene vest.

"Office safe is empty."

"Expected contents?"

"Company cashbook, according to source description."

"Source reliable?"

"Moderate."

"So absence proves nothing."

"Yes."

Daniel's voice came through Rahman's earpiece.

"Dato', I need you in the mobile command unit."

"Now?"

"Preferably before somebody decides the computer logs are boring."

Rahman left the warehouse.

The command vehicle sat behind a row of tactical vans.

Daniel had three screens open.

Access logs on one.

Warehouse CCTV on another.

Vehicle-tracking data on the third.

He pointed to the access timeline.

"Final target annex opened at 20:51."

Rahman looked at the line.

"User?"

"Authorised privileged identity."

"Which?"

Daniel hesitated.

"Direct-access pool."

"How many?"

"Six."

Rahman felt the first contraction of suspicion.

"Names?"

"Not until I verify the log is not inherited session activity."

Aisyah climbed into the vehicle behind him.

"Good."

Daniel looked offended.

"I was going to verify."

"You were going to say the name first."

"Names are efficient."

"Names bias."

Rahman looked at the timestamp.

20:51:03.

Session duration: forty-seven seconds.

The final target annex included raid time, entry teams, target identity and storage-bay numbers.

"Any download?"

"No."

"Print?"

"No."

"Screenshot?"

"System cannot tell."

"Remote?"

"No evidence yet."

Rafiq appeared at the door.

"We have CCTV."

Daniel switched screens.

The warehouse exterior camera showed the front parking area.

Timestamp 21:22:48.

A black Mercedes rolled from behind the office building.

Daniel froze the image.

Driver visible only in profile.

Passenger seat empty.

Vehicle registered to Zafir Razak.

A second camera caught the gate.

21:23:17.

Zafir's car left.

The raid began at 21:30.

Seven minutes.

Nobody spoke.

Rahman watched the gate image again.

Zafir did not speed.

Did not flee.

He simply left.

As if he knew exactly how much time he had.

Rafiq said, "That is our leak."

Aisyah looked at him.

"That is our timing."

"Seven minutes."

"Yes."

"You think coincidence?"

"I think seven minutes is evidence of departure time."

Rafiq's jaw tightened.

Daniel said, "I can make it worse."

Rahman looked at him.

"The annex access at 20:51 was the last privileged view before the raid."

"So thirty-two minutes before Zafir leaves."

"Yes."

"Enough time for a warning."

"Yes."

"Not proof of warning."

Aisyah said it first.

Daniel nodded reluctantly.

Rahman looked at the six-person pool.

He did not ask for names yet.

That surprised him.

Good.

He was learning.

They secured the scene.

No dramatic breakthrough.

One office computer.

Two phones belonging to warehouse employees.

Paper invoices.

Vehicle logs.

A locked cabinet containing customs forms and maintenance contracts.

Nothing that justified the empty safe.

Nothing that explained the tea.

Zafir did not answer his phone.

His lawyer did.

"My client is travelling."

"Where?"

"I am not authorised to say."

"He left the warehouse seven minutes before police entered."

Silence.

Then: "That sounds like something you should ask him."

"We are."

"Then when he returns, he will respond through counsel."

Rahman ended the call.

At 23:40, ORION reconvened in SOC 4.

Daniel had verified the access pool.

Six identities had privileged authority to open the final package directly.

Not necessarily the six people Rahman later listed as suspects.

The access system grouped permissions by role, not by suspicion.

One command authority.

One integrity authority.

One digital-security function.

One operations coordination function.

One case-command function.

One authorised liaison identity.

Daniel displayed the names only after freezing the audit copy.

Rahman read them.

His own was there.

Aisyah's.

Daniel's.

Others.

Enough to damage trust.

Not enough to identify a leak.

Rafiq said, "One of us warned him."

Aisyah replied, "Or one credential was used by someone else."

"Same problem."

"No. Different problem."

Daniel said, "Could also be session shadowing."

Rafiq stared.

"In English."

"A user leaves an authenticated session open. Another person accesses under it."

"Would the system show that?"

"No."

"Excellent."

Rahman looked at the timeline.

"External surveillance?"

Rafiq said, "Possible."

"Tactical staging seen?"

"No obvious sign."

"Police radio?"

"Encrypted."

"Source compromise?"

Aisyah said, "Possible."

"Target watching us?"

Daniel said, “Always possible.”

Rahman wrote on the board:

20:51 — FINAL ANNEX ACCESSED — 47 SECONDS

21:23 — ZAFIR DEPARTS

21:30 — ENTRY

Then beneath it:

ACCESS ≠ LEAK.

DEPARTURE ≠ KNOWLEDGE.

SEVEN MINUTES = FACT.

Rafiq looked at him.

“You enjoy making obvious things sound bureaucratic.”

“No.”

Rahman capped the marker.

“I enjoy not arresting the wrong person.”

The room stayed tense.

At 01:10, Daniel found that the 20:51 session came from a workstation inside headquarters.

Not remote.

The workstation was in a secure planning area used by multiple ORION-authorised personnel.

Camera coverage existed.

The relevant corridor camera was operational.

Good.

They pulled footage.

At 20:48, two officers entered the corridor.

At 20:52, one left.

The second remained.

Neither was one of the six privileged identities.

Daniel stared.

“That helps and hurts.”

Aisyah leaned forward.

“Badge readers?”

“One officer badged into the planning room under escort protocol.”

“Escort by who?”

Daniel checked.

“Authorised user.”

“Name?”

He showed them.

A legitimate administrative reason existed.

The escorted officer had delivered updated vehicle photographs.

The authorised user had opened the planning room.

That did not prove the escorted officer touched a terminal.

Did not prove the authorised user opened the annex.

Did not prove either had anything to do with Zafir.

Rafiq said, “We are drowning in possible.”

Aisyah replied, “Possible is where we are.”

Rahman looked at the footage.

The temptation was immediate.

Freeze the frame.

Choose the suspicious face.

Build a story around posture, timing, opportunity.

He remembered Ramli Osman.

A photograph proves a meeting.

Not corruption.

“Interview both separately,” he said.

“Tonight?”

“Yes.”

“Accuse?”

“No.”

“Phones?”

Aisyah said, “Preservation request first.”

Daniel added, “And terminal forensics before reboot.”

Rahman nodded.

The authorised user was interviewed at 02:05.

He remembered entering the room.

Remembered opening a computer.

Claimed he had checked an updated vehicle annex, not the final raid package.

Could he have clicked the wrong file?

“Possible.”

Did he warn Zafir?

“No.”

Did he know Zafir personally?

“No.”

Financial check showed nothing obvious.

Phone preservation showed no immediate contact to known target numbers.

The escorted officer denied touching the terminal.

No evidence contradicted him.

At 04:00, ORION still had seven minutes and no culprit.

Daniel looked exhausted.

“I hate clean logs.”

Aisyah said, “They are not clean.”

“They are technically clean.”

“That is not the same.”

Rahman sat at the table.

The operation had failed.

Again.

But failure was not one thing.

Maybe Zafir had been warned.

Maybe he had detected surveillance.

Maybe the departure was routine.

Maybe somebody had opened the target package for innocent reasons.

Maybe the compromised point was not among the six at all.

The institution wanted one answer because one answer could be managed.

One mole.

One arrest.

One press statement.

Rahman looked at the access pool.

Six privileged identities.

His own included.

Trust had become evidence now.

That was dangerous.

At dawn, the warehouse forensic team called.

They had recovered a paper shredder bag from the office.

Mostly ordinary invoices.

One fragment showed a handwritten time.

21:30.

Nothing else.

No date.

No raid reference.

Could be shift change.

Pickup schedule.

Meeting.

Delivery.

Or the exact moment police intended to enter.

Rafiq stared at the photograph of the fragment.

"That is it."

Aisyah said, "It is a number."

"21:30."

"Yes."

"Our raid time."

"Yes."

"And you want to call it coincidence."

"I want to call it handwriting until we know who wrote it and why."

Rahman looked at the fragment.

The case was beginning to offer them exactly what frightened investigators most.

Facts that looked like answers.

He said, "Bag it. Compare handwriting. No assumptions."

At 07:15, Daniel updated the ORION board.

RZ MERIDIAN LOGISTICS.

ZAFIR RAZAK.

20:51 ACCESS.

21:23 DEPARTURE.

21:30 RAID.

SEVEN MINUTES.

The words looked clean.

The reality was not.

Rahman stood in front of the board.

Somewhere inside the police—or very close to it—information might be moving faster than ORION could protect it.

But the seven minutes did not tell him who.

Only that time had become evidence.

And someone, somewhere, had used it better than they had.

The handwriting result arrived the next afternoon.

No match to Zafir.

No match to the warehouse manager.

No match to the two employees whose desks were nearest the shredder.

The fragment still read 21:30.

Nothing more.

Rafiq looked at the forensic note and said, “So whoever wrote it is unknown.”

“Yes,” Aisyah said.

“Which means it could still be the raid time.”

“Yes.”

“And could still be unrelated.”

“Yes.”

Rafiq threw the report onto the table.

“I hate your job.”

Aisyah picked the report up and put it back into the file.

“You hate uncertainty.”

“Same thing this week.”

Daniel had spent the morning rebuilding the access event from system records.

The forty-seven-second session showed no file export, no print spool, no attachment creation and no remote connection. The target annex had opened, stayed active and closed.

That was all.

“Could someone read enough in forty-seven seconds?” Rahman asked.

Daniel opened the annex on an isolated test machine.

Raid time sat near the top.

Target name beneath it.

Primary warehouse bays one screen lower.

“Yes.”

“Could they have opened it accidentally?”

“Yes.”

“Could another person have been standing beside them?”

“Yes.”

“Could somebody photograph the screen?”

“Yes.”

Rahman looked at him.

"You enjoy that answer."

"No. I enjoy not pretending the system can tell us what it cannot."

Aisyah glanced at Daniel.

Progress.

The authorised user from the planning room voluntarily surrendered his phone for forensic review. No communication to Zafir. No unexplained encrypted app activity. No unusual payment.

The escorted officer did the same.

Nothing.

Rahman refused to call that exoneration.

He also refused to keep treating absence of evidence as suspicious simply because the raid had failed.

By the third day, the six privileged identities had become dangerous inside ORION even without accusation.

People watched who entered rooms.

Conversations stopped when someone approached.

Requests that once took minutes now came with written confirmation.

Aisyah found Daniel checking his own access history twice.

"You think someone used your credential?" she asked.

"I think if they did, I would like to know before you arrest me."

"I would not arrest you from one log."

"That is comforting in an oddly specific way."

Rahman saw the change too.

At the evening briefing, he erased the six names from the temporary board and replaced them with one line:

PRIVILEGED ACCESS POOL — SIX IDENTITIES / NO CULPRIT ESTABLISHED.

Rafiq looked at him.

"You are protecting them."

"I am protecting the investigation from us."

"Same thing Farid would say."

The words landed harder than Rafiq intended.

Rahman did not answer immediately.

Then he said, "That is why the evidence stays visible."

No hidden conclusion.

No quiet clearing.

No quiet accusation.

Only six identities and forty-seven seconds.

The failure had damaged ORION in a way the empty warehouse had not.

It had taught the team that access itself could become suspicion.

Suspicion, once attached to colleagues, was difficult to put back where evidence ended.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

THE DEAD WITNESS

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Faiz Idrus died before ORION could interview him a second time.

The call came at 05:32.

Aisyah answered.

By 06:10 she was standing outside a condominium in western Kota Aruna while rain moved across the car park in thin diagonal lines.

Faiz Idrus had been forty-two.

Civilian witness.

Former accounts manager for a services company linked indirectly to two businesses on Daniel's financial map.

Not a hero.

Not a criminal.

A man who had agreed, reluctantly, to explain why invoices moved through companies that appeared to provide nothing.

His first interview had lasted ninety minutes.

He had been nervous.

Careful.

He had asked twice whether ORION could protect his family.

Aisyah had not promised more than the system could provide.

Two days later, he was dead.

The initial report called it suicide.

A fall from the twenty-first-floor service balcony.

No witness to the fall.

No sign of struggle inside the unit.

A note on the dining table.

His phone beside it.

Local CID had secured the scene before ORION arrived.

That was correct.

Aisyah still hated it.

The investigating officer met her at the lobby.

“Inspector.”

“Scene log.”

He handed it over.

Seven names.

First responder.

Medical officer.

Scene photographer.

Duty investigator.

Building security supervisor.

Two forensic staff.

Times recorded.

No obvious gap.

“What time found?”

“04:46.”

“By?”

“Security guard. Body landed inside service courtyard.”

“Wife?”

“In Penang with children.”

“Confirmed?”

“Yes.”

“CCTV?”

“Building system.”

“Working?”

“Mostly.”

The word stopped her.

“Mostly?”

“Lift cameras. lobby. car park. service corridor on twenty-one had outage.”

“When?”

The officer looked at his notes.

“03:58 to 04:31.”

Aisyah looked at him.

“Thirty-three minutes.”

“Yes.”

“Cause?”
“System reboot.”
“Automatic?”
“Security says yes.”
“Logs preserved?”
“Yes.”
Good.
Not proof.
Anomaly.
She entered the unit at 06:28.
One investigator already inside.
He did not touch anything.
Good.
Aisyah stood near the doorway and looked before moving.
Dining table.
Half glass of water.
Printed note.
Phone.
Living room tidy.
One chair slightly angled away from the table.
Balcony door open.
Rain had blown onto the tile.
The note was short.
Too tired.
Sorry.
No names.
No accusations.
No explanation.
Aisyah read without touching.
“Handwriting?”
“Looks like his.”
“Looks?”
“Family confirmation pending.”
“Printer?”
“Handwritten.”
She nodded.
Faiz’s phone was sealed in a transparent evidence bag.

“Unlocked?”
“Screen was active when found.”
“Who handled?”
“First responder saw it. Did not open apps.”
“Passcode?”
“Unknown.”
The scene officer pointed to a charger.
“Phone was connected to power.”
Aisyah looked at the body-position photographs.
The fall path was physically plausible.
No obvious restraint marks visible in preliminary images.
No broken furniture.
No blood inside.
No forced entry.
Everything could be exactly what it looked like.
That bothered her more than disorder would have.
Rahman arrived at 07:05.
He stood in the kitchen.
“You think murder?”
“No.”
“Good.”
She looked at him.
“That answer disappointed you?”
“No.”
“It should not.”
“I know.”
Aisyah turned back to the note.
“I think the scene contains questions.”
“That is different.”
“Yes.”
Rahman studied the room.
“What questions?”
“CCTV outage.”
“Yes.”
“Protection schedule.”
He looked at her.
“What about it?”

Faiz had not been under full-time protection.

He had refused.

He agreed only to periodic checks and a discreet patrol pattern around the building.

Aisyah pulled the roster.

“Last night’s check was missed.”

“Why?”

“Roster amendment.”

“Approved?”

“Appears so.”

“Who?”

“Duty supervisor.”

“Reason?”

“Staffing.”

Rahman’s expression tightened.

Another anomaly.

Not proof.

“When changed?”

Aisyah checked.

“Yesterday afternoon.”

“Before or after Faiz’s second interview was scheduled?”

“After.”

Rahman looked toward the balcony.

The second interview had been due at ten that morning.

Faiz had told ORION he wanted to “clarify one company.”

He had not named it on the phone.

Now he never would.

Daniel arrived at 07:40.

He stayed outside the scene until Aisyah cleared him to review building-system logs from a duplicate export.

“CCTV reboot was manually initiated.”

Aisyah looked at him.

“By building security?”

“Credential says maintenance admin.”

“Who holds?”

“Two staff and vendor remote account.”

“Remote login?”

"Local network."

"So somebody inside building network."

"Yes."

"Could be scheduled maintenance?"

"Not scheduled."

"Could be fault response?"

"Yes."

"Any fault?"

"System reported camera packet loss at 03:57."

"Real?"

Daniel shrugged.

"Could be."

Aisyah disliked that word less today.

Could be was honest.

Rahman asked, "Faiz phone?"

"Not yet. Need warrant scope and forensic image."

"Get it."

The building security supervisor insisted nobody suspicious entered.

Aisyah did not ask whether he had seen criminals.

She asked for all entries from midnight to five.

Residents.

Visitors.

Delivery riders.

Maintenance.

Parking access.

At 02:14, a vehicle entered using a resident-linked transponder.

At 02:29, it left.

At 03:36, a delivery rider entered.

Food delivery to floor eighteen.

At 04:02, a man in maintenance clothing used the rear service entrance.

Camera caught only partial profile.

Security log showed vendor technician.

Vendor company said no technician had been dispatched.

Now Rahman looked at Aisyah.

She said, "Still not murder."

"No."

"But?"

"But someone entered under false maintenance status during the CCTV outage."

Daniel corrected her.

"Just before."

"What time?"

"Rear entry 04:02. Outage begins 03:58."

Aisyah looked at him.

"Then during."

"Camera at rear entrance was on separate recorder. It survived."

Good.

Facts correcting story.

Always.

The man left at 04:28.

No clear face.

Cap.

Maintenance polo.

Tool bag.

Average height.

Nothing distinctive.

Could be connected.

Could be unrelated trespass.

Could be a contractor avoiding paperwork.

Could be the person who killed Faiz.

They did not know.

At 11:20, the forensic pathologist gave preliminary findings.

Fall injuries caused death.

No obvious defensive injuries.

No sedative result yet.

No ligature marks.

No clear evidence of assault.

Aisyah asked, "Could he have been forced over without leaving signs?"

"Yes."

"Could he have jumped voluntarily?"

"Yes."

"Could someone have threatened him?"

"Not a pathology question."

Good answer.
By afternoon, Faiz's phone had been imaged.
No dramatic confession.
No message saying THEY ARE COMING.
Last outgoing call at 22:13 to his wife.
Seventeen minutes.
Normal, according to her.
Several work messages.
One deleted chat thread with an unknown prepaid number.
Daniel recovered fragments.
The most recent readable message from Faiz:
I will speak tomorrow. Need to correct something.
Response:
Your choice.
Nothing else.
No threat.
No identifiable sender.
Rafiq said, "That is intimidation."
Aisyah said, "It is a sentence."
Rafiq stared at her.
"You enjoy ruining evidence."
"I enjoy not ruining cases."
Rahman stood near the board.
"Trace number."
"Working."
"Family finances?"
"Working."
"Building man?"
"Working."
"Protection roster?"
Aisyah said, "Duty supervisor claims staffing shortage."
"True?"
"Yes."
"Why Faiz check specifically?"
"Two missed checks that night, not only his."
"So could be ordinary failure."
"Yes."

The answer did not comfort anyone.

That was the difficult thing about institutional vulnerability.

A genuine staffing problem could create exactly the opening a criminal needed.

No corrupt order required.

Only knowledge.

By evening, media had heard a witness connected to a financial case had died.

No name yet.

Command wanted a statement.

Rahman refused language implying homicide.

Also refused language closing the death as suicide.

The approved line read:

MNPS is reviewing the death of an individual who had previously provided information to an active investigation. The cause and circumstances remain under examination. No conclusion regarding third-party involvement has been established.

Farid called Rahman after the statement went out.

“You are creating pressure.”

“Yes.”

“If it is suicide?”

“Then we will say so when evidence supports it.”

“If it is not?”

“Same answer.”

Farid was silent.

Then: “Good.”

Rahman ended the call.

At 22:00, Aisyah sat alone with the scene timeline.

03:58 — CCTV service-corridor outage begins.

04:02 — false maintenance entry.

04:28 — false maintenance exit.

04:31 — cameras recover.

04:46 — body found.

Protection check missed.

Second interview due at 10:00.

Deleted message.

All suggestive.

None decisive.

She wrote in the ORION record:

DEATH CURRENTLY CONSISTENT WITH FATAL FALL. SUICIDE NOTE PRESENT. MULTIPLE CIRCUMSTANTIAL ANOMALIES REQUIRE INDEPENDENT EXAMINATION. HOMICIDE NOT ESTABLISHED. SUICIDE NOT YET TREATED AS EXCLUSIVE EXPLANATION.

Daniel read over her shoulder.

“That is aggressively unsatisfying.”

“It is accurate.”

“People hate accurate uncertainty.”

“Yes.”

Rahman entered.

He looked exhausted.

“Anything new?”

“Not enough.”

He nodded.

Aisyah looked at him.

“You expected a witness death.”

“No.”

“You look like you did.”

Rahman stood by the windowless wall.

“Harun used to say disappearance was also evidence.”

“That sounds dangerous.”

“It is.”

He looked at the timeline.

“Because once someone is gone, investigators start making the absence explain everything.”

Aisyah closed the file.

“Then we don’t.”

“No.”

“Faiz does not become proof of a pattern.”

“No.”

“Does not become proof of murder.”

“No.”

“Does not become proof of police involvement.”

“No.”

Rahman nodded.

"We prove what happened."
Aisyah looked at the note again.
Too tired. Sorry.
Maybe genuine.
Maybe forced.
Maybe written earlier.
Maybe written in a moment no one else understood.
A life reduced to ambiguity.
That angered her.
Not because she wanted murder.
Because certainty had become another thing taken from him.
At 01:30, Daniel returned with the prepaid-number trace.
No subscriber identity.
Cash purchase.
SIM activated three weeks earlier.
Used only six times.
Three towers.
All within central Kota Aruna.
No direct tie to known ORION subjects.
He looked at Aisyah.
"Nothing."
"Not nothing."
"What?"
"A controlled communication channel existed."
"Between Faiz and someone."
"Yes."
"Who?"
"We don't know."
Daniel sighed.
Rahman said, "Log it."
They did.
No revelation.
No accusation.
One more piece.
The next morning, Faiz's wife identified the note as his handwriting.
She also said he had never spoken of suicide.
Both facts entered the file.

Neither cancelled the other.

ORION opened a full integrity and death-circumstances review.

Not a murder case.

Not yet.

That distinction would irritate people outside the room.

Inside ORION, it was the only honest place to stand.

Faiz Idrus was dead.

Someone using false maintenance access had entered his building during a camera outage.

His protection check had failed.

His phone contained a deleted exchange.

He had planned to speak again.

And none of that, together, was yet enough to tell them who had killed him.

Or whether anyone had.

The toxicology results took two days.

No incapacitating drug.

A small amount of prescribed sleep medication, within therapeutic range.

Alcohol below the level expected to impair coordination significantly.

Nothing that turned the death into murder.

Nothing that made suicide certain either.

Faiz's wife returned to Kota Aruna for the formal family interview.

Aisyah conducted it with a counsellor present.

Mrs. Idrus looked at the handwritten note for almost a minute.

"That is his writing."

"You are certain?"

"Yes."

"Did he normally write in English?"

"Sometimes."

"Did he use this kind of paper?"

"It came from our house."

Aisyah waited.

"Had he been depressed?"

Mrs. Idrus looked at her.

"No."

"Any treatment?"

"No."

"Any recent fear?"

Now the pause.

"He said work from years ago had come back."

"What did he mean?"

"He did not say."

"Did he mention police?"

"Yes."

Aisyah did not move.

"What exactly?"

"He said the police were asking about invoices. He said maybe he should have told the truth earlier."

"Earlier when?"

"I don't know."

"Did he say anyone threatened him?"

"No."

"Did he say he was afraid?"

Mrs. Idrus looked toward the window.

"He said, 'If I talk, people will say I knew more than I did.'"

That sentence mattered.

Not because it proved danger.

Because Faiz understood the same problem ORION did.

Proximity could become guilt after the fact.

Aisyah asked, "Did he know a person named Zafir Razak?"

"No."

"Raziq Jamal?"

A slight reaction.

Not recognition exactly.

"Maybe. I heard that name once."

"When?"

"I don't remember."

Aisyah recorded it without interpretation.

After the interview, Rahman asked, "Raziq?"

"Maybe."

"That is new."

"It is weak."

"Yes."

They searched Faiz's old accounting records again.

Raziq Jamal appeared once in a scanned visitor log from four years earlier.

No meeting purpose.

No signature beside Faiz.

Another fact that could become too much if investigators wanted it to.

The false maintenance man remained unidentified.

Building access records showed he had used a service code created three months earlier for contractors.

The code should have expired after two weeks.

It had not.

Administrative failure.

Maybe exploited.

Maybe coincidental.

Rahman stared at the code history.

"You don't need a corrupt guard if the system forgets to close a door."

Aisyah nodded.

"And you don't need to control the whole building. Only know which door stays open."

Neither said what both were thinking.

That logic sounded uncomfortably familiar.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

THE SECOND ENVELOPE

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Aisyah found the second envelope in a place where corruption rarely looked dramatic.

A lunchbox.

The junior officer who owned it was Constable Amirul Hakim, twenty-six, attached to a regional coordination desk that handled routine requests from CID, traffic, customs liaison and organised-crime units.

His job sounded administrative because most police vulnerability sounded administrative before something went wrong.

Amirul could see unit movements.

Vehicle allocations.

Meeting-room bookings.

Occasional operational requests before they were classified into final packages.

Not ORION.

Never ORION.

That distinction mattered.

He came to IID attention after a financial review found cash deposits inconsistent with salary.

Not large.

RM500.

RM800.

RM1,200.

Irregular.

Always below the amount that would have looked theatrical in a newspaper graphic.

Aisyah and Razak interviewed him in a small integrity room with no two-way glass.

Rahman observed through secure video because Amirul's access might intersect wider ORION concerns.

Daniel sat beside him.

"First envelope?" Daniel asked quietly.

Rahman looked at him.

"What?"

"Your old bribe story. You told us once."

"I did not tell you the amount."

"People talk."

"Police talk too much."

Daniel nodded toward the screen.

"Apparently."

Aisyah placed the bank records in front of Amirul.

"Explain these."

Amirul looked at the page.

"Loans."

"From who?"

"Friends."

"Names."

He gave two.

Neither matched the deposit locations.

Aisyah showed him the ATM images.

A man depositing cash into Amirul's account at two different branches.

Amirul looked away.

"Who is he?"

"I don't know."

"Then why is he putting money in your account?"

"No idea."

Aisyah waited.

Silence did work sometimes.

People hurried to fill it.

Amirul lasted thirty-seven seconds.

"His name is Raziq."

Rahman leaned forward.

Daniel stopped typing.

Aisyah asked, “Full name.”

“I know him as Raziq Jamal.”

“How?”

“Friend of my cousin.”

“Which cousin?”

“Fikri.”

“What does Raziq do?”

“Business.”

Aisyah’s expression did not change.

“What business?”

“Transport. Events. I don’t know.”

“You accepted money from a man whose work you cannot describe.”

“He helped me.”

“With what?”

Amirul looked embarrassed.

“Motorcycle.”

“What about it?”

“Repair.”

The first favour was not cash.

That mattered.

Amirul’s motorcycle had been damaged in a minor accident. Insurance excess, workshop delay, parts he could not afford immediately.

His cousin introduced him to Raziq.

Raziq knew a workshop.

The repair was done quickly.

No payment requested.

“How much did you save?” Aisyah asked.

“Maybe eight hundred.”

“What did he ask in return?”

“Nothing.”

“Never?”

“Not then.”

Aisyah let the words sit.

“Later?”

Amirul looked at the table.

“A small thing.”

"What?"

"He asked whether traffic enforcement was heavy near Tanjung Keris that weekend."

"What did you tell him?"

"Normal deployment."

"From memory?"

"I checked."

"Where?"

"Coordination system."

"Authorised purpose?"

"No."

Rahman watched Amirul's shoulders collapse by a fraction.

There.

The first step.

Not RM500 in an envelope.

A repair.

Then information that felt harmless.

Aisyah said, "Next?"

"He asked whether a certain CID unit was in Kota Aruna or North Corridor."

"You checked."

"Yes."

"Next?"

"Meeting day for a task group."

"Which task group?"

"Port cargo theft."

"Next?"

Amirul rubbed his face.

"He asked who was leading a vehicle-theft operation."

"Name?"

"I gave the unit, not the officer."

Aisyah said nothing.

Amirul rushed to fill it.

"It was not secret-secret. People around HQ knew."

"Then why did Raziq need you to check?"

Amirul stopped.

Exactly.

"Did he ever ask about ORION?"
"No."
"Did you ever access ORION?"
"No."
Daniel checked independently.
Amirul did not have ORION permissions.
No direct access to the final target annex.
No access to Salmah's protection schedule.
No documented custody role in Hafiz's phone.
He was compromised.
He was not their seven-minute answer.
Aisyah continued.
"When did money start?"
"After my mother's hospital bill."
"How did he know?"
"My cousin."
"Raziq offered?"
"Yes."
"What did you say?"
"No."
"And?"
"He said it was not for anything. Just help."
"Then he deposited anyway."
Amirul nodded.
"Did you return it?"
"No."
"Why?"
"I needed it."
The answer was almost a whisper.
Rahman thought of Harun's line.
They don't control people. They control what people are afraid to lose.
Family.
Debt.
Shame.
Amirul did not look greedy.
He looked ordinary.
That was worse.

Aisyah asked, “What did Raziq request after the hospital money?”

“More things.”

“Such as?”

“Which units were moving. Whether customs had joint operations. If a certain officer was on leave.”

“Did you understand why?”

“Not really.”

“You never wondered?”

“Of course I wondered.”

“Then why continue?”

Amirul looked at her.

“I already took the money.”

There it was.

Not loyalty.

Obligation.

Aisyah leaned back.

“Did he threaten you?”

“No.”

“Blackmail?”

“No.”

“Say he would expose you?”

“No.”

“Then what stopped you?”

Amirul’s eyes reddened.

“I don’t know.”

Aisyah did.

The favour had changed the relationship.

The first request created the second.

The second made refusal harder because refusal would force Amirul to admit what the first one had meant.

By the time money arrived, the moral argument had already been lost.

After the interview, Daniel pulled Raziq Jamal’s records.

Forty-three.

Transport broker.

Event logistics.

Vehicle leasing.

No serious conviction.

Several companies over fifteen years.

One minor commercial dispute.

Two civil judgments.

Three businesses that had provided services to companies on Daniel's financial graph.

Interesting.

Not proof.

Rafiq joined the briefing.

"So Amirul is our leak."

"No," Rahman said.

Rafiq looked at him.

"He admits passing police information to Raziq."

"Yes."

"Then what do you call that?"

"Compromise."

"Difference?"

"He could not access the major ORION material."

"Maybe Raziq has others."

"Maybe."

"That is the network."

"Maybe."

Rafiq exhaled.

"Everything is maybe."

Aisyah said, "Until it isn't."

Daniel displayed Amirul's transaction history.

Cash deposits.

Workshop invoice showing zero balance.

Hospital account payment made by a company called Latif Murni Services.

That name did not match Raziq directly.

Daniel searched.

A director's brother had once partnered with Raziq in an events company.

Three degrees of separation.

Maybe deliberate.

Maybe normal business life.

Rahman said, “Do not call it payment from Raziq unless we can trace it.”

Daniel nodded.

Aisyah added, “And do not call Amirul part of anything. Not yet.”

Rafiq looked at her.

“Part of what?”

Nobody answered.

Nobody inside ORION had yet given the thing a name.

Good.

Rahman wanted it that way until evidence—or a source—gave them a reason.

Amirul agreed to cooperate.

Not immunity.

No promise of avoiding charges.

His devices were surrendered.

His access suspended.

IID opened formal proceedings.

He cried only once.

When Aisyah told him his mother would not be interviewed unless necessary.

“Please don’t tell her,” he said.

“That is not a promise I can make.”

“She thinks I am a good policeman.”

Aisyah looked at him.

“You can still decide what kind of policeman you are after this.”

He shook his head.

“No. It is finished.”

“Your career may be.”

The distinction made him look up.

Aisyah continued.

“That is not the same as your choices being finished.”

Later, Rahman asked why she had said it.

“Because he is guilty,” she replied.

“That usually makes you less gentle.”

“I was not being gentle.”

She closed Amirul’s file.

"I was making sure guilt did not become an excuse for the next bad decision."

Rahman understood.

Farhan would matter later for the same reason.

So would he.

That night, Daniel added Raziq Jamal to the network graph.

Not as leader.

Not as criminal mastermind.

A connector.

One man who knew a workshop, a cousin, a service company and a young constable whose mother had a hospital bill.

Daniel stared at the line between Raziq and Amirul.

"No bribe at the beginning."

Aisyah stood beside him.

"No."

"Just help."

"Yes."

"Then information."

"Yes."

"Then money."

"Yes."

Daniel added a note beneath the link:

DEPENDENCY PATH — FAVOUR → INFORMATION → BENEFIT → OBLIGATION.

Rahman read it from across the room.

That was the second envelope.

Not paper.

Not cash handed across a table.

A relationship that had learned how to become an envelope without ever needing one.

The first controlled contact with Raziq produced nothing dramatic.

That was exactly why Aisyah believed Amirul.

Under supervision, Amirul sent a short message from his own phone.

Need to talk. Problem at work.

Raziq replied eleven minutes later.

Tonight cannot. Tomorrow maybe.

No panic.

No instruction to destroy anything.

No criminal language.

A man answering someone he knew.

Daniel looked disappointed.

“You wanted him to say burn the files?” Aisyah asked.

“It would help.”

“It would help television.”

“Also prosecution.”

Rahman said, “Keep going.”

The next day Raziq called instead of messaging.

The call was lawfully monitored under the cooperation arrangement.

Amirul’s voice shook.

“Abang, IID asking about my account.”

A pause.

Raziq said, “Then tell truth.”

Daniel looked at Rahman.

Not what they expected.

Amirul continued, “About the money?”

“What money?”

“The hospital.”

Another pause.

“That was help.”

“They ask what I gave you.”

“You gave me nothing.”

Amirul looked through the glass at Aisyah.

She gave no signal.

“Roadblocks. unit movements.”

Raziq exhaled.

“You answered questions. People answer questions.”

“Police questions.”

“Amirul, listen. You never stole file. You never sell operation. You help friend understand when road busy, who working. Small things.”

There it was.

Rationalisation supplied from outside.

Not threat.

Not confession.

A story Amirul could use to remain himself.

Amirul said, “IID thinks it is corruption.”

Raziq replied, “IID thinks everything corruption.”

The line ended two minutes later.

Daniel removed his headset.

“He is careful.”

Aisyah said, “Or he believes what he said.”

“That is worse.”

Rahman looked at Amirul through the glass.

Yes.

Corruption that required villains was easier.

Corruption carried by ordinary self-explanation could reproduce forever.

The call gave them no arrest basis for Raziq.

It did give them probable cause to widen financial and communications review through lawful process.

Over the next week, Raziq’s name appeared near five other people already known to police.

Near.

Not inside.

A vehicle-rental owner investigated for stolen cargo.

A bookmaker whose brother used Raziq’s event company.

A property agent who arranged a warehouse lease.

A former customs clerk who attended the same community association dinner.

And a solicitor who had represented two men from unrelated smuggling cases.

Daniel put the links on screen.

Aisyah made him remove three.

“Why?”

“Community dinner is noise.”

“Could be relationship.”

“Could be eight hundred people in one ballroom.”

“The solicitor?”

“Lawyers have clients.”

“The rental owner?”

“That one stays. Direct transaction.”

Daniel reduced the graph.

Again.

The network got smaller and more credible.

Rahman preferred it that way.

A broad theory could explain anything.

A narrow one had to survive facts.

Amirul's formal statement took six hours.

At one point he asked for a break, went to the washroom and vomited.

When he returned, he said, "Can I lose pension?"

Aisyah answered, "Possible."

"Prison?"

"Possible."

"My mother's house?"

"Why would she lose her house?"

"I help pay."

The answer exposed another dependency created by the first.

Not Raziq's doing this time.

Consequence.

Amirul had become easier to control because he had more to lose after accepting help.

Rahman asked through the intercom, "Ask when he first realised the information could be used criminally."

Aisyah did.

Amirul stared at his hands.

"After Tanjung Keris."

"What happened?"

"Raziq asked if enforcement heavy Saturday. I said joint traffic and customs check near old interchange."

"And?"

"Next Monday someone in office joked smugglers changed route before checkpoint."

"You connected it to your answer?"

"Yes."

"Did you stop?"

"No."

"Why?"

"I told myself he already knew."

Aisyah waited.

Amirul closed his eyes.

“I told myself my answer did not matter.”

That sentence entered the case summary almost exactly as spoken.

Not because it proved a conspiracy.

Because it explained how small compromise survived inside a person who still wanted to think of himself as honest.

After the statement, Rahman stood alone in the interview room.

The table was bare.

No envelope.

No money.

Nothing like his first bribe attempt decades earlier.

That was the difference.

The old corruption he understood announced itself.

The new kind arrived disguised as kindness, convenience and information too small to feel like betrayal.

By the time it looked like corruption, the person inside it had already spent months explaining why it was not.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

THE CIRCLE

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Kelana chose the restaurant.

It was the first of his three conditions.

The second was no police vehicle within sight.

The third was that Rahman come alone.

Rahman ignored the third.

Aisyah sat two blocks away in an unmarked car with no line of sight to the table.

Kelana did not know she was there.

Rahman told himself that mattered less because she would not intervene unless he signalled.

Then he heard Aisyah's voice in his head asking whether hidden safeguards became acceptable simply because the good man in the room had chosen them.

He almost smiled.

Too early in their relationship for the sentence she would one day use against him.

But the principle already existed.

The restaurant was in an old commercial row near Taman Suria.

No air-conditioning.

Metal tables.

Fans that moved hot air from one wall to another.

Kelana sat at the back beside a window facing the alley.

He had changed since 1999.

Grey at the temples.

Thinner.

Still the same eyes.

Always counting exits.
“Boss.”
“Don’t call me that.”
“You have rank now. Makes boss more accurate.”
Rahman sat.
Kelana poured tea.
Rahman did not drink.
“You asked for me.”
“You asked too many people for Raziq.”
“We asked one person.”
Kelana smiled.
“That is what police always think.”
“Do you know him?”
“Know is expensive word.”
“Have you met him?”
“Yes.”
“When?”
“Many times.”
“Doing what?”
Kelana looked toward the kitchen.
“Making things easier.”
“For criminals?”
“For people.”
“That answer is why nobody trusts informants.”
“That answer is why informants live.”
Rahman let him have it.
“What does Raziq do?”
“Introduces.”
“Who to who?”
“Depends who asks.”
“Police?”
“Sometimes.”
“Criminals?”
“Sometimes.”
“Businessmen?”
“Mostly.”
“Why does a businessman need him?”

Kelana shrugged.

“Same reason police need me. Normal door closed, find side door.”

Rahman watched him.

“Amirul Hakim.”

Kelana showed no reaction.

“Do you know him?”

“No.”

“Raziq compromised him.”

“Then your boy was cheap.”

Rahman’s expression hardened.

Kelana corrected himself.

“Not cheap money. Cheap need.”

“What does that mean?”

“Everyone expensive in different currency.”

There it was.

Kelana had always spoken in street metaphors because direct nouns got people killed.

“Raziq works for who?” Rahman asked.

Kelana laughed softly.

“That question again.”

“What question?”

“Who is boss.”

“I did not ask boss.”

“You ask who he works for. Same disease.”

Rahman leaned back.

“Then cure me.”

Kelana poured more tea.

“Raziq works for need.”

“That means nothing.”

“It means man wants warehouse, Raziq knows warehouse. Man wants lawyer, he knows lawyer. Man wants police information, maybe he knows policeman. Policeman wants debt fixed, maybe he knows businessman.”

“Who pays him?”

“Sometimes person asking. Sometimes nobody.”

“Why help for nothing?”

Kelana smiled.

“Nothing is expensive later.”

Rahman thought of Amirul.

The motorcycle.

Hospital bill.

First favour.

Second request.

“Is this organised?”

“Yes.”

“By who?”

“No.”

Rahman stared.

Kelana tapped the table.

“You want organisation because police know how to arrest organisation.”

“People coordinate.”

“Yes.”

“Somebody connects them.”

“Many somebodies.”

“Somebody knows the whole picture.”

Kelana looked at him for a long time.

“That is the dangerous belief.”

“Why?”

“Because if you believe one man sees everything, you spend your life looking for king.”

“And?”

“And king may not exist.”

Rahman felt irritation.

“Then what do you call it?”

Kelana’s face changed.

Small.

Enough.

He looked toward the alley.

“The Circle.”

Rahman did not move.

First use.

No dramatic music.

No whispered revelation.

Just two words at a metal table.

"The Circle."

Kelana nodded.

"Who calls it that?"

"People who do not want to explain how they know somebody."

"Criminal group?"

"Sometimes criminals use name. Sometimes police. Sometimes businessmen. Mostly people outside use it more than people inside."

"Inside what?"

Kelana smiled without humour.

"Exactly."

Rahman took out no notebook.

He wanted Kelana talking.

"What is The Circle?"

"Not gang."

"What then?"

"People who can make things easier for each other."

"That describes every golf club in Kota Aruna."

"Yes."

Rahman stared.

Kelana continued.

"Difference is what things."

"Drugs?"

"Sometimes."

"Gambling?"

"Yes."

"Smuggling?"

"Yes."

"Police information?"

Kelana took a sip of tea.

"Yes."

"Money laundering?"

"Maybe."

"Trafficking?"

"Maybe."

"You don't know much for someone giving it a name."

"I know my street."

“What street?”
“The one where people ask favours.”
Rahman studied him.
“Raziq is Circle?”
Kelana made a face.
“Again membership.”
“Answer.”
“He is useful to people in it.”
“That is not answer.”
“It is only answer I have.”
“Zafir Razak?”
Kelana looked down at his tea.
That was more reaction than Amirul’s name had earned.
“Know him?”
“Seen him.”
“Circle?”
“Higher than Raziq.”
“In rank?”
“Usefulness.”
“What does he do?”
“Moves things.”
“Goods?”
“Yes.”
“Money?”
“Maybe.”
“Information?”
Kelana looked at him.
“Everything moves.”
Rahman felt the phrase settle.
“Who protects him?”
Kelana’s eyes sharpened.
“Now you ask better question.”
“Who?”
“I don’t know.”
“Police?”
“Sometimes police protect people without knowing.”
“How?”

"Wrong officer assigned. File late. Warrant delayed. Person transferred. Source says wait. Boss says bigger case."

Rahman did not like the list.

It sounded too close to legitimate police work.

Kelana noticed.

"That is why hard, boss."

"Don't call me boss."

"Policemen and criminals are not opposites, boss."

Kelana leaned closer.

"They're neighbours."

Rahman looked at him.

"Meaning?"

"Same roads. Same coffee shops. Same lawyers. Same businessmen. Same information. Sometimes same fear."

"That does not make police criminals."

"No."

Kelana shook his head.

"Neighbour not same family."

Good.

He still understood distinctions.

Rahman asked, "Who leads The Circle?"

Kelana's face lost all humour.

"That is the question that gets people killed."

"Because there is a leader?"

"No."

"Then why?"

"Because asking makes people think you want one."

Rahman frowned.

Kelana continued.

"King is dangerous idea. If people believe you found king, everybody else can disappear."

"What do you mean?"

"Arrest one big man. Newspaper happy. Police happy. Other people continue."

"Who are other people?"

"Broker. runner. lawyer. accountant. officer. businessman. whoever useful this year."

Rahman heard one word.
“Accountant?”
Kelana shrugged.
“Every business has one.”
Not Daniel’s reveal.
Not yet.
Just ordinary language.
Rahman did not chase it.
“How long has this existed?”
“Before me.”
“You were around in the nineties.”
“Yes.”
“Same people?”
“Some.”
“Same groups?”
“No.”
“Same name?”
Kelana shook his head.
“Name came later.”
That mattered.
Historical files should not contain it.
“What existed before the name?”
“Favour.”
Rahman waited.
Kelana smiled slightly.
“You police like labels. Street only needs phone number.”
A waiter approached.
Kelana stopped speaking until he left.
Then he said, “You are looking for leak.”
Rahman’s face stayed neutral.
“Why say that?”
“Because you ask old friends only when new friends fail.”
“Who told you ORION leaked?”
“I did not say ORION.”
Rahman said nothing.
Kelana laughed softly.
“See? Police also leak with face.”

“Answer.”
“Nobody tells me. I hear people stop being afraid before police arrive.”
“Zafir?”
“Maybe.”
“Seven minutes?”
Kelana looked genuinely blank.
Good.
The detail had not travelled through him, at least not visibly.
Rahman changed direction.
“If The Circle is not a gang, how do we investigate it?”
Kelana looked at him as if the question belonged to someone younger.
“Same way you investigate river.”
Rahman waited.
“You don’t arrest water.”
“What do you arrest?”
“People who poison it.”
Kelana stood.
Meeting over.
Rahman said, “Raziq.”
Kelana paused.
“Find who asks him for help.”
“Zafir.”
“Find who makes Zafir feel safe.”
“Police?”
“Maybe.”
Kelana looked toward the street.
“And boss?”
Rahman did not correct him this time.
“Do not ask who sees everything.”
“Why?”
“Because nobody does.”
Then Kelana left through the alley.
Rahman remained at the table for another minute.
Aisyah called only after he reached his car.
“Well?”
“He gave us a name.”
“Person?”

“No.”
“What?”
Rahman looked at the restaurant behind him.
“The Circle.”
Silence on the line.
Aisyah asked, “What does it mean?”
“I don’t know.”
That was the correct answer.
He would keep it that way until evidence gave the name shape.
Aisyah did not like the name.
That made Rahman trust it slightly more.
“The Circle sounds organised,” she said when he returned to SOC 4.
“Kelana said it isn’t.”
“Then the name will make us think it is.”
Daniel had already created a node.
THE CIRCLE.
Aisyah pointed at it.
“Delete that.”
Daniel stared.
“We finally get a name and you want me to delete it?”
“As a master node, yes.”
“It is literally what the source called it.”
“Source also said nobody sees everything.”
Rahman looked at Daniel.
“She’s right.”
Daniel sighed theatrically and changed the display.
CIRCLE — HUMAN SOURCE TERM / STRUCTURE UNKNOWN.
Aisyah nodded.
“Ugly.”
“Apparently ugly is our doctrine now.”
They debriefed Kelana formally from Rahman’s notes and memory.
No recording had been made.
That weakened the evidentiary value.
Rahman said so first.
Aisyah asked, “Why no recorder?”
“He would have left.”
“Did he say that?”

"No."

"So you decided."

"Yes."

She wrote it down.

Rahman felt the mild irritation he always felt when integrity turned judgment into a sentence.

Good.

The irritation was useful.

Kelana's information was classified as human intelligence requiring corroboration.

Not fact.

Not organisational chart.

Not proof that every link Daniel had found belonged to one thing.

Rafiq arrived midway through the debrief.

"The Circle?"

"Source term," Aisyah said immediately.

Rafiq looked at her.

"Fine. Source term. What is it?"

Rahman answered, "Relationships."

"That tells me nothing."

"Exactly."

Rafiq sat.

Rahman continued.

"Kelana says different criminals use recurring intermediaries. Business, law, transport, information."

"Police?"

"Yes."

"Leader?"

"No confirmed leader."

Rafiq frowned.

"Every organised network has someone higher."

"Higher in what?" Aisyah asked.

"Authority."

"What if authority changes by transaction?"

Rafiq looked at her.

"Then it is not organisation."

Daniel said, "Could be platform."

Everyone turned.

He shrugged.

"Not digital platform. Functional. People use it when they need something."

Rahman thought of Kelana's side door.

"That is closer."

Rafiq looked unconvinced.

"How do you charge a platform?"

"You don't," Rahman said.

"You charge people for acts."

That answer became important later.

For now, it simply prevented the new name from becoming a new shortcut.

Daniel searched historical intelligence systems for "Circle."

Nothing relevant before the late 2010s.

Good.

Kelana had said the name came later.

A handful of criminal-intelligence notes used phrases like circle of contacts, inner circle, business circle.

None clearly referred to the same concept.

Daniel marked the term as non-historical.

"No retroactive naming," Aisyah said.

"I know."

"You were about to put it on 1990s files."

"I was considering it."

"That is retroactive naming with better public relations."

Daniel removed it.

They tested Kelana's other claims.

Raziq as connector.

Supported by Amirul and business records.

Zafir as higher-level logistics figure.

Supported partly by RZ Meridian evidence and the seven-minute raid, though not by Kelana's claim alone.

Police protection without direct bribery.

Possible in theory; multiple modern access failures gave the idea relevance but no specific proof.

No king.

Unverifiable.

Nobody sees everything.

Also unverifiable.

By evening the source had given them one useful word and no solved case.

That was probably healthy.

Rahman called Kelana again two days later.

No answer.

Again that evening.

No answer.

The third day, a message arrived from an unknown number.

Too many questions make people remember you.

No signature.

Rahman believed it was Kelana.

Belief only.

He showed Aisyah.

“Threat?” she asked.

“Warning.”

“Difference?”

“One predicts harm. One advises caution.”

“Those can be the same sentence.”

“Yes.”

She photographed the message into the file and did not assign sender identity.

Daniel traced the number.

Prepaid.

One use.

No result.

Rafiq said, “Convenient.”

Rahman looked at him.

“For who?”

“Kelana. He gets to sound mysterious and unverifiable.”

“That is also how sources survive.”

“Or manipulate police.”

“Yes.”

Rahman appreciated the objection.

Kelana had helped him before.

That did not make Kelana honest.

It made him historically useful.

The distinction had to remain.

At home that night, Mariam found Rahman standing on the balcony with his phone in his hand.

“You are waiting for someone.”

“No.”

“That means yes.”

He put the phone down.

“Old source.”

“Dangerous?”

“Possibly.”

“To you?”

“Possibly.”

“To him?”

Rahman looked at her.

“Yes.”

Mariam folded her arms.

“You say that word a lot now.”

“What word?”

“Possibly.”

He almost smiled.

“It is an accurate word.”

“It is an exhausting word.”

She went inside.

Rahman stayed.

Kelana had given him The Circle.

A name could focus an investigation.

It could also become a story investigators fell in love with.

Rahman had seen enough cases ruined by names that became conclusions.

The Circle would remain a question.

Until the evidence said otherwise.

CHAPTER TWENTY

THREE POLICEMEN

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Daniel put three policemen on the screen and immediately regretted the title.

THREE POLICEMEN.

Aisyah looked at it.

“That sounds like a children’s story.”

“It is temporary.”

“Good.”

Rahman entered.

“Who?”

Daniel brought up the first profile.

Sergeant Azmi Noor.

Forty-one.

Traffic enforcement background.

Transferred twice in seven years.

No ORION access.

No direct link to Zafir.

No direct link to Faiz Idrus.

But six cash deposits over eighteen months totalling more than his salary could explain comfortably.

Rafiq said, “That one is dirty.”

Aisyah replied, “That one has unexplained cash.”

Daniel opened supporting records.

Azmi’s wife ran a small catering business.

Some deposits could be family income.

Two matched catering jobs.

Four did not.

A phone extraction from an unrelated gambling investigation showed Azmi communicating with a bookmaker.

Messages included roadblock locations.

Not ORION.

Not Circle proof.

Genuine misconduct likely.

Daniel moved to the second.

Inspector Firdaus Rahim.

Thirty-eight.

CID.

No unexplained deposits.

No suspicious messages.

But his brother's construction company had received two profitable subcontracts from a developer whose director appeared on Daniel's wider network graph.

Rafiq frowned.

"That is nothing."

"Maybe."

"The brother has a real company."

"Yes."

"Does real work."

"Yes."

"Won tenders."

"Private subcontracts, not public tender."

"That is normal."

"Yes."

Aisyah asked, "Why is he here?"

Daniel changed screens.

Firdaus had been transferred into a unit handling cargo theft three months after the first subcontract.

Transfer recommendation signed by an assistant commissioner who had attended a corporate event hosted by the developer.

Again, not proof.

Rahman looked at Daniel.

"Any evidence Firdaus asked for the transfer?"

"No."

"Any evidence developer asked?"

"No."

"Any evidence brother's contract depended on police action?"

"No."

"Then remove him from suspect list."

Daniel frowned.

"He is not on suspect list."

"Your slide makes him look like he is."

Daniel looked at the title.

Fair.

He relabelled:

OFFICERS REQUIRING CONTEXT REVIEW.

Aisyah nodded.

"Better."

Then the third profile.

Inspector Farhan Zakaria.

Thirty-six.

CID.

Good performance.

Ambitious.

Likeable enough that people used his first name in briefings.

No cash deposits.

No visible unexplained wealth.

Brother owned Zakaria Auto Works.

The workshop serviced police officers' private vehicles and small commercial fleets.

Nothing unusual.

Then Daniel showed access history.

Farhan had broader cross-unit access than his current posting obviously required.

Temporary assignments.

Secondments.

Coordination privileges retained longer than expected after one project ended.

Aisyah leaned closer.

"Why retained?"

"Administrative failure, according to Digital Security."

"Common?"

"Very."

Rahman said, "Again, vulnerability is not compromise."

Daniel nodded.

"Then transfers."

Farhan's career showed a pattern.

Not suspicious by itself.

A difficult district assignment shortened.

A desirable investigations posting followed.

A training course nominated after another officer withdrew.

A temporary coordination role became permanent access.

Rafiq said, "He is competent."

"Yes," Daniel said.

"People who are competent get opportunities."

"Yes."

"So what is the pattern?"

Daniel looked at Rahman.

"Access accumulating around career help."

Aisyah said, "That is interpretation."

"Yes."

"Evidence?"

"Not enough."

Rahman looked at Farhan's photograph.

He knew him.

Not well.

Professional overlap.

The kind of officer who volunteered for difficult work and remembered senior people's preferences without appearing sycophantic.

Nothing wrong with that.

"Why these three?" Rahman asked.

Daniel displayed the comparison.

AZMI — DIRECT PERSONAL BENEFIT / INFORMATION DISCLOSURE INDICATORS.

FIRDAUS — INDIRECT FAMILY COMMERCIAL BENEFIT / NO MISCONDUCT EVIDENCE.

FARHAN — UNUSUAL ACCESS + CAREER ADVANTAGE / NO PROVEN BENEFIT.

"Three different shapes," Daniel said.

Aisyah looked at the screen.

“Or one corrupt officer, one ordinary officer with a successful brother, and one ambitious officer with sloppy permissions.”

“Yes.”

“That needs to stay visible.”

“Yes.”

Rahman thought of Kelana.

Everyone expensive in different currency.

Money.

Career.

Family.

Access.

Protection.

The mistake would be assuming every benefit meant purchase.

But ignoring benefits because they were not envelopes would be another mistake.

“Change the question,” Rahman said.

Daniel looked at him.

“From what?”

“Corruption.”

“To?”

“Dependency.”

Aisyah’s eyes sharpened.

Rafiq frowned.

“Explain.”

Rahman went to the board.

“Azmi may depend on money.”

“Maybe,” Aisyah said.

“Firdaus may depend on nothing. His family may simply have a good contract.”

“Yes.”

“Farhan may depend on career help. Or may simply have been good at his job.”

“Yes.”

“So we do not ask only who took cash.”

Daniel said, “We ask who owes.”

“Not enough.”

Rahman wrote:
WHAT CAN THIS PERSON LOSE?
Aisyah stared at the line.
Harun again.
Fear as leverage.
Rahman added:
WHO CAN AFFECT IT?
Then:
HAS ANY REQUEST FOLLOWED A BENEFIT?
That was more useful.
Dependency required sequence.
Benefit.
Relationship.
Request.
Behaviour.
Not just suspicious prosperity.
They started with Azmi.
IID interviewed him the next morning.
He denied selling information.
Admitted telling a bookmaker where traffic roadblocks would be.
“Friend,” he said.
“Why?” Aisyah asked.
“He asked.”
“Money?”
“No.”
She showed him deposits.
Azmi looked down.
“Loans.”
“From him?”
“Sometimes.”
“Repaid?”
Silence.
The pattern looked familiar.
Small favour.
Information.
Cash.
Obligation.

Amirul again, but rougher.

Azmi's misconduct became clear enough for formal action.

Still no ORION access.

Still not their leak.

Firdaus was different.

His brother's contracts were real.

Pricing competitive.

Work completed.

No evidence Firdaus had intervened.

The developer knew the brother through a golf club and had hired several contractors from the same network.

Aisyah closed the review.

Daniel looked at her.

"That fast?"

"We opened because of pattern."

"Yes."

"The context explains it."

"Mostly."

"Do you have contrary evidence?"

"No."

"Then stop."

Daniel did.

That mattered.

An investigation that could not clear people was not an integrity process.

It was a machine for producing suspects.

Farhan remained.

No one interviewed him yet.

The evidence was not mature enough.

Instead they mapped his access.

Farhan had worked cargo theft.

Organised crime coordination.

Two regional operations.

A temporary liaison role.

He knew people across units.

That could be a strength.

It could also make him useful to anyone who wanted information to travel without obvious hacking.

Aisyah asked, “Does he know Amirul?”

Personnel overlap showed six months in the same coordination building.

Thousands of officers shared buildings.

Not enough.

“Raziq?”

No direct phone contact.

No company link.

No payment.

Daniel searched workshop records.

Zakaria Auto Works had serviced vehicles for dozens of clients.

Nothing suspicious in the first pass.

Rafiq looked relieved.

Rahman noticed.

“You like Farhan.”

Rafiq shrugged.

“He is good.”

“That was not my question.”

“Yes. I like him.”

“Then stay out of the financial review.”

Rafiq’s expression hardened.

“You think I will protect him?”

“I think you are human.”

The phrase belonged to Harun.

Rafiq stared for a moment.

Then nodded.

“Fine.”

Good.

No drama.

Just controls around ordinary loyalty.

That evening, the team reviewed the three cases again.

Azmi: likely corrupt.

Firdaus: currently no evidence of misconduct.

Farhan: unresolved.

Daniel looked at the board.

"One dirty. One clean. One maybe."

Aisyah said, "Do not call Firdaus clean."

Daniel looked at her.

"You just closed him."

"We found no evidence supporting our concern."

"That is clean."

"No. It is what the evidence says today."

Daniel sighed.

Rahman understood her point.

Integrity was not sainthood certification.

It was investigation of conduct.

He looked again at Farhan.

The problem was becoming clearer.

The Circle—if Kelana's name meant anything useful—did not need hundreds of officers taking envelopes.

It might need different people for different moments.

One willing to sell information.

One willing to check a roster as a favour.

One who owed someone.

One whose family needed help.

One who wanted a promotion.

Maybe no one saw the full structure.

Maybe nobody needed to.

Aisyah stood beside the board.

"Dependency is not guilt."

"No," Rahman said.

"But it is where we look."

"Yes."

Daniel added the word beneath the three profiles:

DEPENDENCY.

Then smaller:

MONEY / FAMILY / CAREER / ACCESS / OBLIGATION.

Rahman watched the categories appear.

They were not proof.

They were a better question.

And sometimes the right question was the first thing corruption had spent years making difficult to ask.

The deeper review made the three officers less similar, not more.

That was useful.

Azmi's case strengthened quickly.

A bookmaker admitted paying him.

Not for ORION.

Not for organised crime strategy.

For roadblock locations, enforcement patterns and occasional vehicle-registration checks.

RM300 here.

RM700 there.

Sometimes no money at all.

Sometimes a meal.

Sometimes football tickets.

Azmi said he never considered himself bought.

Aisyah asked what word he preferred.

He had no answer.

His case moved toward charge and disciplinary action.

The Circle remained unnecessary to explain him.

A corrupt officer could be simply corrupt.

Rahman insisted that sentence enter the analytical notes.

Daniel thought it obvious.

Rahman did not.

Once investigators had a network theory, every guilty person became tempting proof of membership.

Firdaus moved the opposite direction.

The developer who hired his brother produced invoices, site photographs, work completion certificates and tax records.

The pricing sat within market range.

Other contractors confirmed the selection process was ordinary.

The golf-club relationship was real.

So was the work.

Aisyah closed the integrity lead.

Rafiq asked, "Completely?"

"On current evidence."

"What if something appears later?"

"Then we reopen."

"You don't keep him quietly flagged?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because suspicion that survives clearance becomes punishment without process."

Rahman watched Rafiq absorb that.

Police culture was full of invisible marks.

Officer talked too much.

Officer complained.

Officer had once been investigated.

Officer's name appeared in a file.

None official.

All capable of affecting careers.

Aisyah refused to add another.

Farhan was harder.

The access itself was legitimate enough.

His old permissions should have been removed sooner, but hundreds of officers carried similar stale access.

The career advantages could be merit.

His performance reports were strong.

Supervisors described him as reliable, quick and politically intelligent.

Daniel highlighted the last phrase.

Aisyah removed the highlight.

"That is not misconduct."

"It is interesting."

"To you."

"To everyone."

Rafiq said, "It means he knows how to work with senior people."

Daniel looked at him.

"Politically intelligent is what people write when they want to say ambitious politely."

Rahman said, "Ambition is not corruption either."

Daniel leaned back.

"I am running out of useful personality traits."

"Good."

They pulled Farhan's historical assignments.

One stood out.

A temporary posting to Special Operations Coordination.

Only four months.

It gave him access to multi-unit schedules, vehicle deployments and operational liaison contacts.

The posting ended.

Some permissions did not.

Aisyah asked who authorised the access retention.

Digital Security produced an old bulk-extension request signed by an administrative manager.

Forty-seven officers on the same form.

No special treatment.

Another suspicious fact collapsed into bureaucracy.

Daniel hated it.

Rahman did not.

Every collapsed suspicion made the remaining ones more honest.

Then Grace found something small.

Zakaria Auto Works had serviced a commercial fleet belonging to a company called Murni Event Solutions.

Daniel looked at the name.

“Amirul’s hospital payment came from Latif Murni Services.”

Aisyah said, “Different company.”

“Same Murni.”

“Murni means pure. Half the country uses it in company names.”

Daniel searched directors.

No overlap.

Addresses different.

Banks different.

No corporate relationship.

He removed the link.

Again.

Rafiq said, “You look sad.”

“I enjoy relationships.”

“That explains a lot about your personal life.”

Daniel stared at him.

Even Aisyah smiled.

The relief lasted less than a minute.

Then Daniel found a legitimate invoice from Murni Event Solutions to Zakaria Auto Works.

Fleet maintenance.

RM1,800.

Normal amount.

Normal work.

No reason to care.

He kept it only because the workshop might become relevant later.

Not a clue.

A data point.

Rahman approved.

At the next morning briefing, he returned to dependency.

"Do not turn this into a personality test."

Daniel looked offended.

"I use data."

"Data about people."

"Yes."

"Then hear me. Need is not guilt."

He wrote NEED on the board.

"Debt. family. ambition. fear. reputation. access."

Aisyah added, "Shame."

Rahman looked at her.

"Yes."

She thought of Amirul.

A young constable who continued because stopping would require admitting what he had already done.

Shame could become leverage without anyone threatening exposure.

Rafiq said, "So everyone is vulnerable."

"Yes."

"Then this framework is useless."

"No."

Rahman wrote a second word.

REQUEST.

"Vulnerability alone means nothing."

Then a third.

BEHAVIOUR.

"Someone has to connect need to action."

Daniel nodded slowly.

"Benefit, then request, then behaviour."

"Sometimes."

"Amirul."

"Yes."

"Azmi."

"Yes."

"Farhan?"

"We do not know."

"Firdaus?"

"No evidence."

That was the framework.

Not who had needs.

Everyone did.

Who had a relationship capable of converting need into conduct.

That afternoon, Farhan himself entered SOC 4 for a routine coordination briefing.

Nobody had told him he was under contextual review.

He joked with Rafiq.

Asked Daniel whether the task force had finally learned to use printers without breaking them.

Nodded respectfully to Aisyah.

Spoke to Rahman about staffing for an unrelated operation.

Completely ordinary.

Rahman watched him and disliked himself for watching.

Once suspicion entered, normal behaviour became performance.

A smile became charm.

A question became fishing.

Competence became access.

Harun had warned him about this too.

Evidence first.

Story later.

Farhan left after twelve minutes.

Daniel said, "He asked about staffing."

Rafiq looked at him.

"It was a staffing meeting."

"I know."

"Then stop."

Daniel did.

Aisyah wrote something in her notebook.

Rahman asked, “What?”

“Nothing about Farhan.”

“About us?”

“Yes.”

“What?”

She looked at him.

“Suspicion changes observers before it changes subjects.”

Rahman nodded.

Keep that too.

By the end of the week, the three-policeman exercise had produced one misconduct case, one cleared concern and one unresolved access question.

That was less satisfying than a conspiracy.

It was also more useful.

The institution was not full of identical corrupt officers.

It contained different people with different needs, different boundaries and different opportunities.

If The Circle existed as Kelana described, it did not have to corrupt everyone.

It only had to understand the difference.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

THE PROMOTION

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

The promotion notice appeared at 08:12.

Daniel found it before anyone else because he had begun reading the internal administrative bulletin for reasons he refused to explain.

“Congratulations,” he said.

Farhan looked up from the operations desk.

“For what?”

Daniel turned the screen.

ACTING DSP — SPECIAL OPERATIONS COORDINATION.

FARHAN ZAKARIA.

Effective Monday.

The room went quiet for half a second.

Then Rafiq grinned.

“You kept that quiet.”

Farhan stared at the notice.

“So did they.”

“You didn’t know?”

“I knew I was shortlisted.”

He read it again.

“Not that it was final.”

Rafiq stood and slapped him once on the shoulder.

“Belanja makan.”

Farhan smiled.

“After payday.”

The moment should have been ordinary.

A competent inspector moving upward.

Thirty-six. Good service record. Strong operational evaluations. No disciplinary finding.

Exactly the kind of promotion MNPS wanted to be routine.

Aisyah looked at the screen longer than everyone else.

Rahman noticed.

Farhan noticed too.

“You look disappointed.”

“I’m reading.”

“It’s six lines.”

“I read carefully.”

Daniel looked between them.

“This is why offices need cake. It gives people something else to do with their faces.”

Farhan laughed.

Aisyah did not.

Rahman called her into the small interview room twenty minutes later.

She closed the door.

“You think the promotion is protection.”

“I think the timing is interesting.”

“Because?”

“He appears in our dependency review.”

“So do two other officers.”

“He has operational access.”

“So do many officers.”

“He will have more.”

“Yes.”

Aisyah folded her arms.

“You don’t think it matters?”

“I think it matters.”

“You sound calm.”

“I am trying to be accurate.”

She looked at him.

Rahman continued.

“Suspicion does not cancel a promotion.”

“No.”

"Neither does an ORION review nobody outside this room is supposed to know about."

"No."

"But if someone inside the system is protecting him—"

"Then we prove it."

Aisyah's jaw tightened.

"What happens when the system prevents proof from being built?"

Rahman held her gaze.

"That is the question."

She did not like the answer.

Good.

Neither did he.

They pulled the promotion file.

Not secretly.

Through IID and command authority.

The process had begun six months before ORION.

The promotion file contained the kind of detail conspiracy theories disliked.

Scores.

Dates.

Signatures.

Committee attendance.

Training credits.

Leave history.

Two written references.

One panel member had marked Farhan down for being "occasionally overconfident in cross-unit coordination." Another had marked him up for exactly the same trait under "initiative."

Aisyah read both.

"Human resources remains the greatest unsolved crime."

Daniel looked over.

"You found manipulation?"

"No. Subjectivity."

"That is legal."

"Usually."

Rahman reviewed the nomination dates.

Farhan's regional commander had put his name forward six months earlier, before ORION existed.

The shortlist was finalised before the seven-minute raid.

The acting vacancy opened because an officer had gone for medical treatment.

Nothing in the sequence appeared engineered around ORION.

That mattered.

Rahman wrote at the top of the working note:

PROMOTION PROCESS PRE-DATES ORION.

Then:

NO EVIDENCE CURRENTLY SUPPORTS PROMOTION AS REWARD OR PROTECTION.

Aisyah looked at the second line.

"You are clearing the process."

"Not Farhan."

"Good."

"Would you prefer I wrote suspicious because the timing feels bad?"

"No."

"Then?"

"I am adjusting."

Rahman almost smiled.

"So am I."

The review showed something else.

Farhan had been considered promotable for years.

He was exactly the kind of officer a network might value after compromise because the institution would move him upward without anyone needing to interfere.

Competence itself could become access.

That was less satisfying than a corrupt promotion board.

More plausible too.

That weakened the obvious theory immediately.

Farhan had been nominated by his regional commander.

Two other candidates were considered.

Performance scores were strong.

Training complete.

No sudden change in ranking.

No unexplained intervention from Farid.

No last-minute instruction from senior command.

No missing interview note.

The board minutes were dull.

Aisyah read them twice.

Daniel read the metadata.

"Created when it says. Modified by secretariat. No late edits."

Rafiq looked relieved.

"So we can stop treating a promotion like organised crime."

Aisyah said, "We can stop treating the timing as proof."

"That sounds almost healthy."

"It is not clearance."

Rafiq sighed.

Rahman looked at the file.

The promotion was real.

Merited, probably.

And still potentially useful to whoever had learned how to exploit ordinary institutional movement.

That was the harder possibility.

Corruption did not always need to manufacture careers.

Sometimes it waited for careers to happen.

Farhan's new post would place him near cross-unit schedules, special-operation coordination and vehicle movements.

Not full ORION access.

Not command authority.

But more information than before.

Rahman asked, "Can the posting be altered?"

Rafiq frowned.

"On what grounds?"

"Operational conflict."

"With no finding?"

"No."

Aisyah said, "Then no."

Rafiq looked at her.

"You're defending him now?"

"I'm defending procedure."

Farhan spent the morning pretending nothing had changed.

At noon he bought drinks for the room.

Even Aisyah accepted one.

"Peace offering?" she asked.

"Promotion diplomacy."

"Dangerous precedent."

"I'll note it in the integrity file."

She looked at him.

He smiled.

Likeable.

That mattered.

People trusted likeable officers for reasons that had nothing to do with evidence.

Aisyah knew that.

So did Rahman.

Farhan sat across from him later that afternoon.

"You want to ask me something."

Rahman looked up.

"Do I?"

"You've looked at me three times today like I misplaced a firearm."

Rahman closed the file he was reading.

"Did anyone discuss ORION when you were shortlisted?"

"No."

"Did anyone offer help?"

"With the promotion?"

"Yes."

Farhan thought.

"My old commander called one board member."

"Normal?"

"I assumed."

"Anything else?"

"No."

"Family?"

Farhan's expression changed slightly.

"What about them?"

"Any business support, loans, contracts, favours tied to police contacts?"

He stared.

"This is the review."

"Yes."

Farhan leaned back.

"My brother has a workshop."

"I know."

"He services police officers' cars because police officers need mechanics."

"I know."

"You think that bought this?"

"I asked."

Farhan's smile disappeared.

"No."

Rahman nodded.

"Good."

"That's it?"

"For now."

Farhan stood, then stopped.

"If you thought I was dirty, would you tell me?"

"No."

Farhan looked at him.

"Appreciate the honesty."

"You asked."

He left.

Rahman watched the door.

Promotion had changed nothing and everything.

Farhan was still the same man.

Only the institution had moved him closer to information.

At 17:40, Aisyah received a call from SAC Razak.

She stepped into the corridor.

Razak said, "I saw the promotion."

"We pulled the process."

"And?"

"Routine. Started before ORION. Merit defensible."

"Any intervention?"

"None found."

"Then do not invent one."

"I'm not."

A pause.

Razak continued.

"But test the procedure."

"How?"

"Not whether the board was corrupt. Whether the new role creates access relevant to our inquiry."

Aisyah looked through the glass.

Farhan was helping Rafiq compare transport schedules.

"Meaning?"

"Separate the question of how he got promoted from what the promotion now lets him see."

Aisyah understood.

"Deeper review?"

"Yes."

"Formal?"

"Quiet."

"Farid informed?"

"No."

That caught her.

"Why?"

"Because this is an integrity inquiry into access. Need-to-know."

Aisyah said nothing.

Razak added, "Do not confuse caution with accusation."

"Understood."

After the call, she returned to the room.

Rahman asked nothing.

That irritated her for reasons she did not examine.

Daniel had built a permissions comparison.

Farhan's old role versus new.

The increase was real but limited.

Regional movement schedules.

Special-operation coordination notices.

Vehicle allocation.

Meeting dates for certain cross-directorate actions.

No automatic access to ORION evidence.

No final target annex.

No integrity files.

Daniel said, “If he is our mole, promotion makes him slightly better at being one.”

Aisyah replied, “He is not established as our mole.”

“Fine. If he is hypothetically our mole.”

Rahman looked at the chart.

“Wrong question.”

Daniel waited.

“What does the role allow any compromised person to do?”

That changed the analysis.

They removed Farhan’s name.

Looked only at function.

An officer in Special Operations Coordination could know when units moved.

Could infer operational tempo.

Could identify unusual deployments even without target details.

Could know which vehicles were reassigned.

Could notice when certain commanders met.

Information without full access.

Enough, sometimes, to warn someone.

Aisyah looked at Rahman.

“Strategic position.”

“Yes.”

“You don’t need the whole file.”

“No.”

“You need the right fragment.”

Rahman nodded.

The insight mattered more than the promotion.

Farhan’s career might be entirely legitimate.

The position could still be useful to a criminal relationship.

That was how institutions became vulnerable without being captured.

On Monday, Farhan’s new permissions activated.

Daniel monitored the change with his consent.

Not because Farhan was uniquely suspicious.

Because ORION now reviewed access changes for every member touching its information.

At 09:02, Farhan gained regional operations-dashboard visibility.

At 09:04, special-vehicle scheduling.

At 09:07, inter-unit meeting calendars.

No ORION evidence repository.

No witness files.

No target package.

Daniel projected the before-and-after view.

“There. That is the danger.”

Rafiq said, “He can see meetings.”

“He can see patterns.”

“Same for dozens of officers.”

“Exactly.”

Aisyah looked at the screen.

A compromised person did not need the target name if he could see that six unmarked vehicles had been reassigned, a narcotics tactical unit had cancelled leave and two commanders were meeting after midnight.

Information could be inferred.

The institution leaked meaning even when it protected facts.

Rahman said, “Build that into the ORION threat model.”

Daniel typed.

INFERENCE FROM ADMINISTRATIVE METADATA.

He looked at Rahman.

“Very exciting heading.”

“Make it accurate.”

“It is painfully accurate.”

Farhan stood behind them reading his own permissions.

“So my promotion creates a vulnerability.”

“Your position creates a vulnerability,” Aisyah said.

“Comforting distinction.”

“It should be.”

He looked at Rahman.

“You doing this for every posting?”

“From now on.”

Farhan nodded.

“Then I can live with it.”

Rahman watched him walk away.

A guilty man could say that.

An innocent man could too.

The statement proved nothing.

The willingness to submit to scrutiny still mattered.

At the end of the day, Farhan packed his desk.

He would not leave ORION entirely.

His new acting rank came with additional responsibilities, but Farid had approved continued liaison until replacement arrangements were made.

Farhan held up an old mug.

“Do promotions include better cups?”

Daniel said, “Only after corruption.”

Aisyah looked at him.

“What?”

“Too soon?”

“Yes.”

Farhan laughed anyway.

Then he saw Rahman watching.

“Still investigating my promotion?”

“Not your promotion.”

“What, then?”

Rahman considered the answer.

“The job.”

Farhan’s expression changed.

He nodded slowly.

“That sounds worse.”

“It might be.”

Farhan left with the mug in one hand and a cardboard box in the other.

Nothing about the scene looked sinister.

That mattered.

The system had not rewarded a proven criminal.

It had promoted a competent officer through a process that appeared ordinary and defensible.

If Farhan was compromised, the promotion was not proof of protection.

It was something more dangerous.

An ordinary institutional decision could place the wrong person at the right point of access without any corrupt hand touching the process at all.

Procedure had worked.
ORION still had to ask what happened next.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

THE LEAK

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

The leaked document was found beneath a betting ledger.

That was the first insult.

The second was that it was genuine.

The gambling office sat above a tyre shop in Kota Aruna's eastern commercial belt. CID had entered under a warrant unrelated to ORION, looking for illegal betting records and cash movement.

They found six computers, two counting machines, RM83,000 in cash, customer lists and one black document wallet inside a locked steel drawer.

The wallet contained three pages.

ORION.

Restricted.

A vulnerability review prepared after the seven-minute failure.

Rafiq brought the pages into SOC 4 inside an evidence sleeve.

Nobody touched them.

Daniel leaned close.

"That is ours."

Aisyah looked at him.

"You know from three metres?"

"I made the table."

Rahman stood at the end of the room.

"Chain."

Rafiq read from the custody sheet.

"Recovered 11:42. Drawer opened under video. Pages photographed in place. Bagged 11:48. Transported direct."

"Who knew it was ORION?"

“Scene officer recognised classification marking. Called me.”
“Copies?”
“None authorised.”
Daniel said, “Phone photos?”
“Devices of scene team preserved.”
Aisyah nodded.
Good.
No accusation yet.
Rahman looked through the sleeve.
The document listed ORION’s internal vulnerabilities.
Shared planning rooms.
Privilege inheritance.
Weak printer controls.
Regional export dependence.
Human escort protocols.
Nothing operationally current.
No target names.
No raid dates.
Still damaging.
It told criminals where ORION itself was soft.
“How old?” Rahman asked.
Daniel checked.
“Twelve days.”
Aisyah said, “Who had it?”
“Full digital access: seven. Printed distribution narrower.”
Daniel was already at the terminal.
The review had been written collaboratively.
Daniel produced the technical sections.
Aisyah added evidence-integrity concerns.
Rahman added command controls.
Farid had received the final copy.
Rafiq had read it digitally but had not printed.
Daniel pulled printer logs.
Three confirmed prints.
“Mine,” he said.
Aisyah looked at him.
“You printed?”

"One working copy for annotation. Returned to shred."

"Witness?"

Daniel paused.

"No."

Aisyah's expression said enough.

"Noted."

Second print.

Aisyah.

She did not hesitate.

"Briefing copy for Razak. Logged into IID pouch. Returned next morning."

"Receipt?"

"Yes."

Third.

Farid's office printer.

Rahman looked at the line.

Rafiq exhaled.

"Farid."

Aisyah said, "A printer is not a person."

Daniel kept scrolling.

Then stopped.

"There may be a fourth."

"May?"

"Spool event without completed device acknowledgement."

"In English," Rafiq said.

"A job entered the print queue. Printer did not return final confirmation."

"Paper?"

"Unknown."

"User?"

Daniel enlarged the line.

Service account.

Not a named user.

The room went quiet.

"What does that mean?" Rahman asked.

"Could be failed print. Could be cancelled. Could be maintenance replay. Could be output."

"Which printer?"

"Secure planning-room device."

The same planning area implicated in the 20:51 access event.

Aisyah said, "Can we recover printer memory?"

"Maybe partial."

"Do it."

Rafiq stared at the pages.

"Someone printed and carried this into a gambling office."

"Maybe," Aisyah said.

He turned.

"What else?"

"Digital photograph of a printed page."

Daniel nodded.

"Possible."

"Scanned copy reprinted elsewhere."

"Possible."

"Original removed from legitimate custody."

"Possible."

Rafiq rubbed his face.

"I miss crimes where people steal televisions."

Rahman said nothing.

He looked at the document.

A genuine ORION page in criminal possession.

No theory could make that harmless.

By afternoon, the gambling-office computers produced no source file.

No PDF.

No scan.

No obvious email attachment.

One phone contained a photograph of the first page.

Taken two days earlier.

Metadata stripped by messaging application.

The image had been forwarded into a group chat from a deleted account.

No original sender recovered.

A second device contained text copied from the vulnerability review.

Not the image.

Someone had extracted the useful parts.

Rahman read the messages.

Shared room weak.

Printer issue.

Escort access.

They were not reading ORION for curiosity.

They were using it.

Aisyah said, “Criminal possession established.”

“Yes.”

“Leak mechanism not established.”

“Yes.”

“Leaker not established.”

“Yes.”

Rafiq looked at her.

“Can we at least agree somebody leaked?”

She considered.

“Yes. Information moved outside lawful custody.”

Daniel said, “Historic moment.”

Aisyah ignored him.

The document itself went to forensic examination.

Paper stock.

Printer markers.

Toner.

Staple pattern.

The physical pages were consistent with MNPS secure-office supply.

The physical-document examination produced its first useful negative finding that afternoon.

No handwritten notes.

No fingerprints suitable for attribution beyond recovery staff.

No staple holes.

No fold pattern matching the pouches used by IID.

The pages had been carried flat at some point, then bent once inside the gambling-office wallet.

Daniel’s copy had been annotated before destruction.

Aisyah’s had been stapled into an IID briefing packet.

Farid said his had been loose.

That made his copy superficially more similar to the recovered pages.

Superficially.

Aisyah refused to let the word disappear.

"Same condition is not same source."

Rafiq said, "We understand."

"No. We understand when the condition points at someone we like."

Farid looked at her.

"Continue."

She did.

Printer microdots narrowed device family but not one machine.

Paper batch marks were common across headquarters purchasing.

The recovered pages might have originated in Farid's office.

They might also have originated from another secure device using the same stock and printer series.

Rahman felt the theory form anyway.

Senior office.

Loose pages.

Missing destruction record.

Farid.

He wrote nothing.

Not yet.

The photograph on the gambling-office phone complicated it further.

The page in the photograph had a slight shadow along the top edge.

Possibly from a desk tray.

Possibly from another sheet.

Possibly meaningless.

Daniel enlarged it until toner became landscape.

"Enhancement won't create provenance."

Aisyah said, "Please put that on a wall."

"I would, but nobody reads walls unless Rahman writes on them."

Rahman ignored both of them.

The truth was that the document could have left ORION through one person, several people, a careless office routine or a deliberately exploited print-control weakness.

Every mechanism changed who they should suspect.

None yet won.

Not conclusive.

Printer micro-pattern analysis narrowed likely devices.

Farid's office printer.

Aisyah's IID printer.
Daniel's secure technical printer.
Or one of two same-model secure printers elsewhere.
Not enough.
Daniel looked almost offended by the hardware.
"It should be more distinctive."
Aisyah said, "Reality has disappointed you again."
Rahman asked, "Where is your printed copy?"
Daniel's face changed.
"Shredded."
"Proof?"
"Shred bin is sealed and collected under contract."
"When?"
"Last week."
"Gone?"
"Likely pulped."
Aisyah said nothing.
Daniel looked at her.
"Say it."
"Say what?"
"That I should have logged destruction."
"You should have logged destruction."
"Thank you."
Her own copy had stronger custody.
Printed.
Sealed pouch to Razak.
Returned.
Shredded under IID two-person procedure.
Farid's copy had been delivered to his office.
Administrative log showed receipt.
No return or destruction record.
Rahman called him.
Farid came down himself.
He read the evidence summary standing.
"Your copy?" Rahman asked.
"Read in office."
"Then?"

"Left in restricted tray for destruction."

"Who collected?"

"My executive assistant normally."

"Normally?"

"I do not remember that day."

"Assistant?"

"On leave this week."

"Can contact?"

"Yes."

No defensiveness.

No outrage.

That made nothing easier.

Aisyah asked, "Who enters your office?"

Farid looked at her.

"Too many people for this question to help."

"It helps if we list them."

"Then list them."

He sat.

For forty minutes he gave names.

Executive assistant.

Command staff.

Cleaning access under supervision.

Two senior visitors.

A legal adviser.

Rahman.

Once.

Aisyah.

Once.

The office was secure.

Not sealed from human life.

At the end, Farid looked at the document again.

"This is worse than the seven minutes."

Rafiq said, "Why?"

"Because the raid leak could have been one target detecting one operation."

He tapped the pages.

"This shows somebody is interested in how ORION fails."

Nobody argued.

Farid looked at Rahman.

“Restrict access.”

“Already.”

“Collect devices.”

Aisyah said, “Under authority.”

“Get it.”

“Already.”

Farid almost smiled.

Then didn’t.

By evening, ORION members surrendered official devices for imaging in rotation.

Personal devices required legal basis or consent depending on scope.

Daniel consented loudly.

Rafiq complained and consented.

Aisyah consented without comment.

Rahman surrendered his.

Farid did too.

Farhan, now Acting DSP, was informed because his liaison work had included some vulnerability discussions.

He stared at the leaked pages.

“I never saw the final review.”

“Draft content?” Aisyah asked.

“Rafiq complained about printer controls once.”

“That is not the same.”

“No.”

“Any photograph?”

“No.”

“Any request from anyone asking what ORION changed after the failed raid?”

Farhan thought.

“People ask.”

“Who?”

“Operations people. Regional people. Everyone wants to know why we suddenly changed escort rules.”

“Names.”

He gave them.

Ordinary officers asking ordinary questions.

Again, the network did not need magic.

Only curiosity in the right direction.

At home after midnight, Mariam found Rahman sitting in the dark living room.

She switched on one lamp.

“You are doing the thing again.”

“What thing?”

“Coming home but not arriving.”

Rahman looked at her.

“Long day.”

“Bad?”

“Yes.”

She sat opposite him.

“Can you tell me?”

His first instinct was no.

Operational.

Restricted.

Protect her.

Then he remembered how easily that instinct became a wall.

“Something from our investigation was found outside the police.”

Mariam listened.

“Sensitive?”

“Yes.”

“People in danger?”

“Not directly from this document.”

“Do you know who?”

“No.”

“Do you trust your team?”

Rahman looked down.

“I don’t know who to trust.”

The admission felt worse aloud.

Mariam was quiet.

Then: “Do they know that?”

“No.”

“Why not?”

“Because suspicion changes people.”

"So does being secretly suspected."

Rahman looked at her.

She held his gaze.

"I'm not telling you how to run your case."

"It sounds like it."

"I'm telling you what secrecy does to people who think they are standing beside you."

Aisyah came to mind.

Daniel.

Rafiq.

Farhan.

Farid.

All of them.

Mariam said, "You keep saying trust must be earned."

"Yes."

"Then remember it can also be damaged."

He nodded.

Not agreement.

Recognition.

That night, after Mariam went upstairs, Rahman reopened the custody summary on his secure device.

Aisyah's print first.

He read the pouch number.

The IID desk log.

Razak's signature.

Return time.

Two-person destruction.

Clean.

Then Daniel.

Print confirmed.

Annotation described.

Destruction not individually logged.

Weak.

Then Farid.

Office receipt.

No specific return.

Weak.

Rahman closed the file.

Reopened Aisyah's.

Why?

Because clean chains could be constructed.

Because IID officers knew how evidence systems worked.

Because Aisyah had independent authority he could not see.

Because she had challenged him from the first morning and he had begun to trust that challenge.

He realised he was turning trust into suspicion simply because the leak required somebody.

That was how investigators corrupted themselves.

He shut the device.

Mariam stood on the stairs.

"You're still at work."

"Yes."

"At least now I can see it."

Rahman looked at the dark screen.

He had suspected Aisyah for twelve minutes without one new fact.

He would remember that later.

The next morning, Daniel recovered a fragment from the secure planning-room print spool.

Filename matched the vulnerability review.

Timestamp matched the possible fourth print event.

Output status remained unknown.

User token originated from a service process triggered when a document was opened through a shared briefing package.

No named person.

"So anyone with briefing access could cause it?" Rahman asked.

"Under certain conditions."

"Without intentionally pressing print?"

"Yes."

"Could paper still emerge?"

"Yes."

"Could no paper emerge?"

"Yes."

Rafiq said, "Your system is useless."

Daniel looked personally insulted.

"My system has just prevented you from accusing the wrong person."

That ended the argument.

The three legitimate prints remained.

Daniel.

Aisyah.

Farid.

The possible fourth remained mechanism, not identity.

Rahman looked around SOC 4.

For the first time, every person in the room seemed to carry two versions.

Colleague.

Possibility.

He hated what that did to his thinking.

One of the three legitimate prints was hers. On the first day she had asked who investigated ORION. He had never asked who read what she sent to Razak.

He told himself it was method. It did not feel like method.

The Circle—if Kelana's name meant anything—had not merely obtained a document.

It had placed suspicion inside the task force.

Maybe deliberately.

Maybe as a by-product.

Either way, the effect was the same.

Rahman looked at Aisyah.

She looked back.

Neither spoke.

The evidence had escaped.

Now trust was leaking with it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

SIX NAMES

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Rahman wrote the names by hand.

The first mistake was writing them down.

Or the first honest thing.

He was no longer sure.

The paper came from an old training manual on intelligence handling that nobody used anymore. He removed the blank back page because he did not want the list inside ORION's digital systems.

Then he wrote six names.

RAHMAN AZIZ.

NUR AISYAH RAHIM.

DANIEL LIM.

FARHAN ZAKARIA.

RAFIQ HAMDAN.

FARID KAMAL.

He looked at them.

Six people.

Not the six privileged identities from the seven-minute access pool.

Different question.

These were the people who, through authority, proximity, technical access, liaison work or command, could plausibly know enough about ORION's vulnerabilities to matter.

Plausibly.

That word saved him from accusing them.

Or allowed him to pretend he was not.

At the bottom he wrote:

NO ONE CLEARED.

NO ONE ACCUSED.

He did not write reasons beside the names at first.

Reasons hardened too quickly.

Instead he created six questions.

WHAT ACCESS DID THIS PERSON ACTUALLY HAVE?

WHAT INFORMATION COULD THEY INFER WITHOUT ACCESS?

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS COMPROMISE?

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS INNOCENT EXPLANATION?

WHAT COULD THEY BE AFRAID TO LOSE?

WHAT WOULD PROVE MY THEORY WRONG?

The last question came from ORION's own rule.

No theory owns the evidence.

He started with himself.

Access: almost everything.

Inference: command gave him context others lacked.

Compromise evidence: historical procedural breaches, secret six-name list now in his hand.

Innocent explanation: command required access. No financial corruption evidence. No criminal contact tied to current leaks.

Afraid to lose?

Rahman stopped.

Reputation.

Family.

Team.

The idea that his career had meant something.

He wrote only:

REPUTATION / FAMILY / ORION.

Then Aisyah.

Access to integrity material.

One legitimate print.

Independent conversations with Razak.

Could protect evidence.

Could also conceal what she was doing from him.

Afraid to lose?

Career? Father's legacy? Professional certainty?

He crossed out the guesses.

He did not know.

Daniel.

Systems.

Logs.

Print controls.

The ability to make technical conclusions other people could not easily challenge.

No evidence he had manipulated data.

Farhan.

Operational metadata.

New access.

Family business.

Ambition.

No proof any of those amounted to compromise.

Rafiq.

Field schedules.

CID loyalties.

Operational impatience.

Farid.

Senior access.

Historical intelligence restrictions.

A legitimate printed copy that could not be fully accounted for.

Rahman stared at that line longest.

Then he wrote beside every name:

UNKNOWN ≠ SUSPICIOUS.

The page was becoming a warning to himself more than a suspect list.

Good.

It needed to.

He folded the page once.

Then stopped.

Hiding a list was an act with meaning.

Harun had hidden copies because official storage became unsafe.

Rahman was hiding suspicion because he no longer trusted the room.

Those were not the same thing.

They felt close enough to trouble him.

He opened the old manual.

Placed the page between chapters on source validation.

Closed it.

Put the manual in the bottom drawer.

Then locked the drawer.

At 07:30, Aisyah walked into his office without knocking.

“Razak wants expanded access preservation.”

Rahman looked at the locked drawer.

Then at her.

“Approved.”

She noticed.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

Her expression changed.

The word had become dangerous between them.

Rahman corrected himself.

“I was thinking.”

“About?”

“The leak.”

“That narrows nothing.”

He almost smiled.

She did not.

“Do you suspect me?” she asked.

Direct.

Typical.

Rahman looked at her.

“Yes.”

She held still.

“Good.”

That surprised him.

“Good?”

“If you didn’t, your integrity framework would be performance.”

“Do you suspect me?”

“Yes.”

The answer came faster.

He should have expected it.

“Why?”

“Access. authority. history of discretionary breaches. command position.”

No softness.

No personal apology.

Rahman felt irritation anyway.

That interested him.

He had told the team nobody was exempt.

Hearing the principle applied to him felt different.

Aisyah watched.

"You don't like it."

"No."

"Good."

He gave her a look.

She almost smiled.

Then turned serious.

"Suspicion cannot become secret punishment."

"I know."

"People lose access based on evidence, not your feelings."

"I know."

"Do you?"

Rahman's eyes moved toward the drawer again.

Aisyah followed the glance.

He hated that.

"What is in there?"

"Nothing relevant to your request."

Narrow answer.

Her eyes changed.

Rahman heard himself.

Too late.

Aisyah said, "All right."

She left.

The door closed.

Rahman sat still.

He had not lied.

That was not the same as being open.

By midmorning, Daniel had completed device comparisons from the leaked vulnerability review.

No direct transmission found from ORION devices.

No photograph of the pages on Daniel's phone.

No unauthorised copy on Aisyah's.

Farid's official device clean within available scope.

Rafiq's clean.

Rahman's clean.

Farhan's contained normal scheduling discussions and one message that bothered Aisyah.

Tomorrow bad for movement.

Too many units out.

The message was to a regional operations coordinator.

Perfectly legitimate context.

A convoy-support question.

Still, the wording demonstrated how little information a person needed to communicate operational tempo.

Farhan explained it.

The explanation matched the thread.

Aisyah logged it as contextual, not suspicious.

Rahman watched her do it.

Fair.

That mattered.

At lunch, Rafiq closed the door to SOC 4.

"We are paralysing ourselves."

Daniel looked up.

"How?"

"Every question becomes an integrity investigation."

Aisyah said, "Because an internal document is in criminal hands."

"Yes. We know."

"Then what do you suggest?"

"Operate."

"We are."

"No. We are auditing our own shadows."

Rahman listened.

Rafiq pointed toward the board.

"Zafir is still out. Gambling operations continue. Warehouse network still moving."

"Yes."

"We keep staring at ourselves, they win."

Aisyah said, "If we ignore the leak, they win differently."

Rafiq looked at Rahman.

"Pick."

Rahman shook his head.

"No."

Rafiq frowned.

"We do both."

"With what people?"

"Fewer targets. tighter teams. independent evidence cells."

Daniel said, "Compartmentalise."

The word returned.

Rahman felt it.

Aisyah did too.

Her expression changed.

"Carefully," she said.

Rahman nodded.

"Every compartment logged. Every restriction reviewable."

Rafiq said, "That slows us."

"Yes."

"Everything slows us."

"Good investigations are slow until they are not."

Rafiq exhaled.

No one was satisfied.

Good.

Rahman had stopped trusting plans everyone liked.

Later that day, Daniel asked the question Rahman had hoped nobody would ask.

"Do we have an internal suspect list?"

The room quieted.

Rahman said, "We have access review."

"That is not what I asked."

Aisyah looked at Rahman.

Rafiq did too.

Rahman felt the folded page in the locked drawer though it was three metres away.

"We do not have an accused-person list."

True.

Daniel frowned.

"Do we have names under enhanced scrutiny?"

“Yes.”

“Whose?”

“Relevant access holders.”

“That includes us.”

“Yes.”

“Are we allowed to know who else?”

“Not if disclosure compromises the review.”

Aisyah watched him carefully.

She knew the shape of narrow answers.

Rahman continued before she could speak.

“If integrity develops a formal subject, procedure applies. Until then, we work evidence, not gossip.”

Daniel accepted that.

Rafiq did not look satisfied.

Aisyah said nothing.

The conversation moved on.

Rahman knew he had stayed inside the line technically.

That did not make him comfortable.

He was beginning to understand how easily procedural truth could serve emotional secrecy.

That afternoon, Farid requested a private update.

Rahman went to his office.

The leaked document lay in a red evidence folder.

Farid looked older than he had a week earlier.

“Any name?”

“No.”

“Working theory?”

“Multiple.”

“Give me your best.”

Rahman did not.

Farid noticed.

“You don’t trust me.”

Rahman said nothing.

Farid leaned back.

“That is appropriate.”

Again.

Everyone was too comfortable being suspected.

Or pretending to be.

Farid continued.

"You think suspicion is a moral failure."

"No."

"You carry it like one."

Rahman looked at him.

"What would you do?"

"Reduce assumptions."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only answer before evidence."

Rahman almost laughed.

Harun.

Farid.

Aisyah.

All of them teaching him the same lesson from different directions.

"Did you lose your printed copy?" Rahman asked.

"I do not know."

"Could someone remove it from your office?"

"Yes."

"Who?"

"More people than I like."

"Did you ever discuss ORION vulnerabilities outside authorised channels?"

Farid thought.

"General concerns. Not document content."

"With who?"

"Senior command. regional commanders. oversight."

"Names."

Farid gave them.

No resistance.

Rahman left with more names and no greater certainty.

That evening, he opened the drawer.

Read the six.

Rahman.

Aisyah.

Daniel.

Farhan.

Rafiq.

Farid.

What did each name mean?

Rahman — command access, grey history, ability to shape reports.

Aisyah — integrity access, printed copy, independent authority.

Daniel — technical access, printed copy, ability to manipulate or explain logs.

Farhan — operational coordination, information fragments, dependency concern.

Rafiq — field operations, broad scheduling knowledge.

Farid — senior command, printed copy, historical relationship to restricted intelligence.

Every description sounded suspicious when written that way.

That was the danger.

A list created gravity.

Once a name appeared, evidence began orbiting it.

Rahman wrote beside the six names:

ACCESS IS NOT GUILT.

Then:

REPUTATION IS NOT CLEARANCE.

Aisyah's language.

He stared.

The list was useful only if it prevented exemptions.

It became corrupt if it made suspicion permanent.

He folded the page again.

Mariam called while he was still at the office.

"Home?"

"Later."

"How much later?"

"I don't know."

"Dinner is not an intelligence operation, Man."

He smiled despite himself.

"I'll come."

After the call, he placed the list back in the manual.

Not in his pocket.

Not at home.

He did not want his family carrying his suspicion.

Before he locked the drawer, he added one final line.

NO ONE CLEARED. NO ONE ACCUSED.

He underlined neither sentence.

That mattered to him.

The Circle, if it existed as Kelana described, depended on relationships becoming obligations.

Rahman could feel another kind of relationship forming inside ORION now.

Suspicion becoming distance.

Distance becoming secrecy.

Secrecy becoming control.

He had begun a private list because he feared information could not be trusted inside the team.

The list itself was now information the team did not know existed.

For the first time, Rahman understood that an investigator could reproduce the shape of the thing he was investigating without taking a single bribe.

All he had to do was decide that his own silence was necessary.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

THE MISSING PHONE

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Hafiz Rashid's phone had disappeared twice.

The first disappearance was physical.

The second had been administrative.

Daniel found the second one.

He had spent three days rebuilding Hafiz's evidence-transfer history from systems that had never been designed to agree with each other.

Regional evidence inventory.

CID transfer register.

Digital-forensics intake.

Property-room ledger.

One phone entered the chain.

A black Android handset.

Serial number recorded at the scene.

Logged again at regional custody.

Then headquarters inventory reduced it to:

1 MOBILE DEVICE.

No serial.

No model.

No evidence seal number.

After that, nothing.

Daniel projected the chain.

Aisyah stood beside him.

"Where does it disappear?"

"Between regional dispatch and headquarters intake."

"Courier?"

"Two officers."

"Interviewed?"

"Yes. Both remember sealed package, not contents."

"Vehicle?"

"Tracked."

"Stops?"

"Fuel. toll. headquarters."

"Tamper?"

"No recorded anomaly."

Rahman looked at the sequence.

"Could the headquarters entry refer to Hafiz's phone?"

"Yes."

"Could be another device?"

"Yes."

"So physical disappearance point uncertain."

"Yes."

Daniel changed the screen.

"But the phone exists somewhere else."

A cloud-backup record.

Not the device.

A synchronised account.

The original investigation had requested only handset extraction.

Nobody had preserved the associated backup account before the phone vanished.

Daniel found an old legal-authority reference in Hafiz's digital case notes and reopened the request through current process.

Partial backup remained.

Contacts.

Messages.

Thumbnails.

Application metadata.

Not everything.

Enough.

Rafiq leaned closer.

"You can recover his phone?"

"No."

"You just said—"

"I can recover pieces of what the phone knew."

"That sentence is disturbing."

Daniel looked pleased.

Aisyah said, "Chain."

He sighed.

"Provider preservation order. Legal production. Hash on receipt. Working copy isolated. Happy?"

"Moderately."

They began with contacts.

Most ordinary.

Family.

Colleagues.

Sources already known.

Then aliases.

K.

NORTH.

H.I.

Aisyah looked at Rahman.

His face had changed.

"H.I. means something."

"Maybe."

"What?"

Rahman stared at the contact label.

Two letters.

Could be initials.

Company code.

Location.

Nothing.

"Harun Ismail."

The name sat in the room.

Rafiq said, "Your old superintendent."

"Yes."

"Dead."

"Yes."

Daniel looked at the contact metadata.

"No full number. Backup retained alias and fragment only."

"Last activity?"

"Old."

“How old?”
Daniel checked.
“Contact created years ago. Modified more recently.”
“Call history?”
“Partial.”
No direct call to H.I. in the retained period.
Messages were more useful.
One note entry:
K — NOT DIRECT. USE OLD ROUTE.
Another:
NORTH STILL ACTIVE?
Then:
H.I. — ASK ABOUT OLD CASE.
Rahman moved closer.
“What old case?”
Daniel said, “No text.”
Aisyah looked at him.
“Search files.”
Daniel did.
One image thumbnail had a filename:
1794_REF.JPG
He froze.
Rafiq said, “Seventeen ninety-four?”
Daniel enlarged the metadata.
“Filename only. Original image absent.”
Rahman felt the room narrow.
17/94.
Harun’s old case.
The file restricted in 2000.
The network he had never fully understood.
Aisyah said, “Do not jump.”
Rahman looked at her.
“I know.”
“What else can 1794 mean?”
“Many things.”
“Good.”
Daniel searched the backup for the string.

One additional note.
17/94?
Question mark included.
No context.
No attachment.
No name.
That was enough to justify looking.
Not enough to connect Hafiz to Harun directly.
Aisyah said, “Who knew Hafiz had an old-case reference?”
“No one yet,” Daniel replied.
“Keep it narrow.”
Rafiq frowned.
“We have been narrow for months.”
“And documents still leak.”
That ended it.
Rahman requested archival existence confirmation for Case 17/94.
Not content.
Existence first.
Records returned a result.
CASE 17/94.
Historical organised-crime/intelligence matter.
Status: RESTRICTED.
Not closed.
Access required elevated authority.
Rahman stared at the screen.
“Still restricted?”
“Yes,” Daniel said.
“After thirty-two years.”
“Apparently.”
Aisyah said, “Restriction can persist automatically.”
Rahman knew.
Or deliberately.
Both possibilities remained.
He remembered Harun making duplicate folders.
NOT COMPLETE.
He remembered the meeting with young Farid.
Containment.

Mapping.

Silence.

Hafiz had been investigating modern transport routes when he died.

Why would he have a note about an old case?

Coincidence.

Research.

A name inherited through another source.

Someone told him.

Or Hafiz had found the same repetition Harun found decades earlier.

Rafiq said, “We open it.”

Aisyah replied, “Through process.”

“Yes.”

“Not because Rahman recognises the number.”

“That is why we know it matters.”

“It is why we know it may matter.”

Rahman said, “She’s right.”

Rafiq looked frustrated.

Again.

Everyone was tired of caution.

That was when caution mattered most.

Daniel moved to the alias K.

Partial message fragments suggested K warned Hafiz about transport schedules.

Could be source.

Could be criminal contact.

No identity yet.

NORTH appeared in notes around warehouse routes.

Not one person necessarily.

H.I. appeared only once in surviving text.

The strongest old-case link was the filename.

1794_REF.JPG.

A file that no longer existed.

A reference to evidence they could not see.

Aisyah said, “Could backup provider retain thumbnail cache somewhere else?”

Daniel shook his head.

“Maybe, but legal process will take time.”

“Do it.”
He did.
At 15:30, Rahman called Farid.
“Case 17/94.”
Silence.
Not long.
Long enough.
“What about it?” Farid asked.
“Hafiz had the number in his phone backup.”
Farid did not answer immediately.
“Exact?”
“17/94. Also filename 1794_REF.JPG.”
Another pause.
“Context?”
“Missing.”
“You want access.”
“Yes.”
Farid said, “Submit the request.”
“That is all?”
“What do you want me to say?”
“That you remember it.”
“I remember many cases.”
Rahman’s jaw tightened.
“Harun’s case.”
Farid’s voice stayed calm.
“Yes.”
There.
Not denial.
“Why is it still restricted?”
“I don’t know current archival basis.”
“You were involved.”
“In 2000.”
“Did you maintain the restriction?”
“Not personally for thirty years.”
A precise answer.
Rahman heard it.

Farid added, “Do not make old memory do the work of current evidence.”

The sentence annoyed him because it was right.

Rahman ended the call.

Aisyah had heard only his side.

“What did he say?”

“He remembers.”

“Anything else?”

“No.”

Narrow answer.

He noticed.

Aisyah did too.

Their eyes met.

Neither commented.

Rahman went to the basement records room before the controlled archive request was approved.

Not to open 17/94.

He knew better.

He wanted the index.

A records officer searched the historical catalogue.

“Case moved categories more than once.”

“Why?”

“Old system.”

“That is not a reason.”

“It is the only one I have.”

The officer printed a routing history.

1994 — organised crime.

1998 — intelligence support.

2001 — restricted intelligence.

Later references became administrative.

Some box numbers.

Some missing cross-links.

Nothing obviously improper.

Rahman looked at Harun’s name in one early routing field.

The sight of it struck harder than expected.

He had spent years remembering Harun as a man.

Now the system reduced him to initials, routing authority and a dead case number.

H.I.

The alias in Hafiz's phone might mean Harun.

Or Hafiz might have used the initials for someone else entirely.

Rahman folded nothing.

Copied nothing privately.

He requested the index through ORION and left.

Small discipline.

No one saw it.

That was probably why it mattered.

By evening, records approved a controlled archival review.

Not immediate.

The file had to be retrieved from regional storage and access reconciliation completed.

Daniel complained.

Aisyah said, "Old paper does not become digital because you are impatient."

"Everything becomes digital eventually."

"People say that about death too."

Daniel stared.

"That was unusually dark."

She returned to work.

Rahman sat alone later with Hafiz's reconstructed note list.

K.

NORTH.

H.I.

17/94?

Three decades apart.

Harun.

Hafiz.

Two investigators asking about information moving through transport relationships and police access.

The temptation was to draw a line.

Rahman did not.

Not yet.

He wrote only:

HAFIZ POSSESSED REFERENCE TO CASE 17/94 BEFORE DEATH.

SOURCE / MEANING UNKNOWN.

Then:

H.I. MAY REFER TO HARUN ISMAIL. NOT ESTABLISHED.

He saved the note.

That distinction mattered.

But when he closed the screen, he could still feel the old case opening somewhere in his memory.

Case 17/94 had not called to him.

Hafiz had carried its number into the present.

That was different.

And much worse.

* * *

Mariam made lunch on Sunday as if the week had been ordinary.

Nasi lemak. Fried chicken. A sambal she had been perfecting for fifteen years and still described as unfinished.

Adam was in Melbourne and had sent a voice note that nobody was allowed to talk over. Hana arrived late, with her laptop bag and her mother's way of entering a room as though she had already read the minutes.

She waited until the second helping.

"Papa, can I ask a question that is not a question?"

"Those are my least favourite."

"I am looking at a company. Government records and disposal. Latif Murni Services. They won the eastern region tender and nobody can tell me how."

Rahman kept his face where it was.

He had learned that in interview rooms. Never move the muscle that moves first.

The name sat on the table between the rice and the sambal. Latif Murni. It had paid a hospital bill for a constable named Amirul Hakim.

"Why are you telling me?"

"Because you taught me to tell a source what I know, so that she lies to me less."

At the end of the table, Mariam had gone very still.

"I cannot talk about it."

"I haven't asked you anything. I am telling you I am looking."

"Be careful."

"Papa."

"I mean it."

"You say be careful when you mean stop."

"Sometimes they are the same."

"Sometimes they are not." She smiled to take the edge off. It did not take the edge off.

Later, while Mariam stacked the plates, Rahman caught himself.

He had looked at his daughter across the table and, for the length of one breath, done to her what he had been doing to everyone for weeks. Who does she talk to? Who sees her notes? Who could know she had said that name?

He put the thought down like a hot dish.

He hated it.

He hated more that it had arrived without being invited.

Mariam said, without turning from the sink, "You went somewhere."

"Work."

"You always say work." She dried her hands. "It is getting to be a very large country."

* * *

On Monday, before the others arrived, he found Aisyah at her desk with her coat still on.

"I have to disclose something," he said.

She put down her pen.

"My daughter is a journalist. You know that. She is looking at Latif Murni Services. The eastern disposal tender. She told me yesterday, over lunch, so I would know."

"Did you ask her to stop?"

"No."

"Did you tell her anything?"

"I told her to be careful."

Aisyah considered that.

"Her telling you is not a leak," she said. "Your telling me is the correct response. I will log the time and the content of what you said, and I will log that you came to me first."

"Thank you."

“Do not thank me. It is procedure.” She opened her notebook. “Sir, may I say something that is not procedure?”

“Yes.”

“You will want to protect her. That is allowed. But decide what you are protecting. Her safety, or her not finding the thing.”

He had no answer ready.

She wrote the time and underlined it once.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

AISYAH INVESTIGATES RAHMAN

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

SAC Razak did not call Aisyah to his office.

He called her to a records-review room two floors below IID command.

No windows.

No assistants.

One secure terminal.

One paper file on the desk.

Rahman Aziz.

Aisyah looked at the cover.

“This is already in my ORION review.”

“Not like this.”

Razak sat opposite her.

“Effective today, you are conducting an enhanced integrity vulnerability review of DCP Rahman Aziz.”

She looked at him.

“Formal subject?”

“No criminal allegation.”

“Misconduct?”

“Not established.”

“Then basis?”

Razak folded his hands.

“ORION is compromised. Rahman commands ORION. His history includes discretionary breaches, restricted-source relationships and incomplete reporting.”

Aisyah said, “That describes half of senior intelligence service.”

“Then half should survive scrutiny.”

She looked at the file.

“Does Rahman know?”

“No.”

“Farid?”

Razak paused.

“I am not answering that.”

Aisyah’s expression hardened.

“That is an answer.”

“No. It is a boundary.”

“Who receives my findings?”

“Me.”

“Only you?”

“For now.”

She leaned back.

“Why me?”

“You already have access.”

“That is convenience.”

“You distrust reputation.”

“That is not qualification.”

“It helps.”

Aisyah looked at Rahman’s name again.

She had started trusting him.

That was precisely why the order felt dangerous.

Razak saw something in her face.

“Problem?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

She almost laughed.

Everyone had adopted that word.

Razak continued.

“If you were eager, I would assign someone else.”

“What am I looking for?”

“Whether Rahman can be leveraged. Whether he concealed conduct that could compromise command. Whether source relationships bypassed oversight. Whether old decisions create present pressure.”

“Farid?”

“Do not build a theory around Farid.”

"I asked if he is in scope."

"Everyone is in scope where evidence puts them."

Aisyah heard Rahman saying the same thing.

That made the order worse, not better.

Razak slid the file toward her.

"Do not confuse moral seriousness with moral safety."

She looked up.

"Meaning?"

"Good officers are dangerous when they believe being good makes their exceptions safer."

The sentence stayed with her.

She began with money.

Always eliminate the simple explanation.

Bank declarations.

Property.

Family interests.

Loans.

Known gifts.

No unexplained wealth.

No suspicious property expansion.

No family company suddenly benefiting from police-linked contracts.

Nothing connecting Rahman to criminal payments.

She wrote:

NO CURRENT FINANCIAL INDICATOR OF CORRUPTION.

Then career.

Promotions normal.

Some senior sponsorship, including Farid.

Nothing extraordinary for performance.

No evidence of purchased advancement.

Then operations.

That was where Rahman became complicated.

2006 — Musa Halim.

Unauthorised delayed detention.

Successful wider disruption.

Separate supervisory record.

General report incomplete in emphasis but not false.

Aisyah wrote:

BREACH DOCUMENTED. OUTCOME FAVOURABLE. REPUTATIONAL MEMORY EMPHASISES SUCCESS.

Then source history.

Muhammad Khairul.

Kelana.

The file changed names over time.

1995 — first criminal contact.

1999 — documented source activity.

Later periodic contact.

Some properly registered.

Some irregularly recorded because Kelana moved between informant, criminal intermediary and occasional intelligence source.

One note troubled her.

CONTACT MAINTAINED AT CASE OFFICER DISCRETION. NO ENFORCEMENT ACTION ON MINOR OFFENCE DUE ANTICIPATED INTELLIGENCE VALUE.

Rahman's initials.

Aisyah read supporting records.

The minor offence involved possession of untaxed cigarettes.

No arrest.

No formal source-authorisation entry that day.

Later intelligence from Kelana contributed to a larger seizure.

Again.

Exception.

Success.

Incomplete process.

She wrote:

PATTERN: RAHMAN SOMETIMES TREATS OPERATIONAL VALUE AS BASIS FOR DISCRETION BEFORE FORMAL AUTHORITY CATCHES UP.

She disliked the sentence.

That was why she kept it.

At noon, Daniel messaged asking whether she wanted lunch.

She declined.

He sent:

THIS IS WHY INTEGRITY PEOPLE HAVE NO JOY.

She ignored him.

The deeper operational sample did not produce a new smoking gun.

That was important.

Aisyah found several occasions where Rahman had held information tightly, delayed wider circulation or protected source relationships until he believed action was safe.

Most had documented operational reasons.

Some had clear authority.

Some sat in the grey zone between command expectation and case-officer discretion.

The recurring feature was not criminality.

It was ownership.

Rahman tended to carry difficult choices personally.

He asked advice when necessary, but he did not distribute moral burden easily.

A note from an old supervisory review described him as:

RELIABLE UNDER PRESSURE. MAY WITHHOLD CONCERN UNTIL SOLUTION FORMED.

A compliment in one context.

A warning in another.

Aisyah added:

COMMAND VULNERABILITY: CENTRALISES JUDGMENT IN SELF.

Then:

POTENTIAL EFFECT — TEAM MAY RECEIVE DECISION WITHOUT FULL BASIS.

That connected to 2006 without inventing a new offence.

Kelana's history remained more troubling because the relationship crossed categories.

Suspect.

Criminal intermediary.

Source.

Unregistered contact.

Registered source again.

Useful person.

Dangerous person.

No single status survived all years.

Rahman's notes sometimes reflected that complexity honestly.

Other times, the administrative record lagged behind the reality.

One 1999 source report clearly documented Kelana's intelligence value.

A later contact note was entered days after the meeting.

Another had only a restricted cross-reference.

One minor offence appeared to have been overlooked while Rahman sought higher-value information.

No evidence money changed hands.

No evidence Rahman protected Kelana for personal benefit.

But discretion had accumulated.

Aisyah wrote:

KELANA RELATIONSHIP PRESENTS REPUTATIONAL / PROCEDURAL LEVERAGE EVEN ABSENT CORRUPTION.

She stopped.

That might be the point.

A person did not need to be guilty to be vulnerable.

They only needed something difficult to explain quickly.

Rahman's public reputation was simple.

Incorruptible.

His actual career was not.

No honest long career was.

If someone possessed selective records—the unauthorised delay, the irregular source contacts, the incomplete general reports—they could make a true story look false or a complicated story look criminal.

Aisyah understood suddenly why Razak had used the word leverage.

The review was not asking only whether Rahman had done wrong.

It was asking what truth about him could be weaponised.

She opened a new field.

POTENTIAL LEVERAGE:

— reputation for incorruptibility — loyalty to Harun / unresolved 17/94 history — family exposure — ORION failure under his command — discretionary operational history — source relationship with Kelana

Then she deleted family exposure.

Too generic.

Everyone had family.

She restored it only after asking whether there was any evidence someone had approached Mariam, Hana or Adam.

None.

So:

FAMILY — GENERAL VULNERABILITY ONLY; NO CURRENT EVIDENCE OF TARGETING.

Better.

She searched disciplinary archives for accusations against Rahman.

Several complaints.

Rough treatment? Unsubstantiated.

Failure to follow reporting line? Partially sustained in an early case.

Improper source favouritism? No evidence.

Political interference? Closed as unsupported.

The existence of complaints meant nothing by itself.

Senior officers collected accusations like old files collected dust.

What mattered was whether the same mechanism repeated.

She did not find bribery.

She did not find unexplained benefit.

She did not find fabricated evidence.

She did not find a target Rahman had warned for personal gain.

She found a man who sometimes decided that the safest place for responsibility was inside himself.

That could become moral courage.

It could also become concealment.

At 17:00, Razak returned.

“You found something.”

“Procedural pattern.”

“Criminal?”

“No.”

“Financial?”

“No.”

“Leak?”

“No evidence.”

“Then?”

Aisyah turned the screen.

“Repeated private judgment near the edge of authority. Often successful. Sometimes documented only in restricted channels. Source relationships with inconsistent registration. Selective withholding.”

Razak read.

“Leverage?”

"Potentially reputation."

"How?"

"If Rahman's public identity depends on being incorruptible, someone could threaten to expose decisions that look worse without context."

"Would he care?"

"Yes."

"You know that?"

"I infer."

"Mark it."

She did.

INFERENCE.

Razak pointed to Kelana.

"Criminal leverage?"

"No evidence Kelana controls him."

"Farid?"

"Historical sponsorship. operational overlap. no evidence of improper benefit."

"Harun?"

Aisyah looked at him.

"Emotional vulnerability."

Razak waited.

"Rahman idealises him."

"Evidence?"

"The way he reacts. old file interest. persistent doubt about official story."

"That is thin."

"Yes."

"Keep it thin."

She nodded.

Razak read the new leverage section without comment.

Then he pointed to one line.

"Loyalty to Harun."

"Yes."

"Fact or interpretation?"

"Interpretation supported by behaviour."

"What behaviour?"

"Rahman's response to the name. persistence around the old case. distrust of the official account."

"Could be professional concern."

"Yes."

"Could be grief."

"Yes."

"Could be guilt."

"No evidence."

"Then do not let the word appear."

"It doesn't."

Razak nodded.

This was why she respected him.

He could be hard without being hungry for a finding.

"Your provisional conclusion?"

Aisyah thought.

"No evidence he is bought."

"That is not the same as safe."

"No."

"No evidence he leaked ORION."

"No."

"Could he be compromised?"

"Yes."

"How?"

"Through his own judgment. Through selective records. Through people he feels responsible for. Through the need to protect the institution without admitting he is doing it."

Razak looked at her.

"That last part is broad."

"Yes."

"Prove it before you keep it."

She deleted the sentence from the formal draft.

Kept the question in her notebook.

Different places for different levels of certainty.

The distinction was becoming personal.

Before Razak left, she asked, "Does Rahman get told?"

"When findings reach response threshold."

"Who decides?"

"I do."

She disliked that.

Razak saw it.

"Procedure has to locate responsibility somewhere."

"Yes."

"Your job is not to like where."

After he left, Aisyah opened a new section.

PROTECTIVE FACTORS.

It mattered.

An integrity review that collected only danger would be propaganda.

No unexplained assets.

No evidence of selling information.

No evidence of target warning.

No evidence of fabricated evidence.

No evidence of family benefit.

Documented willingness to preserve adverse supervisory records in some cases.

Accepts external correction more than reputation suggests.

Has explicitly placed himself within ORION scope.

She hesitated.

Then wrote:

MORAL SERIOUSNESS GENUINE.

Below it:

DO NOT CONFUSE MORAL SERIOUSNESS WITH MORAL SAFETY.

Razak's phrase.

At 21:30, Rahman entered SOC 4.

Aisyah had returned before him.

He placed a coffee beside her.

"No drinks near evidence terminals," she said.

"It is on the side table."

"Learning."

"Slowly."

He looked at her screen.

She had closed the review before he entered.

Not because the file was improper.

Because he was the subject.

The act felt like betrayal.

That was information too.

Rahman said, “Archive request approved. Seventeen ninety-four tomorrow.”

“I saw.”

“You coming?”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

Then paused.

“You all right?”

Aisyah looked at him.

She could tell him.

Not the findings.

The existence.

She could refuse the assignment.

Ask Razak to appoint someone else.

Instead she said, “Tired.”

True.

Narrow.

Rahman nodded.

“Go home.”

“You first.”

He almost smiled and walked away.

Aisyah watched him cross the room.

The review had not found a corrupt man.

That would have been easier.

It had found a disciplined, serious officer who repeatedly believed he could carry exceptional decisions alone if the operational reason was strong enough.

A man whose good outcomes had sometimes protected him from consequences.

A man who understood institutional secrecy because he had used it.

A man who might be impossible to buy with money and still vulnerable to something else.

Reputation.

Loyalty.

Harun.

Family.

ORION.

Service.

The need to believe his choices had meant something.

Harun Ismail's own record was the thinnest in the cabinet.

Died 19 October 2001. Found in his parked car, service pistol beside him. Inquiry finding: suicide. Closed in nine days.

A liaison officer from Special Intelligence had attended the inquiry. The name was not recorded.

Case 17/94 had been closed the same week, with him.

Aisyah added one final line before closing the file.

NO EVIDENCE RAHMAN IS THE ORION LEAK.

Then:

INTEGRITY RISK IS NOT LIMITED TO BRIBERY.

She saved.

The next morning she would stand beside Rahman and open Harun's old case.

He would believe she was there only as his investigator and colleague.

He would be wrong.

For the first time since joining ORION, Aisyah understood exactly how an honest secret could begin damaging trust before anyone discovered it existed.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

THE OLD CASE

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

The old case did not arrive as a file.

It arrived as a smell.

Dust, damp paper, cabinet metal, and the faint sourness of rooms where the air conditioning had failed years ago but the records had stayed. Grace stood in the basement archive with a mask pulled below her chin and a torch in her hand. The fluorescent tubes overhead had been replaced in some bays and not in others, so the aisles went from bright to brown to bright again, like a road seen through trees.

“Case Seventeen of Ninety-Four,” she said.

Daniel looked up from the index ledger.

“You found it?”

“I found where it should have been.”

That was how the morning began. Not with discovery, but with absence.

Rahman came down ten minutes later. He had not wanted the team to see his face before he had seen the shelf himself. The stairwell smelled of floor polish and old rain, and on the way down he caught himself counting steps, as he had when he was young and had been sent below to fetch things for men who did not look up from their desks.

The row was intact until it reached the grey spine labelled 16/94. After that came 18/94, then 19/94, then a replacement folder from 2003 that did not belong in the sequence at all. Someone had slid it into the gap the way a man slides a coin under a door.

Aisyah ran her finger along the empty space.

“Somebody removed one case and trusted nobody would count.”

“Or somebody counted for thirty years,” Rahman said, “and waited until now to make us notice.”

She looked at him for a moment, then back at the shelf. She had been quiet since they arrived. Quieter than usual, which was already quiet. Rahman put it down to the room.

The ledger was worse.

It was a long green book, bound in cloth that had gone soft at the corners, with entries in three or four hands over the years. Daniel laid it flat on the metal table and turned the pages with the tips of his fingers, as if the paper might tear if he breathed on it. Case 17/94 had been opened under Superintendent Harun Ismail. The subject line had been written in old blue ink:

SUSPICIOUS PROTECTION OF GAMBLING AND BORDER TRANSPORT NETWORK.

Under officers assigned, in smaller handwriting, Rahman’s own name appeared.

He stared at it longer than he meant to.

“You worked it?” Daniel asked.

“I assisted.”

“Do you remember it?”

“No.”

Aisyah heard the lie because it was too immediate. People who had forgotten something paused first, looked for it, found nothing. Rahman had answered before the question had finished arriving. She said nothing. Writing it down would have been a finding, and she was not ready to have findings about this man in a room full of other people’s coffee cups.

Rahman remembered.

A night road. A lorry stopped under rain with its hazard lights ticking orange on wet tarmac. Harun’s hand raised for silence, flat, the fingers slightly spread, and the whole team going still without being told. And a witness at the side of the road who had looked more frightened of the policemen than of the men he was about to name.

He remembered being young enough to think fear could be solved by telling the truth to the right superior.

The right superior had been Harun.

Then Harun disappeared from the case record.

Rahman turned the page. And the next. Harun's signature stopped halfway down a column, and the entries that followed were in a hand he did not know, tidier and less certain. Officer reassigned. File transferred. Subject closed pending review. The language of a case being walked out of a building by people who did not want to be seen carrying it.

Grace photographed every page of the ledger, twice, with and without the ruler beside it. Daniel built a chain from surviving cross-references, writing on a legal pad because he did not trust the room's network yet: vehicle seizures, dock permits, an unexplained transfer of a customs officer, a dead informant entered under a different case number.

"Different case number," Rahman said.

"Misfiled?"

"Moved."

Daniel looked at him. "Why would you move a dead man?"

"So nobody asks what he was alive for."

Daniel wrote that down too, then crossed it out, because it was an interpretation and not a fact. Aisyah noticed. It was one of the small reasons she was glad to have him.

They worked through the shelves either side. Seventeen of Ninety-Four had left traces everywhere except in its own place. A reference in a seizure register. A permit number in a dock log with no matching file. A memo in 15/94 that mentioned a "parallel matter" and then stopped, as if the writer had been called away and the next person had thought better of finishing the sentence.

The basement had its own weather. Two hours in, the damp had worked into everyone's collar. Daniel sneezed into his elbow and apologised to a cabinet. Grace's mask had slipped again and she pushed it up with the back of her wrist, because her gloves were too dirty to touch her face.

Rahman stood at the end of an aisle where a bulb had failed and let his eyes adjust. The smell was exactly as he remembered it from thirty years ago, wet cardboard and cold metal and something under both that might have been the building itself. He realised that he had been holding his breath the way Harun used to, shallowly, as if the air had listeners.

He let it out. It sounded very loud.

Daniel ran the names in the traces against ORION's target list on his tablet. He ran it twice. Three of the companies had changed owners since

1994 and kept their addresses, and all three were already on ORION's board.

None of it proved The Circle.

All of it felt like its shadow.

Rahman kept expecting to feel something large. Fear, perhaps, or anger. What he felt was closer to embarrassment. He had spent thirty years believing he understood how this building kept its secrets. Now he was standing in the basement of it, looking at a single missing folder, and discovering he had never once come down here to check.

At noon, Grace went upstairs to fetch lunch for everyone and came back without it, with a face that told him to follow her. A procurement box in the far bay, labelled in a clerk's careful hand, contained uniform invoices, boot supplier quotations and thirteen years of stationery orders. In the bottom of it, folded once and pressed flat by everything above, lay one surviving slip.

It was only half a page. It had been torn through the signature, cleanly, as if by a man who did not want the paper but could not bring himself to burn it.

Harun's handwriting filled the margin.

Rahman knew it before he could read it. The capitals leaned forward, as though every word was in a hurry to reach the next.

If the file vanishes, follow the people who benefited from the silence.

Below that, a name had been pressed so hard into the paper that the pen had nearly cut through.

Farid Kamal.

Nobody spoke.

Aisyah looked at Rahman. Daniel looked at the slip. Grace, who had found it and understood exactly what she had found, looked at the floor.

Rahman closed his eyes.

He saw Farid in a doorway, thirty years younger, adjusting his cuff, the first superior he had ever believed. He saw Harun beside him, taller, impatient, already half turned away.

He opened his eyes.

"Photograph it in place," he said. "Then log it. Then log it again."

Grace nodded and lifted her camera.

Aisyah waited until the others had gone up with the sleeve.

She stood on the bottom stair with her torch switched off, the way a person stands when she has decided not to be kind about timing.

"Harun's inquiry closed in nine days."

"I know."

"As suicide."

"I know what it said."

"Do you believe it?"

For twenty-five years the answer had been ready whenever he needed it. He had used it at the graveside, and before the board, and on nights when sleep would not come. Yes. A man who had lost his case and his friend. It was a kind sentence, and it fitted.

He remembered the graveside in 2001. The rain had come in sideways. The wreath from headquarters was larger than the congregation, and a man from Special Intelligence named Farid Kamal had come, stood under the tree at the back, and left before the closing prayer. Rahman had read that as grief. He had been grateful for it.

On the stair, with Aisyah's torch switched off and the cold coming up through the concrete, he wondered what else it could have been read as.

He opened his mouth to say it.

It was not there.

"I cannot say yes."

She did not write it down. That was how he knew she had heard it.

The old case was not old anymore.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

THE PATTERN

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Daniel liked patterns because they behaved better than people.

People lied, forgot, performed loyalty, mistook fear for judgement and called convenience wisdom. Patterns simply repeated. You could be wrong about a pattern, but it never wounded you by being wrong on purpose.

By late afternoon the wall screen in SOC 4 held thirty-two fragments from Case 17/94 and its neighbouring files. Grace had colour-coded them by year, blues for the nineties, ambers for the early two-thousands, a dull green for anything she could not date. Aisyah had marked every point where the official explanation required an improbable coincidence, with a red dot and a number, and the red dots had begun to outnumber the fragments.

There were too many.

A lorry released after a telephone call that appeared in no log. A witness statement shortened before filing, three paragraphs reduced to one. A junior officer transferred to a district nobody had requested. A raid delayed by a maintenance issue that did not exist when Daniel checked the maintenance roster. A prosecutor receiving a replacement evidence bundle with a cover sheet bearing the old date.

Daniel stood back from the screen with his arms loose at his sides, which was how he stood when something had stopped being a hypothesis.

“It is not one leak.”

Rahman did not answer. He was looking at the wall, but Daniel had the feeling he was looking through it, at something older.

"It is a method," Daniel continued. "Small pressure at every joint. Nobody has to own the whole corruption. Each person only does one small wrong thing."

Aisyah folded her arms.

"That is how institutions learn to deny guilt."

"Because every individual can truthfully say they did not do it."

"Because every individual did not."

Daniel nodded, grim, almost pleased, and then looked ashamed of being pleased.

The first cluster ran from 1994 to 1997. The second revived in 2001. The third connected to port expansion contracts and the dock permits they had found that morning in the basement. Each time, the same categories reappeared: transport, gambling rooms, customs brokerage, police schedules and quiet disciplinary removals.

Not the same names.

The same uses.

Rahman watched Daniel draw a line from an altered seizure report to a company that, three years later, had donated vehicles to a police welfare event. He remembered standing beside one of those vehicles at the ceremony. A white van with a ribbon on the bonnet, the businessman's hand in his, a photographer saying one more, please. He had smiled. He had meant it.

He had not known.

That was the sentence every compromised man eventually offered, and he had begun to distrust it, including in his own mouth.

Grace found a second repetition. Whenever a file threatened to connect police access with commercial protection, an internal inquiry opened somewhere else. Attention moved. Officers defended themselves. The original matter cooled while everyone was busy with something that looked more urgent.

"Diversion," Aisyah said.

"No," Rahman said. "Exhaustion."

They looked at him.

"Diversion is active. Someone has to decide to do it. Exhaustion is better, because nobody needs to decide. You create enough official work that the honest people burn their strength proving they are honest. Then you

wait." He heard his voice, flat and tired, and recognised it. "I have spent a career being the man who answers the second inquiry."

Silence settled over the room.

The pattern was not merely criminal. It understood the police. It knew how long an inquiry took, which signatures cost the most to obtain, how many weeks a transfer could delay a witness, and what a decent officer would choose to do first when two things were on fire.

Rafiq came in at three with a carrier bag of nasi kandar in polystyrene boxes and the expression of a man who disagreed with the room and had decided to feed it first.

"A method is comfortable," he said, setting out the boxes along the end of the table. "It means nobody is to blame. A mole is a person. A person I can arrest."

"They are not alternatives," Daniel said.

"They are to a prosecutor."

"Then the prosecutor needs a better imagination."

"The prosecutor needs a name and a date, Daniel. A judge cannot convict a pattern."

"Then we give the judge both."

"Both of what?" Rafiq turned to Rahman. "You tell me. You have been standing at that board since lunch. Which one do you want to find?"

Rahman looked at the thirty-two fragments and the thin blue thread down the left edge.

"I want to find the one who would be surprised by the other," he said.

Rafiq laughed, once, without much humour, and pushed a box of rice towards him.

"Eat," he said. "You look like a man who has been told something."

At a quarter past four a sealed packet came up from Special Intelligence. No covering note. Farid's initials on the routing slip, nothing else.

Inside was a restricted liaison extract: a reconstruction of who had opened ORION's vulnerability review in the hours before it was finished. ORION's own logs had failed to produce one in three weeks.

It named a single account. Coordination desk. Hakim, Amirul. An export at 21:12.

Daniel read it the way a hungry man reads a menu, looking for the catch and hoping there was none.

"He did not have to send this," Aisyah said.

"No," Rahman said.

For weeks the leak had been a mechanism without a name. Now it had one, delivered unasked by a man whose own printer was on the list. Rahman noticed that he was grateful. He noticed the gratitude, and was not sure he trusted it.

At ten past five Daniel asked, carefully, why the slip from the basement was not on the board.

The slip lay in its evidence sleeve at the end of the table, half a page, torn through the signature. Harun's margin note. And below it a name pressed through the paper.

"It is not a pattern," Rahman said. "It is a signature on nothing."

"It is a name."

"It is one name on one scrap, and every case file in this building has the names of senior officers in it, because senior officers sign things." He did not look at the sleeve. "Log it. Log it separately. It does not go on the wall until we can say what it is evidence of."

Daniel's mouth tightened. Aisyah said nothing. She wrote something short on her pad and turned the page.

At seventeen minutes past five, Rahman sent a request to the Special Intelligence registry for the cross-references on Seventeen-Ninety-Four. The reply took six minutes. Registry regretted that records of that classification required senior authorisation from within the directorate. He read it twice and put his phone face down.

At half past six Rahman stepped into the stairwell and called home.

He told himself it was to say he would be late. It was not.

Mariam answered on the second ring. Behind her a television murmured a cooking programme to nobody.

"You have said work four times this week," she said, before he had finished.

"It has been four times."

"It has been four times that you didn't say anything else."

He leaned his shoulder against the cold wall. Somewhere below, a door closed on a spring and the sound climbed the stairs.

"Do you remember," Mariam said, "when we were young, you used to tell me about your cases at the table, and I told you to stop because I wanted to sleep?"

"I remember."

"I would like to be kept awake now."

He closed his eyes.

"I can't."

"I know. I'm not asking you to. I'm telling you which one I would choose."

The cooking programme laughed at something.

"Eat," she said. "Whatever it is, eat."

"Yes."

"You're lying."

"Yes."

She hung up first, which she never did.

He stood in the stairwell for another minute with the phone dark in his hand and understood that the list of things he could not say aloud had begun to include her.

At 7.40 p.m., Daniel overlaid the present ORION breach points with the 1994 pattern.

The room had been quiet for some time. People had stopped eating. The overlay took ninety seconds to render, because Daniel had insisted on a clean model rather than eyeballing it, and when it finished it did not look like a match. It looked like a transparency laid over the original, two maps of the same country drawn thirty years apart by someone who knew the roads.

The match was not perfect.

It was worse than perfect.

It showed adaptation. Where Harun's investigators had once been stopped by a telephone call, the present breach had been routed through a vulnerability review. Where a statement had once been shortened, an export had now been altered. The method had kept its shape and changed its tools. Technology had been absorbed. Habits had not.

Aisyah read the screen and said what everyone else was avoiding.

"Someone studied Harun's investigation and improved the method."

Nobody asked who.

Rahman stared at the oldest line on the board, a thin blue thread running down the left edge to a single numbered box.

Case 17/94.

A file removed from history had become a manual.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

FARID

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Farid Kamal arrived without haste.

That was one of the things Rahman had always disliked and admired about him. Farid never rushed into a room. He came in as if time had agreed to wait, and for a long moment time usually did.

For the past month he had been a different kind of presence in SOC 4. He did not summon anyone. He came down on his own, after six, with his jacket over his arm, and stood before the board as if it were a patient. When Daniel's team had been refused database access by a directorate that preferred not to be read, Farid cleared it in four hours with one telephone call and no visible irritation. When Aisyah asked for sealed personnel files, he signed the release himself and told the registry to stop calling it a favour. He read the board in silence and left small corrections in the margin: a dead man's rank, a misfiled directorate, the spelling of a Malay name that Grace had got wrong because the file had. Daniel, who trusted almost nobody, had begun to save him the better chair. Aisyah had not. She had thanked him each time in exactly the same words, and Rahman had noticed that she wrote the date beside each thanks.

It was ten to nine at night. The pattern board still filled the wall of SOC 4, thirty-two fragments in Grace's year colours, with Aisyah's red marks wherever the official account needed a coincidence. Farid stopped in front of it before he spoke to anyone. He read it the way other men read a face.

He was older now, narrower through the cheeks, his hair silver at the temples. His eyes were as calm as they had been when Rahman was twenty-six and angry enough to mistake urgency for courage.

"You asked for me," Farid said.

"I asked for records. You came instead."

Farid smiled faintly.

"Records are shy around you today."

Aisyah stood near the window with her arms folded. Daniel kept his laptop open on the table but did not type. Grace had gone home an hour earlier, and Rahman had been glad of it without being able to say why.

He placed the torn half-page on the table between them.

Farid looked at it once.

Only once.

"Harun's handwriting," he said.

"Your name below it."

"Many people wrote my name in those years."

"Not pressed through the paper."

Farid sat. He did it unhurriedly, adjusting his cuff, and the room waited for him to finish. Thirty years had been carried into the present and made to breathe the same air. Rahman felt the weight of it settle on his shoulders.

"Harun believed exposure could save the institution," Farid said at last. "I believed exposure without control would only teach the corrupt how much we knew."

"And which of you was right?" Aisyah asked.

He turned to her. He took his time.

"Both of us lost."

Rahman set the other paper on the table, the liaison extract that had come up at a quarter past four.

"You sent us this."

"I did."

"Unasked."

"A leak is the one subject on which I take no pleasure in delay." Farid glanced at the page without touching it. "It was compiled by my liaison desk from the audit trail of the review system."

"Which our own technicians could not recover," Aisyah said.

"Which yours could not recover. Mine were intact." A small movement of one hand, an apology for the efficiency of his own people. "Is there a difficulty with it?"

"No," Rahman said.

It was the truth. There was no difficulty yet. There was only the sensation of having been handed exactly what he needed, tidily, at the hour he needed it.

Aisyah said nothing. She wrote the time on her pad and underlined it once.

Rahman felt the old anger rise. It had been stored somewhere in him, labelled and put away, waiting for the right hand to open it. He kept his voice level.

"What happened to Case Seventeen?"

"It was sealed."

"By whom?"

"Above my level."

"Convenient."

"Everything that survives this long becomes convenient to somebody."

Aisyah did not say anything. She uncapped her pen and wrote three words on her pad, small, with the pad tilted away. Rahman saw her do it. Farid, who missed nothing, probably did too.

Daniel could not help himself.

"Were you protecting the investigation, or protecting yourself?"

Farid looked at him without offence.

"At your age I would have asked the same question with less politeness."

"That isn't an answer."

"No." Farid considered him. "It is a compliment. Take it while the evening is young."

Rahman leaned forward.

"Answer him."

The calm thinned, just slightly, like paper held up to a lamp.

"Harun wanted a witness on the record," Farid said. "A man who knew how the transport and the gambling rooms and the police schedules fitted together. Harun was certain of him. Harun was certain of everything that winter."

"And?"

"And the man would have been dead within a week."

Nobody moved.

"I moved him. I buried the statement. I let Harun believe I had betrayed him, because the alternative was telling Harun where the man

was, and Harun would have gone to see him." He stopped. "Harun was never careful about where he walked."

Aisyah's expression did not change.

"Name."

"Kelana."

The room altered.

Rahman saw again the informant's tired eyes. He heard him speak of The Circle as if it were weather, something dangerous because it surrounded everybody and belonged to no one. For years he had believed Kelana had come to them. That the first contact had been his own: a warehouse fence in the north, a boy who ran, fell and complied too easily. He had put it down to luck.

"Kelana was Case Seventeen?"

"Part of it," Farid said. "The part that could speak."

"You never told me."

"You never asked the right question. And you were twenty-six. You had a conscience like a lit match, Rahman, and no idea what it could burn."

"Harun died."

"Yes."

"Believing you had betrayed him."

Farid's hands lay flat on the table. He looked at them, then at Rahman.

"I do not know what Harun believed at the end," he said. "I have spent a great deal of time trying to know."

It was the first sentence all evening that sounded unrehearsed. Rahman noticed it and distrusted it, in the same breath, and was ashamed of both.

Farid reached into his jacket and took out a sealed envelope. Plain brown. No writing on it. He set it beside Harun's torn note, squaring the two edges with a fingertip.

"I kept one copy," he said, "because I did not trust the system. I did not give it to Harun because I did not trust his grief."

Rahman did not touch it.

"What is it?"

"Open it only when you are ready to know who Harun was willing to accuse."

Farid stood. He buttoned his jacket. At the door he paused, not turning.

"Seventeen-Ninety-Four was not the case you think it is. It was not the case Harun thought it was either." A pause. "I should like to be wrong about that."

Then he was gone, and the door closed on its slow hydraulic arm, and nobody spoke until the latch clicked.

Daniel exhaled.

"He gave us Kelana."

"Yes," Aisyah said.

"That is good. That is a real thing. That explains the informant file, the missing statement, why Harun's notes go quiet in the winter."

"Yes."

"So why does it feel like we lost something?"

Aisyah turned her pad toward Rahman.

Above my level.

Under it, smaller:

Not a name.

"He answered the question about Kelana," she said. "He did not answer the question about the seal. A man who gives you something true and expensive at the start of an interview is often buying a better position for what he doesn't give you."

"I know."

"Do you?"

"I was trained by him."

She held his eyes. For a moment he thought she would say more. She capped her pen instead.

Rahman looked at the envelope.

He had been in rooms with sealed things all his life. Warrants, packages, coffins. He had learned to open them in daylight with a witness. It was nearly nine o'clock at night and the only witnesses were an integrity officer, an analyst and the empty chair Farid had just left.

He opened it anyway.

Inside was a list.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

THE WRONG ENEMY

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

The list did not begin with criminals.

Its first violence was how ordinary it looked.

Rahman had braced for names. He had carried the envelope back to the table with his shoulders already set, expecting gang names, transport bosses, gambling financiers, border fixers, men whose faces belonged in surveillance photographs and whose guilt could be made visible with enough patience. He had braced, privately, for one name in particular, and he had not been sure whether he feared to find it or to miss it.

Instead Harun had written professions.

It was a single sheet, folded in thirds, in Harun's forward-leaning capitals. The back of a duplicate duty roster, paper from the early two-thousands. No heading. No date. A column of nouns, each on its own line, as if he had been naming furniture in a room he could not see.

Licensing officer.

Customs broker.

Police clerk.

Disciplinary secretary.

Bank relationship manager.

Political aide.

Deputy superintendent.

Beside the last, a small circle in the margin, drawn and not filled in.

Aisyah read it twice.

"This is not an organisation chart."

"No," Rahman said. "It is an access map."

Daniel pulled the chair closer, forgetting that he had been told twice that evening to stop.

“The Circle is not a gang. It borrows gangs.”

The sentence landed with an ugly neatness. Nobody argued with it, which was how Rahman knew it was true.

For thirty years he had chased men who carried weapons, moved money, threatened witnesses and paid officers. Some had deserved prison. Some had deserved worse than the law could give them. He had given them his nights. And they had not been the centre. They had been instruments that believed themselves powerful because they were permitted to be loud.

The quieter power sat behind counters. It sat inside committees, near filing rooms, beside printers. It sat at dinners where everyone wore batik and smiled for cameras, and where a man with a licence to sign could do more by being late than a man with a pistol could do by being present.

Grace was in by six. She matched Harun’s professions against ORION’s current anomalies at the end of the table with a mug of tea going cold beside the keyboard, and when the shape reappeared she stopped typing and simply turned the screen.

Not the same people.

The same positions.

A compromised clerk did not need to steal a whole file. She only needed to delay one page. A banker did not need to launder millions. He only needed to ask the wrong question late. A disciplinary secretary did not need to clear a corrupt officer. He only needed to misplace a complaint until promotion season passed. The damage came from where they stood, not from what they took.

Aisyah looked at Rahman.

“We have been looking for the enemy among suspects.”

“Because suspects are honest enough to look like enemies,” he said.

* * *

Rafiq had not waited for the professions.

The extract from Special Intelligence gave him an account, an export time and a man who had already admitted taking money. A Deputy Public Prosecutor signed the warrant that evening, while Rahman was still reading Harun’s list.

Rahman had asked for a week.

Rafiq had asked what a week would buy a leak.

Rahman did not stop it. He would remember that.

* * *

They brought Amirul Hakim in at 05:40, in a borrowed shirt. He held out his wrists before anyone reached for them.

The first time, he had lasted thirty-seven seconds against Aisyah and a bank statement. This time Rafiq did not need the bank statement.

“I exported it.”

“The vulnerability review.”

“Yes.”

“To whom?”

“Raziq.”

By noon there were eleven signed pages. Rahman watched through the glass and waited for relief. It came. There was nothing underneath it.

Rafiq set the statement on the table in SOC 4 at one o’clock.

“That is your leak.”

Aisyah turned the pages without reading them.

“I asked him twice in the last hour. How many pages. What colour the wallet was. He said, ‘The big one.’ Both times.”

“He was frightened.”

“He was. Of what?”

Rafiq had no answer, and went home to tell his wife it was over.

* * *

Daniel waited until nine.

“I need to ruin somebody’s evening.”

He put two lines on the wall screen.

EXTRACT — Hakim export, 21:12.

ORION REVIEW — final version saved, 21:40.

“He sent it twenty-eight minutes before we finished writing it.”

Nobody moved.

“Clock drift,” Rahman said, because someone had to.

“Our server syncs every hour. Drift is seconds.” Daniel enlarged a third line. “And the extract’s own seal does not match its contents. The time was changed after the log was closed.”

“By whom?”

“Somebody between the source system and the desk that sent it to us.” He did not look at Rahman. “Or that desk.”

Rahman thought of a sheet of paper in a drawer at home, six names long. He did not say so.

Aisyah had been quiet. Now she set down her pen.

“Duty counsel was in the building at 06:15. Amirul had not asked for one. He had not yet been allowed a call.”

Daniel stared at her.

“Somebody arranged his confession as carefully as his export.”

“So we arrested the wrong man.”

“We arrested the right man for the wrong crime. He did take money. He did hand over small things. That is why he was usable.” She looked at the board. “They did not invent a guilty man. They found a cheap one and asked him to be guilty of more.”

“A finish line,” Rahman said.

“So that we stop asking who.”

At ten past ten Rahman withdrew the leak charge. The bribery counts would proceed on their own. Amirul Hakim would stay in the cells for the one thing he had done, and not for the thing he had been told to say.

Rahman knew what would be written about it before anyone wrote it.

Daniel’s phone vibrated on the table. He checked it, frowned, and turned the screen around without a word.

An internal bulletin had gone out five minutes earlier, to the whole of command distribution. ORION would be reviewed for operational overreach and evidence-handling irregularities, effective immediately, pending the findings of the integrity directorate.

No one outside the command group should have known enough to draft it.

Rahman read it twice. The wording was careful. It accused him of nothing by name. It simply listed what a review of a task force commander might find, in the order a critic would choose to say it: secrecy, unauthorised retention of documents, pressure on subordinates, contamination of an old file, and an arrest made on material nobody had verified.

Some of it was false.

Some was close enough to the truth to be useful.

He thought of the half-page in its evidence sleeve. Of the envelope he had accepted from a man who had every reason to want him looking at professions and not at him. “They are making you the case,” Aisyah said.

It was the quietest thing she had said all evening, and the most exact.

The wrong enemy had moved first.

Rahman folded Harun's list along its old creases and put it into his inside pocket. The room watched him do it, and he understood that they were waiting for him to defend himself, and that it would be a mistake.

"Then we stop defending my reputation."

"Sir?"

"Reputations are how they keep us busy."

He looked at Daniel.

"Find the person who drafted that bulletin."

Then at Grace.

"Find the clerk who released it."

Then at Aisyah.

"Find out whether I deserve any part of it."

Aisyah held his gaze a moment longer than the sentence needed.

"You want the bulletin's claims tested."

"Every one. Start with the ones that are true."

CHAPTER THIRTY

THE ARCHIVE

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

The archive had two doors.

One was official, logged and watched by a camera that worked whenever the maintenance forms were properly submitted. The other was a service entrance behind shelving marked for disposal, known to cleaners, contractors and officers who had been young before security became a performance.

Grace found it in the building plans. Aisyah found it in a cleaner's memory, a woman named Kak Sabariah who had pushed a trolley down that corridor for nineteen years and said, without being asked twice, that the lower door had never closed properly since the flood. Rahman found it in himself.

He had used that door once, in 1994, following Harun into the records basement after midnight because Harun trusted silence more than procedure. He remembered a smell of wet cardboard, and Harun's torch held low against his leg, and how little he had understood of what he was being shown.

Now they entered legally, through the front, with written authority and two named witnesses. The bulletin of the night before had settled that. Anything ORION touched that morning would be read as overreach unless proven otherwise, and the proof would be paper. It felt less clean than the old trespass.

The disposal cage held boxes from three decades. Most were harmless: payroll duplicates, vehicle maintenance forms, outdated circulars, training manuals swollen by damp. Daniel went through them with a patience he never showed in meetings, lifting each carton, reading the label,

setting it aside, as though the building owed him something and he was prepared to be paid in small instalments.

Then he saw the blue string.

Not tied around a box. Caught under one.

Blue had been the archive's colour for sealed matter, before the department had moved to barcodes and stopped caring what colour anything was. He lifted the carton carefully. Beneath it lay a packet wrapped in brown paper, flattened by years of institutional forgetting, tied once with the string.

On the front, someone had written one word.

RAHMAN.

Nobody touched it immediately.

Aisyah photographed the position. Grace logged the time. Daniel stepped back as if the packet might accuse him by proximity. Rahman looked at the capital R, leaning forward, and thought of a hand raised for silence on a wet road.

He opened it himself.

Inside were copies. Not originals. Harun had known better than to leave originals where theft would be noticed. There were witness summaries, vehicle plates, a partial financial memo, and a photograph of a heavyset man in a pale suit standing beside two officers and a third man whose face had been cut from the print with a blade so sharp it had left no fibres.

At the bottom lay a cassette tape.

Daniel almost laughed from shock.

"Do we even have anything that plays this?"

"Evidence store," Grace said. "Old interview equipment."

The label was in Harun's hand.

KELANA — NOT FOR FILE.

Rahman thought of Farid at the table the night before. I buried the statement. This was not the statement. This was what Farid had buried it to prevent. A voice.

They played it in a secure room with the volume low. The machine ticked and wound. Kelana's younger voice filled the silence, thinner than Rahman remembered but unmistakable, careful with its vowels.

He spoke of police schedules sold as favours. Of gambling rooms protected through well-timed warnings. Of transport companies that carried legal cargo by day and debt by night.

Then Harun asked the question.

Who coordinates it?

The tape hissed.

Kelana answered, “You keep asking who leads. That is how they make you blind. Ask who benefits when everyone is afraid to sign their own name.”

Another pause.

“There is a policeman. Not the biggest. The useful one. He knows how files move.”

Harun asked for the name.

A sound interrupted the recording. A chair. A breath. Kelana refusing.

Then, barely audible:

“If I say it, Farid will bury me and you will hate him for saving my life.”

The tape ended there.

Nobody moved. The machine ran on for several seconds, the dead tape slipping across the head, and Aisyah reached over and pressed stop.

Rahman sat back.

He had sat across a restaurant table from that voice only weeks before, older, amused and careful. Hearing it young, on Harun’s tape, he understood that the amusement had always been a kind of caution.

A man who gave you a name was no longer needed. A man who gave you weather could be kept.

The archive had not given them an answer. It had given them the shape of the question Harun had died carrying: who knew how files moved, and who had loved the man who kept them hidden.

Aisyah looked at the cut photograph.

“Can we restore the missing face?”

Grace was already scanning.

“Maybe not. But we can find the original event. Somebody took this at something. A dinner, a ceremony. There will be other pictures.”

They were still bagging the tape when the shutter went.

It was a heavy sound, steel on steel, travelling up through the floor of the basement, and every one of them knew it was not a sound the build-

ing made by accident. Grace was already on her feet. Rahman reached the service stairs ahead of the younger officers and did not remember deciding to run.

The loading bay sat at the back of the complex, under a sheet-metal roof that amplified rain into applause. A lorry stood against the ramp with its tailgate down. On its door, in neat green letters: LATIF MURNI SERVICES — RECORDS & DISPOSAL.

Four men in company polo shirts were wheeling the contents of the disposal cage onto it. Not the harmless cartons from the top. The old ones, from the back, with the damp stains and the faded blue string.

"Stop," Rahman said.

Nobody stopped.

A man with a clipboard and a thick neck turned around, smiling with the professional patience of someone who had been told to expect interference. His name was stitched on the pocket: SHAHRIN.

"Dato'. Good morning. Scheduled disposal."

"Not today."

"It is on paper, sir." He held the clipboard out as if offering a cup of tea. "Records Retention Committee. Everything is in order."

Aisyah took it before Rahman could.

She read it standing in the rain, which came in sideways under the roof. Daniel photographed it over her shoulder. Rahman watched her face the way he had once watched juniors read exhibits, looking for the moment the line is found.

"Authorised at seven twelve this morning," she said. "Destruction advanced by eleven days."

"There was a backlog," Shahrin said.

"Signed for the committee by a delegated officer. No name. Initials only."

"I do not make the forms."

"The committee," Grace said quietly, "has not met since March. I checked the registry this morning."

Shahrin's smile did not leave. It simply stopped being attached to anything.

"Please step aside. We are on a schedule."

A trolley rolled forward. The man pushing it was young and plainly did not want to be there, and he kept his eyes on the ramp rather than on any of them.

Rahman moved into its path.

He did not raise his hand and he did not touch his holster. He had learned a long time ago that an authority which needs to prove itself is already losing. He stood where the trolley would have to go through him, an old policeman in a wet jacket, and said in the voice he used for the last question of an interview, “Put it down. Slowly. Not because I am asking.”

The boy stopped.

For a long moment the only sound was rain on tin and a lorry engine idling.

“Sir,” Shahrin said, “you are blocking a lawful contractor.”

“I am holding a lawful search warrant. It covers this building, this cage and anything that has left it in the past twelve hours.” Rahman took the paper from Aisyah’s folder and put it on top of the clipboard. “Read it aloud, please. For the benefit of your men.”

Shahrin did not read it.

His phone vibrated in his breast pocket. He took it out, glanced at the screen, and turned half away. Rahman heard only one side of the call, and the one side was short.

“Yes.”

“Yes.”

“No. He is here himself.”

A silence long enough for another person to speak.

“Understood.”

When Shahrin turned back, the neck had gone slightly pale.

“I am told to cooperate,” he said.

“By whom?”

“By head office.”

“Give me the number.”

“It was private.”

Aisyah was already writing down the digits displayed on the lit screen, reading them upside down, a skill she claimed to have picked up in the Inspectorate and had never explained.

They sealed the cage. Two constables from the front desk were posted on the ramp with instructions that surprised no one: nobody in, nobody

out, nobody on the telephone. Daniel counted what remained on the trolleys, and what remained in the cage, and what the registry log said should have been there.

"Fourteen cartons missing," he said.

"Taken when?"

"The gate camera says the first lorry left at six forty."

"Before the authorisation."

"Before the authorisation was signed," Daniel agreed. "Forty minutes before. Which means the paper was written to describe something that had already happened."

Grace had the plate. Grace always had the plate.

Kak Sabariah had been watching from the doorway of the staff room, a stainless-steel teapot in both hands. Nobody had asked her to come. She had put on a clean tudung and walked over as if the building were her kitchen and the visitors were due.

"I told you the lower door never closed," she said to Aisyah.

"You did."

"Today it was open at five. I thought it was the cleaners."

Aisyah took her statement on the ramp, in the rain, with Daniel holding an umbrella over the paper.

Rahman stood on the ramp and watched the other lorry back slowly out into the rain with its tailgate still open and its trolleys empty. He thought of the lower door that had never closed properly since the flood, and of the careful, legal, written way he had come in through the front.

Someone had known the exact morning. Not because anyone in ORION had spoken. Because the bulletin the night before had told the whole building that the morning would belong to the paper.

He had walked in lawfully, and the lawfulness had given them six hours' notice.

Upstairs, Harun's tape sat in its evidence bag, and the packet marked with his name lay on the table where they had left it.

The cartons that were gone were gone. The ones they had saved were saved only because a boy with a trolley had hesitated for four seconds.

Rahman looked at the packet with his name on it.

Harun had not left him proof.

He had left him responsibility.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

THE FIRST NAME

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

The first recurring name was not a policeman.

That surprised Daniel.

He had expected the archive to produce a senior officer, a fixer, somebody whose biography could carry the weight of a theory.

Instead the name belonged to a businessman.

RAHIM NASIR.

Harun had written it eleven times across twenty years of duplicate material.

Not always the same way.

R. Nasir.

Rahim N.

Nasir Transport.

R.N.

Once, only:

Ask who introduced them.

Daniel built the references on a clean screen.

Aisyah stood behind him.

“Eleven occurrences.”

“Yes.”

“In how many documents?”

“Seven.”

“Over what period?”

“1995 to 2001.”

“Same context?”

“No.”

“Then eleven does not mean eleven times suspicious.”

Daniel looked at her.

“I know.”

“You sounded excited.”

“I am allowed to be excited by recurrence.”

Rahman entered carrying the sealed-copy index.

“What?”

Daniel turned the screen.

“First name that repeats enough to stop looking random.”

Rahman read.

RAHIM NASIR.

The name meant nothing to him at first.

Then something small moved in memory.

Not recognition.

Familiarity.

He had seen it somewhere.

Old trade pages, maybe.

A port-development dinner.

One of the businessmen who appeared in newspapers because he donated ambulances, sponsored sports clubs and sat on committees nobody remembered after the photographs were taken.

Aisyah said, “Start with the man, not the theory.”

Daniel sighed.

“Fine.”

Rahim Nasir had been born in the late 1940s.

Western docks.

Maternal family from Seri Merbau.

Lorry driver in his twenties.

Fleet supervisor.

Then owner.

NASIR CONSOLIDATED TRANSPORT.

Warehousing.

Customs brokerage partnerships.

Fleet services.

Port property.

A small hotel investment.

Nothing in the growth curve was impossible.

Good years aligned with port expansion.

His companies won contracts.

Bought land.

Borrowed.

Restructured.

Paid tax.

Made donations.

A real businessman.

That mattered.

Grace added historical commercial records.

"No sudden unexplained wealth spike."

Daniel looked disappointed.

"Can you stop taking things personally?"

"I like anomalies."

Rahman said, "Then like the honest ones too."

The first troubling reference came from 1995.

A Nasir company vehicle had been photographed outside premises later raided for illegal gambling.

No evidence Rahim was present.

Harun's note:

Vehicle may be commercial. Do not infer meeting.

Second.

A legitimate invoice between Nasir Consolidated and a freight company later tied to smuggling.

Third.

A question in Harun's notebook:

Why do rival groups use same freight broker?

Underneath:

R. Nasir introduced Lim K.S. to Goh K.B.? Verify.

Question mark.

No confirmation.

Rahman looked at the initials.

Lim Kee Seng.

Goh Kian Boon.

Both had appeared in older investigations.

Again, connection.

Not command.

Daniel opened Harun's 17/94 diagram.

Rahim Nasir sat near the centre because many lines passed through him.

Not because Harun had labelled him leader.

Beside the name:

Does he organise, or does he simply connect? Important difference.

Aisyah read it twice.

"That is the chapter."

Daniel looked at her.

"What?"

"The question."

Rahman ignored both of them.

The 1995 statement 17/94-31C should have contained Rahim's formal interview.

It was missing from the official file.

The index described him as:

COOPERATIVE.

Harun's duplicate note said:

Polite. Exact. Does not volunteer. Answers only question asked.

Rahman almost smiled.

"Sounds familiar."

Aisyah looked at him.

"You?"

"No."

She did not believe him.

The strongest pattern was not money.

It was introductions.

1997.

A transport dispute between two companies with rival criminal associations ended after a meeting at a restaurant in Taman Suria.

Harun's note:

R.N. arranged?

Another:

Not obvious command. More useful as connector.

Then:

People seek him when normal channels become expensive, slow or dangerous.

Daniel said, "Broker."

Aisyah immediately replied, “Historical description, not final category.”

He held up his hands.

“I said a word.”

Rahman read further.

Knows businessmen, lawyers, transport people, at least one senior police contact.

Does not appear to require loyalty. Favour returned later, sometimes by third party.

Then the question that mattered:

Is R.N. building network, using existing network, or simply good at surviving inside one?

No answer.

Harun had left the ambiguity intact.

They did too.

By noon, Daniel had enough to build a historical profile.

RAHIM NASIR — HISTORICAL RELEVANCE.

Not suspect.

Aisyah insisted on that label.

Daniel objected.

“He is central in the old graph.”

“Centrality is not guilt.”

“High-degree connector.”

“That is better.”

Rahman nodded.

“Use that.”

The next record changed the temperature.

Civil death certificate.

Rahim Nasir.

Died 18 September 2008.

Pulau Sentosa private medical centre.

Acute cardiac event.

Age sixty-one.

Burial recorded in Seri Merbau family plot.

Estate processed.

Tax closure.

Corporate succession.

Nothing missing.

Aisyah sat back.

"There."

Daniel looked at the screen.

"Dead."

"Yes."

"Officially."

She turned.

"Officially and administratively. Do not perform resurrection because a dead man is interesting."

Daniel said, "I wasn't."

"You were about to."

Rahman looked at the death record.

Seri Merbau.

The hometown detail made the name feel closer than it had any right to.

He asked for burial verification.

Not because he believed the death false.

Because the profile required completion.

The burial register existed.

Family plot.

No anomaly.

One cemetery record showed attendance list unavailable.

Normal.

Rahman said, "Death increases uncertainty. It does not reduce it."

Aisyah looked at him.

"That sounds dangerously poetic."

"It means we stop expecting current conduct from a dead man."

"Good."

Daniel reopened Harun's photographs.

One from 1998.

A surveillance image outside a logistics federation event.

Rahim Nasir stood near a doorway.

Older than the 1995 file photo.

Broad face.

Dark hair receding.

Calm posture.

Rahman leaned closer.
Something moved again.
Not enough.
Then Daniel opened a 2007 logistics federation dinner photograph.
Rahim with businessmen and state officials.
Grey beginning at the temples.
Rahman stared.
Aisyah saw.
“What?”
“I’ve seen him.”
“Where?”
Rahman did not answer immediately.
The retirement ceremony.
Idris Hamzah.
The old man without a lanyard.
Grey hair.
Watching Rahman.
Disappearing into the crowd.
He felt certainty try to arrive too quickly.
“No.”
Daniel frowned.
“No what?”
“I have a resemblance.”
“Where?”
“Retirement event.”
Daniel was already moving toward the archive footage.
Aisyah said, “Stop.”
He stopped.
She looked at Rahman.
“Resemblance is not identity.”
“I know.”
“Say it.”
“It is not identity.”
“Good.”
The retirement security footage was poor.
Wide angle.
Compressed.

Visitor area near the side entrance.

One elderly man.

Grey-haired.

No visible lanyard.

Partially obscured.

The same man Rahman had noticed.

Daniel froze the frame.

"Face comparison?"

Aisyah looked at Rahman.

He shook his head.

"No low-quality certainty."

"I can give confidence bands."

"No."

"Why?"

"Because the footage is bad and the historical images are old."

Daniel looked unhappy.

Rahman continued.

"You give me forty-two percent and my brain hears maybe. You give me seventy-one and everyone hears probably."

"That is not my fault."

"It becomes our problem."

Aisyah nodded.

The only visitor in the retirement registry with similar initials was R. Nordin.

Daniel checked.

Retired officer.

Real person.

Attended.

Photograph did not match the old man.

So the unidentified man remained unidentified.

Nothing more.

Aisyah wrote the ORION note herself:

DCP Rahman Aziz reports visual resemblance between historical images of Rahim Nasir and unidentified elderly male observed at MNPS retirement event. Identification not established. No action to be based on resemblance without corroboration.

Rahman approved it.

No edits.

The profile remained:

RAHIM NASIR — HISTORICAL RELEVANCE.

Not suspect.

At 18:20, Farid came into SOC 4.

He saw the profile on screen.

His face gave nothing.

Rahman asked, “You knew him?”

Farid read the name.

“Professionally.”

“How?”

“Intelligence interest. Business contact. Useful source of context at times.”

“Source?”

“No.”

“Asset?”

“No.”

“Target?”

“Sometimes.”

“Leader?”

Farid looked at him.

“Of what?”

Rahman almost answered The Circle.

Stopped.

Good.

“The old network.”

“No evidence.”

“Harun thought he was important.”

“Yes.”

“Did you?”

“Yes.”

“As what?”

Farid took a moment.

“A man who knew people.”

Daniel said, “Connector.”

Farid looked at him.

“If you need a word.”

Rahman showed him the retirement still.

Farid leaned closer.

For the first time that day, surprise appeared.

Small.

Real.

“You think that is Rahim?”

“I think he resembles him.”

Farid looked again.

“Rahim died.”

“Yes.”

“Verified?”

“Administratively.”

Farid leaned back.

“Then be careful.”

“You sound surprised.”

“I am.”

Rahman believed him.

That was not evidence either.

Farid left.

At home, Rahman stood at the kitchen window after midnight.

Mariam had gone upstairs.

A black sedan moved slowly along the road outside.

Not stopped.

Not watching.

Just passing.

Rahman watched until it turned at the junction.

He almost laughed at himself.

A black car had become a symbol because his mind wanted symbols.

He refused it.

The car was a car.

The old man was an unidentified man.

Rahim Nasir was dead according to every official record they had.

And Harun’s archive still contained eleven references to him because dead men could remain historically important without becoming ghosts.

Daniel had not enjoyed the afternoon.

“We have a man who looks like a dead man,” he said, “standing beside a car that looks like his car. In a photograph that looks like 1999.”

"Yes."

"That is four looks-likes."

"Yes."

"I could build a very convincing board out of four looks-likes."

"So could the people who want us to."

Daniel stared at the screen for a moment longer. Then he reached across and turned the monitor a few degrees away from himself, the way a man turns a photograph face down.

Rahman returned to the table.

On the controlled copy of the profile, he wrote only one line:

HIGH-LEVEL CONNECTOR — HISTORICAL. CURRENT RELEVANCE UNKNOWN.

Then below it:

DO NOT PROMOTE RESEMBLANCE INTO IDENTITY.

He closed the file.

For the first time, The Circle had a recurring human name.

That did not make it a leader.

It made it a question.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

THE FATHER

SERI MERBAU — 2026

Harun had written Rahman's father's initials in the margin of a storage receipt.

Nothing else would have taken Rahman back to Seri Merbau.

The note appeared on the final page of the second archive folder.

Faded pencil.

second copy not at office A.M. — Merbau safe because nobody will look there

Aisyah read it first.

"A.M."

Rahman did not answer.

She looked at him.

"Your father?"

"Aziz bin Mahmud."

"Initials fit."

"Yes."

"That does not prove it."

"No."

Daniel looked at the storage receipt.

MERBAU SAFEKEEPING & STORAGE.

2001.

PERSONAL PAPERS.

INDEFINITE.

The depositor name had torn away.

No surviving customer account in the modern company database.

Daniel said, "We can subpoena."

Rahman shook his head.

"Not yet."

Aisyah looked at him.

"Why?"

"Because the company closed years ago and the address is now a pharmacy."

"That is not the real reason."

Rahman looked at the faded initials.

No.

The real reason was that his father had spent thirty-one years teaching school.

No intelligence work.

No politics.

No hidden police relationships Rahman knew.

If Harun had involved him, the involvement mattered personally before it mattered evidentially.

That thought itself was dangerous.

Aisyah saw the hesitation.

"We log the lead."

"Yes."

"And if your father is part of it?"

"He is dead."

"That is not an answer."

Rahman looked at her.

"If evidence makes him part of it, we follow evidence."

She nodded.

That was enough.

Mariam drove with him north.

Rahman had intended to go alone.

She had refused.

"You are going to your family house because a dead policeman may have left papers with your dead father."

"Yes."

"And your solution is to go alone."

"Yes."

"No."

He had not argued long.

The drive to Seri Merbau took them through towns Rahman had known before they had flyovers, franchise coffee and housing estates spreading into old rubber land.

Mariam watched him become quieter the farther north they went.

“You always do this.”

“What?”

“Turn into your younger self without admitting it.”

“I’m driving.”

“That is not a personality.”

“You do it too.”

“I am a doctor. I am paid to be calm.”

“Is that a personality?”

“After twenty-five years it is.”

The family house remained at the edge of the old town.

Paint newer than Rahman remembered.

Roof repaired.

Garden smaller.

His younger sister Rohani lived in Ipoh now but refused to sell the house after their mother died.

She arrived an hour after them with keys and questions.

“What is this about?”

“Abah may have kept papers for someone.”

Rohani looked at him.

“Police?”

“Maybe.”

“Harun?”

Rahman stopped.

“You remember him?”

“Tall. Quiet. Came once.”

Mariam looked at Rahman.

He looked at Rohani.

“When?”

“Long time ago. Before Abah got sick.”

“Did they know each other?”

“I don’t know. Abah said he was your police friend.”

“My senior.”

Rohani unlocked the back room.

"Abah kept everything."

That was true.

Old school timetables.

Repair receipts.

Insurance letters.

School photographs.

Plastic folders with labels written in neat block capitals.

No secret archive.

No coded files.

A father's ordinary bureaucracy.

In the second folder he found his own school reports.

Standard One to Form Five, in order, each stapled in the top left corner. Every one signed in the same block capitals, the way a teacher signs a thing he intends to be read.

Under Standard Six, in pencil, small, in the margin where no examiner would look, his father had written: Too serious. Let him laugh more.

Rahman held the page for longer than he meant to.

Rohani appeared in the doorway with a plate of cut mango from next door.

"He wrote that on everyone's," she said.

"Did he?"

"No." She put the plate on the table. "Only yours."

The green metal trunk sat beneath folded prayer mats in the wardrobe.

Rahman remembered it.

His mother had kept blankets inside.

Rohani said, "After Mak died, I moved documents there."

"Did you open everything?"

"Mostly."

"Anything marked Harun?"

"No."

They carried the trunk to the dining room.

Inside:

Land papers.

Birth certificates.

Death certificates.

Old salary statements.

A teacher's long-service medal.

At the bottom, one brown envelope.

No name on front.

On the back:

MAN — IF NEEDED.

Rahman did not touch it immediately.

Mariam stood beside him.

"Breathe."

He looked at her.

"I am breathing."

"Poorly."

He opened the envelope.

Three photocopied documents.

One newspaper clipping.

One handwritten note.

Aziz bin Mahmud's handwriting.

Rahman knew it before reading.

If you are the one reading this, then probably Harun never came back for these.

Rahman sat.

Rohani went quiet.

The note continued.

He asked me to keep papers because he said police storage was not safe enough for all copies. He did not tell me what was inside. I did not ask. Perhaps I should have.

A father also makes mistakes when he thinks he is protecting his son.

If somebody comes asking and you do not trust him, burn this.

If it is you, use your judgment.

Rahman stopped at the final line.

Kalau kau tak boleh ubah dunia, jangan jadi orang yang menambah kerosakan.

If you cannot change the world, don't become another source of its damage.

His father's sentence.

The one Rahman had carried for decades.

Mariam sat opposite him.

Rohani looked confused.

"What is it?"

Rahman handed her the note.

She read.

Then looked at him.

"I knew the envelope existed."

"You did?"

"Abah said don't trouble Man unless needed."

Rahman felt something twist.

"He said that?"

"He always said you carried enough."

Mariam looked at him.

The sentence was not kind.

Not cruel.

True.

The three documents were duplicates.

Nothing new.

A Nasir company extract.

A 1998 payment summary.

An incomplete relationship diagram.

Harun's archive already contained versions.

No hidden names.

No confession.

No proof Rahman's father knew anything about the investigation.

The clipping was an old newspaper article about a smuggling investigation.

Harun's name appeared once.

On the back, Aziz had written:

This is the man.

That was all.

Aisyah joined by secure call after Rahman photographed the contents without moving them further.

"Provenance?"

"Family house. Envelope stored by father. Sister knew envelope existed, not contents."

"Any sign he added material?"

"No."

"Any evidence he participated in investigation?"

"No."

"Then record safekeeping only."

Rahman heard the firmness.

She was protecting Aziz from his son's imagination too.

"Agreed."

They arranged formal collection the next morning.

Not in Rahman's private possession.

Chain.

Photographs.

Rohani's statement.

Mariam's witness statement.

Rahman's conflict disclosure.

It felt excessive until Rahman imagined someone years later asking whether he had inserted the documents himself.

Then it felt necessary.

That evening, he and Mariam walked to the old bus station.

The building had been renovated badly.

The roofline survived.

So did the tea stall at the corner, under new ownership.

Rahman stood where he had once waited for the afternoon bus home from his father's school.

Mariam said, "He was trying to protect you."

"Yes."

"And Harun."

"Yes."

"And himself?"

Rahman looked at her.

"I don't know."

"There."

"What?"

"You always stop one question early when the answer might make someone you love smaller."

He looked away.

Mariam continued.

"Your father took secret police papers into your family home."

"Duplicates."

"Still."

“He didn’t know what they were.”

“He says that.”

“You don’t believe him?”

“I believe him.”

“That is not the point.”

Rahman looked at her.

Mariam’s voice softened.

“People can love you and still hurt you.”

The sentence landed.

Rahman thought of his father.

Harun.

Farid.

Aisyah.

Himself.

“You think I do the same thing.”

“Yes.”

“Protect people?”

“Control what they are allowed to know.”

“That is sometimes necessary.”

“Exactly.”

He almost smiled despite himself.

She continued.

“You keep using the emergency rule for ordinary life.”

Rahman looked at the old station.

“I thought I was protecting you.”

“I know.”

“Hana. Adam.”

“I know.”

“That matters.”

“Yes.”

Mariam stepped closer.

“But reasons do not undo cost.”

He had no answer.

For years, operational secrecy had given Rahman a clean language for distance.

Need-to-know.

Protection.

Risk.

Source safety.

Family safety.

All real.

All useful.

All capable of hiding fear.

Mariam asked, “What are you afraid of now?”

Rahman almost gave the old answer.

That the case was compromised.

That The Circle had survived thirty years.

That someone inside MNPS had killed or betrayed people.

Instead he said:

“That Harun may have died because he saw something the institution decided to carry instead of expose.”

Mariam listened.

“That Farid knows more.”

“Yes.”

“That I have made decisions I distrust in him.”

She nodded.

“That I cannot tell anymore when I am protecting people and when I am protecting myself.”

Mariam said nothing for a long time.

Then:

“That one sounds useful.”

Rahman looked at her.

“You are very cruel for a doctor.”

“I charge extra.”

He almost laughed.

The next morning, Aisyah arrived from Kota Aruna with an IID evidence officer.

She wore no triumph.

No intrusion.

Only procedure.

Rohani gave her statement.

Mariam hers.

Rahman signed conflict acknowledgment.

Aisyah sealed the envelope.

Before closing the bag, she looked at Aziz's note one last time.

"Your father's line."

"Yes."

"You use it often?"

"Not aloud."

"Maybe you should."

Rahman looked at her.

She did not know she was investigating him more deeply than he knew.

That secret sat between them.

He could not see it yet.

Aisyah sealed the bag.

On the drive south, Mariam asked:

"What did your father give you?"

Rahman looked out at the road.

"Nothing new."

"You know that is not what I mean."

He did.

Harun had given Aziz papers.

Aziz had given Rahman silence.

Or perhaps Rahman had inherited the same method from both men.

Carry it alone.

Protect others by deciding what they can bear.

Keep copies.

Keep secrets.

Do not trouble the people you love unless needed.

Maybe his father had not only given him a moral rule.

Maybe he had given him the silence too.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

THE BARGAIN

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Farid asked to meet without phones.

Rahman did not refuse.

He did tell Aisyah where he was going.

Farid drove.

Not official transport.

An older dark-blue sedan.

They left Kota Aruna after dusk and stopped at a government rest house overlooking the river.

The building was mostly unused.

One caretaker.

No sign-in because Farid knew him.

That detail bothered Rahman.

He noted it mentally.

Inside, the lights were yellow and weak.

Farid poured water.

No tea.

No staff.

Rahman stayed standing.

“What is this?”

Farid looked at him.

“Case 17/94 was not wrong.”

The sentence entered quietly.

Rahman did not move.

Farid continued.

“The old network existed.”

Rahman stared.

"Circle?"

"No."

The correction came immediately.

"That word came later."

"Stop correcting the word."

"It matters."

Rahman sat.

"Fine. Network."

Farid nodded.

"Enough of it was real to justify Harun's concern."

"Enough?"

"Transport. protection. gambling. smuggling. information. commercial intermediaries. police contacts."

"You knew."

"Yes."

"How much?"

"Less than Harun thought I knew. More than I told you."

Rahman felt anger arrive cleanly.

"You restricted it."

"We restricted parts of it."

"Who is we?"

Farid looked toward the dark window.

"People above me. People beside me. Sometimes me."

There.

Not full confession.

Enough.

"Why?"

"Because Harun's map was not only criminals."

Rahman said nothing.

"It included legitimate businesses. authorised police contacts. undercover channels. lawyers in source arrangements. informants. people whose names meant different things in different files."

"And corrupt officers."

"Yes."

"Criminal intermediaries."

"Yes."

"People who made evidence disappear."

"Some."

"Witnesses disappeared."

Farid's face tightened.

"Yes."

"So you buried it."

"No."

Rahman almost laughed.

Farid continued.

"We contained it."

"Same word."

"Different act."

"Explain the difference to Hafiz."

Farid looked at him.

Rahman continued.

"Faiz is dead. Salmah disappeared. Zafir left seven minutes before we entered. Amirul was compromised. Farhan was dirty. Our own vulnerability review ended up in a gambling office."

Farid said quietly, "I know."

"And you still want to defend containment."

"I want you to understand why it existed."

Rahman stood.

"I understand why people say it."

"No."

Farid remained seated.

"You understand the moral argument. You do not understand the operational cost of total exposure."

"Then tell me."

Farid took a breath.

"Some names in 17/94 were active intelligence contacts."

"Yes."

"Some police officers were conducting authorised work that looked corrupt if stripped of source context."

"Yes."

"Some companies were being used by us while being used by criminals."

Rahman's jaw tightened.

"Convenient."

"True."

"According to who?"

"According to records that still exist."

"Show them."

"I will where law permits."

"That sentence is why we are here."

Farid looked at him.

"If we had exposed everything in 2000, some informants would have died."

Rahman said nothing.

"Undercover operations would have collapsed. Pending prosecutions would have been compromised. Innocent officers would have been named beside guilty ones. Criminals would have learned our methods."

"Yes."

Farid leaned forward.

"And the public would have received one simple story because simple stories travel."

Rahman sat again.

"That does not justify thirty years."

"No."

The answer came too quickly.

Rahman stopped.

Farid looked tired.

"Not thirty years."

"Then when did it stop being justified?"

Farid did not answer.

That silence mattered more than argument.

Rahman said, "You helped decide what remained hidden."

"Yes."

"You knew police were compromised."

"Yes."

"You knew relationships persisted."

"Yes."

"You used intelligence from the same environment."

Farid looked at him.

"Sometimes."

"Against what?"

"Larger threats."

"What does that mean?"

"Arms movement. trafficking. organised violence. cross-border narcotics. situations where closing one channel immediately would have cost us access to something worse."

Rahman stared.

Farid continued.

"You think law, intelligence and institutional survival always point in the same direction."

"No."

"You used to."

"Maybe."

"They do not."

"That does not mean you choose secrecy forever."

"No."

Farid stood now.

"Some systems survive because somebody manages damage."

Rahman heard the philosophy beneath the sentence.

Not greed.

Not envelopes.

Not personal wealth.

Management.

Containment.

Someone deciding which harm the institution could live with.

"Did you protect criminals?"

"I protected channels."

"That is not an answer."

"Sometimes the channel was a criminal."

"Did you protect corrupt police?"

Farid paused.

"Sometimes we moved people rather than expose them because immediate exposure would compromise wider work."

Rahman felt cold.

"Farhan?"

"No."

The answer was immediate.

"Current?"

“No. I am speaking historically.”

“Names.”

“No.”

“Why?”

“Because some records remain source-protected.”

Rahman laughed once.

“Still.”

“Yes.”

The rest house felt suddenly smaller.

Farid walked to the window.

“I did not bring you here to confess.”

“Then why?”

“To ask you to close ORION.”

Rahman looked at him.

There it was.

“Close.”

“Restructure.”

“Same effect.”

“No.”

“What do you want?”

“Use the successes.”

“Which?”

“Badrul. warehouse. Farhan. Current criminal conduct.”

“Arrest individuals.”

“Yes.”

“Discipline corrupt officers.”

“Yes.”

“Prosecute what can be proved.”

“Yes.”

“And the architecture?”

Farid turned.

“Do not expose thirty years of intelligence history as one institutional scandal.”

Rahman stared.

“Why?”

“Because you cannot separate all legitimate secrecy from corruption yet.”

“Then we separate it.”
“Quietly.”
“No.”
Farid’s face did not change.
“Review old police links discreetly.”
“Inside the same institution that contained them?”
“Yes.”
“Why should I trust that?”
“You should not.”
The answer stopped Rahman.
Farid continued.
“You should trust procedure where it still works.”
Rahman thought of leaked documents.
Missing phones.
Altered exports.
“Which part?”
“The part that still works.”
Farid’s voice was almost pleading now.
Not for himself.
That was worse.
“You think I am protecting my career.”
“Aren’t you?”
“No.”
“Your decisions?”
“Some.”
“Your reputation?”
“Less than you think.”
“Then what?”
“The institution.”
Rahman looked at him.
Farid said, “Public trust collapses faster than it rebuilds.”
“Trust built on hidden corruption is not trust.”
“Trust can survive imperfection.”
“Not if imperfection is being managed as policy.”
Farid looked away.
The river outside was black.
Rahman said, “Rahim Nasir.”

Farid turned.
“You knew him professionally.”
“Yes.”
“Useful contact.”
“Yes.”
“Source?”
“No.”
“Asset?”
“No.”
“Leader?”
“No evidence.”
“Alive?”
Farid’s expression shifted.
Small.
Genuine surprise again.
“I told you. I thought he died.”
“You believed the record?”
“Yes.”
“You never questioned it?”
“No reason.”
“The man at Idris’s retirement—”
“May be another man.”
“Yes.”
Rahman watched him.
Farid was not pretending certainty.
That mattered.
“Harun.”
Farid’s face closed.
“What about him?”
“You were involved after he died.”
Farid did not answer.
Rahman felt it.
“You were.”
“I was informally involved in the inquiry.”
“What inquiry?”
“Circumstances. files. source exposure.”
“Did you believe suicide?”

Farid looked toward the river again.

"Some truths arrive too late."

Rahman stood.

"That is not an answer."

"No."

"What do you know?"

"Enough to know I should have acted earlier."

"On what?"

Farid looked at him.

"Not tonight."

Rahman felt anger sharpen.

"You ask me to close ORION and still keep the one thing that might explain Harun."

"I am asking you not to destroy living operations with dead uncertainty."

"That is exactly what you asked Harun."

Farid did not deny it.

Rahman moved toward the door.

Farid said, "Containment did not fail completely."

Rahman stopped.

"Hafiz is dead."

"Yes."

"Salmah is gone."

"Yes."

"Your argument survived better than they did."

Farid's jaw tightened.

Rahman continued.

"If this network still exists after thirty years, containment failed."

Farid said, "Not entirely."

That was the sentence Rahman carried out of the rest house.

Not entirely.

As if avoided disasters could be weighed against corruption that survived.

Maybe they could.

That was the problem.

Farid's argument was not absurd.

It was dangerous because it was partly true.

On the drive back, Rahman's phone remained where he had left it.

Mariam's message waited.

Home tonight?

Rahman typed:

Yes. I'll tell you what I can.

Then he called Aisyah.

She answered immediately.

"Well?"

"Farid knows the old network was real."

Silence.

"And?"

"He knows more."

"What do we do?"

Rahman looked through the windscreen at Kota Aruna approaching.

"We prove what he knows."

He ended the call.

When traffic slowed at the Kota Aruna toll he took out his notebook and wrote three lines, because on days like this he trusted ink more than memory.

The network was real.

Harun had known it.

Farid had known that Harun knew.

Then, below, he wrote a fourth line and looked at it for a long time.

Why nine days?

Harun's inquiry had closed in nine days. Men who died by their own hand were mourned for longer than that. Cases closed faster only when someone needed them closed.

He did not write the name of who that someone might be. He had a strict rule against writing names he could not prove.

But the pen had stopped, for a moment, on the last letter of the word days, and he understood that he already knew whose office a nine-day inquiry would have crossed.

Farid had spent years deciding what silence was for.

Rahman understood now that the next fight was not only over hidden facts.

It was over who had the right to decide which truths an institution could survive.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

THE BETRAYAL

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Rahman learned Aisyah had been investigating him from a folder with his name on it.

Not from Aisyah.

He could not forgive that part at first.

SAC Razak called him to IID at 09:10.

No explanation.

When Rahman entered the office, Aisyah was already there.

One chair between them.

One sealed folder on the desk.

RAHMAN AZIZ.

Razak did not soften the opening.

“This is a formal disclosure.”

Rahman looked at Aisyah.

She held his gaze.

Razak continued.

“IID has conducted a confidential integrity and vulnerability review of your historical service relevant to ORION.”

Rahman looked back at the folder.

“Who conducted it?”

He already knew.

Razak said, “Inspector Nur Aisyah Othman.”

Silence.

Rahman looked at her again.

“When?”

“Initial screening from ORION start. Enhanced review later.”

“How much later?”

"After the internal compromise indicators strengthened."
"Before 17/94?"
"Yes."
"Before my father's documents?"
"Yes."
The answer hurt unexpectedly.
He had told her things while she was examining him as a subject.
Harun.
Kelana.
His father.
Mariam.
Not operational secrets only.
Parts of himself.
Rahman looked at Razak.
"You authorised it."
"Yes."
"Farid?"
Razak said, "This review was under IID authority."
Narrow answer.
Rahman heard it.
He almost laughed.
Everyone had learned the same language.
Razak pushed the folder toward him.
"You have response rights."
Rahman did not touch it.
"Any corruption finding?"
"No."
"Leak?"
"No evidence you leaked ORION."
"Money?"
"No unexplained benefit."
"Target warning?"
"No evidence."
"Then what?"
Razak looked at Aisyah.
"You explain."
She opened the folder.

Her voice was precise.

"Historical service shows recurring procedural exceptions where you exercised discretion beyond or ahead of ordinary authority."

Rahman said, "2006."

"Yes."

"Musa Halim."

"Yes."

She placed two records side by side.

The general operational report.

The restricted supervisory note.

Rahman looked at them.

Aisyah said, "The general report did not foreground that detention had been authorised and you delayed it without approval."

"It did not lie."

"No."

"The restricted note recorded it."

"Yes."

"So what is the finding?"

"That the institution remembered the success more than the breach."

Rahman looked at her.

"That is not my misconduct."

"No. The breach is."

"Documented."

"Yes."

"Then why am I here?"

Aisyah's face did not change.

"Because good outcome does not retroactively make breach non-breach."

Rahman felt irritation sharpen.

"You think I don't know that?"

"I think your career benefited from the result."

"That is not the same."

"No."

She held his gaze.

"But the question is whether you recognise the boundary before harm occurs, not only afterward."

Rahman sat back.

Razak said nothing.

Aisyah moved to the next file.

2008.

An interdiction deferred while Rahman expected contact with a higher-priority subject.

Target later lost.

Rahman claimed verbal authorisation from Superintendent Jalil.

Jalil was dead.

No written confirmation.

Rahman said, “He authorised it.”

“I cannot verify.”

“That does not mean he didn’t.”

“I know.”

“Then write that.”

“I did.”

She showed him.

AUTHORITY CLAIM UNVERIFIED — NOT CONTRADICTED.

Fair.

Rahman hated that it was fair.

Next.

2011.

A source was protected from prosecution on a lesser offence.

Case scope narrowed.

The source later provided information that helped prevent an armed robbery.

Aisyah asked, “Who authorised the evidentiary narrowing?”

Rahman looked at the note.

“Operational command.”

“Written?”

“Not fully.”

“Who?”

He gave the name.

Retired.

Available.

She had already requested verification.

No accusation.

Only gap.

Then 2014.

That one changed him.

A compromised-deployment test.

Rahman had suspected an operational schedule was leaking.

He altered exposure.

Allowed a deployment to proceed partly to observe information movement.

Junior officers were not told the full integrity-test purpose.

No one was hurt.

Target location was empty.

Analysis later proved useful.

Farid had been copied but had not explicitly approved the test.

Aisyah said, “Whose decision?”

“Mine.”

“Authority?”

“Command discretion.”

“For deploying officers into a situation partly designed as an integrity test without telling them?”

Rahman’s jaw tightened.

“They were not sent into greater tactical danger.”

“That is not the only risk.”

“No.”

“Would you accept the same decision from a subordinate?”

Rahman stopped.

The room became quiet.

“Depending on circumstances.”

“That is not an answer.”

He looked at her.

She waited.

“No,” he said.

Aisyah nodded once.

There.

Not triumph.

Record.

Rahman felt anger move toward her because the question had worked.

He disliked himself for that.

Aisyah closed the file.

“I found no evidence you took money.”

“No evidence you sold information.”

“No evidence you fabricated evidence.”

“No evidence you warned criminal targets for personal benefit.”

“No evidence your family received improper benefit.”

Rahman looked at her.

“So you believe I’m clean.”

Aisyah shook her head.

“That is not what integrity review means.”

“What does it mean?”

“That corruption is not the only danger.”

Rahman stared.

She continued.

“You make private decisions when you believe you are the safest person to carry the consequence.”

“Sometimes somebody has to.”

“Yes.”

“You did too. This review.”

Aisyah’s face changed slightly.

“I was authorised.”

“So was Farid, often.”

The sentence landed between them.

Aisyah did not retreat.

“If you stop believing the rules apply to you because you’re the good man in the room, you’re becoming Farid.”

Rahman went still.

Razak looked at her.

Not warning.

Attention.

Rahman said quietly, “I am not Farid.”

“I did not say you are.”

“You just did.”

“I said there is a road.”

Silence.

Aisyah continued.

“Farid’s problem is not that every exception he made was wrong.”

Rahman knew that.
“His problem is that exceptions became his authority.”
Rahman looked away.
Harun.
Aziz.
Farid.
Himself.
Protection by deciding what others could know.
What they could bear.
What rules could wait.
The comparison hurt because it was not ridiculous.
That was why he hated it.
Rahman asked, “Did you think I was the leak?”
“Yes.”
The answer was immediate.
“Do you now?”
“No evidence supports it.”
“That is not what I asked.”
Aisyah looked at him.
“I considered the possibility you were compromised.”
“By money?”
“No.”
“Then?”
“Reputation. Harun. family. ORION. your own past decisions.”
He stared.
“Family?”
“General vulnerability only. No evidence anyone targeted them.”
“You reviewed them.”
“Only to establish whether benefit or targeting existed.”
Rahman stood.
“That was not yours to do.”
“It was exactly mine to do.”
Razak intervened.
“Enough.”
Rahman turned.
Razak said, “You demanded ORION exempt no one.”
“I did.”

"You are not exempt."

"I know."

"Then do not destroy the working relationship because procedure made it uncomfortable."

Rahman looked at Aisyah.

"Procedure did not sit beside me while I opened my father's envelope."

Aisyah's face tightened for the first time.

"No."

"You knew."

"Yes."

"And said nothing."

"I was not authorised to disclose the review."

"Did you want to?"

A pause.

"Yes."

That made it worse in a different way.

Razak stood.

"I'm leaving you both in this room for ten minutes. Neither of you will make an employment decision during those ten minutes."

He left.

The door closed.

Rahman remained standing.

Aisyah sat.

"You could have recused."

"Yes."

"Why didn't you?"

"Because if ORION's integrity officer recused from the commander because she trusted him, then our integrity system was performance."

Rahman said nothing.

"I was afraid," she added.

That surprised him.

"Of me?"

"Of what I might find."

"Because you thought I was corrupt."

"Because I had started trusting you."

Rahman looked at her.

The anger did not disappear.
It changed shape.
“You answered me narrowly.”
“Yes.”
“You never lied.”
“No.”
“That is a lawyer’s defence.”
“It is also true.”
Rahman almost laughed.
He had used the same defence in reports for years.
Not false.
Incomplete emphasis.
Aisyah had mirrored him.
He hated that too.
Razak returned.
Rahman sat.
“I don’t trust her at the moment.”
Aisyah looked down once.
Rahman continued.
“But I trust her work.”
Razak said nothing.
“I want the review to continue.”
Aisyah looked up.
Razak asked, “With her?”
Rahman paused.
This was the moment.
He could ask for another investigator.
Procedurally reasonable.
Emotionally satisfying.
“No.”
Aisyah’s face changed.
Rahman corrected:
“No change. She continues.”
Razak nodded.
“Good.”
Rahman gave him a look.
“Stop saying that.”

For the first time, Razak almost smiled.

The damage did not vanish.

Back in SOC 4, Rahman excluded Aisyah from Daniel's afternoon review.

He did it without thinking.

"Daniel. Rafiq. With me."

Aisyah looked up.

"Do you need me?"

"No."

The word came too fast.

She watched him leave.

Ten minutes into the review, Rahman realised what he had done.

Punishment.

Not evidence-based access control.

Anger disguised as command.

He stopped mid-sentence.

"Get Aisyah."

Rafiq looked at him.

"She's downstairs."

"Get her."

Aisyah arrived five minutes later.

She stood near the door.

Rahman said, "Sit."

She did.

After the meeting, she remained.

"You excluded me."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"I was angry."

"That is not a procedural reason."

"No."

"Will it happen again?"

"I don't know."

She looked at him.

Rahman exhaled.

"I will try not to let it."

"That is better."

He looked at her.

“The part I am angriest about is knowing exactly what you meant by Farid.”

Aisyah said nothing.

That evening, Rahman opened the old manual containing the six-name list.

He added beneath it:

Being willing to suspect yourself is not the same as being willing to be judged.

Then:

Outcome does not erase breach.

Then:

If exception is necessary, record it. Accept consequence.

He closed the manual.

At home, Mariam listened while he told her enough.

“Aisyah investigated you.”

“Yes.”

“Properly?”

Rahman looked at her.

“That is your first question?”

“Yes.”

He laughed once without humour.

“She is cruel.”

Mariam waited.

“And she is not entirely wrong.”

“About Farid?”

Rahman looked away.

“She said I’m on the road.”

Mariam shook her head.

“No.”

“No?”

“She said there is a road. You heard a destination.”

Rahman looked at her.

Mariam continued.

“Are you willing to be reviewed?”

“Yes.”

“Really?”

He thought of the 2014 operation.

The officers not told.

The success that had made the decision easier to remember than the breach.

“Apparently not as much as I thought.”

The next morning, he submitted his written response.

He disputed two findings factually.

Requested verification on three authority claims.

Accepted four procedural breaches.

On the 2014 deployment, he wrote:

I request this operation be reviewed again as my command decision. Operational benefit and absence of injury do not remove the question of whether personnel were exposed to an undisclosed integrity-test purpose without sufficient authority.

Then:

If rules only matter when they protect me from other people, they are not rules.

He signed.

Delivered it to Razak.

Then went to SOC 4.

Aisyah was at her desk.

Rahman stopped beside her.

“I still think you should have told me.”

“I know.”

“I’m not over it.”

“I know.”

“If you find something else, follow it.”

She looked at him.

“You’re sure?”

“No.”

He held her gaze.

“Do it anyway.”

Aisyah nodded.

Trust was not restored.

Something more useful had replaced part of it.

Neither could pretend the other was innocent of secrecy now.

The betrayal had not disappeared.

It had become part of the record.

And for once, Rahman did not ask anyone to make the record cleaner than the truth.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

THE LIST

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Daniel stopped using names first.

The list began there.

The Harun archive had created too many people.

Some dead.

Some retired.

Some innocent.

Some compromised.

Some impossible to classify without turning a thirty-year history into accusation by diagram.

So Daniel opened a blank model and wrote four words.

OPERATORS.

BROKERS.

KEEPERS.

PROTECTORS.

Aisyah read them.

“Working categories?”

“Yes.”

“Not membership?”

“Yes.”

“Not guilt?”

“Yes.”

“Put that on the screen.”

Daniel sighed.

He added:

FUNCTIONAL ROLE — MAY ROTATE. CATEGORY DOES NOT ESTABLISH CRIMINALITY OR FORMAL MEMBERSHIP.

Rahman entered.

Looked at the four words.

“Keep them ugly.”

Daniel stared.

“They are four words.”

“Do not let the model become more elegant than the evidence.”

Grace joined them with financial records.

They were Latif Murni’s. Three years of payments from the eastern region disposal tender, passing through subcontractors into small accounts with names like staff welfare fund and community outreach.

“Every transfer is inside the tender rules,” Grace said. “That is what makes it elegant.”

“Operator?” Rafiq asked.

“It does not run anything. It carries things.”

“Keeper, then?”

Daniel shook his head. “It holds nothing. It forgets very efficiently. That is the service.”

Rahman thought of a hospital bill paid for a constable who had said he did not know the company, and of a journalist at a Sunday table asking, politely, how a tender was won. He said nothing about the second. It was not ORION’s information.

But he saw that he had begun to keep a list of what he did not say, and that it was getting longer.

Rafiq arrived halfway through.

The first category was easiest.

Operators.

The visible layer.

Gambling rooms.

Smuggling crews.

Fraud operations.

Warehouses.

Trafficking routes.

People who committed the underlying crimes or ran the businesses used to support them.

Zafir Razak fit partly.

Not because every part of RZ Meridian was criminal.

Because evidence now tied parts of its operation to facilitation.

Badrul sat uncertainly at the edge.

Raziq Jamal too.

Different confidence levels.

Aisyah insisted every name carry one.

HIGH.

MODERATE.

LOW.

UNKNOWN.

No visual red colour for suspicion.

Daniel complained.

"Colours help."

"They also convict."

He used grey.

Second.

Brokers.

Daniel typed:

CONNECT OTHERWISE SEPARATE PEOPLE / SERVICES / INTERESTS.

Kelana fit.

But not always.

BROKER / INFORMANT / HISTORICAL INTERMEDIARY — STATUS VARIABLE.

Rahim Nasir:

BROKER? / POSSIBLE HIGH-LEVEL CONNECTOR.

Question mark mandatory.

Aisyah watched Daniel type it.

"Good."

"I know."

Raziq Jamal appeared under modern intermediary activity.

Mansor Rahim too.

Several old names from Harun's notes.

No one became a permanent Broker by title.

The role described conduct.

Third.

Keepers.

That took longer.

Grace said, "Harun's phrase."

"What?"

"People who preserve memory."

Daniel looked at the notebook copy.

Page thirty-seven.

If relationships persist, find the people who preserve memory.

He typed:

KEEPER — PRESERVES OBLIGATION / HISTORY / LEVERAGE / ACCESS MEMORY.

Rafiq frowned.

"A person?"

"Maybe."

"A database?"

"Maybe."

"A lawyer's file?"

"Maybe."

"A family?"

Grace said, "Maybe."

Daniel looked annoyed.

"Very helpful."

Aisyah said, "Financial memory and social memory are not the same."

Daniel nodded.

"Good."

They built two subtypes.

FINANCIAL MEMORY.

RELATIONSHIP MEMORY.

The unknown financial architecture entered here.

Daniel typed:

THE ACCOUNTANT.

Aisyah looked immediately.

"No reveal by typography."

"It is already our label."

"Then qualify it."

He added:

UNKNOWN FINANCIAL ARCHITECT — "THE ACCOUNTANT."

Grace said, "Could still be several professionals."

Daniel looked at her.

"I know."

"You hate it."

"Yes."

Rahman said, "Keep it unresolved."

Daniel typed:

IDENTITY / NUMBER OF ACTORS UNKNOWN.

That was as far as they went.

No role reveal.

No inherited office.

Not yet.

Fourth.

Protectors.

The room changed.

Daniel defined:

POSITIONED TO REDUCE / INTERRUPT / REDIRECT CONSEQUENCE.

Rafiq said, "Police."

"Sometimes."

"Who else?"

Aisyah answered.

"Regulators. business executives. lawyers. administrators. anyone with legitimate authority capable of changing consequence."

Daniel added examples without names.

Delay.

Restrict.

Warn.

Transfer.

Reclassify.

Bury.

Redirect.

Legitimise.

Grace said, "Some of those are legitimate."

Rahman looked at her.

"That is what makes it dangerous."

Silence.

A source protector could delay disclosure lawfully.

A corrupt officer could do the same thing for money.

A commander could transfer someone to protect an investigation.

Or to avoid scandal.

Same act shape.

Different intent.

Different consequence.

Sometimes impossible to distinguish quickly.

Rafiq pointed to Farhan.

“Protector.”

Aisyah shook her head.

“No.”

“He warned people.”

“He passed information.”

“Same effect.”

“Not same function.”

Daniel looked interested.

Aisyah continued.

“He was a compromised access point. Information broker, maybe. But he did not control consequence at the institutional level.”

Rafiq said, “Then add access points.”

Daniel started typing.

Rahman stopped him.

“No.”

“Why?”

“Access is what all four use.”

They looked at him.

Rahman continued.

“Operator needs access to goods, territory, customers.”

“Broker to people.”

“Keeper to memory.”

“Protector to consequence.”

Daniel slowly deleted ACCESS POINTS.

“That is annoyingly good.”

Rahman ignored him.

The model created the first insight that frightened the room.

Daniel said it while looking at the police names.

“The Circle never needed the police.”

Rafiq frowned.

“What?”

"Not the service."

Daniel stood.

"It never needed to control MNPS."

He pointed at the categories.

"One officer who can see movement schedules."

"One person who delays evidence."

"One person who warns about a transfer."

"One person who can change the context of a file."

Aisyah said, "Strategically placed points."

"Yes."

Daniel looked at Rahman.

"It did not need thousands of corrupt policemen."

Rahman understood.

"Only one in the right place."

"At the right time," Aisyah said.

The room went quiet.

That made the institution less corrupt than paranoia suggested.

And more vulnerable than comfort allowed.

Most officers could be honest.

Most administrators could do their jobs properly.

A network could survive on exceptions.

Strategic minorities.

Rafiq sat back.

"That is worse."

"No," Rahman said.

"It is different."

It meant the service was not captured.

It meant it could still be penetrated.

Those were not the same thing.

Daniel rebuilt the police entries.

No suspect category.

Only observed or possible functions.

Aisyah insisted on one line at the top:

ACCESS IS NOT PROTECTION. OPPORTUNITY IS NOT COMPROMISE.

They narrowed the Protector list to historical actions supported by more than one record.

Five possible active interventions across the old archive.

Not forty-three police names.

Five.

That mattered.

One cluster contained initials.

F.K.

Daniel brought up Harun's notes.

F.K. — restriction.

Another:

F.K. — source objection / no action.

Another:

F.K. — protect channel?

Question mark.

Routing sheet:

Reviewed: F. Kamal.

Harun note:

F.K. argues exposure will collapse larger map.

Rafiq said, "Farid."

Rahman replied, "Likely."

"Likely?"

"Not certainly."

Daniel searched the archive index.

Seven F.K. occurrences.

Three unquestionably Farid by context.

Two likely.

Two ambiguous.

None said bribery.

None said Circle.

None said criminal protection directly.

They clustered around restriction, delay, source protection and controlled dissemination.

One:

F.K. recommends no criminal referral pending broader intelligence assessment.

Another:

F.K. says too early.

Daniel leaned back.

"That is Protector."

Grace said, “It can also be legitimate protection.”

Rahman looked at the screen.

“That is the problem.”

Rafiq said, “He is either protecting the network or protecting operations.”

Aisyah shook her head.

“False binary.”

“What else?”

“Both at different times.”

Silence.

That was worse.

Rahman looked at Farid’s history.

A person could begin by protecting a source.

Then an operation.

Then the unit.

Then the institution.

“Eventually,” he said, “they may fail to notice when they start protecting the relationship itself.”

Nobody spoke.

Daniel asked, “Put Farid under Protector?”

“No.”

“Why?”

“Category is not accusation.”

“He matches.”

“Functionally.”

“So?”

“Intent unknown.”

Daniel looked frustrated.

Rahman dictated:

F.K. — POSSIBLE PROTECTOR FUNCTION / INTENT UNKNOWN.

Rafiq said, “That is almost useless.”

Aisyah replied, “No. It is honest.”

Rahman nodded.

The distinction felt harder after her review of him.

Good outcome.

Bad process.

Necessary exception.

Unnecessary secrecy.

Same problem.

Different scale.

They tested the model against police names.

Forty-three historical officers appeared somewhere in Harun's material.

Twelve had repeated suspicious access or proximity.

Five had possible active interventions supported by more than one record.

Five.

Not an army.

Not a captured institution.

Daniel said, "Strategic minorities."

Grace nodded.

"Exceptions."

Rahman looked at the number.

Most officers had done their jobs.

That truth mattered as much as corruption.

If ORION ever exposed the pattern, it could not turn honest police into collateral damage for a cleaner scandal.

Aisyah built the final matrix.

PERSON.

PERIOD.

ROLE.

EVIDENCE CONFIDENCE.

KNOWN BENEFIT.

KNOWN ACCESS.

RELATIONSHIPS.

ALTERNATIVE EXPLANATION.

Daniel frowned at the last column.

"You enjoy making my work weaker."

"I enjoy showing where it can break."

Farid's alternative explanation:

Legitimate intelligence containment / source protection / institutional risk management.

Rahim Nasir:

Successful legitimate connector in relationship-heavy sector.

Kelana:
Informant / criminal intermediary / survival behaviour.
The Accountant:
Multiple professionals using recurring method.
Daniel stared at the last line.
“I object.”
“On evidence?”
“Emotionally.”
“It stays.”
Late in the afternoon, Grace found the strongest F.K. note yet.
Back of a duplicate financial sheet.
Around 2000 or 2001.
Harun’s handwriting.
F.K. not taking money?
Below:
says protection is for institution
Then:
danger may be that he believes it
No accusation.
No source cited.
Harun’s opinion.
Rahman felt the sentence move through him.
Farid at the rest house.
Protect the part that still works.
Daniel said, “That is him.”
Rahman replied, “That is Harun’s view of him.”
“Still.”
“No.”
Rahman looked at the note.
“Historical analyst opinion. Not evidence.”
Aisyah watched him.
He could feel the comparison to his own review.
Intent.
Motive.
Reputation.
No shortcuts.
Daniel logged it exactly that way.

HISTORICAL ANALYST OPINION — NOT INDEPENDENTLY ESTABLISHED.

Later, Aisyah stood beside Rahman while Daniel saved the final model.

“What changed?” she asked.

“About?”

“Farid.”

Rahman looked at the initials.

“I already suspected him.”

“Yes.”

“Context changed.”

“How?”

Rahman thought before speaking.

“Farid is not just someone who may have hidden information.”

Aisyah waited.

“He may have built a career around deciding when information should be hidden.”

“That may still be legitimate.”

“Yes.”

“His job required it.”

“Yes.”

“A legitimate Protector and a compromised Protector can look identical until motive or consequence separates them.”

Rahman nodded.

“Which means we still don’t know what he is.”

“No.”

He looked at the screen.

“We know where to look.”

Daniel saved:

FUNCTIONAL RELATIONSHIP MODEL — WORKING DRAFT.

Below:

This model does not assert formal membership, central command, fixed roles or criminality. Categories describe observed or hypothesised functions only and remain subject to alternative explanations.

Aisyah approved.

Rahman approved.

Cooler now.

More formal after the betrayal.

Also stronger.

They no longer needed trust to mean exemption.

At ten to ten Rafiq's phone rang.

He looked at the screen, then at Rahman, and said nothing, which was how Rahman knew.

The number was one Rahman had never saved because he had never needed to. It belonged to a pay phone outside a Chinese medicine shop in the old quarter. A voice he had known since 1995 spoke without greeting.

"Dato'. Two men asked my landlady how my name is spelled."

"Which name?"

"The first one. The one on the arrest sheet. Nobody has used that spelling since you wrote it."

Rahman understood at once what that meant. Kelana had been invisible for thirty years not because he hid well but because nobody had needed to find Muhammad Khairul. Somebody needed him now.

"Where are you?"

"Where I am is not the question. Where I can be in forty minutes is."

"Name it."

"Not on the phone. You have friends who listen to phones."

Rahman thought, very quickly, about The Circle's only real weapon: it knew when the police were coming. Every raid that had failed, every witness who had vanished, every warehouse with warm food and no people had been the same trick. Information moved faster than the people carrying it.

"Listen," he said. "At eleven you walk to the all-night laundrette on Jalan Kenanga. Go inside and sit by the fourth machine. If a car stops outside, do not get in unless the driver says your mother's name."

"My mother is dead."

"Then he will say it correctly."

He ended the call and took the SIM from the handset, and for the first time in weeks Rafiq saw him do something that looked like pleasure.

"Who knows?" Rafiq asked.

"You. Me."

"Aisyah?"

"Afterwards."

"Daniel?"

"He is going to be annoyed."

It was the cleanest operation Rahman had run in years, and it consisted almost entirely of not telling people things.

They used Rafiq's own car, an unremarkable grey Alza that smelled of air freshener and cold coffee. Sergeant Iskandar followed three hundred metres behind in a rented van. No radios. A burner phone each. At 22:32 Rafiq turned off Jalan Kenanga a block early, parked behind a shuttered tailor's, and sent the address to Iskandar by text message that deleted itself.

Rahman sat in the passenger seat with the window down an inch and listened to the street.

A food-delivery rider cut through the lane. A cat on a car roof. Two schoolboys in uniform, out far too late, sharing a bag of fried bananas.

At 22:51 a grey Hilux rolled past the laundrette and parked on the far side of the road with its lights off.

"Wait," Rahman said.

Rafiq had already stopped breathing.

The Hilux sat there. Two men inside. Neither got out. The one in the passenger seat lit a cigarette and held it below the dash so the glow would not show, which was a tradecraft mistake and also a clear statement of intent.

"They weren't told by us," Rafiq said.

"No."

"They've been following him all day."

"Probably since the landlady."

Through the laundrette's fogged glass Rahman could see a thin figure in a faded shirt sitting at the fourth machine, one hand resting on a plastic bag of nothing at all. He was watching the dryer turn as if it were the most interesting thing he had seen in a decade. Only the very still shoulders gave him away.

Kelana had always been good at being looked at without appearing to be seen.

"Plan B," Rafiq said.

"Is there a Plan B?"

"There is now."

Rafiq started the car. He drove it round the block, into the back lane behind the laundrette, and stopped where a delivery door stood half open

to let out the steam. Iskandar's van swung in behind them and parked across the lane mouth. Two men with shopping bags stepped out and stood talking beside it, arguing loudly about football, blocking the view.

Rahman got out and walked through the steam into a room full of tumbling clothes.

Kelana looked up.

For a second neither man said anything. There were thirty years between them and a very small room.

"Dato'. You look like a man who has been reading."

"I have been listening."

"That is worse."

"Your mother's name," Rahman said, "was Zainab."

"Yes."

"Then come."

They went out through the steam in the back and into the lane. Kelana moved the way old informants move, close to the wall, hips turned, as though the street were still a corridor in a building where somebody was waiting. He got into the back of the Alza beside the child's seat and sat very upright, hands on his knees.

The Hilux started its engine as they pulled away.

"Left," Rahman said.

Rafiq turned into the market lane. It was nearly eleven at night and narrow enough that the wing mirrors almost touched the awnings, and the stallholders were hosing down for the morning. A vegetable lorry had been left half across the lane, hazard lights blinking. Rafiq drove through the gap with perhaps a hand's width on either side. Behind them the Hilux did not fit.

Three minutes later they were in a multi-storey car park, and two minutes after that Kelana was in the back of a different car, a white Proton with a family sticker on the bumper, being driven away by someone he had not met.

Rahman sat with him for the first part of that drive.

"Do not say the name," Rahman said. "Not in a car. I do not want it said in a car."

"I was not going to."

"Say it to a judge."

"With a lawyer who isn't yours."

"With whichever lawyer you choose."

Kelana studied him with the tired, appraising look of a man pricing a house he cannot afford.

"You found the tape," he said.

Rahman was careful not to move. "How would you know that?"

"Because you came for me at once. Before you had even decided what to ask." A thin smile. "Harun told me he would never keep it. He said it was too dangerous to be kept. He said it twice. So I knew he had."

They crossed the river. Kota Aruna slid by in orange and black.

"I said I would give you the name when the country could afford it," Kelana said.

"That was thirty years ago."

"It could not afford it then."

"Can it now?"

Kelana looked out of the window.

"Ask me in a week," he said. "If I am still here."

The rest house was on a ridge forty minutes out, an old government property with a gate that someone had repainted last year and a guard who was told only a number. Rahman did not go in. He stood beside the car with his hand on the door, and Kelana got out and stood with him for a moment in the cool dark that smelled of cut grass and wet laterite.

"You carried him a long time," Kelana said.

Rahman did not ask which him.

Then Kelana walked in through the gate with his plastic bag of nothing at all, and the guard closed it behind him.

Rafiq was waiting at the bottom of the hill.

"No one followed."

"Someone did."

"Not to this point."

"No," Rahman said. "Not to this point."

It was not a victory. It was a man not dying on a night when somebody had intended it. In Rahman's experience The Circle did not lose often, and when it did, it did not lose loudly.

He told Aisyah and Daniel at midnight, in SOC 4, with the door closed. Daniel was annoyed, as promised, then silent, then asked whether Kelana had eaten. Aisyah only said, "Who knew about the call?" and Rafiq said, "The three of us," and Aisyah wrote that down.

"You included yourself," she said.

"I included everyone," Rahman said. "That is the point of a list."

He said it lightly. He was not at all certain that it was a joke.

At two in the morning Rahman stood alone in SOC 4.

Four words remained on the screen.

Operator.

Broker.

Keeper.

Protector.

No king.

No master list.

No single permanent mole.

People placed at useful points.

Roles that could change.

Functions that could outlive names.

F.K.

The initials no longer needed imagination.

Most likely, they meant Farid Kamal.

That was not yet the same as knowing what Farid had done.

And Rahman had learned too much, too painfully, to pretend otherwise.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

THE MISSING NAME

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Aisyah found Farid's signature where the name should have been.

That was what changed the case.

Not initials.

Not office authority.

Not an archival code.

His signature.

Blue ink on a photocopied authorisation sheet from 2001.

The document had been tucked behind a source-protection review inside Harun's duplicate archive, folded once and misfiled beneath a transport-company schedule.

At the top:

SPECIAL INTELLIGENCE — RESTRICTED DISSEMINATION ORDER

Subject:

CASE 17/94 / ASSOCIATED COMMERCIAL AND POLICE LINKS

Reason:

Protection of active intelligence relationships and ongoing source exploitation.

Authorising officer:

SUPERINTENDENT FARID KAMAL

Aisyah read the final section twice.

Distribution outside Special Intelligence requires express written authority. No criminal referral to be initiated on intelligence-derived police associations pending validation of source status and operational consequence.

Signed.

Farid Kamal.

Dated 14 March 2001.

She sat very still.

Daniel looked over from the forensic station.

“What?”

Aisyah did not answer.

He came closer.

Read.

Stopped.

“Oh.”

No joke.

That mattered.

Rahman was across the room reviewing the functional matrix.

Aisyah looked toward him.

He saw her face.

Walked over.

She turned the document without speaking.

Rahman read.

Once.

Then again.

His expression did not change.

Daniel said:

“This is direct.”

Aisyah nodded.

Rahman asked:

“Original?”

“Duplicate copy.”

“Can we verify?”

“Already started.”

Daniel pointed to the page.

“Paper ageing consistent. Signature scan can be compared to known contemporaneous Farid documents. Routing code is valid for the period.”

Rahman looked at Aisyah.

“Anything else?”

“Yes.”

She pulled another document.

A 2002 memorandum.

Different file.

Different subject.

A police officer had appeared repeatedly in several intelligence summaries involving logistics contacts.

The memorandum recommended that the officer be referred for formal internal investigation.

At the bottom, a handwritten direction:

Hold referral. Reassign officer from sensitive access. Continue intelligence monitoring. Exposure at this stage risks wider compromise. — F.K.

This one was not a signature.

But the file-routing sheet attached to it recorded:

Directive confirmed by Supt Farid Kamal.

Aisyah said:

"The officer was transferred two weeks later."

"Charged?"

"No."

"Investigated?"

"No formal IID file I can find."

"What happened to him?"

"Retired in 2007."

Daniel added:

"No later major disciplinary finding."

Rahman looked at the memorandum.

"What evidence existed in 2002?"

Aisyah shook her head.

"Partial financial contact. unauthorised access suspicion. two source reports. Enough for referral, apparently. Maybe not enough for charge."

"So Farid could argue transfer reduced risk while preserving intelligence coverage."

"Yes."

"That is not corruption by itself."

"No."

She placed a third record on the table.

"This is worse."

The third document came from a 2004 cross-directorate review.

A commercial intermediary had offered police operational information to an organised-crime source.

The intermediary was connected to two transport businesses.

One later appeared in modern ORION research through a successor company.

The review recommended arrest and controlled public disclosure.

Farid's authorisation changed the outcome.

No overt action. Maintain monitored contact. Information channel assessed as potentially useful against higher-order trafficking subjects.

Signed:

FARID KAMAL

The intermediary remained operational for another three years.

During that period, Special Intelligence reports credited information from the channel with helping identify an arms route through Kota Lagenda and a narcotics transfer corridor in the North Corridor.

Real intelligence value.

Real police success.

No fantasy.

No easy villainy.

Aisyah said:

"He used it."

Rahman looked at her.

"Yes."

"He knew the channel involved police information leakage."

"Yes."

"And still kept it alive."

"Yes."

Daniel said:

"Because it produced higher-value intelligence."

Rahman looked at the documents.

Same logic.

Again.

2001.

2002.

2004.

Not one isolated decision.

Method.

Farid had not merely inherited containment.

He had authorised it.

Repeatedly.

Aisyah said:

"There's more."

Rahman looked up.

She showed him a distribution ledger.

Several 17/94 annexes had been reduced from wider criminal-investigation access to Special Intelligence only.

Farid's office.

Farid's signature.

A later entry recorded:

Selected police-integrity names removed from working circulation pending independent validation.

No record that independent validation had ever occurred.

Rahman read the line.

"What happened to the names?"

"Not in the surviving file."

"Harun's duplicate?"

"Some initials. No full list."

"Official archive?"

"Missing annex."

Daniel said:

"The missing name may not be one person."

Rahman looked at him.

Daniel pointed to the ledger.

"The archive was curated by removal."

Aisyah said:

"Somebody decided certain names did not travel."

Rahman's eyes remained on Farid's signature.

No longer F.K.

No longer possible Protector function.

Farid Kamal.

Directly tied to historical containment.

Still not proof of why every decision had been made.

Still not proof of current criminal collusion.

But enough.

More than enough for confrontation.

Aisyah said:

"We interview him formally."

Rahman looked at her.

"No."

Her face hardened.

"Why?"

"Not yet."

"You have direct authorisation evidence."

"Yes."

"Signed."

"Yes."

"Historical suppression."

"Containment."

"Same effect."

"Not necessarily same intent."

Aisyah stared.

"Rahman."

He heard the warning in her voice.

Farid.

The good man in the room.

Do not become him.

Rahman said:

"I am not protecting Farid."

"Then why private?"

"Because if I put him in an IID room now, he stops talking."

"Maybe he should."

"No."

She looked at him.

Rahman continued.

"We know he made the decisions. We do not yet know how far they went."

"That is what interviews are for."

"Formal interviews make positions."

"Meaning?"

"He becomes subject. We become investigators. Lawyers arrive. Everything narrows to what can be proved as misconduct."

Aisyah's eyes hardened.

"That is the law."

"Yes."

“And?”
“I want to know what he thinks he was doing.”
Daniel said quietly:
“That sounds dangerous.”
Rahman looked at him.
“It is.”
Aisyah crossed her arms.
“You want confession without process.”
“No.”
“You want context before accountability.”
“Yes.”
Her face changed.
The word had history.
Containment.
Mapping.
Wait until we understand more.
Rahman saw it.
“I know what this sounds like.”
“Do you?”
“Yes.”
“Then why repeat it?”
“Because sequencing is not the same as avoidance.”
Aisyah said nothing.
Rahman continued.
“Give me one conversation.”
“Off record?”
“No.”
She looked surprised.
Rahman said:
“I will document immediately after. Time, place, substance.”
“Record it?”
“If possible without destroying the conversation.”
“That is not good enough.”
He held her gaze.
“You can stop me.”
Silence.
She actually considered it.

That mattered.
Finally:
“One conversation.”
Rahman nodded.
“Then formal process.”
“Yes.”
“Regardless of what he says.”
Rahman hesitated.
Aisyah saw.
“Rahman.”
“Yes.”
“Regardless.”
He nodded.
“Regardless.”
Only then did she agree.
Farid chose the meeting place himself.
Not the government rest house.
This time his office.
That surprised Rahman.
No secrecy of location.
No missing phones.
No private vehicle.
Farid’s door remained open when Rahman arrived.
He was reading an intelligence brief.
Ordinary.
Two officers passed outside.
A secretary placed tea on a side table.
Nothing about the room suggested confession.
Farid looked up.
“You found something.”
Rahman closed the door.
Farid watched him.
“No Aisyah?”
“No.”
“No Razak?”
“No.”
“Then this is either personal or unwise.”

"Both."
Farid leaned back.
Rahman placed copies of the authorisation documents on the desk.
Farid read the first.
No visible shock.
Second.
Third.
He did not deny the signature.
He did not ask where the papers came from.
That told Rahman enough.
"You remember them."
"Yes."
"All?"
"Some."
Rahman sat.
"You restricted 17/94."
"Yes."
"Personally."
"Yes."
"You stopped integrity referrals."
"Some."
"You transferred at least one officer instead of investigating him."
"Yes."
"You kept compromised information channels alive."
"Yes."
"Knowing they were compromised."
"Yes."
The answers came without drama.
That unsettled Rahman more than denial would have.
Farid picked up the first document again.
"I wondered whether these copies survived."
"Harun kept them."
Farid looked at him.
"Of course he did."
No contempt.
Almost affection.
Rahman said:

"You knew he was copying."

"I suspected."

"You did nothing."

"Not nothing."

"What?"

"I stopped asking where his duplicates were."

Rahman stared.

Farid looked down at the document.

"He did not trust official custody."

"Was he wrong?"

Farid did not answer.

Rahman leaned forward.

"You knew about the network."

"Yes."

"How early?"

Farid thought.

"By the late nineties, I knew the relationships were real."

Rahman let the answer stand.

He asked instead:

"What did you contain?"

Farid looked at him.

"People."

"Who?"

"Compromised officers."

"How many?"

"Never as many as people imagined."

"Names."

"Some changed."

"Farid."

"Some I never knew."

"Names you knew."

Farid looked tired.

"Officers who took money. officers who traded access. officers who passed information for favours. officers who helped relatives. officers who wanted promotions."

"And you buried them."

"No."

"You stopped referrals."

"Sometimes."

"That is burying."

"No."

Farid's voice remained calm.

"I moved some. monitored some. allowed cases to continue against others."

"Without IID."

"Yes."

"Without prosecution."

"Yes."

"Without anyone outside your circle knowing."

Farid's mouth tightened at the word.

"Yes."

Rahman stared.

"Why?"

Farid looked at him as though the answer should have been obvious.

"Because they led upward."

"To who?"

"Not one person."

"Then what?"

"More valuable information."

Rahman almost laughed.

"Always."

Farid ignored him.

"One compromised constable tells you who paid him."

"Yes."

"You arrest him immediately, you get a constable."

"Yes."

"You watch him, maybe you get the intermediary."

"And after that?"

"Transport broker."

"Then?"

"Businessman."

"Then?"

"Someone with access."

"And when do you stop?"

Farid looked at him.

“That was the problem.”

Rahman sat back.

“There was never a point.”

“No.”

“You kept going.”

“Yes.”

“Because there was always someone bigger.”

“Sometimes there was.”

“And when there wasn’t?”

Farid looked away.

Rahman waited.

“That became harder to tell.”

The admission came quietly.

Rahman said:

“You used information from them.”

“Yes.”

“Criminal information.”

“Yes.”

“Leaked police information.”

“Sometimes.”

“Against other criminals.”

“Yes.”

“Against larger threats.”

“Yes.”

Farid folded his hands.

“We prevented killings.”

Rahman said nothing.

“Arms shipments.”

Still nothing.

“Narcotics routes.”

Rahman looked at him.

“Like 2004.”

“Yes.”

“The intermediary in your file.”

“He gave us a route through Kota Lagenda that led to an arms-transfer network.”

"And you protected him."

"I protected the channel."

"He was helping criminals."

"Yes."

"He was receiving police information."

"Yes."

"And you kept him operational."

"Yes."

Farid's voice did not rise.

"That information later identified men planning to move military-grade weapons through a civilian logistics chain."

Rahman stared.

"How many arrests?"

"Seven."

"Deaths prevented?"

"Probably."

"Probably."

Farid looked at him.

"You want arithmetic?"

"No."

"That is what you are asking for."

"No."

Rahman leaned forward.

"I am asking when using a compromised channel became participating in it."

Farid said nothing.

That was the real question.

Rahman pointed at the 2001 order.

"You removed police-integrity names from circulation."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Some were active source contacts."

"All?"

"No."

"Some were corrupt?"

"Yes."

"And you removed them too."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because exposing them would have exposed how we knew."

Rahman's jaw tightened.

"So source protection."

"Sometimes."

"And the rest?"

Farid looked at him.

"Operational containment."

Rahman laughed once.

There it was.

The phrase had survived three decades.

"Tell me what that meant."

Farid took his time.

"Restrict information. move compromised officers away from access. monitor intermediaries. use what could be used. act when evidence was strong enough or risk became intolerable."

"Who decided intolerable?"

"We did."

"Who is we?"

Farid looked at him.

"Senior intelligence command. Sometimes criminal investigation. sometimes me."

"Harun?"

"No."

The answer was immediate.

"Why not?"

"Because Harun would have acted sooner."

"Yes."

"He thought delay became complicity."

Farid looked toward the window.

"He may have been right."

Rahman felt the words settle.

"May?"

Farid looked back.

"Yes."

The office seemed smaller now.

Rahman looked at the man across from him.

Not a criminal kingpin.

Not a bought officer.

No envelope.

No secret account.

Nothing simple.

A senior policeman who had believed information could be managed.

Who had taken compromised relationships and turned them into tools.

Who had hidden some wrongdoing to expose larger wrongdoing.

Who had protected sources, investigations, officers, channels and eventually perhaps the system that made those choices necessary.

Rahman understood too much of it.

That was what frightened him.

"You thought you could control it."

"Yes."

"Did you?"

"Sometimes."

"And when you couldn't?"

Farid smiled without humour.

"You are looking at the result."

Rahman said:

"ORION."

"Yes."

"Hafiz."

Farid's face tightened.

"I did not order his death."

Rahman had not asked.

The denial entered the room anyway.

Rahman watched him.

"Faiz Idrus?"

"No."

"Salmah?"

"No."

"Zafir warning?"

"No."

"The leaked ORION document?"

"No."

"The extract you sent us. Its timestamp was altered."

"I forwarded what I was given."

"By whom?"

"By the people who give me things." He did not look away. "I should have asked why it arrived so complete."

It was an answer built to be true and no more.

"Farhan?"

"I knew nothing about his payments until ORION."

Rahman held his gaze.

He believed some of that.

Maybe all.

Belief remained irrelevant.

"Did you ever give the network police information?"

Farid paused.

Rahman's stomach tightened.

"Answer."

"I gave information to sources and intermediaries where I believed doing so served an intelligence purpose."

"That is not what I asked."

"It is the accurate answer."

"Did that information reach criminals?"

"Yes."

"Did you know it would?"

"Sometimes."

Rahman looked away.

There.

Not sale.

Not bribery.

Use.

Calculated release.

Controlled contamination.

At least in Farid's mind.

"Did people benefit because you warned them?"

"Sometimes."

"Did prosecutions disappear?"

"Some were not brought."

"Evidence buried?"

"Restricted."

"Same thing to the victim."

Farid's face changed.

"Yes."

The agreement hurt more than defence.

Rahman said:

"When did the line move?"

Farid did not answer.

"When did source handling become protection?"

Silence.

"When did containment become dependency?"

Farid looked down at his hands.

For the first time, he seemed unsure.

Not strategically.

Actually unsure.

Rahman waited.

Farid said:

"At first, every decision had a reason."

Rahman said nothing.

"One source was too valuable to expose."

A pause.

"One officer could be moved instead of arrested while we mapped his contacts."

Another.

"One company could remain open so we could watch who used it."

Another.

"One financial intermediary could be tolerated because his records showed us bigger flows."

Farid looked up.

"Every decision was temporary."

Rahman thought of his own breaches.

One necessary exception.

One successful outcome.

One justification.

Farid continued.

"Then the network learned us."

The words were quiet.

Rahman felt them.

“How?”

“It learned what we protected.”

“Sources.”

“Yes.”

“Reputation.”

“Yes.”

“Ongoing cases.”

“Yes.”

“Officers.”

“Yes.”

“Institutions.”

Farid’s mouth tightened.

“Yes.”

“And used it.”

“Yes.”

Rahman leaned back.

Farid looked suddenly exhausted.

“At some point I stopped knowing whether I was controlling it or it was controlling me.”

There it was.

No theatrics.

No collapse.

Just a man admitting the boundary had disappeared.

Rahman did not feel triumph.

Only grief.

Farid stood and walked to the window.

He kept his back to Rahman.

“I never took their money.”

Rahman said nothing.

“I never bought property through them.”

Nothing.

“I never asked them to promote me.”

Rahman looked at him.

“That is not your defence.”

Farid turned.

"No."
"Good."
Farid nodded.
"It is simply true."
Rahman believed him.
Or wanted to.
Again irrelevant.
Farid continued.
"My mistake was worse in some ways."
Rahman waited.
"I believed motive protected method."
The sentence stayed in the room.
Rahman thought of Aisyah.
Good man in the room.
Farid said:
"If I delayed a case to save a source, I was still protecting the law."
"If you hid an officer?"
"To reach someone above him."
"If you kept a compromised intermediary alive?"
"To stop something larger."
"If you restricted Harun?"
Farid's expression changed.
"That was not only me."
"You signed."
"Yes."
"Why?"
"Because by then 17/94 touched active intelligence relationships."
"And corrupt police."
"Yes."
"Which mattered more?"
Farid looked at him.
"That depended on the day."
Rahman hated the answer because it sounded honest.
"What happened to Harun?"
Farid's face closed slightly.
Not fully.
Rahman stood.

“This is where the confession stops?”

“I told you before.”

“Some truths arrive too late.”

“Yes.”

“That means you know.”

“I know pieces.”

“Tell me.”

Farid looked toward the documents.

“No.”

Rahman felt anger sharpen.

“Why?”

“Because I am not going to turn uncertainty into accusation because you are angry.”

“Who am I accusing?”

“You have not decided yet.”

Rahman stared.

Farid continued.

“I did not order Harun’s death.”

Again.

“You keep telling me what you did not do.”

“Because I know where your mind is going.”

“Did you know he was in danger?”

Farid paused.

“Yes.”

Rahman went still.

“How much?”

“Enough to worry.”

“From who?”

“Several directions.”

“Network?”

“Yes.”

“Police?”

Farid did not answer.

That was enough.

“Did you protect him?”

“I tried.”

“How?”

"Restricted some of his movements. reduced circulation of his work. told him to stop contacting certain people."

"And did he?"

Farid almost smiled.

"No."

Of course.

"Did he trust you?"

"Less by then."

"Why?"

Farid looked at Rahman.

"Because he believed containment had already become compromise."

Silence.

Rahman felt something old settle into place.

Not answer.

Shape.

Again.

The confrontation lasted another hour.

No confession to murder.

No secret ledger.

No master list.

Farid gave names of old intelligence operations Rahman would have to verify independently.

He identified two source channels that had been protected despite criminal contamination.

He admitted approving selective removal of police names from working dissemination.

He admitted using information derived from corrupt relationships to target larger organised-crime threats.

He admitted transferring officers quietly rather than exposing them when operational considerations outweighed immediate discipline.

He denied ever accepting money.

Denied ordering violence.

Denied controlling The Circle.

Denied knowing its complete modern structure.

Rahman believed the last one most.

Farid had known more than ORION.

Not everything.

Maybe nobody did.

Before Rahman left, he asked:

“Why tell me now?”

Farid remained standing behind his desk.

“Because you found the signatures.”

“That is not enough.”

“No.”

“Then why?”

Farid looked at him.

“Because if I lie now, you will spend the next week proving the lie instead of understanding what happened.”

Rahman almost smiled.

“Still managing the investigation.”

“Yes.”

At least he admitted it.

Rahman picked up the copies.

Farid said:

“Rahman.”

He stopped.

“I meant what I said about ORION.”

“Close it.”

“Yes.”

“Still?”

“Yes.”

“After this?”

“Especially after this.”

Rahman looked back.

Farid continued.

“What you are uncovering will not separate cleanly into innocent and guilty.”

“I know.”

“Then be careful.”

Rahman said:

“You have used that word for thirty years.”

“Yes.”

“Maybe too often.”

Farid looked toward the window.

"Maybe."

Rahman left.

Aisyah was waiting in SOC 4. Daniel too. No one asked immediately.

Rahman closed the door and set the documents on the table.

"He admits the authorisations," he said. "He admits the network was real. He restricted evidence, stopped some referrals, moved compromised officers instead of exposing them."

Daniel stopped typing.

"Did it work?" he asked.

"Sometimes."

That was the whole tragedy.

"Formal interview now," Aisyah said.

"Yes."

No hesitation. She noticed. Good.

"He denies taking money."

"That is not necessary for corruption."

"I know. And he admits Harun believed containment had already become compromise. On how Harun died, nothing but fragments."

"Then we keep going."

Rahman nodded.

"Yes."

He returned to his office after midnight.

The six-name list remained inside the old manual.

He took it out.

F.K.

Possible Protector function.

Intent unknown.

That line was no longer enough.

Rahman added beneath it:

Direct historical containment authorisations confirmed.

Then:

Admits knowledge of network.

Then:

Admits use of compromised information channels against larger targets.

Then:

Admits restriction/burial of some information and quiet management of compromised officers.

He paused over the word burial.

Farid would object.

Rahman left it.

Then he wrote the sentence exactly as Farid had said it.

"At some point I stopped knowing whether I was controlling it or it was controlling me."

Rahman looked at the page.

No relief.

The missing name had not been missing because no one knew it.

It had been missing because, for years, Farid Kamal had occupied the space between crime and consequence while telling himself that was where responsible men had to stand.

Perhaps sometimes he had been right.

That was the worst part.

Rahman folded the paper.

Put it back.

Farid had begun confessing. Now ORION would have to decide what, exactly, those confessions made him.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

THE TRUTH

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

Farid's formal interview began at 8:05 in the morning.

By 8:17, Rahman understood the interview room was too small for what they were discussing.

Not physically.

Morally.

Aisyah sat opposite Farid with the recording system active.

SAC Razak occupied the chair beside her.

Rahman sat at the end of the table.

Daniel observed through secure video from the adjacent room.

Farid had declined legal representation for the first session.

Razak had advised him twice.

Farid understood.

He signed the acknowledgement.

No defiance.

No performance.

He wore a dark suit without his uniform.

Rahman had never seen him look less like a senior police officer.

It made no difference.

Aisyah began.

"For the record, Datuk Farid Kamal, do you understand that this interview concerns historical intelligence containment decisions, unauthorised restriction or suppression of investigative material, possible facilitation of compromised officers and intermediaries, and any connection between those matters and current Task Force ORION investigations?"

"Yes."

"You may stop at any time."

"Yes."

"You may request counsel."

"Yes."

Aisyah looked at him.

"Are you willing to proceed?"

Farid folded his hands.

"Yes."

She walked him through the documents one at a time: the 2001 order, the 2004 monitored-contact decision, the removal of police-integrity names from wider distribution. Farid confirmed each signature. He argued only the reading.

"The names did not all mean the same thing," he said. "Some officers were compromised. Some were source handlers. Some simply appeared near the same businesses because police work repeats itself."

"And who decided which interpretation was correct?" Aisyah asked.

"We did."

"That is the problem."

"Yes."

Farid looked toward Rahman.

"I know."

After an hour, they stopped repeating history.

Aisyah had documents.

Farid had admitted authorship.

Razak had enough for disciplinary and criminal review pathways to begin.

But the thing underneath remained shapeless.

Rahman asked:

"The network."

Aisyah looked at him.

It was not his turn.

He knew.

Farid looked back.

"What about it?"

Rahman leaned forward.

"You keep saying network, but every time we try to define it you change the word."

“I correct the word.”
“Then correct it now.”
Farid was silent.
Rahman continued.
“What is The Circle?”
Aisyah did not interrupt.
Razak looked at Farid.
The room became very still.
Farid exhaled.
“The name is useful because it is wrong.”
Daniel, in the adjacent room, would have hated that sentence.
Rahman said:
“Explain.”
Farid looked at the recording light.
Then back at Rahman.
“There was never one Circle.”
Rahman’s expression hardened.
“Do not play with language.”
“I am not.”
“You admitted the old network existed.”
“Yes.”
“Harun mapped it.”
“Parts.”
“Kelana named it.”
“Later.”
“Modern evidence shows continuity.”
“Yes.”
“So what are you saying?”
Farid leaned back.
“That you keep looking for continuity in people.”
Rahman said nothing.
Farid continued.
“Leader. members. command. succession.”
“Yes.”
“Because that is how police understand organised crime.”
“Usually.”
“And that is why this survived.”

Aisyah asked:

“What survived?”

Farid looked at her.

“Functions.”

He spoke carefully.

Not like a man revealing a secret mythology.

Like an intelligence officer finally describing a model he had resisted formalising for years.

“Criminal groups need things they cannot provide for themselves.”

Rahman waited.

“Transport.”

“Yes.”

“Information.”

“Yes.”

“Introductions.”

“Yes.”

“Protection.”

“Yes.”

“Money movement.”

“Yes.”

“Records.”

Aisyah said:

“Memory.”

Farid looked at her.

“Yes.”

Rahman thought of Daniel’s board.

Operators.

Brokers.

Keepers.

Protectors.

Farid continued.

“Street operators come and go quickly. They are the visible part. Arrest one group, another fills the market.”

“We know.”

“The relationships around them last longer.”

“Yes.”

“Someone introduces.”

"Broker."

Farid nodded.

"Someone remembers what was promised, paid, owed, threatened or forgiven."

"Keeper."

"Yes."

"Someone interrupts consequence."

"Protector."

Farid looked at Rahman.

"Yes."

"And the Accountant?"

Farid's eyes shifted.

Only slightly.

Daniel's black node seemed to appear in the room despite being on another screen.

Rahman asked again.

"The Accountant."

Farid said:

"That was never a person."

Silence.

Rahman felt something settle rather than explode.

Of course.

Aisyah spoke first.

"A role."

"Yes."

Rahman stared at Farid.

"Daniel has been looking for one financial architect."

"He would."

"Why?"

"Because the records look consistent."

"Yes."

"They are."

"So one person."

"No."

Farid shook his head.

"One method."

Aisyah leaned forward.

“How many Accountants?”
Farid almost smiled.
“That question assumes membership.”
“How many people performed the function?”
“I don’t know.”
“Estimate.”
“No.”
“Why?”
“Because some did not know they were performing it.”
Aisyah’s eyes narrowed.
Farid continued.
“One corporate secretary creates a shell company.”
“One accountant structures a loan.”
“One lawyer holds client funds.”
“One finance officer moves money between legitimate businesses.”
“One criminal bookkeeper reconciles debts.”
“One business adviser knows which company can absorb a payment.”
Rahman said:
“And together they become The Accountant.”
“No.”
Farid looked at him.
“Not together.”
“Then?”
“At different times.”
That mattered.
Farid continued.
“The role moves.”
Aisyah said:
“Inherited.”
“Sometimes.”
“Deliberately?”
“Sometimes.”
“Informally?”
“Often.”
“Meaning there is continuity without succession being formal.”
“Yes.”
Rahman thought of Daniel’s frustration.

Consistency could belong to method.

Grace had been right.

The Accountant was not a man sitting in a dark office maintaining one perfect ledger.

It was a function that could migrate between professionals.

A method.

A discipline.

Perhaps a tradition.

Farid said:

"You looked for one financial brain because the pattern was too orderly."

Rahman said:

"It is orderly."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because people copy what works."

Silence.

"Forms."

"Structures."

"Law firms."

"Corporate vehicles."

"Invoice methods."

"Ways of disguising obligation."

"Old solutions become new templates."

Rahman thought of habit.

Daniel had been closer than he knew.

Razak spoke for the first time in several minutes.

"You are describing decentralised organised crime."

Farid looked at him.

"Partly."

"That exists everywhere."

"Yes."

"So what makes this different?"

Farid took his time.

"The Keeper."

Razak frowned.

Farid continued.

“Most decentralised criminal relationships break when memory breaks.”

“Records?”

“Sometimes records.”

“People?”

“Yes.”

“The Keeper remembers which businessman once needed help. Which officer’s brother was rescued from debt. Which case disappeared. Which family received a contract. Which intermediary betrayed whom and was forgiven because he became useful later.”

Aisyah said:

“Leverage.”

“Yes.”

“Blackmail?”

“Sometimes.”

“Favours?”

“More often.”

Rahman thought of Harun’s line.

They do not control people. They control what people are afraid to lose.

Farid continued.

“The Keeper does not need to command anyone.”

“Only remember.”

“Yes.”

“And remind.”

“Yes.”

Aisyah looked toward Rahman.

Dependency.

That was the word.

Farid said:

“That is why money never explained enough.”

Rahman nodded slowly.

“Because payment is only one record of obligation.”

“Yes.”

“Sometimes the debt comes before the payment.”

“Yes.”

“Sometimes there is no payment.”

"Yes."
Farid looked at him.
"Sometimes all it takes is a phone call answered at the right time."
Rahman said:
"Broker."
Farid nodded.
"Connects."
"Who?"
"Whoever needs connection."
"Criminal to businessman."
"Yes."
"Businessman to lawyer."
"Yes."
"Officer to intermediary."
"Yes."
"Operator to Protector."
"Sometimes."
"Kelana."
Farid considered.
"He has functioned as broker at different points."
"Rahim Nasir?"
A pause.
"Yes."
Rahman felt Aisyah's attention sharpen.
"High-level?"
"Sometimes."
"First?"
"No."
"Architect?"
"I don't know."
"Leader?"
"No evidence."
Farid's answer was immediate.
Rahman believed him.
Not because he trusted Farid.
Because the answer fit everything else.
Rahim may have been important without being king.

Rahman asked:

“Alive?”

Farid looked at him.

“I don’t know.”

That answer felt less certain.

Rahman noticed.

Did not chase it.

Not yet.

“Protector,” Aisyah said.

Farid’s face changed.

The word belonged closer to him.

She continued.

“Define it.”

Farid looked at her.

“Someone positioned between action and consequence.”

“That is broad.”

“Yes.”

“Police.”

“Sometimes.”

“Judges?”

Farid shook his head.

“I am not giving you a list of professions and asking you to criminalise them.”

“I asked a question.”

“Then ask conduct.”

Aisyah stared.

“Fine. What does a Protector do?”

Farid counted nothing on his fingers.

He did not need to.

“Delays a raid.”

“Moves an officer.”

“Restricts a file.”

“Warns that a witness is unsafe.”

“Reframes intelligence.”

“Redirects enforcement.”

“Explains away a suspicious transaction.”

“Creates time.”

Rahman said:

"Time for what?"

"Whatever the relationship needs."

"That sounds like corruption."

"Often."

"Often?"

Farid looked at him.

"A Protector can also be legitimate."

Rahman almost laughed.

"Of course."

Farid ignored the tone.

"An undercover operation has Protectors."

"Command."

"Yes."

"A source has Protectors."

"Yes."

"A covert method."

"Yes."

"So corruption hides inside the same function."

Farid looked at him.

"Exactly."

That was the fatal design.

Not that institutions and criminal networks were identical.

That some functions looked similar from the outside.

Protection could be lawful or corrupt.

Secrecy could preserve a source or bury misconduct.

Delay could save an operation or warn a target.

Compartmentalisation could defend an undercover officer or prevent accountability.

Intent mattered.

Consequence mattered.

Evidence mattered.

And over time, the difference could become invisible even to the person making the decision.

Rahman looked at Farid.

"You became a Protector."

Farid did not answer immediately.

Then:

“Yes.”

No qualifier.

No possibly.

Yes.

Aisyah remained still.

Rahman asked:

“For the institution?”

“At first.”

“And later?”

Farid looked down.

“That is harder.”

Daniel entered the room twenty minutes later.

Aisyah had authorised it.

He carried no laptop.

Only a printed version of his financial architecture map.

He placed it on the table.

Black node:

THE ACCOUNTANT

Daniel looked at Farid.

“You knew we were wrong.”

Farid said:

“I knew your label was wrong.”

“You could have told us.”

“Yes.”

“Why didn’t you?”

Farid looked at Rahman.

“Same reason he did not tell me every source name he had in 2006.”

Daniel’s irritation sharpened.

“That is not comparable.”

“No.”

Farid nodded.

“It is worse.”

Daniel stopped.

Farid continued.

“If I told ORION too early that The Accountant was a function, you would have changed your search.”

"That is generally the point of information."

"You would have started looking for professionals, templates, family succession, repeated service relationships."

"Yes."

"And the people watching ORION would have noticed."

Rahman said:

"You were still running containment."

"Yes."

"Even after ORION began."

"Yes."

There.

Present-tense compromise.

Not merely history.

Aisyah's voice hardened.

"You were manipulating the task force."

"I was trying to prevent uncontrolled exposure."

"You approved us."

"Yes."

"While limiting what we could know."

"Yes."

"Why create ORION at all?"

Farid looked at her.

"Because containment was failing."

Silence.

Rahman felt the admission move through the room.

"So you created us."

"I supported creating you."

"To do what?"

"Cut away what had become dangerous."

Rahman stared.

"Not expose it."

"No."

"There was your bargain from the beginning."

Farid said nothing.

Rahman understood.

ORION had been authorised not because Farid wanted the whole truth.

Because he needed intervention.

Remove destabilising operators.

Find the worst leaks.

Restore control.

Not destroy the ecosystem.

Not expose the historical bargain.

Contain it again.

Only better.

Daniel looked at his map.

"So The Accountant role."

"Yes," Farid said.

"Do people inherit records?"

"Sometimes."

"Digital?"

"Now, probably."

"You don't know?"

"No."

"Physical ledger?"

Farid shook his head.

"I have seen fragments. Never one master ledger."

Daniel looked disappointed and relieved.

"Then why the consistency?"

"Templates. copied structures. retained advisers. repeated corporate vehicles. institutional memory."

"Keeper."

"Yes."

"Accountant may overlap with Keeper."

"Sometimes."

"Broker too?"

"Sometimes."

Daniel frowned.

"Then categories are not fixed."

"No."

"They are functions."

"Yes."

"One person can perform multiple."

"Yes."

“Or one function can be split across several.”
“Yes.”
Daniel stared at the black node.
Rahman watched his theory collapse in real time.
Not uselessly.
Productively.
Daniel picked up the printout.
With a pen, he crossed out the singular heading.
Then wrote:
ACCOUNTANT FUNCTION
No one commented.
Rahman looked at Farid.
“One leader?”
“No.”
“Ever?”
“Maybe local leaders. temporary organisers. dominant brokers.”
“But no permanent head.”
“Not that I ever found.”
“Rahim?”
“No proof.”
“Someone must decide strategy.”
Farid shook his head.
“That is your last attachment.”
“To hierarchy.”
“Yes.”
Farid leaned forward.
“Think about a market.”
Rahman frowned.
“No owner controls every transaction.”
“That is too convenient.”
“It is also accurate.”
“Markets have rules.”
“Habits.”
“Enforcers.”
“Relationships.”
“Gatekeepers.”
“Yes.”

"Somebody benefits more."

"Yes."

"But no one needs to command the whole thing."

Rahman thought of The Circle.

A name invented by people who did not want to explain how they knew someone.

Not a board.

Not a syndicate headquarters.

A system of exchange.

Favours.

Information.

Protection.

Obligation.

People entering and leaving.

Roles surviving.

That was the truth.

Or close enough to change everything.

The Circle was not one conspiracy hiding inside Malaysia.

It was a recurring way of making criminal relationships durable.

Farid said:

"That is why arrests never killed it."

"Because we arrested operators."

"Yes."

"Sometimes brokers."

"Yes."

"Rarely Keepers."

"Rarely."

"And Protectors?"

Farid looked at him.

"Almost never."

Rahman felt anger return.

Not because Farid's model was wrong.

Because it explained his choices too well.

"You knew that."

"Eventually."

"And instead of exposing Protectors, you became one."

Farid's expression hardened.

"I prevented chaos."

Rahman stared.

"There it is."

Farid did not retreat.

"Yes."

"You still believe it."

"Some of it."

"After everything."

"Especially after everything."

Aisyah looked between them.

Farid continued.

"You think exposure purifies systems."

"I have never said that."

"You act as if truth is self-executing."

"No."

"As if once facts are known, institutions become honest."

"No."

"Then what?"

Rahman leaned forward.

"I think hidden corruption becomes stronger when the institution starts depending on it."

Farid said:

"And I think institutions can be destroyed by exposing legitimate secrets alongside corruption."

"Then separate them."

"Easy sentence."

"Hard work."

"Yes."

"Do the hard work."

Farid's eyes sharpened.

"While people die?"

"They already died."

"More will."

"Maybe."

Farid stared.

Rahman continued.

"You keep presenting future harm as justification for past silence."

“Because future harm is real.”

“So is past harm.”

“Yes.”

“Then who gets justice?”

Farid said nothing.

Rahman pressed.

“Hafiz?”

No answer.

“Faiz?”

Silence.

“Hamid?”

Farid’s face shifted.

“Harun?”

Farid looked away.

Rahman saw.

There.

The old wound.

“What happened to Harun?”

Farid closed his eyes briefly.

When he opened them, the senior commander was gone.

Not literally.

The armour.

For a moment.

Rahman’s voice remained flat.

“You keep telling me what you did not do. Did you withdraw his protection?”

Farid paused.

Rahman saw it.

“What?”

“I reduced his operational access.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“No.”

Farid looked at him.

“I did not order protection withdrawn so someone could harm him.”

“Was protection withdrawn?”

“Not formal protection.”

“What then?”

"He had informal monitoring."

"By who?"

"Special Intelligence."

"Your people."

"Yes."

"Did it stop?"

Farid looked down.

"Yes."

Rahman's jaw tightened.

"Before he died."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"He had stopped cooperating with containment measures."

The words sounded obscene in the room.

Aisyah went still.

Rahman said:

"You removed monitoring because he would not stop investigating."

"No."

"Then why?"

"Because he began meeting people outside controlled channels. contacting officers we were monitoring. keeping copies. refusing to tell us where."

"So you stopped protecting him."

"We stopped following him."

"Same effect if someone else was."

Farid looked at him.

"Yes."

The admission came like a bruise.

Not murder.

Failure.

Maybe worse because it had been administrative.

Rahman asked:

"After his death?"

Farid was silent.

"What did you do?"

No answer.

Rahman leaned closer.

"What did you bury?"

Farid looked at Aisyah.

Then Razak.

Then back to Rahman.

"His final findings were incomplete."

"That was not my question."

"They contained names that could not be validated."

"What did you do?"

"We restricted them."

"Only?"

"We separated source material."

"And?"

"Moved some annexes under Special Intelligence control."

"And?"

Farid's voice lowered.

"I supported the decision not to reopen 17/94 as a criminal conspiracy inquiry after his death."

Silence.

There it was.

Rahman did not move.

Aisyah asked:

"Why?"

Farid looked at her.

"Because Harun was dead. His working theory was unfinished. Some of his contacts were compromised. Some were legitimate sources. Several implicated officers without sufficient evidentiary foundation."

"And some?"

Farid did not answer.

Aisyah repeated:

"And some?"

"Were probably corrupt."

Rahman felt his hands tighten.

"You knew."

"Yes."

"And you buried the findings."

"I restricted findings that could not safely be separated."

Rahman stood.

"Stop correcting the word."

Farid looked at him.

"You buried them."

Farid's face did not change.

After a long moment:

"Yes."

That was enough.

Rahman walked away from the table.

The room had no window.

He wanted one.

Air.

Distance.

Something.

Harun had not left a solved case because he died while asking questions.

Farid had then helped ensure those questions never became a full public criminal inquiry.

Not because he had murdered Harun.

Not because someone paid him.

Because he believed exposure would do more harm.

Rahman turned.

"You did not kill him."

"No."

"But after he died, you made sure what he found could not hurt the institution."

Farid's voice hardened.

"I made sure incomplete intelligence did not destroy innocent people."

"And guilty ones survived with them."

"Yes."

"Say it."

Farid looked at him.

"Some guilty people survived."

Rahman nodded.

"And what did they learn?"

Farid said nothing.

"They learned the institution would protect the structure if exposure threatened enough legitimate operations."

No answer.

"They learned your limits."

Farid's face tightened.

"The network learned us," Rahman said.

Farid looked at him.

"You said it yourself."

"Yes."

"And you still call what you did prevention."

"It was prevention."

"No."

Rahman stepped closer.

"You prevented consequences."

"For some people."

"For the system."

"Yes."

"And that preserved the conditions that allowed the corruption to survive."

Farid stood.

Finally.

The two men faced each other across the table.

Farid said:

"You think if we had exposed everything in 2001, this ends?"

"I think we would have known what we were fighting."

"You would have burned sources. Collapsed investigations. Named innocent officers beside guilty ones."

"Maybe."

"And after the scandal? What then?"

Rahman held his gaze.

"Then the institution would have had to decide what it was."

Farid almost laughed.

"You believe institutions decide once."

"No."

"Then?"

"They decide every time."

That stopped Farid.

Rahman continued.

"You decided every time too."

"Yes."

"And every time you chose containment, containment became easier."

Farid said nothing.

"Every time a compromised officer helped you reach someone worse, you found a reason not to expose him yet."

Farid's jaw tightened.

"Yes."

"And eventually 'yet' became thirty years."

No answer.

Rahman looked at him.

"That is your corruption."

Farid did not flinch.

Perhaps because he had already said it to himself.

Or because he disagreed.

Rahman did not know.

Farid said:

"My corruption, if that is the word you need, was believing I could choose which damage mattered."

Rahman stared.

Farid continued.

"I watched operations succeed on intelligence we would never have had along clean lines. I watched people live. I thought that gave me time."

He looked tired.

"Then time became policy."

"I know what you think."

"Do you?"

"You think I preserved corruption."

"Yes."

"I did."

The admission shocked the room only because it was so simple.

Farid continued.

"And I prevented other harms."

"Yes."

"Both are true."

"Yes."

Rahman's voice lowered.

"But only one of those truths became your excuse to continue."

Farid looked at him.

That one landed.

The formal interview was suspended at 13:42.

Not ended.

Razak requested legal consultation for Farid before continuation.

Farid agreed this time.

Aisyah sealed the documents.

Daniel took his revised model back to SOC 4.

No one celebrated.

No one said they had solved The Circle.

They had not.

What they had was something stranger.

The architecture was not architecture in the usual sense. No central tower. No permanent leadership. Roles that could survive their occupants: overlap, rotate, disappear, return under new people. Some participants were criminal. Some were compromised. Some were legitimate professionals whose services were used without their full knowledge. And at least one was a senior commander who had spent years believing the system could safely use the relationships it was supposed to dismantle.

That was the truth.

Not complete.

Enough.

Back in SOC 4, Daniel stood in front of the board with his arms folded.

"I hate this."

Aisyah asked:

"Why?"

"Because it is harder."

"Yes."

"I wanted one person."

"We all did."

Rahman entered.

He heard.

Stopped.

Kelana's voice returned.

You want a king because kings can be arrested.
Daniel looked at him.
“What now?”
Rahman studied the four functions.
“Now we stop trying to arrest a shape.”
Aisyah said:
“And?”
Rahman looked toward the secure evidence room.
“Now we prove conduct.”
Person by person.
Decision by decision.
Not membership.
Not mythology.
Acts.
That was the only way law could survive the complexity.
Farid’s interview resumed the next morning with counsel present.
Less philosophical.
More precise.
Names withheld pending verification.
Dates.
Orders.
Classification decisions.
Source channels.
Rahman listened without anger when he could.
Aisyah led.
Razak documented.
Farid admitted only what he could defend factually.
That was his nature.
He refused to name people based solely on memory.
That frustrated everyone.
It was also correct.
At one point Aisyah asked:
“Do you consider yourself corrupt?”
Farid thought for a long time.
His counsel shifted slightly.
Farid answered anyway.
“I consider myself responsible.”

"That was not the question."

"No."

"Then answer."

Farid looked at Rahman.

Then Aisyah.

"I do not know when responsibility became corruption."

Aisyah said:

"Can you identify decisions that crossed the line?"

"Yes."

"Which?"

Farid looked at the authorisation records.

"Some of the ones in front of you."

No self-pity.

No absolution.

No villain's confession.

Just recognition.

Afterward, Rahman found him alone in the corridor outside counsel room.

Two IID officers stood farther away.

Farid looked toward SOC 4.

"You have your truth."

Rahman shook his head.

"No."

"No?"

"We have a truth."

Farid almost smiled.

"Harun would approve."

"Do not use him."

The smile disappeared.

Rahman stood beside him.

Not close.

Not far.

Farid said:

"You still believe full exposure is the answer."

"No."

Farid looked at him.

"Then perhaps you learned something."

"I learned you were right about the danger."

Farid waited.

"And wrong about who should carry it."

Farid's expression changed.

Rahman continued.

"No one man gets to decide what an institution can survive."

"Someone always decides."

"Yes."

"Command."

"Courts."

"Investigators."

"Prosecutors."

"Parliament."

"Public."

Farid said nothing.

Rahman looked at him.

"The answer is not that nobody decides."

A pause.

"It is that no one gets to decide alone."

Farid looked away.

For years, he had.

That was the point.

Before returning to ORION, Rahman stopped at the secure evidence room.

Harun's black notebook sat behind glass.

He could not touch it without logging access.

Good.

He looked at the page copied into the catalogue.

Possible central coordination? NO EVIDENCE.

Harun had been right to resist the king.

But he had not lived to see how far the roles evolved.

The Circle survived because people kept mistaking durability for hierarchy. It did not need one leader. It needed memory, access, introductions, protection: methods that outlived the people who invented them.

Rahman finally understood the difference between them.

Not that Rahman had never crossed lines.

He had.

Not that his motives were purer.

Motives were dangerous things to worship.

The difference would be what happened after the line became visible.

Farid had hidden it.

Rahman could not.

Not anymore.

He turned away from Harun's notebook and walked back toward SOC 4.

Farid's tragedy was not that he had failed to destroy it.

It was that, convinced he was preventing chaos, he had helped preserve the conditions in which it could continue without ever needing him at all.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

THE CHOICE

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

The choice was smaller than Rahman had expected.

In the years he had spent imagining a night like this, it had weather in it. A held breath, a hand over a switch, a city waiting below a window. What he got was a table in Secure Operations Centre 4 at ten past eleven, a sealed evidence drive in a clear bag, and four people who had not slept properly in a week.

Aisyah sat with the custody log open and a pen she had not yet used. Daniel held a paper cup in both hands, long gone cold. At the far end of the table Farid Kamal sat in the dark suit he had worn all day, his counsel beside him. The lawyer had agreed to the meeting on one condition: nothing Farid said in this room would be treated as a statement. Aisyah had put that in writing. Razak disliked the arrangement and signed it anyway.

Rahman had asked for Farid to be there. He knew how it looked.

The drive held everything ORION had built and everything Harun had left. The account maps. The access logs from the seven minutes. The archive copies, the transcript of Kelana's cassette, the 17/94 annexes, the authorisations with Farid's signature. Daniel's functional model, with its warnings printed above every category.

It also held people who had trusted the service with their lives. Source registers. Protected witnesses. Two undercover officers who had been, for years, nothing but a reference number.

And it held Rahman. The 2006 delay. The 2014 deployment. The six-name list he had kept in a training manual because he no longer trusted his own system. He had added those himself on the second night, before anyone asked.

Sent whole, the drive would wound The Circle. It would wound him too. Sent cut down, it would wound whoever was left in the cut.

“Send the clean version first,” Farid said. “Stabilise the operation. Disclose the rest under controlled review.”

Aisyah did not look at him.

“That is how every dirty thing begins calling itself controlled.”

Rahman waited for anger. It did not come. He was tired past anger, and under the tiredness something he had not felt in weeks, which was clarity. It was not comfortable.

“I am not sending a clean version,” he said. “And I am not sending everything to everyone.”

Daniel looked up. “Those are the only two options.”

“They are the two that have already been tried.”

He stood and went to the screen. For a moment he wrote nothing. Then, in the plain capitals ORION used for working notes, he wrote four words.

IID. PROSECUTION. OVERSIGHT. PRESS.

“Four doors,” he said. “Each one gets what it is able to use, and nothing it is not.”

He started with the first.

“IID gets all of it. Unredacted, under chain of custody, including my section. They are the people who are allowed to see names, and they are the people who will investigate me.”

Aisyah’s pen moved at last. “Razak briefed the Public Prosecutor’s office on Monday. A deputy there has read the outline. She asked for proof and nothing else.”

“Then she gets proof and nothing else. What can be shown in court: Badrul, Farhan, the authorisations. With a note on what cannot be shown, and why.”

“An admissibility annex,” Daniel said. “That is a second document.”

“Write it.”

“Third door?”

“The external oversight body gets the history. The 17/94 annexes, the model, the pattern of restriction over thirty years. And it gets Daniel’s rule on every page.”

Daniel almost smiled. “Access is not protection.”

"Opportunity is not compromise. Forty-three officers appear in Harun's papers. Five have anything behind them that survives a second reading. If the file goes out without saying that, forty-three men get the same face."

Aisyah put the pen down. "And the fourth."

"Two editors. Not a leak. Delivered through counsel, redacted, with a hash manifest, under embargo until the Public Prosecutor speaks."

"Why the embargo?"

"Because if the first account comes from a prosecutor, it will be careful. If it comes from a rumour, it will be a mob."

"And if neither paper can be trusted with it?"

"Then the hashes will say so. Every door receives the same manifest. Anyone can check one against another."

Aisyah studied the screen.

"You are not including Hana."

It was not a question, and she had said it gently.

"No."

"She would verify before she printed."

"She is my daughter. Anything she printed from my hand would be a story about me." He turned from the screen. "I would rather she found it than was given it."

"She will find it," Daniel said.

"I expect so."

Aisyah looked at the fourth word for a long moment.

"No law requires that door," she said.

"No."

"It is the door they will name in the first paragraph. Controlled distribution outside the command chain."

"Then the first paragraph should be true."

She did not argue. Her face said what her mouth did not: that she had watched him learn this and wished, a little, that she had not been the one to teach it.

"Before any of it moves," Rahman said, "every name that could get someone killed comes out. That is why you are here."

Farid's counsel started to speak. Farid raised two fingers and he stopped.

"You are asking me to decide who is protected."

"No. I am asking you to say who you believe is a living source. Aisyah checks every name against the sealed register Razak holds. Daniel redacts what she confirms. Razak signs. You propose, she verifies, he signs." Rahman paused. "Nobody decides alone."

Farid was quiet.

"Three keys," he said.

"Four, with the prosecutor."

Something moved in Farid's face. It was not agreement. It was nearer to recognition, the look of a man shown his own method turned the right way up.

They worked until almost two.

Farid flagged fourteen names. It went slowly, line by line, Aisyah reading each against the register, Daniel blacking out each one she confirmed. Twelve matched. For twelve, the man across the table was exactly what he had said he was for thirty years, someone who knew where a life depended on a name staying unwritten, and Rahman watched him say so without ornament.

The thirteenth did not match.

"Retired in 2007," Aisyah said. "The officer from the 2002 memorandum. You held his referral and transferred him instead."

"He was useful."

"He is not in the register."

"He was useful," Farid said again, more quietly.

"Useful is not a category in the register."

Farid looked at the name. Rahman saw him look for the next argument and, for once, fail to find one.

"Take him out of the list," Farid said.

Daniel left the name where it was, unredacted. The fourteenth failed the same test and went the same way. Nobody said anything. It was the first time Rahman had seen Farid lose a point and not go looking for another, and he found he took no satisfaction from it.

Near the end, Daniel spoke without lifting his eyes from the manifest.

"If you release all of it, they will use your mistakes to attack the case."

"Yes."

"They may survive because you told the truth too completely."

"Maybe."

Aisyah's face changed then, not softening exactly, but recognising the cost.

"Sir, I can file the internal report separately. It gives the prosecution cleaner space."

"No."

Farid closed his eyes.

"Rahman."

"Harun exposed too soon. You buried too much. I have spent my career standing between those two mistakes and calling it judgement."

He laid his hand flat on the evidence drive.

"No more versions."

Nobody moved. Outside, the city went on with its ordinary noise. Traffic. Phones. A door somewhere. A world that did not know how often its safety depended on tired people choosing the less convenient truth.

Rahman signed the transfer record. Then he signed the disclosure note naming his own breaches, and under the last line he wrote the date and the time and nothing else.

He thought of his father's sentence. If you cannot change the world, don't become another source of its damage. For thirty-five years he had read it as a warning against doing wrong. Tonight he read it as a warning against hiding it.

Aisyah took both documents.

"I will witness the submission."

Farid stood. He looked older than he had at the start of the evening, and for a second he seemed to consider asking to stay until it was sent. His counsel touched his sleeve. He thought better of it.

"They will not forgive you," he said.

"Good," Rahman said.

"Good?"

"Forgiveness is too easy when nobody has to know what was done."

Farid held his eyes a moment longer. Then he went out between his counsel and the IID escort, and the door closed on the sound of three sets of footsteps.

Grace stayed after the others had gone to eat. She had asked, earlier, for an hour with the redaction list, and nobody had asked why.

When Rahman looked in on her at midnight, she was reading names that were not on the board. Clerks. Cleaners. A records officer who had

signed a form in 1999 because a senior told him to. A woman called Sabariah, who had pushed a trolley down the same corridor for nineteen years and who appeared in the archive plan only because a reference to the lower door had been checked against her memory.

“They are not in the case,” Grace said.

“No.”

“But if you release the building plans, you release who told us about the building.”

“Then take her out.”

“She will notice she has been taken out. She will think it means something.”

“What do you want?”

“I want to ring her before it is public. Not to warn her. To tell her that she did nothing wrong.”

Rahman considered the request for longer than it deserved. In thirty-five years he had not once phoned a cleaner to say that. He wondered how many of his witnesses might have wanted the call.

“Ring her in the morning,” he said. “From your own phone. Say it plainly.”

Grace nodded and went on reading. She did not look up again until she had finished every name.

At two Rafiq came in with the courier schedule in his hand and his jacket over his arm, and the look of a man who had spent an hour arguing with himself about trust.

“Four packets. Eight couriers. Each pair knows its own door and nothing else.”

“And the drivers?”

“Rented. Cash. Different companies, different plates.” He laid the sheet on the table. “Nobody carries more than one door. If a pair is stopped, the other three still arrive.”

“And you?”

“I take the Public Prosecutor’s myself.”

“Rafiq.”

“It is the one door where I would rather not trust a stranger.” He did not smile. “You taught me that. It took thirty years and a very bad week.”

Rahman looked at the schedule. Eight names, four routes, no repetition.

It was, he thought, the cleanest piece of work CID had ever produced for him, and the first one built on the assumption that someone was listening.

At 02:40 Daniel read the manifest aloud, the first and last eight characters of each hash, while Aisyah followed along on paper. Four doors, one manifest. When each acknowledgement came back she logged the time and the recipient's confirmation of the hash. IID. The deputy public prosecutor's office. The oversight secretariat. Last, through counsel, the two editors, whose confirmations came in forty seconds apart and which she logged with the same flat care as the rest.

Four places, Rahman thought. If one was lost, three remained.

"Is that all of it?" Daniel asked. "Every door?"

Rahman looked at the sealed packet, at Harun's handwriting visible through the plastic, at Aisyah's waiting pen.

"Every door the law opens."

He paused.

"And one it doesn't. That one is mine."

Aisyah wrote the final time in the log. Then she signed it, and held the pen out to him, and he signed under her.

Afterwards he sat alone with his phone. He had not spoken to Mariam since the morning. He typed: Home late. Tomorrow will be loud. The reply came before he put the phone down. Eat something.

The choice had been small.

That was why it mattered.

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

THE BLUE SILENCE

KOTA ARUNA — 2026

By nine in the morning, the story had escaped every room designed to contain it.

The first public statement came from the Office of the Public Prosecutor.

Short.

Careful.

A multi-agency criminal and integrity investigation has been opened into allegations involving unauthorised disclosure of police information, historical interference with investigations, corruption-related offences, evidence irregularities and possible abuse of institutional authority.

No names.

No Circle.

No ORION.

No Farid.

No Rahman.

That lasted eleven minutes.

Then one investigative desk published a verified report establishing that senior MNPS officers had, over multiple years, restricted or redirected investigations involving police-linked information channels.

The article did not publish source identities.

Did not publish operational methods.

Did not claim a single criminal syndicate controlled the police.

It was more damaging because it was careful.

At 9:26, Hana's publication released its own report.

Different documents.

Different verification.

Same conclusion.

Certain senior officers had known that criminal intermediaries and compromised police access were intersecting.

Some had chosen containment over exposure.

The reports cited authenticated records from different sources.

Independent hashes matched.

By ten, nobody could dismiss the material as one leak.

By eleven, MNPS headquarters was surrounded by cameras.

By noon, the country had learned a phrase nobody in ORION had intended to make public.

historical institutional containment

It sounded bloodless.

The public understood it anyway.

Rahman watched the first press conference from Secure Operations Centre 4.

The Director-General of the MNPS stood before a blue backdrop.

Beside him:

a deputy prosecutor.

a senior IID representative.

two officials from an external oversight body.

No triumph.

No denial.

The Director-General looked as though he had aged ten years overnight.

“Serious allegations have been raised.”

Flashes.

“We will not prejudge any individual.”

More flashes.

“The Malaysian National Police Service will cooperate fully.”

Questions erupted.

“Is there a criminal network inside MNPS?”

“Did senior police protect organised crime?”

“Was evidence buried?”

“How many officers are involved?”

“Is DCP Rahman Aziz a whistleblower?”

“Is Datuk Farid Kamal under investigation?”

“Was Task Force ORION operating illegally?”

The Director-General raised a hand.

“We will not speculate.”

Daniel stood beside Rahman.

“That phrase has never stopped speculation.”

Aisyah was reading three preservation orders at once.

“Not now.”

Daniel nodded.

He had stopped joking properly two hours earlier.

The Director-General continued.

“Several officers have been placed on temporary administrative leave pending investigation.”

Rahman heard Rafiq exhale behind him.

There it was.

No names.

Not yet.

Aisyah’s phone vibrated.

She read.

Her face changed.

“What?”

Rahman asked.

“Farid.”

Silence.

“Suspended?”

“No.”

She looked at him.

“Detention authority approved.”

Farid was taken into custody at 13:10.

Not by tactical officers.

No spectacle.

Two IID investigators and one prosecutor entered his office.

His counsel was present.

Farid surrendered his secure credentials.

His access card.

Official phone.

Office keys.

He removed his jacket before they asked.

A secretary cried in the corridor.

Farid told her:

“Please don’t.”

She covered her mouth.

Rahman watched from twenty metres away.

He had not intended to be there.

Then Farid saw him.

“Rahman.”

The investigators paused.

Aisyah stood nearby.

She looked at Rahman once.

His decision.

He walked over.

Farid’s hands were not cuffed.

Not yet.

The senior IID officer said:

“Two minutes.”

Farid nodded.

The corridor around them felt too public despite being almost empty.

Years of command had trained both men not to speak carelessly in hallways.

Now it no longer mattered in the same way.

Farid looked toward the windows.

Outside, reporters crowded the gate.

“You sent it.”

“Yes.”

“Multiple channels.”

“Yes.”

Farid almost smiled.

“Harun would have liked the redundancy.”

Rahman did not answer.

Farid looked tired.

Not frightened.

Not relieved.

Something between.

“How bad?”

Rahman asked.

“For me?”

"For the service."

Farid glanced toward the press below.

"Bad enough."

"That is not an answer."

"No."

Farid looked back at him.

"Some good officers will pay for this."

"I know."

"Some careers will end because people cannot distinguish authorised contact from corruption."

"We are trying to separate them."

"Trying."

"Yes."

Farid nodded.

"At least you understand the problem."

Rahman said:

"I understood it before."

"No."

Farid's voice remained calm.

"You understood it intellectually."

A pause.

"Now you will understand what public anger does to nuance."

Rahman looked toward the gates.

"Heard any regret?"

Farid considered.

"For what?"

Rahman almost laughed.

Farid continued.

"I regret things."

"Containment?"

"Yes."

"ORION?"

"No."

"Harun?"

Farid's face changed.

"Yes."

That was all.

The investigators shifted behind him.

Time.

Farid looked at Rahman.

"Who protects the police now?"

Rahman answered without thinking.

"The police."

Farid held his gaze.

Then, quietly:

"Then make sure they protect the right thing."

The IID officer stepped forward.

Farid nodded once.

Allowed himself to be turned toward the lift.

This time they cuffed him.

Not dramatically.

Procedure.

Metal.

Click.

Rahman watched the doors close.

No victory came.

By evening, six businesses had been searched.

Two linked to the warehouse network.

One document-services company.

One logistics broker.

One advisory firm.

One corporate-services office.

One former subcontractor to RZ Meridian.

Zafir Razak's properties were searched again under expanded warrants.

He was not found.

Raziq Jamal remained missing.

Badrul Nizam Yacob was charged with several offences related to unlawful possession and facilitation of protected information.

Farhan Zakaria's charges were expanded.

Not to include Hafiz's critical leak.

Aisyah insisted on that.

His real misconduct was enough.

Amirul Hakim entered formal cooperation under legal supervision.

Three senior officers were suspended.

Two retired officers were summoned for interview.

One former intelligence official hired counsel before investigators reached him.

Another resigned from a government advisory board before sunrise.

No one knew whether the resignation meant guilt.

The press treated it as proof anyway.

Daniel threw a remote control onto the table.

Aisyah looked at him.

"What?"

"They are calling everyone a Circle member."

Rahman turned toward the television.

A panel discussion showed photographs.

Farid.

Farhan.

Rahim Nasir.

Zafir.

Raziq.

Then Rahman himself.

A graphic:

WHO WAS INSIDE THE CIRCLE?

Daniel said:

"We explicitly said no membership model."

Grace, on video call from the financial review team, replied:

"The public likes nouns."

Aisyah said:

"So do investigators."

Rahman looked at Rahim Nasir's photograph.

Dead officially.

Alive only as question.

Now his face sat beside actual charged officers on national television.

Exactly the danger Farid had warned about.

Rahman hated that.

The warning had been right.

The silence had still been wrong.

Both remained true.

The institution reacted in layers.

Senior command issued instructions on media contact.

Then withdrew them after journalists published the instruction as evidence of attempted suppression.

District commanders held integrity briefings.

Some officers applauded.

Others sat with folded arms.

Police associations demanded protection for officers falsely implicated through historical contact.

Retired officers appeared on television defending the service.

Others called for resignations.

Social media did what it always did.

Simplified.

Amplified.

Punished before proof.

One video called every MNPS officer corrupt.

Another called ORION traitors.

Another claimed Farid had personally commanded organised crime for thirty years.

No evidence.

Millions of views.

Aisyah watched thirty seconds and turned it off.

"Useful?"

Daniel asked.

"No."

"Accurate?"

"Less."

Rafiq stood near the window.

His face had not relaxed all day.

"My men are getting shouted at on traffic stops."

Rahman looked at him.

Rafiq continued.

"Patrol officers. constables. people who have never seen an ORION file in their lives."

Aisyah said nothing.

Rafiq looked toward the press outside.

"They get called thieves because of people they never met."

Rahman said:

"I know."

"No."

Rafiq turned.

"You know the institutional argument."

His voice was harder.

"You don't know what it feels like in a district station tonight."

Rahman accepted it.

"Then tell me."

Rafiq looked surprised.

Rahman waited.

Rafiq said:

"They're angry."

"Yes."

"Embarrassed."

"Yes."

"Some are scared every old decision is going to be treated like corruption."

"Yes."

"Some think you burned the uniform."

Rahman felt the words.

"And you?"

Rafiq looked away.

"I haven't decided."

That was honest.

Rahman respected him more for it.

At the Kota Aruna Central District station, Inspector Imran Taib watched a young constable remove his name tag before going to lunch.

Imran stopped him.

"Why?"

The constable looked embarrassed.

"People outside."

"What people?"

"Just people."

"Put it back."

The constable hesitated.

"Sir."

"Put it back."

He did.

Imran was still new enough to remember when the uniform had felt like becoming something larger.

Old enough now to understand that larger things could shame the people inside them.

The station television showed Rahman's photograph.

A commentator called him courageous.

Another called him reckless.

The constable looked at Imran.

"Sir, did he do the right thing?"

Imran watched the screen.

He remembered Idris Hamzah's retirement.

Rahman standing near the front.

Farid beside him.

The grey-haired stranger in the crowd.

Everything ordinary before it wasn't.

Imran said:

"I don't know."

The constable looked disappointed.

Imran understood.

Young officers wanted clean answers.

He had too.

"What do we do then?"

Imran looked toward the charge counter.

A woman waited to report a stolen motorcycle.

An elderly man argued about a missing wallet.

Two officers were preparing to leave for a domestic-violence call.

Normal work.

The service had not stopped existing because people inside it failed.

Imran said:

"We do today properly."

The constable frowned.

"That's it?"

"For now."

He pointed toward the woman at the counter.

"Start there."

The constable went.

Imran looked once more at Rahman's face on television.

He thought of something an instructor had once said.

The uniform did not make you honest.

Choices did.

Imran did not know the instructor had learned it from someone else.

He only knew the sentence felt heavier now.

Hana published nothing about the live source identities.

That disappointed part of her newsroom.

One editor wanted more.

Names.

Photographs.

The scandal already had momentum.

Hana refused.

"We cannot verify criminality."

"But we can verify contact."

"Contact is not criminality."

"Public deserves to know."

"The public deserves not to be lied to by implication."

The argument lasted forty minutes.

Hana won narrowly.

Her second article explained the distinction between compromised access and legitimate intelligence contact.

It received less attention than the first.

She expected that.

Truth with caveats rarely travelled as fast as accusation.

Rahman read it on his office monitor.

Not because she was his daughter.

Because she had done the thing he had spent years struggling to do.

Disclose without pretending context was optional.

He sent no message.

Not yet.

The IID notification arrived at 16:35 the following day.

Aisyah delivered it.

She stood in Rahman's doorway holding a sealed envelope.

He knew from her face.

"What?"

"Administrative order."

He took it.

Read.

DCP DATO' RAHMAN AZIZ

TEMPORARY SUSPENSION FROM OPERATIONAL COMMAND PENDING INTEGRITY AND DISCIPLINARY REVIEW

Grounds included:

historical procedural deviations.

unauthorised operational extensions.

possible incomplete reporting to wider command structures.

the 2014 compromised deployment.

controlled distribution of ORION material outside conventional command channels.

No accusation of corruption.

No presumption of guilt.

Immediate surrender of operational credentials.

Rahman read it twice.

Then folded the paper.

Aisyah watched.

"Effective when?"

"Now."

"Yes."

"ORION command?"

"Transferred temporarily."

"To?"

"Razak for evidentiary preservation. Rafiq for active operational coordination pending senior appointment."

Rahman nodded.

That made sense.

Aisyah said:

"You can challenge."

"No."

"You should read full grounds first."

"I did."

"You can contest the suspension without contesting investigation."

Rahman looked at her.

"I know."

"Then?"

He removed his access card.

Placed it on the desk.

His secure token next.

Official device.

Then the small black notebook he used for command notes.

Aisyah looked at the notebook.

“That stays yours if no classified material.”

Rahman opened it.

Several pages contained ORION references.

He handed it over.

“Review.”

Aisyah took it.

“Rahman.”

“Yes.”

“You don’t have to make this symbolic.”

“I’m not.”

She stared.

He almost smiled.

“You think I am.”

“Yes.”

“Fair.”

He looked at the suspension order.

“Is the review justified?”

Aisyah did not answer quickly.

“Yes.”

Rahman nodded.

“Then it happens.”

“You may be cleared on some findings.”

“Yes.”

“Disciplined on others.”

“Yes.”

“Your controlled distribution may be defended as protected disclosure or treated as command misconduct.”

“Yes.”

“You could lose rank.”

“Yes.”

“Career.”

Rahman looked toward the glass wall.

ORION staff moved beyond it.

People working.

Not waiting for him.

"Yes."

Aisyah's face softened.

"I'm sorry."

Rahman looked at her.

"For what?"

"This."

He thought.

"You investigated me."

"Yes."

"You were right to."

Her eyes changed.

"Not about everything."

"No."

"Enough."

He looked at the access card on the desk.

"If accountability only reaches the men I dislike, it is not accountability."

Aisyah said nothing.

Rahman pushed the card toward her.

"Take it."

She did.

News of his suspension leaked in twenty-three minutes.

This time Rahman did not care how.

Headlines:

ORION COMMANDER SUSPENDED

WHISTLEBLOWER OR RULE-BREAKER?

RAHMAN AZIZ UNDER INTERNAL REVIEW

POLICE SCANDAL WIDENS

Some supporters called it retaliation.

Others called it proof that Rahman himself was corrupt.

Both annoyed him.

Mariam read the headlines at home.

When he arrived, she opened the door before he could use his key.

"You're suspended."

"Yes."

"Are you surprised?"

"No."

"Hurt?"

"Yes."

"Good."

Rahman looked at her.

She almost smiled.

"You told me not to let you hide feelings behind procedure."

He removed his shoes.

"I regret that conversation."

"No, you don't."

"No."

They sat.

Mariam asked:

"What happens?"

"Review."

"Will you fight it?"

"The findings."

"Yes."

"The suspension?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because Aisyah was right."

Mariam waited.

Rahman continued.

"If I insist the rules apply to Farid but not me because my reasons were better, then everything we did was useless."

Mariam reached for his hand.

He took it.

This time immediately.

Outside the service, consequences widened.

One former senior officer was arrested on suspicion of obstructing an old integrity inquiry.

Another was released after interview with no charge.

The distinction barely appeared in headlines.

A logistics company voluntarily suspended operations after banks froze facilities.

Two innocent employees were harassed online because their names appeared on company records.

Hana wrote about that too.

A witness connected to one old case requested protective relocation.

A retired source handler publicly denied wrongdoing and privately provided investigators with records that supported his claim.

One law firm threatened defamation proceedings against three media organisations.

Another surrendered old client files under court order.

Some historical suspicions died under scrutiny.

Others strengthened.

The Circle did not emerge as one monster.

It became less satisfying.

More human.

Specific decisions.

Specific favours.

Specific compromises.

Some deliberate.

Some opportunistic.

Some rationalised.

Some merely adjacent.

Rahman thought that was better.

Truth should become more precise as it grew.

Not more dramatic.

Three days after Farid's detention, Rahman was called to IID headquarters as a witness and subject.

No operational badge.

No command staff.

He entered through the same security line as everyone else.

A young constable at the desk recognised him.

"Dato'."

Rahman handed over identification.

The constable hesitated.

"Sir, I just want to say—"

Rahman stopped him gently.

"Don't."
The young man looked embarrassed.
"You don't know what the evidence will say."
The constable nodded.
Rahman saw himself at twenty-three.
Certain that integrity lived in people.
Then at thirty-eight.
Certain outcomes could justify exceptional decisions.
Then now.
Less certain.
Maybe better.
"Do your job," Rahman said.
"Yes, sir."
Rahman continued toward the interview room.
Farid was brought through the corridor during a break.
Different escort.
Different legal team.
Still detained.
Their paths crossed.
The officers looked uncertain whether to separate them.
Aisyah, present for Rahman's interview, said:
"One minute."
Farid looked at Rahman's plain clothes.
"They suspended you."
"Yes."
"For ORION?"
"Among other things."
"Historical breaches."
"Yes."
Farid almost smiled.
"You could challenge it."
"I will challenge findings I think are wrong."
"Not suspension?"
"No."
Farid studied him.
"Why?"
Rahman looked at him.

"You know why."

Farid did.

His expression changed.

A little.

"You think this makes you different from me."

"No."

That answer surprised him.

Rahman continued.

"Accepting review does not erase what I did."

"No."

"It only means I don't get to decide alone whether it was justified."

Farid looked away.

The escort waited.

Rahman said:

"You were right about one thing."

Farid looked back.

"Which?"

"Exposure hurts innocent people too."

Farid's expression did not change.

"And?"

"And that still didn't give you the right to bury the guilty with them."

Farid nodded slowly.

"I know."

Maybe he did now.

Maybe too late.

The officers moved him on.

That evening, Inspector Imran Taib found Rahman outside headquarters.

Rahman had finished seven hours of IID questioning.

No rank authority.

No task force.

He was walking toward the public parking area.

"Dato'."

Rahman stopped.

Imran approached.

Still in uniform.

Properly worn.

His collar straight this time.

Rahman noticed.

“Inspector.”

“I heard about the suspension.”

“So did everyone.”

Imran looked uncomfortable.

“I wanted to say something.”

Rahman waited.

Imran said:

“Some officers think you betrayed the service.”

“Yes.”

“Some think you saved it.”

Rahman looked at him.

“And you?”

Imran hesitated.

“I think both groups are trying to make it easier.”

Rahman almost smiled.

“Good.”

Imran continued.

“My station is getting abuse.”

“I know.”

“People look at us differently.”

“Yes.”

“My constables are ashamed.”

Rahman’s smile disappeared.

Imran said:

“I was angry at you.”

“That is allowed.”

“I still am, a little.”

Rahman nodded.

“Also allowed.”

Imran looked toward headquarters.

“But today one of my men tried to skip logging a small evidence transfer because he said everything is chaos anyway.”

Rahman waited.

“I made him go back and do it properly.”

“Good.”

“He complained.”

“Better.”

Imran smiled despite himself.

Then became serious.

“Is that how we fix this?”

Rahman looked at the building.

Thousands of officers inside.

Most never touched The Circle.

Most never saw Farid’s files.

Most wanted to finish shift and go home.

Some honest.

Some weak.

Some ambitious.

Some tired.

Some dangerous.

An institution made of people, not slogans.

“No,” Rahman said.

Imran frowned.

“No?”

“That is how you start.”

The young inspector absorbed it.

Rahman thought of himself at Seri Merbau.

Harun.

His father.

The uniform.

Amanah.

Authority borrowed from people who would never know his name.

“Do the small things properly,” Rahman said.

“Yes.”

“And when the big thing comes, don’t assume being a good officer means you get to stop explaining yourself.”

Imran looked at him.

“Is that what happened to Farid?”

Rahman thought.

“Partly.”

“And you?”

The question surprised him.

Good.

Rahman answered:

"Partly."

Imran nodded.

No hero worship.

Better.

The final public development came one week after the files were distributed.

The government announced an independent commission of inquiry into historical police integrity failures and intelligence-containment practices.

MNPS announced structural reforms to evidence auditing, source-management review and cross-directorate access.

The public prosecutor confirmed criminal investigations involving several officers and civilians.

No grand declaration that The Circle had been destroyed.

Because it had not.

No announcement that the police were clean.

Because institutions were not absolved by press releases.

No one could say how many prosecutions would survive.

Some cases were already weakening.

Evidence too old.

Witnesses dead.

Records incomplete.

Memory unreliable.

Law did not become easier because moral truth had finally become visible.

Rahman watched the announcement from home.

Suspended.

Under review.

Mariam beside him.

Hana at work.

Adam arguing about procedural fairness with someone on the phone upstairs.

Life continued.

On television, crowds stood outside MNPS headquarters.

Some carried signs demanding resignations.

Some demanded prosecution.
One sign read:
WHO POLICES THE POLICE?
Rahman looked at it.
Mariam noticed.
“What?”
“Nothing.”
She gave him a look.
Rahman corrected himself.
“Old question.”
“Answer?”
He thought of Farid.
Who protects the police now?
The police.
But not the police alone.
Courts.
Investigators.
Prosecutors.
Journalists.
Oversight.
Citizens.
Rules.
Records.
Officers willing to accuse their own commander.
Commanders willing to be investigated.
No single protector.
That was the lesson too.
Rahman said:
“Everyone who refuses to let them protect the wrong thing.”
Mariam leaned back.
“That is a very long answer.”
“I am improving.”
“Slowly.”
He smiled.
Late that night, Rahman took his uniform from the wardrobe.
Not to wear.
His suspension order prohibited operational duty.

He laid the jacket across the bed.
Dark blue.
Medals.
Name.
Rank.
Years.
Mariam stood in the doorway.
Rahman touched the fabric.
For most of his life, the uniform had meant honour.
Then authority.
Then access.
Then responsibility.
Then compromise.
Now something simpler.
Amanah.
A trust.
Not ownership.
Not identity.
Borrowed authority.
Something that could be taken back.
Mariam said:
“What are you doing?”
Rahman looked at the jacket.
“Putting it away.”
“For how long?”
“I don’t know.”
That answer no longer frightened him as much.
He removed the rank insignia carefully.
Not theatrically.
Not resignation.
Suspension.
Procedure.
Review.
He placed the uniform in its cover.
Hung it at the back of the wardrobe.
Then closed the door.
No music.

No final speech.

No absolution.

Only consequence.

Across Kota Aruna, blue lights still moved through the night.

Traffic stops.

Missing children.

Domestic violence.

Robberies.

Accidents.

Noise complaints.

Deaths.

Ordinary emergencies that did not pause for institutional scandal.

Honest officers answered calls while strangers insulted them.

Compromised officers wondered whether old files would surface.

Investigators carried boxes into secure rooms.

Prosecutors argued over admissibility.

Journalists verified names.

Families waited.

Some people resigned.

Some denied.

Some confessed.

Some lied.

Some were cleared.

Farid remained in custody.

Rahman remained suspended.

The Circle, whatever parts of it still existed, did not collapse because one truth had been released.

But its protection had changed.

Silence was no longer automatic.

That mattered.

For decades, the blue uniform had carried another kind of silence inside it.

Loyalty.

Discretion.

Protection.

Fear of scandal.

Fear of weakening the institution by admitting what was wrong inside it.

Sometimes that silence had protected investigations.

Sometimes officers.

Sometimes the public.

And sometimes it had protected the wrong thing for so long that no one remembered the difference.

Now the silence had been broken.

Not destroyed.

Broken.

Enough for sound to pass through.

Rahman stood at the bedroom window.

Far below, a patrol car moved along the wet street.

Blue lights reflected against the buildings.

For years, he had believed protecting the police meant defending the institution from what threatened it.

Now he understood the harder responsibility.

Sometimes the threat was what the institution had taught itself not to say.

And sometimes protecting the uniform meant allowing the truth to stain it.

So that one day, perhaps, someone younger could wear it without inheriting the silence.

CHAPTER FORTY

THE MAN IN THE CROWD

KOTA ARUNA — THREE MONTHS LATER

Rahman learned retirement and suspension had one thing in common.

Both made mornings too quiet.

He still woke before dawn.

For thirty-five years, his body had understood that waking early meant someone needed something.

A briefing.

An arrest.

A source.

A border crossing.

A dead officer.

A decision.

Now there was only the ceiling fan and the faint sound of traffic beginning on the road below.

He lay awake until the azan.

Then got up.

Mariam was already in the kitchen when he came downstairs.

“You’re getting worse.”

Rahman looked at her.

“At what?”

“Retirement.”

“I’m not retired.”

“You have been suspended for three months.”

“Temporarily.”

“Mm.”

He poured water.

Mariam was slicing papaya.

There was something almost aggressive in how ordinary the scene felt.

A bowl.

Two plates.

Coffee.

Morning news muted on the television.

Rahman sat at the table.

Mariam placed fruit in front of him.

“You have an interview at ten.”

“Yes.”

“Your lawyer?”

“Yes.”

“Another integrity review?”

“Disciplinary panel.”

She nodded.

“Good.”

Rahman looked at her.

“Good?”

“You complained for years nobody investigated senior officers properly.”

“That does not mean I enjoy being investigated.”

“It would be strange if you did.”

He ate one piece of papaya.

Mariam watched.

“What?”

“You’re thinking.”

“I always think.”

“That is also getting worse.”

He almost smiled.

On the television, a headline passed beneath footage of MNPS headquarters.

The independent commission had begun public hearings.

Farid remained under criminal investigation.

Two cases against former officers had moved toward prosecution.

One had collapsed for lack of admissible evidence.

Three suspended officers had been cleared of corruption but remained under administrative review for disclosure failures.

Farhan had pleaded guilty to unauthorised disclosure and corrupt receipt.

Not to Hafiz.

Never Hafiz.

That distinction survived.

Rahman was grateful.

Zafir Razak had been arrested in Kota Lagenda six weeks earlier after a joint operation unrelated to ORION's original warrant.

Raziq Jamal remained missing.

Badrul's case was proceeding.

The external review of historical source handling had cleared several retired officers whose names had been circulated recklessly online.

Hana had written about every one of them.

Public anger had not disappeared.

Neither had public support.

MNPS recruiting numbers had dropped.

Complaints to IID had risen.

Anonymous internal reporting had risen too.

Some officers called that damage.

Others called it overdue.

Rahman had stopped pretending both could not be true.

Mariam sat opposite him.

"What are you going to do today?"

"Panel."

"After."

"I don't know."

"Tomorrow?"

"I don't know."

"Next month?"

Rahman looked at her.

Mariam waited.

He knew what she was asking.

Not schedule.

Life.

"What will you do without the police?"

Once, the question would have offended him.

Without the police.

As though the uniform could simply disappear and leave a blank space where a man had been.

Rahman looked down at his hands.

For most of his adult life, every answer had begun with rank.

Posting.

Command.

Case.

Duty.

He had spent years telling himself the work did not define him.

He had believed that.

Mostly.

Now, for the first time, he had to test it.

"I don't know."

Mariam smiled.

Not happily.

Not sadly.

Just recognition.

"Good."

Rahman frowned.

"Why does everyone keep saying that?"

"Because you finally mean it."

He looked at her.

She reached across the table and moved his coffee slightly away from the edge.

A small thing.

Thirty years of marriage contained thousands of them.

Rahman said:

"I might teach."

"You dislike students."

"I dislike careless students."

"You dislike careful students too."

"Sometimes."

She smiled.

"You could write."

"No."

"Very strong reaction."

"I have spent my entire career telling people not to put sensitive information in writing."

"You would make an excellent memoirist."

He almost laughed.

That was new too.

Not laughter.

The fact that it came more easily.

The disciplinary panel lasted two hours and seventeen minutes.

Rahman answered questions about Musa Halim.

The 2014 deployment.

Historical reporting.

Kelana.

The ORION distribution.

No one called him hero.

No one called him traitor.

That helped.

His counsel argued the ORION disclosure had been structured, proportionate and motivated by legitimate fear of institutional suppression.

The panel noted that he had bypassed conventional command.

Both facts remained.

The 2006 breach was treated similarly.

Operational success.

Unauthorised extension.

Lives likely saved.

Command not properly informed.

Both.

Rahman no longer tried to make one cancel the other.

When the chair asked whether he believed his decisions had been justified, Rahman answered:

"Some."

"And the others?"

"I believed they were justified at the time."

"That was not the question."

Rahman almost smiled.

Aisyah had infected the whole service.

"No," he said. "Some were not."

The chair looked at him.

"Which?"

Rahman told them.

Not everything.

Everything asked.

That distinction mattered now.

When he left the building, no reporters waited.

The scandal had learned to move on.

Another minister.

Another company collapse.

A flood warning in the north.

Three months was a long time in public anger.

Not in institutions.

Rahman drove home by a route he had not used in years.

Along the river.

Past the old commercial district.

Past a warehouse that had once appeared in Harun's notes and was now a furniture showroom.

Past the road where he had followed people who were now dead.

Kota Aruna had always been good at building over memory.

He stopped at a traffic light.

Across the junction, a young patrol officer helped an elderly motorcyclist push a stalled bike out of traffic.

No cameras.

No audience.

Just work.

Rahman watched.

Green light.

Someone behind him honked.

He drove on.

Hana received the package at 14:12.

It was left with reception at her newsroom.

No courier name.

No return address.

Brown paper.

Her name typed.

Not handwritten.

She almost opened it at her desk.

Then stopped.

Three months of reporting on institutional secrecy had taught her one useful thing:

interesting packages deserved boring procedure.

She photographed the exterior.

Logged time.

Called her editor.

Called legal.

Then called Rahman.

He answered on the second ring.

“What?”

“Hello to you too.”

“I’m driving.”

“I got something.”

His tone changed.

“What?”

“Package. Anonymous.”

“Do not open it.”

“I knew you’d say that.”

“Have you?”

“No.”

“Good.”

“Legal is here.”

“Good.”

“Editor too.”

“Good.”

“You know, sometimes you could try being less predictable.”

Rahman pulled over.

“Describe it.”

“Brown paper. My name typed. No return address. About the size of a book.”

Rahman felt something move in his chest.

“A book?”

“Maybe.”

“Any smell?”

Hana paused.

“Seriously?”

“Yes.”
“No.”
“Powder?”
“No.”
“Wires?”
“Dad.”
“I’m asking.”
“No.”
“Then follow your office protocol.”
“We are.”
Rahman looked through the windscreen.
Ordinary afternoon.
A delivery rider waiting under a flyover.
Schoolchildren crossing.
Nothing.
“Call me after.”
“I was actually calling because I thought you might want to be here.”
Rahman hesitated.
That surprised him.
“Why?”
“I don’t know.”
That answer was enough.
“I’m coming.”
The newsroom conference room was too modern for Harun.
Glass walls.
White table.
Screens everywhere.
Hana’s editor sat at one end.
A lawyer at the other.
A security officer stood near the door.
The package lay inside a transparent evidence sleeve.
Hana looked at Rahman as he entered.
“Happy?”
“No.”
“Good. Consistent.”
He ignored her.
The package had been screened.

No explosive indicators.
No chemical hazard.
No electronics.
The lawyer said:
“We’re opening under camera.”
Rahman nodded.
Not his decision.
He appreciated that.
Hana put on gloves.
Cut the paper.
Inside was a black notebook.
Rahman stopped breathing.
Not similar.
Not the same type.
The notebook.
Harun’s.
Or one of them.
Black cloth cover.
Rounded corners.
Elastic long since gone.
Older than the archive copy.
More worn.
Rahman moved closer.
“Don’t touch.”
Hana looked at him.
“I know.”
The front page carried handwriting.
Harun Ismail.
No rank.
No case number.
Just his name.
Rahman sat down.
Hana looked at him.
“You recognise it.”
“Yes.”
“Original?”
“I don’t know.”

“You look like you know.”
“I know the handwriting.”
The lawyer said:
“We photograph before turning pages.”
They did.
Slowly.
Carefully.
The first entries were familiar.
Fragments of 17/94.
Vehicle numbers.
Companies.
Questions.
Some material duplicated from the hidden archive.
But this notebook was different.
Earlier.
Messier.
Less formal.
Several pages were missing.
One section had been cut out cleanly.
Rahman felt his pulse change.
Page thirty-seven.
A note.
Then missing pages.
Then another section.
He knew immediately.
“This is the missing portion.”
Hana looked at him.
“From the archive notebook?”
“Yes.”
“How do you know?”
“Page sequence.”
They documented.
The lawyer nodded.
Hana continued.
The missing pages were not dramatic at first.
A restaurant address.
Three partial vehicle plates.

A note about an unnamed police contact.

A company that no longer existed.

Then:

If this copy survives, assume official file does not.

Next page:

Do not trust continuity to mean command. People change faster than the need they fill.

Rahman felt Daniel's functional model return.

Broker.

Keeper.

Protector.

Accountant.

Harun had never reached the final terminology.

But he had seen it forming.

Hana read silently.

Then stopped.

"Dad."

Rahman looked.

One page contained a sentence alone at the top.

If you are reading this, they survived.

Nobody spoke.

Rahman leaned closer.

Below the sentence were three names.

No explanation.

No roles.

No arrows.

Just names.

The first belonged to a logistics intermediary who had died in prison in 2004.

The second to a former commercial fixer killed in a road accident in 2012.

Rahman knew both from Harun's archive.

The third:

RAHIM NASIR

Hana looked up.

"The dead businessman."

Rahman nodded.

“Officially.”
The lawyer said:
“That word matters.”
“Yes.”
Hana looked back at the page.
“‘They survived’ could mean the people.”
“Yes.”
“Or the relationships.”
“Yes.”
“Or the function.”
“Yes.”
“Or something else.”
“Yes.”
She stared at him.
“You’re being very calm.”
“No.”
He was not.
Inside the notebook was an envelope.
Thin.
Taped to the rear cover.
The adhesive had failed with age.
Inside:
one photograph.
Not old.
Not 1998.
Not 2007.
Recent enough that the paper stock and print quality were modern.
A street scene.
Kota Aruna.
A man crossing outside a café.
Grey hair.
Thinner than Rahim Nasir’s official final photographs.
Older.
No glasses.
Face turned partially toward camera.
Hana whispered:
“Oh.”

Rahman said nothing.

He knew.

Not scientifically.

Not yet.

But this was no longer only the eyes.

The shape of the face.

The walk.

The slight tilt of the head.

The old man at Idris Hamzah's retirement.

The observer without a lanyard.

Rahman saw the ceremony again.

The crowd.

Farid.

Imran.

Hana near the press area.

And the man watching him as though the meeting had been scheduled only Rahman had not known it.

Hana looked at her father.

"You recognise him."

Rahman did not answer immediately.

The discipline mattered.

He looked at the photograph.

Then at the 2007 image on Hana's laptop after she pulled it up.

Then at the saved retirement-security still.

Three faces.

Three ages.

No automated comparison.

No number.

No false precision.

But this time Rahman did not need memory to invent the connection.

The man in the recent photograph and the man at the retirement ceremony were the same person.

He was certain enough to say that.

"That is him."

"The old man?"

"Yes."

Hana looked at the retirement image.

“And Rahim?”
Rahman stared.
Likely.
Very likely.
Still not the same as proven identity.
“I think so.”
Hana sat back.
“Rahim Nasir died in 2008.”
“Yes.”
“Heart attack.”
“Yes.”
“Buried.”
“Yes.”
“Estate settled.”
“Yes.”
“So either the death was false—”
“Or the identification is wrong.”
“Or someone used his identity.”
“Yes.”
“Or the photograph is manipulated.”
“Yes.”
She looked at him.
“You always ruin the good part.”
“That is my job.”
“You’re suspended.”
Rahman almost smiled.
“Habit.”
The lawyer said:
“We authenticate the image first.”
Rahman nodded.
Good.
No resurrection.
Not yet.
No ghost made fact because the story needed one.
Only a dead man’s name.
A recent image.
A face Rahman recognised.

Enough to reopen the question.

Not enough to close it.

They found no fingerprints worth trusting on the package.

No useful return address.

The newsroom camera showed a courier dropping it at reception.

Courier account created with prepaid credentials.

Pickup from a parcel locker near Kota Aruna Central.

Footage from the locker existed.

A cap.

Mask.

Average build.

No face.

Daniel was no longer formally on ORION but still assigned to a technical review unit linked to the commission.

Hana called through official channels.

Not privately.

Rahman approved of that more than he said.

By evening, the photograph had preliminary characteristics consistent with an authentic print from a recent digital image.

No obvious editing.

Timestamp metadata absent.

The notebook paper and ink required proper examination.

Nothing proven yet.

Good.

Rahman had learned to be grateful for uncertainty when certainty arrived too easily.

He returned home after sunset.

Mariam was watering plants on the balcony.

She looked at him once.

“What happened?”

He handed her no documents.

Only told her.

Harun’s notebook.

The line.

The names.

Rahim.

The photograph.

Mariam listened without interrupting.
When he finished:
“And you think the old man at Idris’s retirement was Rahim Nasir.”
“Yes.”
“Dead Rahim Nasir.”
“Yes.”
She looked at him.
“That sounds inconvenient.”
Rahman almost laughed.
“Very.”
“Are you going back?”
“To police?”
“To this.”
He looked toward the city.
“I don’t know.”
Mariam nodded.
“Still improving.”
His phone rang.
Unknown number.
Both looked at it.
Rahman stared.
Mariam said:
“You’re going to answer.”
“Yes.”
“Speaker?”
Rahman considered.
Then nodded.
He answered.
“Rahman.”
Silence.
Not empty.
A line open somewhere.
Traffic faintly in the background.
Then a male voice.
Older.
Calm.
“You spent thirty years looking for The Circle.”

Rahman stood very still.
Mariam stopped moving.
The voice paused.
“You never asked who was looking for you.”
The line disconnected.
No threat.
No demand.
No name.
Rahman looked at the screen.
Call duration:
eleven seconds.
Mariam said:
“Who?”
“I don’t know.”
“Rahim?”
“I don’t know.”
“Farid?”
“No.”
He was too certain.
Farid remained under monitored legal restrictions.
But certainty had become expensive.
Rahman corrected himself.
“Unlikely.”
Mariam looked at him.
“What now?”
He did not answer.
Not yet.
The call was reported.
Immediately.
No private pursuit.
No old habits.
Rahman contacted Aisyah.
Then Daniel through authorised technical channels.
The number was spoofed through multiple services.
No useful subscriber identity.
No voice match sufficient for identification.
The background traffic could have been recorded.

The caller could have been anywhere.

Or nearby.

No conclusion.

Aisyah arrived at the house forty minutes later.

Not because Rahman asked.

Because the commission's protective protocol now included him as a witness.

She stood on the balcony while Daniel spoke through video from a technical lab.

"No clean trace."

Rahman nodded.

"Voice?"

"Not enough."

"Age?"

"Broad estimate only."

"Location?"

"No."

"Could be generated?"

"Possible."

"Could be live?"

"Possible."

Aisyah looked at him.

"You hate this."

"Yes."

"Good."

Rahman gave her a look.

She almost smiled.

Then became serious.

"The wording."

"Yes."

"'Who was looking for you.'"

"Yes."

"Could mean surveillance."

"Yes."

"Could mean recruitment."

"Yes."

"Could mean Harun."

Rahman looked at her.
She continued.
“Harun watched you when you were young.”
“Yes.”
“Farid watched you.”
“Yes.”
“Kelana.”
“Sometimes.”
“The Circle, if we use the word broadly.”
“Maybe.”
“Rahim.”
Rahman said nothing.
Aisyah nodded.
“Exactly.”
Too many interpretations.
No clean answer.
The old structure lived again as ambiguity.
A car moved on the street below.
Mariam saw it first.
“Rahman.”
He turned.
Black sedan.
Parked across from the row of shops opposite their building.
Engine running.
Could be a neighbour.
Ride-hailing driver.
Government car.
Private security.
Journalist.
Nothing.
Rahman stepped closer to the balcony rail.
Aisyah stopped him.
“Stay.”
“I’m staying.”
The sedan remained for five seconds.
Then pulled away.
No rush.

No lights.

No visible plate from their angle.

It turned at the junction and disappeared into Kota Aruna traffic.

Aisyah already had her phone out.

“Vehicle check.”

Rahman said:

“No assumptions.”

She looked at him.

“I know.”

Of course she did.

The sentence belonged to all of them now.

Later, after everyone left, Rahman sat alone in the living room.

Mariam had gone upstairs.

The city continued beyond the glass.

Motorcycles.

A bus.

A siren in the distance.

Somebody laughing in the car park.

A delivery rider arguing with the security guard.

Ordinary Kota Aruna.

No darkness gathering theatrically.

No hidden army waiting.

No proof the sedan meant anything.

On the coffee table lay a copy of the photograph inside a temporary protective sleeve.

Rahim Nasir.

Maybe.

The man from the crowd.

Certainly.

Officially dead.

Certainly, according to the record.

Rahman looked at the face.

He thought about all the ways an investigation could end badly.

With the wrong man arrested.

With the right man acquitted.

With the institution hiding evidence.

With the investigator loving his theory too much.

With truth arriving after law could no longer use it.

With enough truth found to act and not enough found to understand.

That last one was new.

For years, Rahman had imagined resolution as a complete map.

Every name.

Every line.

Every role.

Every decision explained.

But no real case had ever given him that.

Not even the simple ones.

The dead could not answer.

The living lied.

Records failed.

Memory shifted.

Institutions edited themselves.

People acted for more than one reason at a time.

The Circle had survived partly because investigators wanted a cleaner story than reality offered.

Rahman no longer needed one.

Farid had been exposed.

Not as king.

As Protector.

A man who made choices.

Some defensible.

Some corrupting.

Some both.

Farhan had been held accountable for what he actually did, not the crimes investigators once wanted him to explain.

The institution had been forced into review.

Rahman too.

That mattered.

Harun's work had returned to the record.

Aziz Mahmud's quiet act had not vanished.

His father's sentence had never been about the world. It had been about the damage a quiet man adds by staying quiet.

Hana had carried truth publicly without turning every suspicion into guilt.

Aisyah had proved integrity could point inward.

Daniel had proved data needed humility.

Imran and thousands like him still put on blue uniforms and did ordinary work under a heavier gaze.

Those were consequences.

Real ones.

The story had moved.

But finished?

No.

Rahman looked again at the photograph.

Harun's sentence returned.

If you are reading this, they survived.

Not he.

They.

Rahman did not know whether Harun meant three men.

Three relationships.

Three functions.

Three custodians.

Or something else entirely.

He did not know who had sent the notebook.

He did not know who had taken the recent photograph.

He did not know who made the call.

He did not know whether Rahim Nasir had faked his death, survived under another identity, been protected, replaced, misidentified, or mythologised by everyone who came after him.

He did not know whether The Circle had lost part of itself to ORION.

Or shed part of itself.

Or merely watched.

That ignorance no longer felt like failure.

Only responsibility.

The dangerous thing would be pretending uncertainty was the same as innocence.

Or guilt.

Rahman stood.

Walked to the balcony.

The black sedan was gone.

Of course.

Below, traffic moved through wet streets beneath streetlamps.

Blue lights appeared several blocks away.

A patrol car.

Not coming for him.

Not chasing anyone he knew.

Just police going somewhere.

Rahman watched until the lights vanished behind a building.

For most of his life, he had believed the task was to find enough truth to finish the case.

Now he understood something Harun had been trying to teach him from the beginning.

Sometimes you found enough truth to act.

Enough to arrest.

Enough to expose.

Enough to stop protecting the wrong thing.

Enough to accept consequences yourself.

And then you kept living with what remained unknown.

Rahman looked toward the road where the sedan had disappeared.

He had found enough truth to act.

He had not found enough truth to believe the story was finished.

That would have to be enough.

For now.

END OF BOOK ONE